A Ship of Compassion on the Sea of Awakening: Ferrying Beings Across in Hong Kong

Records of the Life of the Venerable Master Hsuan Hua

The Hong Kong Years

Compiled by the Editorial Committee for the Records of the Life of the Venerable Master Hsuan Hua

Translated from the Chinese

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Prologue

In the Venerable Master's own words:

This too came about through a kind of causal connection. The karmic winds [Tr.: the force of one's karma, which drives beings from place to place like a wind] blew me from Manchuria to Tianjin, and then from Tianjin to Shanghai. I came to Hubei, and not long after I arrived in Hubei, they blew me to Mount Putuo. Then, passing by way of Lingyan Mountain in Suzhou, I went to Guangdong to draw near to Elder Master Hsu Yun. I stayed in Guangdong for a while, and then these karmic winds blew me to Hong Kong. Once in Hong Kong, I stayed for more than ten years, so I had this affinity with Hong Kong, neither large nor small; probably it was all meant to be. In 1960 I went to Australia; in 1961 I returned to Hong Kong, and not long after, in 1962, I came to the United States.

Part One: Coming to Hong Kong and Awaiting Conditions

Ages 32 to 34

1949 to 1951 CE

01. Going to Hong Kong in Accord with Conditions

In the summer of 1949, the Venerable Master visited Hong Kong for the first time. After he returned to the mainland, however, Shaoguan changed hands, so he could not go back to Yunmen; he therefore took a boat from Guangzhou to Hong Kong once again. From then on, the Venerable Master stayed in Hong Kong, according with conditions, and began his journey of propagating the Dharma and teaching overseas...

In the Venerable Master's own words:

In the thirty-eighth year of the Republic (1949), I went to Hong Kong for the first time and stayed as a visiting monk [Tr.: the monastic custom of lodging temporarily at a monastery while traveling] at Tung Po Tor Monastery. In the seventh month, I went back from Hong Kong to Guangzhou, planning to return to Dajue Monastery at Yunmen after the Mid-Autumn Festival. But in the eighth month Shaoguan was liberated (Editor's note: according to the *Chronicle of Major Events in the Local History of Shaoguan*, Shaoguan was liberated on October 7, 1949, which was the sixteenth day of the eighth lunar month), and I could not get back to Yunmen. At that time Guangzhou was in imminent danger. I wanted to go to Hong Kong again, but I didn't have even a single dollar in my hand, and on top of that I had a disciple with me, Guo Yi (Heng Ding). On the eighteenth day of the eighth month, the two of us, master and disciple, went to the ship terminal to see whether there were conditions for us to get to Hong Kong, and there we ran into Upasika Chen Kuan Man. I remember that when I was at Nanhua Monastery, the lay Buddhist Xie Kuan Hui, who had come from Guangzhou, said to more than ten laypeople, "Many of the Dharma Masters at Nanhua Monastery don't have enough clothes to wear!" So these lay Buddhists resolved to buy cloth as an offering to the Sangha, and Upasika Chen Kuan Man was one of the donors. Someone introduced me to her at that time, and later we met again at Liurong Monastery in Guangzhou. When Chen Kuan Man saw us at the ship terminal, she said to me, "I'm going to Hong Kong today. Would you like to go?" I said, "I'd like to go. Will you buy me a ticket?" So she bought two tickets for me, and that night we left Guangzhou by boat, arriving in Hong Kong early the next morning. Those were the conditions that brought me to Hong Kong.

I was born the kind of person who fears neither heaven nor earth, neither gods nor ghosts, and I'm not even afraid of Americans speaking Chinese. The newspapers said that if I hadn't been afraid of the Communists, I wouldn't have drifted overseas. I didn't run overseas because I was afraid of the Communists;

it was brought about by the conditions of the times. All along the way, no sooner had I taken a step forward than the ground behind me was occupied by the Communists. Transportation was cut off, and even if I had wanted to go back, I couldn't. That is how I came to Hong Kong. I lived in Hong Kong for more than ten years, until I went to America in 1962.

[Addendum 1] Tung Po Tor Monastery was originally a Way-place for only a few dozen monastics, but in the late 1940s it took on the responsibilities of a public monastery of the ten directions [Tr.: open to all monastics, as opposed to a private hereditary temple]. The reason was the war on the Chinese mainland, after which many monastics fled from the mainland to Hong Kong as refugees: "By day they wandered the streets; by night they had nowhere to rest."

At that time Dharma Master Mao Feng, the abbot of Tung Po Tor, brought forth great compassion and vowed to take in the refugee monks. He insisted on "opening the monastery gates wide and receiving all comers with lodging as vast as the sea," and took the attitude of accepting monastics from the mainland unconditionally. He said, "Every blade of grass has its drop of dew; every Arhat has his share of the meal." In a single day, as many as a thousand monastics came to lodge there. Tung Po Tor turned no one away, and when faithful devotees everywhere heard of it, they donated rice and grain one after another, so that the monastery never suffered from running out of food.

Dharma Master Mao Feng also led the monks in "carrying the timber on their own shoulders and cutting the bamboo poles themselves" to build a "Cloud and Water Hall" to receive the male monastics, and they also built a "palm-leaf shed" to house the female monastics.

[Addendum 2] Upasika Tan Guo Shi has known the Venerable Master since she was a child and has been his refuge disciple [Tr.: one who has formally become a Buddhist disciple by taking refuge in the Buddha, Dharma, and Sangha] for more than 50 years now. Upasika Tan recounted:

When the Master first came to Hong Kong, before he found Guanyin Cave, he stayed as a visiting monk at Tung Po Tor, where Dharma Master Mao Feng was the abbot. Once the Master took me to see Dharma Master Mao Feng. The Master respected him very much. Regardless of how other Dharma Masters behaved, whenever the Master saw a monastic of an older generation, he would always bow to them first.

[Addendum 3] Dharma Master Heng Ding, whose Dharma name was Guo Yi, was the fourth of the Venerable Master's monastic disciples to receive full ordination. The four were Dharma Master Guo Neng (Heng Ji), Dharma Master Guo Shun (Heng Yu), Dharma Master Guo Wei, and Dharma Master Heng Ding. Dharma Master Heng Ding was the only disciple who followed the Venerable Master to Hong Kong; he passed away in Hong Kong in 2003. Bhikshu Heng Ding's oral account:

I met the Master in Shenyang when I was still a student, but it was not until I went to Nanhua Monastery that I followed the Master and left the home-life. In

the thirty-eighth year of the Republic (1949), having just finished receiving the precepts, I followed the Master to Hong Kong. When the Master came from Manchuria to Nanhua Monastery, he didn't bring anything with him except a string of recitation beads; when he got to Hong Kong, he still had nothing, just that same string of recitation beads.

[Addendum 4] Upasika Chen Kuan Man was a refuge disciple of Elder Master Hsu Yun and supported Buddhism for decades. In 1980, when she was in her eighties, she went to Gold Mountain Monastery in America to pay her respects to the Venerable Master.

02. Journey to Thailand

In early 1950, the Venerable Master joined a delegation of study-abroad monks organized by the Chinese Buddhist Vinaya Academy and went to Thailand to observe Theravada Buddhism. He stayed at Wat Mangkon Kamalawat (Longlian Monastery) in Thailand for about four months, studying firsthand the differences between Mahayana and Small Vehicle Buddhism and taking the strengths of each, and he resolved to reform the bad customs of Chinese Buddhism...

In the Venerable Master's own words:

I went on alms rounds in Hong Kong, but in Thailand I didn't. Why not? Because I was staying at a Chinese monastery; they cooked their own food there, unlike the Thai monasteries. Thailand was terribly hot; I couldn't stand it. I had to take a shower every day, because the heat was just too fierce.

In Hong Kong there was a Dharma Master Hui De. When he heard I was planning to go to Thailand to observe Theravada Buddhism, he didn't want me to go. He wanted me to go live in the mountains with him so that we could practice together as "fellow investigators." I said to him, "You investigate your Hui De, and I investigate my An Tse. How can we investigate together?" [Tr.: "fellow investigators" is the usual Chinese term for fellow Chan practitioners; the Master plays on its literal sense.] At last he understood a little, and he no longer tried to stop me from going to Siam (Thailand).

He sat in Chan meditation every day, but because he didn't know the method of applying effort, he sat until he coughed up blood. So in cultivation, it isn't that just because "I'm applying effort" you're sure to succeed; applying effort comes with demonic obstacles just the same. As soon as he applied effort he coughed up blood, and even coughing up blood he kept on applying effort. He wouldn't accept offerings from people, and he wouldn't take money. Wherever he went to stay, if you didn't bother him, didn't pester him, and didn't talk to him, he would stay there peacefully. But if some layperson talked to him, or someone offered him a little money or a box of crackers, he considered it a nuisance; without even looking at it, he would run off and not stay there anymore.

He stayed at Po Lin Monastery on Lantau Island for several years, and he also stayed at Man Cheung Po for a year or half a year. Later some layperson or

other caused him trouble, and he ran off—not even I knew about it. Because this man truly cultivated, some laypeople wanted to make offerings to such a cultivator and tried every way they could to find him so they could make offerings to him; but as soon as they found him, he would run off. This is the true character of cultivating the Way! He wasn't someone who chattered with laypeople from morning to night, squeezing out a few words to curry favor even when there was nothing to say. He was not like that!

Someone like Dharma Master Hui De is in the state of an Arhat, the state of a Solitary Enlightened One. He lived in a little thatched hut, and his clothes were all in tatters. His voice was very faint, as though he were about to run out of breath; he had to lean right up to your ear before you could hear what he was saying. When he stayed at the Tung Lin Buddha Recitation Hall, he ate other people's leftovers. Food that others didn't eat, he took and ate. If they didn't give him this food, he would leave. After he finished eating, he would shut his door and not talk to anyone, not a single word. For him the path of words was truly cut off; he really wanted to be a mute, and it wasn't that he was pretending not to talk.

[Addendum 1] Bhikshu Elder Zhi Ding recounted in his article *In Memory of Elder To Lun*:

On the last day of 1949, I arrived in Hong Kong. At the Hong Kong Buddhist Association I met Dharma Master To Lun again. We truly had affinities; we kept running into each other everywhere. At that time Elder To Lun, with Dharma Master Cheng Yuan as the leader, was going through the formalities for going to Thailand as a study-abroad monk.

[Addendum 2] Upasika Tan Guo Zheng met the Venerable Master when she was 16 and has been his refuge disciple for more than 50 years now. Upasika Tan Guo Zheng recounted:

The Master went to Thailand with a delegation of monks to study Small Vehicle Buddhism, and Dharma Master Heng Ding went along too. The Master stayed in Thailand for several months and closely observed the traditional system of Small Vehicle Buddhism, and he resolved that in the future he would reform the bad customs of Chinese Buddhism. That is why later, at the City of Ten Thousand Buddhas in America, he established for the Sangha such family traditions as "eating one meal a day, at midday" [Tr.: the Buddha's own practice of taking a single meal before noon] and "never lying down to sleep" [Tr.: sitting up in meditation all night instead of lying down].

[Addendum 3] Bhikshu Dharma Master Heng Ding's oral account:

We once went to Bangkok, Thailand, for four months. We had originally gone to learn the system of Theravada Buddhism, but because our paperwork hadn't been completed, we had no choice but to come back. In Thailand we still wore Chinese monastic robes, not Theravada robes, and we didn't go out on alms rounds [Tr.: going out with the bowl to receive food from donors, as monks did in the Buddha's time] either. We stayed at Wat Mangkon Kamalawat (Longlian

Monastery), where the monastics were all Chinese and spoke Mandarin. Originally Thailand did not allow Chinese people to build monasteries, but the Cantonese Dharma Master who founded it was very capable, and his recitation of the Great Compassion Mantra brought strong responses, so the Thai government let him establish Longlian Monastery. This was no easy thing; without the consent of the Thai government, it would have been impossible.

[Addendum 4] Longlian Monastery, built in 1871 and located in Bangkok, the capital of Thailand, is the earliest Chinese Mahayana monastery established in Thailand. Dharma Master Xu Xing of Guangdong Province, China, went to Thailand to propagate the Buddhadharma in the first year of the Tongzhi reign of the Qing dynasty (1862). He was received with courtesy by the King of Thailand, who granted land by royal decree for building a Chinese monastery. The site had originally been a place where merchants sold "dragon lotus seeds" (that is, double-hearted lotus seeds, a Chinese medicinal herb that can also be made into a cooling drink), and so the monastery was named "Longlian (Dragon Lotus) Chan Monastery." Apart from its buildings differing from Thai-style temples, the monastery has also always preserved Chinese-language Buddhist scriptures and the practice of vegetarianism.

03. Settling in a Stone Cave

In early summer of 1950, the 33-year-old Venerable Master returned to Hong Kong from Thailand with nothing to his name but the patched robe [Tr.: a robe pieced together from patched rags, worn by monks as a mark of frugality] he wore, covered all over with patches. A layperson who knew the Venerable Master was looking for a place to cultivate introduced him to Guanyin Cave on Fu Yung Shan in Tsuen Wan...

In the Venerable Master's own words:

In my first year in Hong Kong I had no money, and I didn't go seeking alms from people either. I often held seven-day sessions [Tr.: an intensive seven-day period of meditation or recitation], with nothing to eat. After I came back from Thailand, a layperson named Guo Kuan Pu introduced me to Fu Yung Shan to live in Guanyin Cave.

When I first lived in Guanyin Cave, never mind teacups, there wasn't even a table. No stools, no bed, nothing at all; everything was empty. During the day I would do walking meditation all over the place. On the wall there was a stone ledge. How big was it? Just big enough for one person to sit on with his back straight. At night I sat in meditation on it. Every day I just sat like that.

Guanyin Cave was damp by nature. At first I didn't notice it, but after sitting there the first day, what do you think happened on the second day? My whole body had turned to stone! I couldn't move. It was even as though I had merged into one with the stone wall; I wanted to move but couldn't. After I had been sitting for a little more than half a month, one day I wanted to get up, and what do you think my legs did? They just wouldn't cooperate! My legs had gone so

numb that there was no feeling in them at all. Only after moving them about for half an hour could I slowly stand up. I sat like this for about a month.

One day I actually couldn't get down from the stone ledge, and I started having idle thoughts: "This place is so damp, it's very bad for my health. If I keep living here all the time, how can I stand it?" So I wanted to leave. But if I left Guanyin Cave, where would I go? There was no suitable place for me to live, either.

But when I moved in, it was through Guo Kuan Pu's introduction. At the start he had said, "There's nothing at all in the cave. If you can live there, I'll introduce you; if you can't, don't force yourself." At the time I didn't know it would be this bad. Sitting there every day, my body seemed to have congealed into one lump, and my blood wasn't circulating. Then I thought again: "If I stop living here now, it would be like starting something and not finishing it. Someone had to call in a big favor to get this place. If I don't stay, how can I face them? How would I explain it?" I really couldn't bring myself to say it.

So I made up my mind and said to myself, "Even if I die in this cave, I won't come out! Damp is damp; let it be!" Because "If you can't give up death, you can't gain life; if you can't give up the false, you can't accomplish the true," and "Undergoing suffering ends suffering; enjoying blessings uses up blessings." If this suffering is something I'm supposed to undergo, I'll just go ahead and undergo it! Once I thought this way, that was that: if I die here, so be it; I won't care. After I had lived there for a while, my body stopped being partners with the stone—it closed down the joint-stock limited company—and I could move again. When I got up in the morning, I could get down off the stone ledge again.

In this way I lived there at Guanyin Cave for several years. In the end someone saw that I had no table, no stools, not even a bed, so a layperson resolved to give me a meditation box [Tr.: a wooden box-seat in which a monk sits in meditation day and night] and two stools. With that, I was much more comfortable than before. Every day at mealtime I would go down the mountain to beg for food, going on alms rounds to Chuk Lam Sim Yuen to get food and bring it back to eat.

One day when I came back, I found that a big snake had gotten into Guanyin Cave. This snake was so thick and so big! When it saw me come back, it ran toward the back door, and when it ran, I chased it. When it got to the doorway, it seemed to want to fight with me; it turned its head back to look at me, and then it ran off out the back. After that it came often; I don't know what it wanted. Sometimes when I went out, it would come in; when I came in, it would go out.

I never told anyone that I had lived in Guanyin Cave. There was a man who lived on a mountain for three months, and when he came down he went around advertising, selling his cultivation, always telling people, "Living on a mountain is wonderful! Living on the mountain now is just like being in closed retreat! Up there I did such-and-such practice; it's really great!" I said to him, "You're really clever! You lived on a mountain for three months and you already know to

advertise it everywhere. I've lived on a mountain for more than ten years and nobody knows. I'm too foolish, too stupid!"

[Addendum 1] Bhikshu Dharma Master Heng Ding's oral account:

Guanyin Cave was not a natural cave but a man-made one, so it was very damp. The Master was very capable. When he lived in Guanyin Cave, within just a few months, the cave's appearance changed.

[Addendum 2] Dharma Master Heng Ding, together with Dharma Masters Heng Yue and Heng Zhi, who had come from Sanyuan Monastery in Manchuria (these two Dharma Masters were the Venerable Master's Dharma nephews), stayed as visiting monks at Tung Po Tor Monastery and Chuk Lam Sim Yuen respectively. Dharma Master Rong Qiu, the founding Patriarch of Chuk Lam Sim Yuen, arrived in Hong Kong in 1928 and built Chuk Lam Sim Yuen on Fu Yung Shan in Tsuen Wan. During the Second World War, Dharma Master Rong Qiu led his disciples in clearing land and farming so that together they could get through the hard times. In 1949, when monks were coming south to escape the turmoil, the Dharma Master opened wide the door of convenience and provided them with food and lodging.

[Addendum 3] Bhikshuni Dharma Master Jin Ci, a native of Taishan, Guangdong, was one of the Venerable Master's early refuge disciples from his time at Guanyin Cave in Hong Kong; the Dharma name she received when she took refuge was Guo Sen.

In 1950, Guo Sen, then just past 40, was the young mistress of a wealthy family and had worshipped Guanyin since she was small. One day her friend Mrs. Huang (Luo Guo Ming) asked her, "Would you like to take refuge and bow to a teacher?" At that time she didn't even know what "bowing to a teacher" (taking refuge) was. Mrs. Huang told her about the benefits of taking refuge and about this Dharma Master's compassion and so on, so she met the Master at Wang Guo Hai's home and formally took refuge. When she first met the Master, he was only about 30 and very thin. Later Guo Sen's family business ran into trouble, and the family's fortunes declined. When the Venerable Master learned of her situation, he told her to bear adversity with patience. Guo Sen took tonsure in 1998 and received full ordination in 2000, with the Dharma name Qin Ren and the style name Jin Ci. She passed away peacefully in the eighth lunar month of 2008, at the age of 100.

[Addendum 4] Upasaka Huang Guo Jun took refuge with the Venerable Master at the age of 11, more than 50 years ago now. Upasaka Huang Guo Jun recounted:

On the Master's way from Nanhua Monastery to Hong Kong, he met an Upasaka Fang, a disciple of Elder Hsu, who therefore knew the Master. Upasaka Fang asked the Master whether he knew anyone in Hong Kong. The Master said, "No, I don't know a single person." Upasaka Fang said, "I'll introduce some friends to you." In 1950, Upasaka Fang introduced him to a Mrs. Wang (Wang Guo Hai). Mrs. Wang was a former neighbor of my mother (Luo Guo Ming); she and my

mother, four or five people in all, were the first group of Hong Kong disciples to take refuge with the Master. A few days later, at Mrs. Wang's home, I took refuge with the Master together with Upasika Guo Sen (Bhikshuni Jin Ci).

I remember that right after I took refuge, the Master said I was "stubborn by nature and had a temper." At the time I only knew that having a temper was bad and that I should change it; as for being stubborn by nature, I even thought back then that it was a good quality! It was only later, when I read in the *Earth Store Sutra*, "The beings of Jambudvipa are stubborn and difficult to tame and subdue," that I finally understood what the Master meant. If my temper now can be said to be not too bad, the credit goes entirely to the Master's teaching.

04. The Bearing of the Greatly Virtuous

As the situation on the Chinese mainland was in violent upheaval, many monastics poured into Hong Kong. The Venerable Master, concerned for the safety of Elder Master Lai Guo, an eminent and virtuous elder of the Chan lineage, wrote him a letter urging the Elder Master to come to Hong Kong. From the letters they exchanged, one can sense the bearing of the greatly virtuous.

To Great Master Lai Guo, for your perusal in the Way:

Venerable One, with your great wisdom you carry on the Buddhadharma; you are a great vessel that bears the Dharma. As the situation is turbulent at present, I beg you, Venerable One, to take good care of your precious health and let not a single hair be harmed, just as you protect and uphold the Buddhadharma.

The Second Patriarch cut off his arm to seek the Dharma; the Sixth Patriarch, to protect the Dharma, hid himself among a band of hunters for 16 years. If you, Venerable One, could follow the example of the Patriarchs and come to Hong Kong to protect the Buddhadharma and rescue living beings, my mind would be at ease! This still awaits the full ripening of causes and conditions.

Peace in the Way,

With bows, An Tse

To Great Master An Tse, for your illustrious perusal:

I received your letter yesterday and have respectfully noted its contents. When the Great Dharma is upheld in its entirety, how can there be any division of territory? Even when the human lifespan has dwindled to ten years [Tr.: the lowest point of a kalpa in Buddhist cosmology], I intend to come here to prop up Bodhidharma's banner pole. As descendants of Shakyamuni, we simply practice true practice and shrink from nothing whatsoever. Please be at ease!
Respectfully replying, I wish you

peace in the Way.

Personally written by Lai Guo

In the Venerable Master's own words:

Elder Master Lai Guo of Gaomin Monastery in Yangzhou once wrote me a letter. What I want to talk about now isn't that letter but the envelope. What about his envelope? He used one envelope twice. How did he use it twice? This envelope had been addressed to him by someone else and had already been used; he turned it inside out and used the blank inner side to write to me. So the greatly virtuous, eminent monks of old were all extremely frugal; they didn't waste things or use them carelessly. They would not write a few words on a sheet of paper and then throw it away.

The last time I wrote a verse [Tr.: a gatha, a Buddhist verse form] for Guo Qian, I had him cut the verse off and took the paper back to use again. Why did I do this? It's not that I begrudge even a sheet of paper; it's that we should cherish the material resources of this world. I hope none of you will waste things. If you keep wasting things, then imperceptibly you will have no merit and virtue [Tr.: the blessings and spiritual virtue gained through good deeds and practice], and it won't be easy to succeed in cultivation either. So people who cultivate the Way must be careful in every situation.

05. Sweet Dew in Front of the Cave

Guanyin Cave had a problem with water shortage. After the Venerable Master moved into Guanyin Cave, the pools gushed with sweet, clear water. When the Venerable Master later moved away, the water source in front of the cave dried up as well...

In the Venerable Master's own words:

My neighbor was a Dharma Master from Fujian. He was performing a thousand Flaming Mouth ceremonies [Tr.: a ritual for feeding hungry ghosts], one every day. A thousand Flaming Mouth ceremonies take a thousand days, which is three years. At about three o'clock in the afternoon he would perform the Flaming Mouth ceremony. First he would put on his robe and sash and go outside the door to look down the hill. When he saw eight or ten tourists coming up, he would go back in, pick up his bell, and, all by himself, beat the drum and strike the bell as he performed the Flaming Mouth ceremony, making a great racket. When the tourists passed by and leaned in at the door to look—"Oh, this Dharma Master is really diligent!"—this one would give money, and that one would give money.

Before I went there, he had made two pools in front of the cave to store the water that flowed down from the mountain. There wasn't much water in the pools; they were usually dry. After I got there, water came into the pools every day, and the water was so clear! Today I'm not afraid to tell you: why was there water once I got there? Because in Manchuria ten dragons took refuge with me. I'm not trying to scare you, and I'm not saying how wonderful I am. All these gods, dragons, and the rest of the eightfold division [Tr.: the eight classes of beings who protect the Dharma] and all the ghosts and spirits listen to what I

say—unlike you people, who don't know any better and sometimes are very disobedient.

When I was at Guanyin Cave with no food to eat and no clothes to wear, I came to know Yu Guo Man. She was from Shanghai and was my greatest Dharma protector in Hong Kong. Before she met me, what she feared most was monks. She didn't dare see monastics; when she saw a monk she was frightened out of her wits. If there had been a mouse cage around, she would even have tried to hide in it; that's how scared she was! I said, "In your past lives you must have been cheated by monastics far too often; that's why you're so afraid!"

The first time she came to Guanyin Cave, I was eating. She asked, "What are you eating?" I said, "Noodles!" I invited her to stay and eat noodles with me. She didn't dare to eat, yet she wanted to, and in the end she ate. She drank some water at my place and asked me, "Did you put sugar in this water?" I said, "No! This is plain boiled water." "Then why is it so sweet? It's sweeter than if you'd put sugar in it." I said, "Sweet? Then maybe Guanshiyin Bodhisattva added sweet dew for you, so drink a bit more!" She was so happy she drank four or five bowls of water. She also often bought rice and made short jackets and trousers to give me; she was very sincere. Seeing that the clothes I wore were all in tatters, she resolved to go home and make me two pairs of trousers out of very thick cotton cloth; they could be worn for about ten years without wearing out. That's because she was very honest, and honest people make honest things like that.

[Addendum] Bhikshuni Dharma Master Jin Ci's oral account:

When the Master first came to Guanyin Cave, there wasn't a single drop of water in the pool. Later, water slowly began to flow out of the rock face, and the pool was always full. I drank from it, and it was very sweet. But after the Master left Guanyin Cave, the pool dried up again. In those days the Master went to Chuk Lam Sim Yuen every day to get food. Because the Master would sit for several days at a stretch, sometimes, when it happened that the monastery had no leftover food, he would have to go hungry for ten days or so all told. But he never told anyone, and no one knew about the hard life he led. All this was discovered gradually by his disciples later on. Once they knew, they would bring some food to offer to the Master whenever they went up the mountain.

06. Out of Food and Awaiting Death

Guanyin Cave was severely damp; it was no place to settle down in. The Venerable Master overcame all kinds of difficulties, moved away a large boulder outside the cave, and put up a small thatched hut—but unexpectedly, this brought on demonic obstacles...

In the Venerable Master's own words:

I've seen quite a few cultivators who, when living where the assembly lives, mostly shirk work and take it easy, unwilling to do any more than they must; but

once they live in their own thatched hut, they can do everything. Why? Because if they don't do their own work, nobody else will do it. For example, when a certain person lived at Chuk Lam Sim Yuen, he slept from morning to night. And once he lived in his own thatched hut? He was really vigorous: he kept everything around the hut clean and tidy, and the fence he made was very handsome. But in the monastery he wouldn't lift a finger. There was another person who, in the Way-place, put on the airs of an old cultivator and acted very dull, doing nothing at all. Once he lived in his own thatched hut, he could do this and he could do that. Although he was very clumsy, he could do it. Why? Because he considered the thatched hut his own, while the monastery wasn't his.

My temperament is just the opposite of theirs. In a monastery I like to work, but when I live in my own little thatched hut, I'm casual and easygoing about everything. Guanyin Cave had been built by others beforehand; while I lived there, I neither added anything nor took anything away. I sat in that spot every day and did nothing. It was only because the cave was too damp that I later built a small thatched hut, and I had to move a big boulder. The workers couldn't do it, so I moved it myself. That's my temperament.

I remember that the two workers I hired then were both big fellows, and both very strong. One was over six feet tall, and the other was five foot eight. I told them to move the boulder away; it weighed as much as two tons. The two of them pried at it with iron bars for ages, about four hours, but there was no way they could shift it; they couldn't move it even a fraction of an inch. There was nothing they could do. They came back and told me that the boulder would have to be blasted with explosives; otherwise there was no way to move it. I went over to have a look and said, "This boulder doesn't need to be blasted. You two can't move it, but I'll make a bet with you two now: if I move it, you two give up your wages for today; if I can't move it, I'll pay you double wages. What do you say?" Ah! They said, "Of course, that's fine!"

Why couldn't they pry it up? They were using iron bars, and when they pried, the force underneath it was against the dirt; prying against the dirt, it wouldn't move, because the dirt naturally wasn't as strong as that rock. I moved this big boulder all by myself. How was I able to move it? I put a stone at the edge of the gap underneath the boulder, and then, with an iron bar, gave a pry forward, and up it came. It took me about 20 minutes to move the boulder away. The big boulder went from up top to down below; it moved house all by itself.

I said to them, "How many meals do you two eat a day?" "Three." "How much do you earn a day?" They told me how much they earned, and I said, "If I went out to work, everyone would want to hire me and not you. Because I eat only one meal a day, and the work you can't do, I can get done." That left the two workers with nothing to say.

A year later, I built a tiny thatched hut outside the cave. I put it up with wood and then covered it with tar paper—a small space of about 15 feet by 15 feet. At

last I had a roof over my head. As soon as the thatched hut went up, demonic obstacles came too. Because many people came and saw me cultivating so austerely, some would toss in a little money for incense and oil, or bring some food and drink, and my neighbor next door became jealous and couldn't let it go. Unable to let it go, he told the people who came, "I'm the manager here. Whatever else you bring, hand it over to me. The money you bring has to be handed over to me, and the things you bring have to be handed over to me." That's what this neighboring monk said. And so he would stand blocking the doorway and not let them come over to me. He even fabricated rumors, telling Chuk Lam Sim Yuen that I had a lot of money: "Don't make offerings to him anymore. He has money to build a thatched hut—how could he not have money for food?" The manager there believed it was true and stopped making offerings to me; they stopped giving me food. After they stopped giving me food, some 15 or 20-odd days went by; I don't remember clearly. At that time there really was no one making offerings, and with no one making offerings, I thought, "I'll eat the little bit I have, and then just sit there in meditation."

I didn't tell anyone that I had no food, and I didn't go out or see anyone. If I starved to death, that would be that. I slowly ate the dry provisions stored in the cave to stave off hunger, and barely held out for half a month. By then everything had been eaten up; I was truly out of food, so I just sat there waiting to starve to death, because my principle had always been: "Freezing, we do not scheme. Starving, we do not beg. Dying of poverty, we ask for nothing. We accord with conditions, yet do not change; we do not change, yet accord with conditions."

[Addendum] Lay Buddhist Tang Guo Shan's oral account:

I took refuge in 1950, but I didn't understand the Buddhadharma. Once I took some relatives and friends to Guanyin Cave to visit the Master. We saw rice and vegetables in the Master's bowl and, thinking that eating it would lengthen our lives and make us healthy, we went right ahead and ate it all up. Only later did we learn it was the Master's midday meal, which he had brought back from Chuk Lam Sim Yuen. We hurriedly bought some bread for the Master, and that day the Master got by on just that bit of bread. Looking back on it, what an offense!

07. Weituo Bodhisattva Appears in a Dream

Weituo Bodhisattva [Tr.: the Dharma-protector Bodhisattva, guardian of monasteries] made a vow: "If there is anyone in the world who truly cultivates, I will certainly go and protect his Dharma." Seeing the Venerable Master determined to sit there and wait to starve to death, Weituo Bodhisattva grew truly anxious!

In the Venerable Master's own words:

At that time I just sat there waiting to starve to death. I didn't say to anyone, "Have pity on me, I've got nothing to eat—make me an offering!" or "Help me

out—just think of it as giving to a beggar!" I didn't say it, but Weituo Bodhisattva, watching, couldn't help getting anxious.

I often say that I, as a monastic, don't bow to Weituo Bodhisattva. You may think my way of thinking isn't normal: "Weituo Bodhisattva is a Dharma protector, so why don't you bow to him? If you don't bow to Weituo Bodhisattva, what if he doesn't protect your Dharma?" I'll tell you: I want him to protect other people's Dharma, not mine. Why? If I am a true cultivator, then even if I don't ask him to protect the Dharma, he'll still protect my Dharma; he has to fulfill his duty. If I don't cultivate and just kowtow to Weituo Bodhisattva a few times and he comes to protect the Dharma, then he wouldn't be qualified to be Weituo Bodhisattva. Why? He'd be corrupt, and he'd be selling the Dharma. All of you, think about it: if people kowtow to you a few times, you protect them; if they don't kowtow, you don't fulfill your duty—wouldn't that be corruption? So I don't kowtow to him.

At that time there was a woman of 50 or 60, Liu Kuan Sheng, a Cantonese, who would speak the Buddhadharma to everyone she met, so people called her the "Local Dharma Master." "Local" means from right here, not from somewhere else. She wasn't a Dharma Master at all; she was a layperson. A few months earlier, she had been bitten on the foot by a dog. What kind of dog bit her? Probably a mad dog. She had seen doctors of both Chinese and Western medicine, but none of them had cured it; two or three months went by and it still hadn't healed. One night she had a dream in which Weituo Bodhisattva said to her, "If you want your foot to get well, go and make offerings at Guanyin Cave behind Fu Yung Shan. There's a Dharma Master there named An Tse. Go and make offerings to him, and you'll be all right. Hurry! Dharma Master An has nothing to eat there. Take him some food as an offering, and your dog bite will heal." In the dream, Weituo Bodhisattva showed her my photograph, and once she saw it, she remembered it.

She had this dream three days running, so she believed it was real. She went around everywhere collecting donations and collected more than HK$70, and she bought 30 catties [Tr.: a catty is about 0.6 kg, so roughly 18 kg or 40 lb] of rice herself and carried it up the mountain on her own back to Guanyin Cave. She was short, and her foot had been bitten by a dog besides—now tell me, was she sincere or not!

When the Dharma Master next door saw a donor coming, he hurried out to greet her. Liu Kuan Sheng asked him, "There's a Dharma Master An Tse here. Is he in?" My neighboring monk blocked her at the doorway and said, "I'm the manager here. Whatever you've brought, just hand it to me." He asked her what she had brought; she said it was rice and a little money, and he said it all had to be handed over to him. But Liu Kuan Sheng said, "In my dream Weituo Bodhisattva said he was called Dharma Master An Tse, and in the photograph he didn't look like you. I can't give this to you!" This monk finally lost his temper and started quarreling with her: "What do you mean it doesn't look like me? You're talking nonsense! I'm the manager here, and he isn't the manager at all.

All the offerings you bring should be handed over to me!" The laywoman said, "If it isn't you, it isn't you. Why should I give it to you?"

Hearing the two of them quarreling, I came out to the doorway and looked up. There the two of them were, arguing endlessly, so I asked what was going on. At that, Liu Kuan Sheng said, "Oh, it's him! It's him! It's this monk! Ah, and I even know what his name is!" The neighboring monk said furiously, "You're not allowed to come up this mountain again!" Liu Kuan Sheng paid him no mind and handed the things over to me. I said, "All right, he knows you've come too, so half for each of us!" She said, "I don't want to give him any." I said, "I'll give it to him. He knows you aren't giving him any, and he won't be happy." So I split off 15 catties of rice for him and gave him 35 dollars. Even so, he still wasn't satisfied and was very unhappy.

When Liu Kuan Sheng went back, she told everyone everywhere, "At Guanyin Cave there's a Dharma Master An Tse. I dreamed that Weituo Bodhisattva told me to make offerings to him. After I brought the offerings and came back, my foot healed. It's truly miraculous!" Everyone who heard it thought it inconceivable. And so, after that, more and more people came to know about me, and knew that I was going hungry there, so people often went to make offerings. This one brought offerings, and that one brought offerings. No matter who brought offerings, I always gave half to the Dharma Master next door, but he still wasn't satisfied. Every time someone came to see me, he would first have a quarrel with them, and he also used all sorts of methods to undermine me. Later I stopped living there.

While I lived there, the two pools in front had water every day, enough for ten-odd or even 20 people to use. As soon as I moved away, the pools had no water. Originally there was no water at Western Bliss Gardens either, but when I went to build Western Bliss Gardens, there was water. So the monks living on Fu Yung Shan all said that I had taken the water away with me, taken it to Western Bliss Gardens.

08. Strictly Upholding His Principles

The Venerable Master was the Dharma Master whom the elderly Upasika Liu Kuan Sheng had seen in her dream; at that time the Venerable Master had already been without food for half a month. The story of Weituo Bodhisattva appearing in a dream so that offerings would be made to the Venerable Master spread from one person to ten and from ten to a hundred, and everyone thought it inconceivable. All his life the Venerable Master carefully upheld "Freezing, we do not scheme. Starving, we do not beg..."

In the Venerable Master's own words:

Often not eating is a good method: it saves money, and you don't need to ask people for offerings. We monastics should worry about whether we have accomplished our work in the Way, not about whether we receive offerings. If you receive offerings but don't become enlightened and don't accomplish your

work in the Way, you're still an ordinary person. If you accomplish your work in the Way, then even without offerings, you're a sage. Even though I was about to starve to death there, I didn't starve to death. Now, it's precisely because you're afraid of starving to death that nobody makes offerings to you. If you have cultivation and you aren't afraid of starving to death, naturally there will be a response. So don't worry about whether you receive offerings.

I have never told anyone what I needed. I never said, "I don't have such-and-such clothing; make me one." "Freezing, we do not scheme": I don't tell people I lack this or I lack that. On the mainland I wore a patched robe, and in Hong Kong I also wore very ragged clothes, with patch upon patch, which probably weren't washed even once in several decades; yet they didn't smell of sweat or dirt. Was it that I had no clothes to wear? Not necessarily; it's just that I liked wearing old clothes. Because of this, some people spread a rumor that when I went to take a bus, the driver saw how ragged my clothes were and how bad I smelled and wouldn't let me get on the bus. As for food, I don't tell anyone what I'd like to eat either—unless there's a special situation where I need to take some medicine; that can be mentioned. Apart from that, many people want to buy things for me and ask me, "What do you need? What would you like to eat?" I always say that I eat everything and I eat nothing. I've never said you must give me something—never.

09. Organizing the Refugee Monks

In the late 1940s, as the situation on the Chinese mainland was in turmoil and transition, monks from the north moved south and gathered in the tiny territory of Hong Kong. In 1951, the Venerable Master served as chairman of the Fellowship Association of Mainland Chinese Monastics in Hong Kong and was responsible for conducting a full count of the mainland monastics staying in Hong Kong...

Historical background:

In 1939, the Second World War began. In 1941, Japan made a surprise attack on Pearl Harbor and launched war in Southeast Asia; in the same year Hong Kong, after surrendering on December 25, was occupied by Japan. Hong Kong was under occupation for three years and eight months, and many Hong Kong monastics fled as refugees to the interior of China. In August 1945, the Second World War ended, and Hong Kong remained a British colony. In May 1948, the National Government was formally reorganized as the Government of the Republic of China. On November 22, the first phase of the Huaihai Campaign in the civil war between the Nationalists and the Communists ended in a great victory for the Communist army. In July 1949, the armed forces of the Republic of China began withdrawing from the mainland to Taiwan, and most of the mainland was occupied by the Communists. On October 1, the People's Republic of China was founded, and on December 7, the Government of the Republic of China moved its capital from Chengdu, Sichuan, to the city of Taipei, Taiwan.

In the 1950s, postwar Hong Kong had huge numbers of destitute people without work, and it lacked natural resources; on top of that, refugees were pouring into Hong Kong at a rate of 100,000 a month, and the population problem became extremely serious.

During this period, large numbers of northern monastics came south to Hong Kong; Hong Kong people called it the period of the "southward migration of monks and nuns." Among the waves of monastics who came south, some came from the White Mountains (the Changbai Mountains) and the Black Waters (the Heilong River) and from both sides of the Great Wall, and others from north and south of the Yangtze, from Guangdong and Guangxi, from Hunan and Hubei, and elsewhere. Faced with monastics arriving from all over, some newly built viharas, quiet huts, and thatched huts in the outskirts of Hong Kong, as well as wooden houses built by local Buddhists, became places where the refugee monastics could lodge. The place with the largest number of lodging monastics was, first and foremost, Tung Po Tor Monastery in Tsuen Wan in the New Territories.

In the Venerable Master's own words:

At that time many of the monastics in Hong Kong were afraid of me; almost all of them had been scolded by me, because they didn't look after the refugee monks who had fled to Hong Kong. In Hong Kong I knew a Dharma Master Qing Yan. At that time I was chairman of the "Sangha Fellowship Association," and he helped out by running around everywhere; he was a very young monastic. Later he "ran off" first, in Taiwan [Tr.: i.e., he passed away], and Taiwan had another flesh-body Bodhisattva [Tr.: a monastic whose body remains incorrupt after death and is enshrined] appear. So if you apply effort in cultivation, whether you're young or old, you can accomplish the Way.

In Hong Kong there was once a little Arhat. He was a young monk who was smiling and cheerful from morning to night, and very innocent. When people made offerings to him, he wouldn't take them; or even if he accepted them, he would immediately give them away to someone else. So people gave him the name "Little Arhat." A person with real skill in cultivation, no matter how many days after death, remains sitting upright and dignified; his head will not droop.

In Hong Kong I helped a certain Dharma Master a great deal, yet he still undermined me to my face. I don't blame him. Later this man died of cancer. Before he died, he was still very concerned with saving face. He said that after he died, he too wanted to be seated in a vat [Tr.: the body is sealed upright in a large urn; if found incorrupt when the urn is reopened, it is gilded and enshrined] like Dharma Master Ci Hang, and when the vat was opened three years later, his remains should be gilded and covered in gold leaf. Unexpectedly, the day after he died, his head drooped. His disciples knew it wouldn't hold up and never dared to open the vat.

[Addendum 1] Taiwan's Second Flesh-Body Bodhisattva: Master Qing Yan, Who Manifested the Appearance of Illness and Suffering

Master Qing Yan (1924–1970) left the home-life at 12, received full ordination at 18, and at 22 served as guest prefect at Gude Monastery in Hankou. During the civil war between the Nationalists and the Communists, to escape the fighting, he made his way by a roundabout route to Tung Po Tor in Hong Kong at the age of 25. During his five years in Hong Kong, he took part in the affairs of the Fellowship Association of Mainland Monastics in Hong Kong, safeguarding the rights and interests of the monastic community. In the forty-third year of the Republic (1954) he went from Hong Kong to Taiwan, finally taking up residence at Haizang Monastery in Xindian, and he manifested stillness at the age of 47. A month before entering perfect stillness, he instructed his disciples to keep him seated in a vat for six years. In the sixty-fifth year of the Republic (1976), the vat was opened in public: his flesh body was intact, his features majestic, and his kashaya [Tr.: the monastic precept sash worn over the robe] undamaged. It caused a sensation in society at the time. Afterward the body was gilded, and to this day it remains seated, presiding over Haizang Monastery. During his 15 years in Taiwan, Master Qing Yan constantly manifested the appearance of illness and suffering. In ordinary circumstances he honed his integrity; content in poverty and delighting in the Way, he remained the same for decades, as if it were a single day. He said, "Illness and suffering spur me on so that I dare not slacken." The more seriously ill he became, the more vigorous his practice grew; he was always reciting with his mouth, bowing with his body, and praying with his mind to Guanshiyin Bodhisattva. His famous saying was: "Don't fear having no temple; fear only not accomplishing the Way."

[Addendum 2] In 1951, Dharma Master Meng Sheng was the first chairman of the Fellowship Association of Mainland Chinese Monastics in Hong Kong. That year, in order to conduct a count of the mainland monastics staying in Hong Kong, the Venerable Master compiled the *Membership Roster of the Fellowship Association of Mainland Chinese Monastics in Hong Kong*; not long afterward, the Venerable Master took over the post of chairman.

10. A Ghost Who Knew "Four and Six"

The Venerable Master's virtuous conduct was revered by humans and gods alike; and such was his vow power that even ghosts and spirits begged to take refuge with him. Chen Ruichang was a well-known Hong Kong businessman. His niece had lost both her parents when she was little and had been raised by Mr. and Mrs. Chen Ruichang...

In the Venerable Master's own words:

If I told people to take refuge with me, someone might ask, "Are you qualified to be a teacher? Are you trying to take advantage of me, wanting to be my teacher so you can rank a generation above me?" Then what would I say? It's precisely because of this that I have never told anyone to take refuge with me. If I accept a refuge disciple but don't teach and transform him with the Proper Dharma and can't save him, I've let him down, and I would feel very ashamed. And if I do teach him with the Proper Dharma but he has no true sincerity and won't listen

to the teaching, what can I do about it? So I don't tell people to take refuge with me.

Now so many of you have taken refuge with me; ask yourselves, which one of you did I tell to come and take refuge with me? Even with those who want to take refuge with me, I have to examine them a bit. Sometimes there are so many people that I can't examine them all, so I'm a bit careless and just shut my eyes: "All right, everyone's approved!" In Manchuria and in Hong Kong, when I accepted refuge disciples, I would first talk with each person individually: why do you want to take refuge with me? And it wasn't just so with people; it was the same even with ghosts. Truly, in Hong Kong I accepted a ghost as a refuge disciple.

Many people in Hong Kong said that Dharma Master To Lun had the ability to catch ghosts; this is one of the stories behind that. This ghost—when you talk about it, it really was inconceivable! The niece of Chen Ruichang of the Daguang Company came down with a demonic illness: a ghost possessed her, making her go mad and act demonic, so that the whole household was in an uproar, with no peace even for the chickens and dogs.

Chen Ruichang invited seven monks to recite sutras; these monastics usually made their living by reciting sutras and performing Buddhist services. When they got there, they put on their robes and sashes, set out the *Vajra Sutra* and the Great Compassion Mantra on the table, and began to recite: "Na mo he la da nuo duo la ye ye, na mo e li ye..." From morning to night it was "Na mo, na mo, na mo"; they kept on "na mo"-ing without stopping. They recited the *Vajra Sutra*: "Thus I have heard. At one time the Buddha dwelt at Shravasti, in the Jeta Grove, in the Garden of the Benefactor of Orphans and the Solitary, together with a gathering of great Bhikshus, twelve hundred fifty in all. At that time, the World Honored One, at mealtime, put on his robe, took up his bowl, and entered the great city of Shravasti to beg for food. Having begged in sequence within the city, he returned to his own place. When he had finished eating, he put away his robe and bowl, washed his feet, arranged his seat, and sat down."

Strangely enough, when the monks recited the sutras, the ghost recited along with them. The people recited people's sutras, and the ghost recited ghost sutras. When you said, "arranged his seat, and sat down," she also said, "arranged his seat, and sat down"; every day she dueled with the Dharma Masters in a contest of powers. It got to where these seven monks had recited sutras for seven days and still couldn't get away; she had them at their wits' end, with no way at all to deal with her.

Among these seven monks was my Dharma nephew Heng Yue (a grand-disciple of Dharma Master Chang Yi). He said to Chen Ruichang, "If you want her to get well, you'll have to invite my Dharma uncle So-and-so here. He'll have a way!" The man believed what he said and ran off to Guanyin Cave to invite me.

Ever since I had withdrawn into seclusion at Guanyin Cave, I had been as if deaf and mute, as if dull and witless, single-mindedly cultivating the Way and paying

no attention to worldly affairs. So the first time they invited me, I didn't agree. They came a second time, and again I didn't agree. The third time he came to me, he knelt before me and wouldn't get up. Originally I didn't want to meddle in other people's business, but since he pleaded again and again, I said, "All right! You're so sincere. I'll go!"

When I got there, the patient was on the bed in the middle of a duel with the monks! When the monks recited sutras, she recited sutras; when the monks recited mantras, she recited mantras. She was swaying back and forth there, ever so full of herself! I sat down beside her bed and didn't recite any sutra; I just sat quietly beside the bed. After ten minutes, the patient—the person carrying the ghost, the ghost carrying the person—quietly got down off the bed, crawled over to me, and knelt in front of me. I asked her:

"Who are you?"

"I am a ghost."

"Why are you harassing this person?"

"Because I have an affinity with her from past lives."

I didn't say much at the time; I just took off the string of recitation beads I wore around my neck and slipped it over the patient's neck. Immediately she cried out:

"Aiya! Dharma Master! Spare me! I won't dare do it again."

"What's the matter with you?"

"I'm about to be burned to death by these recitation beads of yours."

"When I wear them, why don't they burn? Why do they burn when you wear them?"

"Dharma Master, please be compassionate and let me go! I really can't bear it!"

"What do you want?"

"I want to take refuge with you."

"You want to take refuge with me? These seven monks have recited sutras for you for seven or eight days; why didn't you take refuge with them? What do you want to take refuge with me for?"

"Them? Even if they took refuge with me, I wouldn't want them. I find them stinking!" You see, this ghost was that conceited. She also said she knew a certain elder Dharma Master. I said, "Since you know that elder Dharma Master, wouldn't it be good to take refuge with him? I don't even have a place of my own right now. What do you want to take refuge with me for?"

"I know him, but I can't take refuge with him. He isn't qualified to be my teacher either!"

"Then how am I qualified?"

"I've been searching for so many years, and it's you I've been looking for!"

"What are you looking for me for?"

"I just want to take refuge with you."

"What's the benefit of taking refuge with me?"

"Your vow power is great: you want every one of your refuge disciples to become a Buddha. Because you have this vow power, I've been looking for you for a long time. I must take refuge with you."

"All right then, if you take refuge with me, what about this patient's illness? Will she get well or not?"

"She'll get well right away!"

After this ghost took refuge with me, the patient got well too. The seven monks who were there all saw the whole thing with their own eyes. You see, even this ghost understood "four and six"! What is "four and six"? The "four" is the character for "father," which has four strokes; the "six" is the character for "mother," which has six strokes. So when we say someone doesn't understand "four and six," it means he doesn't even recognize his own father and mother. This ghost understood "four and six" and knew to take refuge.

Chen Ruichang had once vowed, "If my niece doesn't get well, I won't believe in Buddhism anymore!" Fortunately, his niece did get well afterward. It wasn't that I was afraid he would stop believing in Buddhism; rather, I saw how pitiful his niece was, so I made her well.

Today I'm not telling you this to show what abilities I have; I'm only relating a fact. After this ghost took refuge with me, the patient, once she was well, also asked to take refuge, and the patient's relatives followed suit and wanted to take refuge too. So this whole group of people took refuge; the whole family took refuge. So ghosts can introduce people to take refuge, and when people see a ghost take refuge, they get envious too: "I want to take refuge too!"

After Chen Ruichang's niece got well, the whole family believed in Buddhism; they even had their children take refuge with the Triple Jewel as soon as they were born, and hosted vegetarian meals. Every time a grandson or granddaughter was born, they would host a vegetarian meal for their Buddhist friends, starting a custom of not taking life for celebrations. From then on, I had a reputation for "catching ghosts," and many people in Hong Kong believed that this Dharma Master To Lun had the ability to catch ghosts. Some said I was a "Maoshan (old) Taoist" [Tr.: Maoshan Taoists are popularly known as exorcists and ghost-catchers]; in Malaysia, too, some people spread the word that I was an "Old Demon King," "one of the Five Great Oddities of Hong Kong." Whatever anyone calls me, I won't mind in the least; otherwise, how could I call myself a little ant, a little mosquito, a horse!

[Addendum 1] In 1971 the Venerable Master said: Chen Ruichang was one of my longtime refuge disciples. In August of this year he passed away and went to

rebirth in the Land of Ultimate Bliss. In the hospital he recited the Buddha's name every day; reciting and reciting, he fell asleep, and once asleep he passed away, without any great suffering.

[Addendum 2] Chen Ruichang saw that within half an hour of the Venerable Master's entering the room, his niece had returned to her former healthy, normal self, and he knew deeply that the Venerable Master was a true cultivator whose awesome virtue could subdue deviant demons; so he brought his whole family to take refuge with the Venerable Master. After that, every New Year, they respectfully asked the Venerable Master to write a New Year's blessing. One year Chen Ruichang's son didn't want the Venerable Master's blessing, and that year business was dismal. From then on they earnestly asked the Venerable Master to write a New Year's blessing every year; after the Venerable Master came to America, they even sent registered letters to America imploring him to write it.

11. Lecturing on the *Earth Store Sutra*

In November 1951, Upasaka Chen Ruichang and other lay Buddhists invited the Venerable Master to lecture on the *Earth Store Sutra* at Tung Sin Tan [Tr.: a Taoist hall of the Quanzhen school in Hong Kong] in Hong Kong. The Dharma banner was raised high and the door of expedient means was opened. He lectured for more than 40 days, and no fewer than a hundred faithful devotees came to listen every day.

In the Venerable Master's own words:

In the winter of 1951, the lay Buddhists Luo Guo Ming, Chen Guo Fa, Yuan Guo Lin (Mrs. Chen Ruichang), Tang Guo Shan, Mai Guo Lian, and others acted as sponsors and invited me to lecture on the *Earth Store Sutra* at Tung Sin Tan. The following autumn I lectured on the *Vajra Sutra* there, and I also lectured on the *Amitabha Sutra* at Po Kok Monastery.

You all know that I am always lecturing on the sutras, because if I don't lecture on the sutras, I can't go on living. So as long as I have a breath left, I will lecture on the sutras; only when this breath is cut off will I stop. If you ask, "Can you lecture?" I can't. I can't lecture, but I practice lecturing; I'm learning to lecture. In Hong Kong there were people spreading the word: "Him, lecture on the sutras? He can't even read; how could he lecture on the sutras?" When I lectured on the sutras in Taiwan, there were also people who said this about me: "He can't even read; how can he lecture on the sutras? Don't go and listen!" When you tell people not to go and listen, they get all the more curious and all the more want to see what sutra this illiterate Dharma Master is lecturing on. I find it strange myself: "I can't even read, so why do I lecture on the sutras?"

My handwriting isn't good either. Although some people see that the Master's handwriting isn't good, they still want to keep it to sell as an antique in the future. I'll tell you very frankly and clearly: I don't like to write letters, because, first, I'm busy, and second, I think my handwriting isn't good, and I don't want

my handwriting to become antiques in the future. During the more than ten years I lived in Hong Kong, many monastics said I couldn't read, and I admitted that I couldn't read; I can't read, but I'm willing to learn. Although this prajna of written words [Tr.: wisdom conveyed through language and texts, as distinct from the wisdom of direct realization] isn't the real thing, you still need to know a little of it.

Don't think that whatever I say is right; there may be mistakes in what I say. Why? Because before I lecture on a sutra, I haven't even read it through once. Now in America I'm lecturing on the *Avatamsaka Sutra* for you, and this is the first time I've held the *Avatamsaka Sutra* in my hands to read it. Although I held an "Avatamsaka session" [Tr.: a session devoted to reciting the *Avatamsaka Sutra*] at the Buddhist Lecture Hall in Hong Kong, where everyone recited the *Avatamsaka Sutra* for 21 days, at the time I was busy managing affairs, and in those 21 days I didn't read a single word. So I have never read the *Avatamsaka Sutra*, nor have I recited it. Generally speaking, before lecturing on a sutra, a Dharma Master reads the commentaries, and after reading the commentaries he reads the sutra text, studying it back and forth many times. I haven't read it once, haven't recited it once, and haven't studied the commentaries either, so the principles I explain may be wrong or mistaken in places. Why? Simply because I'm very foolish, and I don't necessarily understand all the principles the Buddha spoke.

All of you are wise people, especially the young wise ones, whose wisdom is who knows how many tens of millions of feet higher than mine. Even if what I say isn't right, I have at least cleared this wasteland for you, so that you can plant it and till it yourselves. Where what I say is right, put it into practice; where it isn't right, you can correct it with your own true wisdom.

[Addendum] Upasika Tan Guo Zheng recounted:

At that time my family didn't have any real religious faith. Although I attended a Catholic English-medium school, nothing the Bible said could make me believe enough to be baptized a Catholic. My father, Tan Pucai (Dharma name Guo Pu), didn't have any particular religious faith either, but he liked to go to Tung Sin Tan. At that time many businessmen took part in the Taoist group at Tung Sin Tan, and my father often went too. He was over 70 then, and I usually went with him to Tung Sin Tan, but I always stayed outside on the veranda, because they burned so much incense inside that it was very smoky, and I had no interest in what they did there.

In the winter of 1951, Upasaka Chen Ruichang invited the Master to explain the *Earth Store Sutra*. Upasaka Chen had a shop selling fabric; his family lived on the second floor, and on the third floor there was a small loft, where the Master stayed. I didn't attend the Master's lectures on the *Earth Store Sutra*, because I had always been indifferent to what went on at Tung Sin Tan. When the Master was lecturing on the *Earth Store Sutra* at Tung Sin Tan, Cai Guo Su, who was 14 or 15, saw the Dharma seat emitting light that illuminated the entire hall, and

she also saw many other states. The Master said she had come from the heavens, and that was why she had the heavenly eye.

12. Taoist Friends Take Refuge

Tung Sin Tan was founded in 1938 and is dedicated to Patriarch Lü Chunyang; belief in Taoism is the foremost condition for a disciple to join. Its aim is "to propagate Taoism and carry out charitable activities for society." At that time the Taoist members would invite spirits to descend to the altar...

In the winter of 1951, while the Venerable Master was lecturing on the *Earth Store Sutra* at Tung Sin Tan, a planchette message from Patriarch Lü encouraged the faithful to take refuge with the Triple Jewel. The message read:

> *I wish to speak the Dharma for the people of the world;*
> *To discuss the sutras and recite the Buddha's name is right and fitting.*
> 願與世人來說法 談經念佛理所宜
>
> *With body and mind, too, exhort and transform;*
> *Cultivate merit within—it is good to take refuge.*
> 亦要身心來勸化 內修功果好皈依

In the Venerable Master's own words:

Lü Dongbin is generally called Patriarch Lü. In Taoism, Patriarch Lü is worshipped. Actually, who is this Patriarch Lü? He is Guanshiyin Bodhisattva. Guanshiyin Bodhisattva manifests as Patriarch Lü to save these old Taoists. Why did he then take refuge with the Triple Jewel? This was returning home and acknowledging his ancestors. You could also say that he went into Taoism and manifested as an old Taoist in order to "cast out a brick to draw forth jade"; in reality, he was also opening the way for Buddhism.

[Addendum 1] Upasaka Tan Guo Pu recounted in his article "Starting from How I Came to Study Buddhism":

It was the first month of winter in the year Xinmao (the tenth lunar month of 1951). Because I revered the Ancestral Teacher, Patriarch Lü Chunyang, I often visited the Tung Sin Taoist altar. It so happened that Upasaka Chen Ruichang had invited Dharma Master To Lun, the Venerable Master, a native of Jilin in Manchuria, to come to the altar to expound the *Sutra of the Past Vows of Earth Store Bodhisattva*. Having heard the essentials of the Dharma, I suddenly awakened to the compassion of the Buddha's Way; deeply moved in my heart, I thereupon took refuge with the Triple Jewel.

[Addendum 2] Tung Sin Tan originated from Qingyun Cave at Chashan in Nanhai, Guangdong. It belongs to the Quanzhen school of Taoism and venerates Patriarch Lü Chunyang as its principal deity. In 1938, several disciples of Qingyun Cave at Chashan in Nanhai came to Hong Kong to do business, and, for the convenience of cultivating their minds and natures, they enshrined the Ancestral Teacher, Patriarch Lü, in a private residence in Central, naming it "Qunxian Tan" (Altar of the Assembled Worthies). It was later renamed "Tung

Sin Tan of Chashan Qingyun Cave in Hong Kong." Its original site was on Gage Street in Central; in the 1960s it moved to Wellington Street.

[Addendum 3] From the diary of Upasika Tan Guo Zheng:

At that time the Taoist members of Tung Sin Tan would invite spirits to descend to the altar and would practice divination and planchette writing [Tr.: spirit writing, in which characters traced by a medium's stylus are believed to come from a deity]. The medium supported with the fingers the underside of the top crossbar of a T-shaped implement, and it would write characters in a tray of sand by itself; a person standing by would read them aloud, and the spirit's predictions were written down. By the time my father saw this poem, it was already the last day of the sutra lectures. That day my father had me copy this poem from the register of planchette messages. Each line of this poem began with a number, from one to ten. The last line, "Cultivate merit within—it is good to take refuge," exhorted the disciples of Tung Sin Tan to take refuge with the Triple Jewel. After my father saw this poem, he decided to go and see the Master, and I reluctantly went along with him.

I saw that this monk, in his tattered, patched robe, compassionate yet stern, was clearly as different as heaven and earth from the monks I had seen before, and different too from all the Catholic priests and nuns I had met. The Master's bearing revealed an extraordinary dignity that inspired admiration. At that time the Master gave me a copy of the *Earth Store Sutra*, and from that day on I felt differently about Buddhism. I read the *Earth Store Sutra* with great energy; even at mealtimes I couldn't bear to put it down for a moment. I didn't understand myself why I had suddenly become interested in believing in Buddhism.

On the fifteenth day of the third lunar month of 1952, my mother and I took refuge together; my mother's Dharma name was Gan Guo Yan. Later my younger sister Tan Mujie (Tan Guo Shi), my younger brother Tan Qiaojian (Tan Guo Xing), and my youngest sister Tan Muyan (Tan Guo An) all took refuge with the Master. Except for my elder brother, who followed Esoteric Buddhism, our whole family took refuge with the Venerable Master. I didn't take refuge because my father had taken refuge; I took refuge because of the teachings of Buddhism.

At the Catholic school there were catechism classes and Bible classes. I had asked the nuns who taught us many questions, and none of them could answer. After meeting the Master, I found that the teachings of Buddhism were very different: everyone can become a Buddha.

The Master once hoped I would write an account of how my father came to take refuge, but I didn't want to write it and said to the Master, "Better to hide my clumsiness than to put my poor skills on display." The Master said, "Why are you attached to the mark of self? If everyone thought the way you do, wouldn't it mean no one would write articles? Lately few people submit articles to the Buddhist magazines; I hope those of you who can write will write more articles."

Looking back, there are truly so many of the Master's teachings that I failed to follow!

[Addendum 4] Upasika Tan Guo Shi recounted:

My Dharma name is Guo Shi, but the Master always called me Mujie. I was able to meet the Master because of my father. Tung Sin Tan invited some businessmen to join, and my father was one of its members. This group often donated money to help the poor, giving out food, medicine, and other daily necessities in relief. My father had read many classical books and works on Chinese medicine. When he heard the Master lecture on the *Earth Store Sutra* at Tung Sin Tan, he found that the Master was so young and yet so learned. The faithful of Tung Sin Tan all revered the Master, something that had never happened before. At the time the Master was only just over 30, and about 10 to 15 Taoist believers took refuge with the Master; my father, then in his seventies, was one of them.

My father, Tan Pucai, was a man of letters who delighted in doing good and giving generously. During the Second World War, he sold off family property and bought rice to give out as porridge, saving the lives of the whole village. He also built a school in the village and ran education there. Perhaps because the villagers respected my father, during the Cultural Revolution both the school and our family house remained completely intact. My father had a certain reputation in the business world; that he could take as his teacher someone younger than his own son, humbly accepting instruction, was very rare. After taking refuge, his Dharma name was Guo Pu, and his name can often be seen at the DRBA Way-places in Hong Kong. In the early records of the Master's life, he wrote a preface, expressing how fortunate he felt that, at nearly 80, he had been able to meet such a great and noble teacher.

I remember that I was in primary school then. He came back from Tung Sin Tan and told my mother in high spirits, "Do you know? I have a teacher now." My mother said, "You're so old, so your teacher must be even older." "No, my teacher is very young. He's even younger than our eldest son!" "Really?" "Yes, I think he's 30-something at most." "How could you take such a young person as your teacher? What could he know?" My father said, "You're wrong! If you had heard him lecture on the sutras, you would know that he's a monk of vast learning and dignified bearing. At my age I've never met anyone so young and so learned, so I took him as my teacher. In a couple of days I'll take you to pay your respects to him, and you'll see that what I've told you is right!"

13. A Life Extended by Twelve Years

One of the legendary anecdotes of the Venerable Master's time in Hong Kong is that he used the "Jeweled Seal Hand," one of Guanshiyin Bodhisattva's Forty-two Hands and Eyes [Tr.: 42 practices, each a hand gesture with its own mantra, in the Great Compassion Mantra tradition], to lengthen the life of the elderly Upasaka Tan Guo Pu...

In the Venerable Master's own words:

I've done many very important things that nobody knows anything about, and if I told about them, nobody would believe me. Among the immortals of old there was a seal called the "Heaven-Overturning Seal"; Guangchengzi [Tr.: a legendary Taoist immortal] had one. In Taoism it's called the "Heaven-Overturning Seal"; with Guanshiyin Bodhisattva it's called the Jeweled Seal Hand. If you have this Jeweled Seal Hand, the gods in the heavens all obey your commands, and King Yama and the ghost kings in the hells also obey your commands; it has the wondrous function of bringing the dead back to life. If you can't perfect it, though, it's of no great use. Someone heard me say the Jeweled Seal Hand had such great benefits and thought, "I'll hurry and perfect this Jeweled Seal Hand. When someone is about to die, I'll stamp him with it once and not let him die!" You can do that. But when your own life comes to an end, there won't be anyone who can use this seal to save you.

I've used this seal twice, when I had no choice: once in Manchuria and once in Hong Kong. What does "had no choice" mean? It means this thing had to be done; I couldn't not do it. Who was it in Hong Kong? It was the father of Madelena (Tan Guo Shi). Her father was 79 that year, and the fortune-tellers who read his birth chart all said he was certain to die. He asked me, "Shifu, can you let me live ten more years? Because my children are still young. If I can live ten more years, I'll be completely content." I said, "All right, it can be done! Not just ten years: I'll let you live 12 more years. How's that?" "Of course that's good!" Afterward he did indeed live 12 more years; he died at 91.

[Addendum 1] Upasika Tan Guo Shi recounted:

My father's request came after Western Bliss Gardens had been built, and I was there at the time. Because my father was old, climbing up to Western Bliss Gardens was very tiring for him. When he sat down on a small wooden stool to rest and talked with the Master, I was standing right beside them.

Actually, how my father came to ask the Master to lengthen his life began with his asking the Master whether he should return to America to live out the rest of his years. My father was a Chinese American with U.S. citizenship who had come back to Hong Kong to do business for my mother's sake. If he returned to America, he could take all of us to America with him, so he told the Master about this idea and asked for the Master's guidance. The Master asked my father, "Would your life in America be as comfortable as in Hong Kong?" "Of course not. Hiring help in America is very expensive!" "Then why go back? Children and grandchildren have their own blessings; why be a horse or an ox for them? If your children have the affinity, they will go there someday." "Actually, I'm already very content. Although I'm not greatly wealthy, I have a driver and servants, and business is doing all right. My only worry is that my daughters are still young. If I could live ten more years and see my children grow up, I would be completely content!"

[Addendum 2] From the diary of Upasika Tan Guo Zheng:

After my father took refuge at 77, he said to the Master, "Shifu, I'm going to die soon!" Earlier, my father had told the Master that at around 30 he had already died once. His family had laid him out in the main hall for several days, dressed him in burial clothes, and were preparing to choose a day to bury him. Without his realizing it, my father's spirit encountered my great-grandfather, who asked him, "Why have you come here? Go back, go back! You should come only when you reach my age." As a result, my father actually came back to life. My father remembered that my great-grandfather had passed away at 89.

[Addendum 3] Upasika Tan Guo Shi recounted:

At the end of 1993, my mother, then in her eighties, suddenly fell ill. Both her thighs were in unbearable pain; she couldn't move, let alone walk. Every night she had nightmares and cried out and shouted, constantly yelling that people had come to collect debts from her, yet she didn't recognize those people. We sought out all the famous doctors of Chinese and Western medicine and tried acupuncture as well, but none of the various methods worked. In the end we decided to phone the Master for help. That very day (in 1994), the Master and Dharma Master Heng Lai came to our home. The Master told us that these were karmic creditors come to collect their debts. Besides doing meritorious deeds on my mother's behalf, one of her descendants also had to resolve to become vegetarian, and we were to recite "Namo Greatly Compassionate Guanshiyin Bodhisattva" for her and recite Guanyin's ten great vows in the Great Compassion Mantra, "I vow to quickly know all dharmas..." If we did this, my mother would still have 11 years of life. We did everything as the Master instructed, and two or three months later my mother's legs suddenly no longer hurt very much, and she gradually became able to get up and walk. She told us about her nightmares: "I saw a monster with nine heads and many tails, and there were many chains on the hands and feet. Suddenly all of it disappeared!" From then on my mother's life was extended by 11 years, until she passed away in 2004.

Part Two: Building Monasteries and Propagating the Dharma

Ages 34 to 36

1951 to 1953 CE

14. Clearing Dry Land

In 1951, during the time that Tung Sin Tan in Hong Kong had invited the Venerable Master to lecture on the *Earth Store Sutra*, no fewer than a hundred people came every day to hear the sutra. After the lectures concluded in the first ten days of the twelfth lunar month, several lay Buddhists proposed building a vihara for the Venerable Master...

The causes and conditions for choosing land and building the vihara came together very quickly. Before long, someone reported that on the ridge above Ma Shan Village at Sai Wan Ho in Shau Kei Wan, Hong Kong, there was a piece of wasteland (Editor's note: after the Japanese surrender, much government-owned public land was left unmanaged; at the time such land was called "overlord land," and private persons could borrow it temporarily) measuring some several dozen square feet. The drawback, however, was that there was no water source on the mountain. One had to rely on the public "street hydrant" beside the road at the foot of the mountain, that is, draw water from the public tap-water pipe on the street, and then carry the water on shoulder poles up several hundred stone steps to the top. The mountain path was steep and rugged, so one can imagine how hard it was!

In the Venerable Master's own words: Not long after, my neighbor at Guanyin Cave, the Dharma Master, didn't welcome my living in the thatched hut and persuaded the people of Fu Yung Shan to move me out, so I moved to Ma Shan Village in Shau Kei Wan and built a small Buddha hall on the mountain. Western Bliss Gardens used to be a piece of mountain land; to get up there you had to climb more than 300 stone steps, and there was no water on the mountain either. Although there was no water, I felt that a small Way-place could be built there.

[Addendum 1] Upasika Tan Guo Shi recounted:

A reporter who had not originally believed in Buddhism told the Master that up on the mountain there was a piece of public land where a small temple could be built, except that it was in a poor district and had no water source. The Master said, "Let's go and take a look!" After seeing it, the Master paid the rent and obtained the right to use it. Not long after, my father took my mother and my elder sister to pay their respects to the Master. I didn't go, because at that time I was attending primary school at a Christian school, and I thought that believing in Buddhism was something only ignorant people did, and that monastics did nothing more than rush from one sutra recitation and repentance

rite to the next. After meeting the Master, my mother and elder sister decided to take the Master as their teacher.

[Addendum 2] From the diary of Upasika Tan Guo Zheng:

In Hong Kong there was a reporter who specialized in reporting news of the religious world; monks and Taoists alike all had to stay on his good side. The Master said, "Even so, if it weren't for him, Buddhism in Hong Kong might not have flourished as it has, so his merit and virtue toward Buddhism is great. If his circumstances were ever bad, it would be only right for Buddhism to support his whole family." The Master's extraordinary breadth of mind filled me with heartfelt admiration.

15. Western Bliss Gardens Monastery

The construction of Western Bliss Gardens Monastery, from the initial planning and design through the supervision of the building work, was handled entirely by the Venerable Master himself. Throughout, the Venerable Master held firmly to his principles: he did not scheme for support, he refused to print notices appealing for funds, and still less did he go from door to door seeking donations to cover the costs...

In the last days of the twelfth lunar month of the xinmao year (late January 1952), the vihara was completed. The Venerable Master named it "Western Bliss Gardens Monastery," and the Three Tathagatas were enshrined there. In August 1984, the Hong Kong government requisitioned the land of Western Bliss Gardens, and the Venerable Master handed it over to the government unconditionally; the Buddha images and memorial tablets were moved to Cixing Monastery (known locally as Tsz Hing Monastery). High-rise buildings have now been built on the original site.

In the Venerable Master's own words:

When Western Bliss Gardens was being built, I was lecturing on the *Earth Store Sutra*: I lectured on the *Earth Store Sutra* from seven to nine every evening. I was living in Central, and every day I went over twice to see how the construction was coming along. It was a half-hour ride from Central to Shau Kei Wan, so the round trip took an hour. Once there, I also lent a hand with the work, because I had watched so much construction that I could tell at a glance how a job should be done. So I became an engineer and graduated without ever having to go to school! It isn't only me who is willing to work for a Way-place like this. The great Good and Wise Advisors of the past did the same. Take Elder Hsu: when he built monasteries, he too went to the work site every day to see how the construction was going. He would put away even a single piece of timber and save it to be used later. No material of any kind was ever carelessly wasted.

[Addendum 1] Bhikshuni Dharma Master Heng Yi recounted on September 25, 2000:

Building Western Bliss Gardens back then was very hard. At the time there were just two people, Dharma Master Heng Ding and Dharma Master Heng Yue, plus one refuge disciple, and two workers were hired to help.

Bhikshuni Dharma Master Heng Yi's oral account, given on January 7, 2001:

It wasn't easy for the Master to build a monastery! Back when Western Bliss Gardens was being renovated, every day there was more work than could ever be finished. The nails in those boards were all hammered straight by the Master, one by one, and used again. Not the tiniest bit was wasted.

[Addendum 2] Upasika Mei Miaoling recounted:

When I was little, it was always my mother (Yuan Guo Zhen) who carried me up the mountain on her back. It was a long way, and every round trip took a whole day. At that time the Master had taken in two monastic disciples, Guo Liang and Guo Li.

[Addendum 3] Upasika Tan Guo Shi recounted:

Because my father was already quite old when I was born, I was frail and sickly from childhood, and every time I fell ill I would say strange, peculiar things. My health was always my parents' greatest worry. So my father gave me a piece of ancient dragon jade to wear to ward off evil, as protection. One night I came down with a high fever all over my body and kept saying that there were lots of people (ghosts) in the house: some were laughing, and some were doing weird things. My mother was terrified, and the whole family was kept from sleeping. When I woke up the next morning, that thick jade pendant had actually cracked. Although I was all right, my mother still couldn't wait to drag me off first thing in the morning to see the Master.

I remember that we climbed a great many stone steps to reach Western Bliss Gardens, passing many dilapidated thatched huts and little wooden shacks, and brushing shoulders along the way with ragged adults and children. I had never seen so many poor people. They all gave off the sour smell of people who had not bathed for a long time. That was my first trip to Western Bliss Gardens. When we finally made it up the mountain, I found that Western Bliss Gardens at that time was a very crude house with a roof of sheet iron. When the weather was hot, it was like an oven inside; when it rained you could hear the dripping, and it leaked too. Even ordinarily, inside the house you could still hear the sounds outside. The ground was covered everywhere with gravel. There was hardly anyone there; apart from the Master, there was only an old woman who did the cooking.

Before my father took the Master as his teacher, he often took us to Tung Lin Monastery in Tsuen Wan. I saw some monastics there, but none of them left any particular impression on me; the first monastic I truly met was the Master. The Master was sitting on a small wooden stool. At first I was a little afraid of him, because the Master's eyes were different from other people's. Being a chatterbox, I asked the Master, "Shifu, what's wrong with your eyes? It seems

you can't look straight at people." The Master told me how he had read the *Dharma Flower Sutra* until his eyes bled, and that moved me deeply. My mother told the Master about my condition, saying, "This is my youngest daughter. She is always seeing unclean things. Shifu, can you help her? Has something attached itself to her?" The Master smiled and said to me, "It's nothing. Go home and recite the Buddha's name diligently; recite 'Namo Greatly Kind, Greatly Compassionate Guanshiyin Bodhisattva,' and you'll get better! Recite 'Namo Greatly Kind, Greatly Compassionate Guanshiyin Bodhisattva' every day; you must keep it up day after day." Still uneasy, my mother said, "That's all it takes? Will just doing that be enough?" From that day on, I have constantly recited the holy name of Namo Greatly Kind, Greatly Compassionate Guanshiyin Bodhisattva.

The Master asked whether my Chinese was very good, and I said yes. The Master said, "Then I'll give you some books to take home and read." Then the Master gave me three books: one was the *Wonderful Dharma Lotus Flower Sutra*, one was the *Sixth Patriarch's Dharma Jewel Platform Sutra*, and the other was *Records of the Life of Elder Master Hsu Yun*. The Master said, "I'm giving you these three books. You must read them properly; you mustn't take them home and toss them aside. I'm going to test you. How long will it take you to finish them? How about a month?" "That's enough! No problem!" I had always been competitive, and my memory was excellent: when the teacher had us memorize texts, I only had to read them or hear them once to remember them. I had no idea that what the Master had given me were such profound scriptures. That is how I first met the Master.

In the blink of an eye the month was up, and I took the three books and ran up to Western Bliss Gardens to report back to the Master. The Master asked me, "Are you ready?" I said, "Ready!" The Master asked which book I liked best. Of course it was *Records of the Life of Elder Master Hsu Yun*. It was in comic-strip form, so you could guess the content just by looking at the pictures; the edition I read was thread-bound. The *Dharma Flower Sutra* was the hardest; I did not understand that scripture as well as I understood the *Sixth Patriarch Sutra*. The Master said, "All right! Then let's have a test on the *Sixth Patriarch Sutra*." With him asking and me answering, I passed that test.

The Master then explained a good deal of the principles in the sutras, especially the meaning of the lines in the *Sixth Patriarch Sutra*, "Produce a thought that dwells nowhere," and "Not thinking of good, not thinking of evil, at just this moment, what is the Senior Monk Ming's original face?" At the time I only half understood what I heard. The Master also had me recite the Great Compassion Mantra and the Shurangama Mantra. Although I had not taken refuge then, the Master gave me a whole new understanding of Buddhism, so whenever I had free time I would go to see the Master, listen to his stories of his days in Manchuria, and study classical Chinese with him, and my health gradually got better.

In 1994, when the Master's health was very weak, I went to Los Angeles to see him. Many people had heard my name but had never met me, and the Master introduced me to them, saying, "She has been my disciple since she was 11. She grew up under my wing!"

16. A Clear Spring Wells Up from the Rock

Because there was no source of water near Western Bliss Gardens Monastery, water became an urgent problem. After the Venerable Master moved into Western Bliss Gardens Monastery, he prayed before the Buddhas and Bodhisattvas, asking them to grant a spring of sweet water. Later, beneath the rock face behind the monastery, the Venerable Master found a crack...

In the Venerable Master's own words:

Before Western Bliss Gardens was built, this place was originally a big pit 7 or 8 feet deep; only after it was filled in could the Way-place be built. At first there was no water on the mountain, but after the little Buddha hall was finished, a rock behind the house unexpectedly split open with a crack, and a trickle of clear spring water came flowing out of the crack. Up on that mountain, drinking water was like consuming oil; it was even more expensive than oil. Suddenly there was water, and the neighbors from all around came over to grab it. The buckets were lined up one after another, dozens of buckets set out there waiting: only when this one was full was it taken away, and then that one would be pushed forward. There were lots of them and only one of me. I couldn't beat them in a fight, and I couldn't out-argue them either: they all spoke Cantonese, and back then I didn't understand what they were saying. They filled and filled and filled... and then suddenly the water stopped coming. With no water, they stopped coming. Once I had fenced it in all around with wire mesh, the water came back, and they could no longer grab it. From then on, even at Dharma assemblies when there were lots of people, there was always enough water.

One year, Hong Kong went more than half a year without rain, and there was water rationing every day. "Water rationing" meant you could only use water for one hour a day, and very little water could be collected in that hour; after that, the water was cut off. There was no water anywhere, but on my mountain there was water. Some people said I had brought this water from Fu Yung Shan, because when I lived at Guanyin Cave, the two pools in front of the cave were full every day, and ever since I moved away, those two pools had dried up. Western Bliss Gardens originally had no water, yet now it had water. Could it be that I really did move the water here? Because I have disciples who are dragons, there was bound to be a response. All of this was a response from the Buddhas and Bodhisattvas, a manifestation of the protection of the gods and dragons!

(Editor's note: The following is excerpted from the Venerable Master's *Simple Explanation of the "Worthy Leader Chapter" of the Avatamsaka Sutra*, dated August 1975, when Guo Tong asked the Venerable Master:)

Guo Tong: The mountain where Shifu built the monastery was all hard rock. Other people said it was a very good place, but there was no water, so what could be done? Would we have to go down the mountain to fetch water? Then Shifu stuck a piece of bamboo into a crack in the rock...

The Venerable Master: No, no! No take bamboo. (I didn't use any bamboo.)

Guo Tong: Did you use something else?

The Venerable Master: No, no other thing. (I didn't use anything.)

Guo Tong: Then you just went to crack in the rock? (So you just made a crack right in the rock?)

The Venerable Master: That's how he wrote it (referring to the *Records of the Venerable Master*), and it isn't right! There was no bamboo. So you people keep "putting a head on top of a head" [Tr.: a Chan expression for adding something superfluous]: there was no such thing, and you've made something up. No bamboo, don't have bamboo. It's these people don't understand this. Not true, no bamboo, no any bamboo, no any stick. (There was no bamboo; they don't know. That isn't true! There wasn't any bamboo, and there wasn't any stick either.)

[Addendum 1] Upasika Tan Guo Shi recounted:

When the water first came, there was no bamboo; only later was a piece of bamboo inserted to let the water flow into the pool.

[Addendum 2] Upasaka Huang Guo Jun recounted:

This pool was very strange. Normally it stayed 70 to 80 percent full. When there were lots of people, with several hundred people at a Dharma assembly using the water, it never ran out; and when there were few people, the water never overflowed either. At the time there was an elderly Upasika named Guo Ping who lived at Western Bliss Gardens to help out; she was in charge of cleaning and odd jobs. The Master said to Guo Ping, "Don't go cleaning the pool whenever you feel like it! Before you clean the pool, you must tell me first." One day Guo Ping saw that there was a lot of moss in the pool and couldn't resist cleaning it, and after that the pool dried up. The Master said, "Guo Ping, now there's no water, and you're responsible! Go pray to Guanshiyin Bodhisattva and ask for the water to come back." Guo Ping was very honest. She spent the whole night in the Buddha hall reciting the Great Compassion Mantra and reciting Guanyin Bodhisattva's name. The next day the pool had water again, and the Master said to everyone, "This water was brought back by Guo Ping's prayers!"

[Addendum 3] As recorded in *Looking Out at the World* (Fangyan Guan Shijie) on September 18, 1978:

After the meal, we all went together to visit Western Bliss Gardens, the first Way-place the Venerable Master built after coming out to Hong Kong. Western Bliss Gardens is located on the ridge above Ma Shan Village in Shau Kei Wan. The slope is steep and the path winding, and only after climbing more than 300

stone steps do you arrive. The Venerable Master insisted on climbing the mountain with us. Our party of more than ten, men and women, old and young, made several large loops around the mountainside, and the older ones were all panting for breath. Seeing the Venerable Master's resolute, unyielding spirit, undaunted by hardship and striding forward just like us young people, gave us a kind of wordless teaching and encouragement.

All along the way we saw scenes of withered poverty: dilapidated wooden-hut settlements all around, a desolate expanse. After walking for about 20 minutes, we rounded a bend and came into a hollow in a small mountain recess, and we had reached Western Bliss Gardens. As we stepped through the little mountain gate, a fresh breeze came to greet us, and at once the summer heat was completely gone. In the garden, tree shadows swayed, clumps of bamboo moved in the wind, and moss lay in mottled patches: truly the serene stillness of "A winding path leads to a secluded spot; the meditation hall lies deep amid flowers and trees." The temple itself measured only 30 feet by 15 feet, with grayish-green tiles and plain cement walls, simple and unadorned, a "humble dwelling" in every sense of the word. Closing my eyes and gathering my thoughts, I faintly pictured the Venerable Master living quietly in his thatched hut in those days, and I could not help sighing softly. Though its outward form was dilapidated, his backbone and integrity remained and his joy was undiminished; dwelling hidden in the mountains, beyond worldly things, with his nature kept whole, he was truly "poor in body but not poor in the Way"!

Having heard so many stories about Western Bliss Gardens, we all wanted to see that natural spring. Walking to the back of the temple, we found a wooden frame about 3 feet square enclosing a rock on all sides, and a pool of clear spring water welling up from the rock. The water was as clear as a mirror. I scooped up a few mouthfuls in my hands and found it pure, sweet, and delicious, and of course the dusty toil and stifling heat we had brought from the city vanished completely.

17. The Opening-the-Light Ceremony

On May 1, 1952 (the eighth day of the fourth lunar month), Western Bliss Gardens Monastery, the first Way-place the Venerable Master built in Hong Kong with his own toil-worn hands and feet, held its Opening-the-Light ceremony [Tr.: a consecration ceremony that formally installs Buddha images and invites the Buddhas' presence into them]...

Material goods at the new monastery were extremely scarce; food, bowls, plates, and other utensils were all lacking, so at the Opening-the-Light ceremony the assembly was served tea and peanuts.

In the Venerable Master's own words: Western Bliss Gardens cultivated the Pure Land Dharma-door, so the first line of the couplet was "Recite Amitabha Buddha's name, and from here one realizes the Three Classes and Nine Grades." In the Land of Ultimate Bliss there are three classes: the upper class, the middle

class, and the lower class; and nine grades: upper-upper, upper-middle, and upper-lower; the middle grades: middle-upper, middle-middle, and middle-lower; and the lower grades: lower-upper, lower-middle, and lower-lower. Once you reach the Land of Ultimate Bliss, even the lower-lower grade counts as having ended birth and death, but you still have to wait 91 great kalpas before becoming a Buddha. That is why it says that by reciting Amitabha Buddha's name one can realize the Three Classes and Nine Grades. The second line was "Cultivate the paramita dharmas, and from this the Six Perfections and myriad practices are perfected." Paramita here means the six paramitas. This was the first couplet I wrote after coming to Hong Kong.

I had a refuge disciple in Hong Kong, Luo Guo Ming, whose arm often hurt terribly. She asked me what she should do to get better. I said, "Do some merit and virtue! Do a bit more merit and virtue and you'll get better." At that time the monastery was holding its Opening-the-Light ceremony, and the basins, the bowls, and the vegetables were all bought by her. After the Opening of the Light, she said, "This arm of mine still hurts so much I can't move it." I said, "Lift your arm forward." With just that one sentence, without doing anything else, her arm got better right away, and the ailment was gone. So sometimes things are truly inconceivable!

[Addendum 1] Upasaka Tan Guo Pu recounted in his essay "Starting from How I Came to Study Buddhism":

In the twelfth month of that year (the twelfth lunar month of the xinmao year, December 28, 1951 to January 26, 1952), the lay devotees, wishing to support and protect the Proper Dharma, pooled funds to build a Way-place. Choosing a site by divination on the summit of Ma Shan in Sai Wan Ho, they established Western Bliss Gardens and earnestly requested the Master to expound the holy teaching, to ferry across those lost at the ford, and to turn the Dharma wheel. The Master generously accepted the charge without declining. As for me, although I had not been studying Buddhism for long, I knew that Buddha images can cause those who see them to give rise to faith, to praise them and make offerings, and so to obtain immeasurable blessings. Therefore I asked craftsmen to sculpt with great care three golden bodies of the Tathagatas to be enshrined at Western Bliss Gardens, and from then on everything was complete. The fragrant light filled the hall; people bowed in repentance and cultivated purely, reciting the Buddha's name together.

[Addendum 2] From the diary of Upasika Tan Guo Zheng:

My father asked the Master, "The monastery is about to be finished. What do you think I should donate?" The Master said, "Most things have already been donated by others. You could donate three Buddha images." So my father donated them.

18. The Porcelain Image of Amitabha

The Venerable Master had an image of Amitabha Buddha. Because the Venerable Master bowed to it with utmost sincerity, the porcelain image gradually turned from snow-white to pale red, as lifelike as a real person. Between the Venerable Master and this image there was an inconceivable, wondrous affinity...

The Venerable Master was in closed retreat at Guanyin Cave for more than a year. Because he had nowhere to enshrine the Buddha image, he asked two Dharma Masters from a nearby monastery to keep it for him. When the Venerable Master decided to build Western Bliss Gardens Monastery, he had prayed to Amitabha Buddha to help him accomplish the construction of the monastery. When the work began, the Venerable Master first moved to the Western Bliss Gardens building site, and he wanted to bring this image of Amitabha Buddha back. But the two Dharma Masters were unwilling to comply, and yet they had no legitimate reason to refuse, so they came to call on the Venerable Master on the first day of the lunar New Year.

In the Venerable Master's own words:

There was once a monastic who had Way-places in both Hong Kong and Taiwan. He had a lot of money, and no small amount of offenses either. Although he was a monastic, he killed several people and drove people to suicide; the retribution for that is inconceivable. In Hong Kong, he and another monastic were driven out by the people at Tung Po Tor, and no one would have anything to do with them; it was I who took care of them. Later, I also "ding"-ed a floor for them on Ladder Street ("ding" is Hong Kong parlance meaning to rent), and I had an image of Amitabha Buddha that I lent them to worship. The image was made of porcelain.

To my surprise, on the evening of the first day of the first lunar month, the two of them knelt down together in front of me and, acting like a pair of scoundrels, said that if I didn't give them the Buddha image, they would kneel in front of me until they died. Back then I was also very foolish and went to pull them up. If it were me today: if you want to kneel till you die, then kneel till you die; I couldn't care less what you do. Both of them were fat monks. I'd pull this one up, and that one would kneel down again; I'd struggle to pull that one up, and this one would kneel down again. I dragged them outside: no sooner had I dragged one out and come back to drag the second one out than the first one would run back in and kneel there; I'd drag the second one out and come back to chase out the first, and the second one would run back in and kneel. They took turns wearing me down like that and kept it up for five hours.

By this time I was really unhappy. I lost my temper and smashed the teapot and teacups, but they paid no attention and just kept up their shameless act, until I had no way out. I said, "All right, I surrender to you! It's not as if I can't become a Buddha without this image; I'll give it to you." Only when they heard me say I was willing to give it to them did they get up. I saw them out the door and said

to them, "From now on, no matter where I am, you are forever forbidden to come through my door again!" With that, I shut the door. For several years after that, we had nothing to do with each other, until a monastic said, "Let me mediate between you!" I said, "What's there to mediate? I'll go and see them." I went there, and we were on good terms again.

[Addendum] The very next day the Venerable Master fell ill, with a high fever that would not go down; he was gravely ill. Fortunately, Dharma Master Heng Yue, who was living with those two Dharma Masters, learned that the two had made an unreasonable scene on the first day of the New Year and that the Venerable Master had fallen ill because of it, and he immediately took that image of Amitabha Buddha back and returned it to the Venerable Master. Once the image came back, the Venerable Master gradually recovered, and the construction of the monastery went ahead smoothly.

19. Hearing of His Ways, Others Follow Suit

The Venerable Master's talent and learning were outstanding, and he had an extraordinary, uncommon wisdom. Whether as a shramanera, as a Bhikshu, as an abbot, or even as president of the Fellowship of Mainland Monks Residing in Hong Kong, in everything he had his own unique style of doing things, and for a time others followed his lead as grass bends before the wind...

In the Venerable Master's own words:

In the thirty-fifth year of the Republic (1946), 14 of us monks traveled south together. When we took the ship from Tianjin to Shanghai, I was a shramanera. As a rule, whatever you are doing, the Bhikshus go in front and the shramaneras behind. But they knew nothing at all about travel procedures and had no common sense whatsoever; they didn't even know about going to the customs office to get vaccinations and smallpox inoculations. So they had no choice but to call me up to the front to lead them in dealing with the officials, and I took them to get all these things done.

Later, when I came to Hong Kong, most of the people in Buddhist circles were also following along behind me. At first, nobody knew how to use English-style correspondence. After I came to Hong Kong, I used English envelopes and letter paper, and only then did they follow suit. I was the first to apply to the government for tax exemption for a Buddha hall, and afterward they followed along behind me and got tax exemption too. I'm not saying how great I am; it's just that they didn't use their brains when they did things. For instance, there was one person in Hong Kong who did the most to undermine me. His mind for scheming for connections was also the biggest, and he was very attentive when it came to serving women: he would carry suitcases and handbags for wealthy female lay devotees. Why was he like this? Because he could barely read. If he didn't act like that, he really had no other way to get by. I hope you will not scheme for connections the way he did!

[Addendum] Dharma Master Heng Sure recounted:

One year we went to New Zealand and met Elder Master Xuan Zhi. He had known the Master back in Hong Kong and had once stayed at Cixing Monastery. Elder Dharma Master Xuan Zhi said that the Venerable Master's way of speaking the Dharma was unique and famous throughout Hong Kong. He said, "Your Master was in a class of his own, a model for monastics speaking the Dharma in those days. He could effortlessly recite the *Three Hundred Tang Poems*, and he could also quote offhand from *Laozi* and the Confucian classics as supporting evidence. Very few monastics had learning like his."

Elder Dharma Master Xuan Zhi also told a story that was widely known in Hong Kong Buddhist circles at the time. One day, when the Master was lecturing on the *Amitabha Sutra* at Western Bliss Gardens Monastery, some monastics came into the hall and sat down to listen to the Dharma. From the Dharma seat, the Master suddenly said, "All of you, go sit at the back." Just as these monastics were about to get up and give up their seats, the Master said, "No need! Monastics should sit in front. I was talking to the gods, dragons, and the rest of the eightfold division, telling them to sit at the back."

(Dharma Master Heng Sure is an American disciple of the Venerable Master in America. From May 7, 1977 to November 4, 1979, to pray for world peace, he made a pilgrimage of "three steps, one bow" [Tr.: bowing to the ground once after every three steps] from Gold Wheel Monastery in Los Angeles, Southern California, to the City of Ten Thousand Buddhas in Northern California.)

20. Printing Sutras and Making Buddha Images

The sutras spoken by the Buddha are, without exception, Dharma treasures that expound the holy teaching and benefit living beings; their value and meaning are like a bright lamp in the dark of night. If the world had no sutras of the Buddhas, then the heavens and the human world would be like an endless long night. How then could the multitudes of living beings nurture their Bodhi wisdom-life?

Translating the Buddhist sutras and circulating the precious canon of the Tripitaka is the foremost work in saving people's wisdom-life, and it was also the Buddha's original intent in coming into the world. Therefore, during his years in Hong Kong, the Venerable Master never for a single moment slackened in his compassionate vow to propagate the Buddhadharma. One after another, he printed large quantities of the *Dharma Flower Sutra*, the *Universal Door Chapter*, the *Earth Store Sutra*, the *Shurangama Sutra*, and others, and sent them everywhere for distribution and circulation.

He also engaged painters to illustrate the life of Elder Master Hsu Yun and had it printed, and the Venerable Master composed verses for it. The result is a biography of a sage that no one should fail to read: the *Pictorial Biography of Elder Master Hsu Yun*.

In the Venerable Master's own words:

Wherever I go, there are lots of sutras. In Manchuria I had no other property; all I had were sutras. At that time in Hong Kong it was extremely hard to find a copy of a sutra, so I did all I could to promote the printing of sutras. I spent more money on printing sutras than on anything else: something over HK$1 million. First I printed the *Dharma Flower Sutra* and the *Shurangama Sutra*. The copies we used in our early days in America for the *Shurangama Sutra* lectures were the ones printed when I lectured on the *Shurangama Sutra* in Hong Kong. Once I promoted it like this, other Buddhist organizations in Hong Kong later started printing sutras too, so now there are lots of sutras in Hong Kong.

Printing sutras is one way of propagating the Buddhadharma: on the one hand you print sutras, and on the other you open your own wisdom. Why haven't you opened your wisdom? It's because your merit and virtue are small. Without merit and virtue, you have little wisdom. Just before I came to America, I gave away all my sutras, worth something over 100,000, because, since I was coming to America, I had nowhere to keep them anyway; so I hurried to give the sutras away. What I like best is printing sutras. This is also part of propagating the Dharma, and I hope every one of you will put some heart into the work of printing sutras.

Western Bliss Gardens had a large collection of scriptures: there was the Tripitaka, and other scriptures besides. The Tripitaka I had obtained from Japan at great expense, and there were other very ancient scriptures that simply can't be bought anymore. There was a Bhikshuni who had originally worked as a servant for others and couldn't read a single character. Because I wasn't there, she got rid of all the scriptures and sent them off to a sutra distribution center. Today Upasika Tan told me, "I didn't dare tell you! If I told you, you'd be sure to lose your temper!" I said, "You guessed wrong! Never mind sending them to a sutra distribution center; even if she had burned the scriptures, I wouldn't care! The Shifu I am now is not the Shifu I used to be. In the past, in Hong Kong, I often lost my temper and often scolded people; now, no matter what you do, I don't scold anymore!" Although I don't scold, in my heart I'm still not happy to have a disciple like this. She is just too ignorant!

I hope that my American disciples, whether or not they can read Chinese characters, will never put Chinese sutras into the stove and burn them; even photocopies must be handled with great care. If you carelessly throw them into the fire and burn them, or carelessly destroy them, in the future you will become more foolish with each life. All scriptures, whether in Chinese or in English, must be specially protected. If a scripture is damaged, it should be repaired. Don't be like this disciple, always doing such dark and benighted things. All of you, pay special attention to this point! Because she couldn't read, she thought that sending them to the sutra distribution center was putting them where they belonged, not realizing that this was completely mistaken! People who study Buddhism must respect the scriptures; only by respecting the scriptures can you open your wisdom.

Why is this disciple so foolish? I'll tell you a little about the causes and conditions. In her past life, this person was a horse, so now that she has become a person in this life she still hasn't changed a horse's habits. She followed me for a long time, and I taught her the Buddhadharma, but she forgot all of it. Her karmic obstacles from past lives are very heavy, so she does many upside-down things, and she doesn't believe in cause and effect either. Why doesn't she believe in cause and effect? The *Sutra of Cause and Effect* says it very clearly: "Those who hear of retribution and will not believe or listen": you talk to them about the cycle of cause, effect, and retribution, and they don't believe it. "Have just escaped the animal realm and obtained a human body": they have just shed an animal body for the first time and obtained a human body, so they don't believe this is retribution. It isn't that she doesn't want to do what is right; it's simply her nature, and so she gets many things wrong.

Today I said to Upasika Tan, "I don't scold people anymore! All things go through formation, dwelling, decay, and emptiness, so what is there to scold about?" This is really a great pity, but that is how worldly affairs are: here something is formed, and there something decays; here something dwells, and there something becomes empty. If I were in Hong Kong, she would never have done such a thing, because I could keep an eye on her. Now that I have come here to America, I trust that people here in America won't do this kind of thing; after I'm gone, though, I don't know.

When I was in Hong Kong, in making Buddha images alone, I remember making more than 100 all told; I made them and then gave them to people. The Three Tathagatas, or perhaps the Three Sages of the West, now at the Chinese Buddhist Association of Hawaii were given to them by me. That was more than 20 years ago.

I hope that Buddha images will enter into everyone's heart, so that every person has a Buddha image in their heart and every home has a Buddha image too. This, too, is layer upon layer without end.

21. A Duckling Listens to the Dharma

In the first month of summer in the renchen year (April 1952), the Venerable Master lectured on the *Universal Door Chapter* at Western Bliss Gardens. On the day the lectures concluded, a little duckling suddenly squeezed through the fence into the monastery grounds and quietly crouched outside the door of the Buddha hall...

In the Venerable Master's own words:

When I was lecturing on the sutras at Western Bliss Gardens Monastery, a duck came to listen to the lecture. It kowtowed behind my bowing bench, kowtowing and quacking at the same time. Gan Guo Hui took a palm-leaf fan and shooed it out, but when she came back in, it came back in too, and it was still there quacking and looking as if it were kowtowing. She'd shoo it out, and it would come back again. After she had shooed it out three or four times, I finally told

her not to chase it away anymore, and only then did she stop. It lay there and listened to a whole session of the lecture. When people went outside to have a photograph taken, this duck went along to be photographed too. The people were all standing up on the platform, and it couldn't get up there, so it had to stay below the platform. The photographer didn't take care to include it in the photo, so in the end it didn't make it into the picture.

Whenever the sutras are being lectured and the Dharma spoken, no matter what kind of living being comes in, you shouldn't drive it out. Even mosquitoes, flies, and moths that fly into the lamps are all here to listen to the Dharma. Do you remember, at Gold Mountain Monastery and at the Buddhist Lecture Hall, when there were bugs in my teacup? Those bugs had also come to listen to the Dharma. Those bugs belong to the dragon class; toads also belong to the dragon class.

22. An Arhat Falls

In the summer of the second year after Western Bliss Gardens Monastery was founded, a Guanyin session was held. During the morning bowing to the Buddhas, people discovered that a sword-shaped wooden board had been placed in front of the altar table. Most of the assembly were beginners in Buddhism, and someone, out of curiosity, asked the Master, "Shifu, is this a wooden sword?" The Venerable Master said, "This is an incense board. In monasteries it is used to strike people who don't follow the rules, who doze off, or who are lazy." A board that thick would surely hurt when it came down, and everyone trembled with fear, wondering who would be the first to try out the incense board. Yet as the Guanyin session was drawing to a close, the incense board was still lying where it had been. That evening, during the great dedication of merit, the Venerable Master picked up the incense board, put it on his shoulder, and strode out of Western Bliss Gardens. With astonished eyes, everyone followed the Venerable Master's figure as they looked outside. It turned out that a middle-aged monk had just come up the mountain; as soon as he saw the Venerable Master, he kowtowed to him and knelt on the ground repenting...

In the Venerable Master's own words:

In the thirty-sixth year of the Republic (1947), a living Arhat appeared in China. This living Arhat was called Wu Jin. What abilities did this Arhat have? He could recite the Great Compassion Mantra to cure people's illnesses; no matter what the illness, once he treated it, it was cured. So at Mount Putuo, the Way-place of Guanyin Bodhisattva, he made a great display of spiritual powers. At that time, more than 500 monks had gone to Mount Putuo to take part in a precept-transmission ceremony. After the ceremony was over, because not many pilgrims went to Mount Putuo that year, the monks couldn't raise any money by seeking alms, so these 500-plus monks who had come to Mount Putuo had no way to get off the mountain and no way to go back to their own monasteries, because none of them had any money. So he cured people's illnesses there, and people came to believe in him especially strongly. In this way he raised enough

donations for two boats and, free of charge, sent all of those 500-plus monks to Shanghai, Shenjiamen, and other places. As a result his fame grew very great; throughout Shanghai, Hangzhou, and Suzhou, there was no one who didn't know about this living Arhat. Some officials believed in him, ordinary people believed in him even more, and in Buddhist circles, monastics and laypeople alike believed in him.

At that time I was staying at the Buddha Recitation Hall on Lingyan Mountain in Suzhou, and once I met him in the recitation hall. I had heard this was the living Arhat. I took a look: his appearance wasn't bad; he looked like an Arhat and wore tattered clothes. But when I looked at him, I saw that this kind of Arhat was about to die. I asked him, "Are you the living Arhat?" He said, "I wouldn't dare claim it; people just call me that!" I said, "What abilities do you have, that you're called a living Arhat?" He said, "I just cure people's illnesses!" I said, "You cure other people's illnesses; you ought to cure your own illness! Have you cured your own illness yet?" He looked at me and said, "What illness do I have?" I said, "You have the illness of seeking fame, and in the future you will also have the illness of seeking profit. You cure other people's illnesses, but in the future there won't be anyone to cure yours!"

I said, "I'll tell you honestly: if you keep on curing people's illnesses and showing off your spiritual powers, you will certainly fall!" "Falling" means either committing offenses or no longer being a monastic; it's like dropping from a high place to a low place, and that is called "falling." When I said this to him, the living Arhat knelt down in front of me. I said, "What are you doing?" He said, "If I fall, I beg you to save me!" Actually, if he simply stopped curing people's illnesses, he could avoid falling. He didn't ask me how he could avoid falling; he just said that when he fell, he wanted me to come and save him. Ai! At the time I didn't think it over either, and I promised him, "All right, if you fall, I'll come and save you!"

This was very strange. When I got to Hong Kong, I met this living Arhat again, and sure enough, he was no longer a living Arhat. He had become an ordinary person, a layman rather than a monastic. When he saw me, I still recognized him. I said, "What's become of you now? Where has your living Arhat run off to? How did you end up like this?" He said, "It's all your fault! Your words were too efficacious! You said I'd fall, and I fell. If you hadn't said I'd fall, how would I have ended up like this!" I said, "Well, you've fallen, and I promised I would save you. Will you leave home again now?" He said, "Leave home? I don't have any money." I said, "If you have no money, I'll give you money; go and leave home!" And so I helped him to leave home again.

There was a Dharma Master who revered him like a living Buddha, bowing to him every day after morning recitation and bowing to him again after evening recitation. Originally that Dharma Master had wanted to invite me; he wanted to use me as his signboard, but I wouldn't go. This signboard of mine is simply not for sale to anyone. So that Dharma Master treated him as a living Arhat again instead. I said, "Be careful! If you revere him like this, he'll fall again!" Later,

sure enough, this living Arhat ran off again, and nobody knew where. This living Arhat also never lay down to sleep and also kept the rule of not eating after noon, and still he could fall. So cultivating the Way is not easy.

[Addendum 1] When the Venerable Master met the living Arhat again in Hong Kong, the man was already married; his wife was the one who had been his chief Dharma protector for many years. The merit and virtue of his many years of cultivation had come to nothing, and his spiritual powers had vanished without a trace. When he saw the Venerable Master he was deeply ashamed and resolved to leave home once more. The Venerable Master gave him money for robes and other expenses, but in less than half a year he returned to lay life again. That day, he had come to Western Bliss Gardens to repent before the Venerable Master; it was the second time he had come to ask the Venerable Master to let him leave home, and the Venerable Master still helped him with money and encouraged him. Later his whereabouts became unknown; it was said that he had returned to lay life again.

[Addendum 2] From the diary of Upasika Tan Guo Zheng:

The Master once said, "Once I said, 'I can know all the paths that others cultivate, but others don't know the Dharma-door that I cultivate!' Just because I said that one wrong sentence, my cultivation of the Way made hardly any progress afterward. Fortunately, at the time I asked my Dharma uncle Chang Ren for guidance, and only then did I realize I had misspoken. So in cultivation, remember: you must never be arrogant."

[Addendum 3] From the diary of Upasika Tan Guo Zheng:

The Master said, "Cultivators must cut off desire and get rid of love! Cultivators who have not yet found their footing must be especially careful!" Looking back on our time in Hong Kong, the Master was very strict in disciplining his disciples, and following the Master meant observing many rules. For example, girls were not allowed to meet male Dharma Masters face to face; if they happened to pass each other, the girls had to lower their heads as they went by. The Master's instruction was, "Don't disturb others as they apply effort!" After coming to America, I once wrote to tell the Master that some young Dharma Masters from Honolulu had visited the San Francisco Buddhist Lecture Hall and that we had received them warmly. The Master wrote back reprimanding us: "Don't get close to them!" Although at the time I didn't dare go against the Master's wishes, in my heart I never understood what the Master meant. Only many years later did I learn that quite a few of these young Dharma Masters who came to America in the 1950s had been unable to withstand temptation and had returned to lay life and married.

23. Cultivation Is Not Easy

The virtuous ones of old often said, "Don't say that leaving home is easily attained; it comes from planting Bodhi seeds life after life." Leaving home is hard to attain, yet people don't realize that the tests after leaving home are even

greater. For a monastic to maintain the resolve for the Way, proper knowledge and views and a firm, sincere, and constant mind are of vital importance.

In the Venerable Master's own words:

There was a monk who had been a soldier before he left home. Later he studied Buddhism and took refuge with the Triple Jewel, ate vegetarian food, recited the Buddha's name, and also led others to recite the Buddha's name. He saw others leaving home and thought it was good, so he left home too. He was a grand-disciple of Elder Hsu, very articulate and a smooth talker. After leaving home, he devoted himself to the Dharma-door of reciting the Buddha's name. I watched him receive the precepts at Nanhua Monastery. Later, when the ** Party came, he fled to Hong Kong. The situation in Hong Kong was very complicated. At that time monastics had nowhere to live in Hong Kong. It wasn't like now, when some monks in Hong Kong live in tall buildings and big mansions; back then, never mind a mansion, there wasn't even a little thatched hut. This monk couldn't get used to living in that one-story wooden building at Tung Po Tor. Probably he had been used to spending a lot of money before, so with no money in hand he found things hard, and he ran off to Tao Fong Shan.

At that place there was a pastor who made it his business to undermine Buddhism and entice monastics to return to lay life. If a monk didn't want to stay in Buddhism, all he had to do was go there, and the pastor would give you 30 or 50 dollars a month, or even 200 dollars. At his place, if you didn't want to eat vegetarian food, he had meat for you to eat; if you didn't want to be a monk, he would give you a wife. And what about Bhikshunis? It was the same for them: if you wanted to get married, he would find you a husband, and if you wanted to marry a monk, that was fine too. He used money and sex to entice monastics, and once they went to live there, they would "drift, linger, run wild, and go to ruin" [Tr.: a phrase from *Mencius*], "drifting" downstream. What is meant by "drifting, lingering, running wild, and going to ruin"? "Following the current downstream and forgetting to return is called drifting; following the current upstream and forgetting to return is called lingering; pursuing the hunt without ever being satisfied is called running wild; delighting in wine without ever being satisfied is called going to ruin." He said his place was the most convenient, and that in times like these this was how things ought to be. He also said, "Here we also recite the Buddhist sutras and do morning and evening recitation." In fact he was hanging out a sheep's head and selling dog meat: his whole purpose was to undermine Buddhism and to get people to stop believing in the Buddha and stop believing in monks. I once went there to take a look, and I got into a debate with this pastor.

I said, "What you are doing here goes against the heart of Jesus. You are not a Christian; you aren't qualified to be a follower of Jesus. Jesus built people up; he didn't ruin them. You don't build people up; you ruin them. You ruin monastics by making them stop being monastics; this is called destroying their pure conduct." I said, "As for me, I'm not a Buddhist either! If I were a Buddhist, I ought to be compassionate like the Buddha and save you. Unfortunately I can't

save you; I don't have the power to save you, so I'm not a Buddhist." What I said left him staring at me wide-eyed with nothing to say. Afterward he wanted to have his photo taken with me. I said, "No photo! A photo of you, a disgrace to Christianity, together with me, a disgrace to Buddhism, would only bring shame on Buddhism and bring shame on Christianity too." So no photo was taken.

This monk went to that place and worked as a cook, at 300 dollars a month. But he wasn't cooking vegetarian food; every day he had to kill chickens, ducks, and fish. He said it didn't matter: every time he killed a chicken, he would recite as he killed it, "Namo Amitabha Buddha, be reborn in the Western Land of Ultimate Bliss! Namo Amitabha Buddha, be reborn in the Western Land of Ultimate Bliss!" He thought that by reciting "Amitabha Buddha" like this he could rescue the chicken and help it to be reborn in the Land of Ultimate Bliss. From morning till night he did nothing but kill chickens and kill ducks; he took a great many lives. I believe he may have killed 360 chickens. But then what happened? The retribution came! After he had been there a little over half a year, he went insane and couldn't stay there anymore, so he went back to Tung Po Tor, back to that place without money, to live. There, from morning till night, he raved: "Look, look and see whether the ducks I killed went to the Land of Ultimate Bliss! Did the chickens I killed get to the Land of Ultimate Bliss or not? Or did they become chickens again? Or will they kill me someday?" All day long he talked crazy talk like that.

Later he wanted to see me. Why did he want to see me? He knew that if he could see me, there might be hope of eradicating his karmic offenses, and then his illness would get better. How did he know that seeing me would make him better? Because in the past, he had brought several people with illnesses like his to see me, and they had all gotten better. Now it was his own turn. When he was lucid he would say, "I want to go and see Dharma Master An Tse. Which of you can help me and take me to see him?" But just when he wanted to go and see me, he would go mad again and talk to himself: "No! If you see him, what will become of us? You knowingly broke the precepts: you killed so many living beings. You, a monk, killed so many chickens and so many ducks. How could this possibly end well!" So he never did get to see me. About half a year later, he took a knife and killed himself. I saw this monk with my own eyes; so cultivation is not easy!

Why did this monk undergo this kind of retribution? Let me tell you. First, this was a great Bodhisattva manifesting this appearance for living beings to see: "Look, all of you: a monastic must not kill. A monastic who kills will undergo this kind of retribution!" He wasn't afraid of disgrace; he didn't shrink back and say, "This is too embarrassing; I don't want to manifest like this!" This is the same as Devadatta. That is putting it in a good light. I can't say he was a bad monk, because I am even worse than he was. Second, he lacked a firm resolve; after he left home he changed and didn't know how to cultivate. True, reciting the Buddha's name can rescue beings, but when you, a monastic, kill living beings, you are knowingly breaking the precepts, and your offense is three degrees

heavier. What qualifications do you have to rescue them? You killed it; are you certain you can rescue it to rebirth in the Land of Ultimate Bliss? You're not certain, and you don't have that right either, and yet you tell yourself, "I think it should have gone to the Land of Ultimate Bliss!" That won't do. So when we hear this case, we must not mistakenly think that we can recite the Buddha's name while creating offenses at the same time. If you recite the Buddha's name, you must not create offenses; all the more should you do good. You should not do a single wrong thing, and you should not create a single offense.

24. The Sea of Suffering Is Boundless

On the vast ocean, people do not know where they are going or which way to head; thus those who awaken are few indeed! In his earnest compassion, the Venerable Master was like a lighthouse on the sea, skillfully offering a ray of dawn light, but living beings were often unable to understand the Venerable Master's great compassion...

In 1950, not long after the Venerable Master came to Hong Kong, Upasika Luo Guo Ming brought her daughter Huang Guo Song and her son Huang Guo Jun, and all three of them took refuge with the Venerable Master together. Luo Guo Ming had come to know the Venerable Master through an introduction from her neighbor, Wang Meigu. This Wang Meigu was the Master's first lay disciple in Hong Kong; her Dharma name was "Guo Hai." Her husband worked on ships and came home only once in a long while, and the family was not very well off.

In the 1950s, many people in Hong Kong believed in Catholicism or Christianity, because it made schooling easier for their children, and the churches all handed out relief goods, such as flour; there were things to eat and also things to use. Because of her family situation, she often went to Christian and Catholic places.

One day she came to Western Bliss Gardens wanting to tell the Master that she had already become a Catholic and would not come to the Way-place anymore, but she just couldn't bring herself to say it. That day, as she was taking leave of the Master to go home, the Master said to her, "Guo Hai, I'll see you down the mountain. You'll take the wrong road!" Guo Hai said, "I won't! I've come to Western Bliss Gardens so many times; how could I take the wrong road?" The Master said, "I'd still better see you down. You'll take the wrong road!" The devotees present all thought it very strange, because the Master never saw anyone down the mountain. After that, Guo Hai never came again.

25. Sincerity Wins the Buddhas' Protection

In the autumn of 1952, Luo Guo Ming ran into several misfortunes one after another. While she was depressed and troubled, she also caught an illness so serious that even the doctors were at a loss. Her daughter, Huang Guo Song, grief-stricken and not knowing where to turn, knelt before the Buddha...

Upasika Huang Guo Song wrote:

In the autumn of the renchen year (1952), because things were not going well for her, my mother was suddenly struck down by illness. Her condition was very serious and she was in terrible pain; her face was ashen, she couldn't get out of bed, and the doctors we called in brought no improvement. Later the doctor said my mother could die at any moment. The family was very distressed to hear this, and I felt even more lost and helpless, so I prayed to the Buddhas and Bodhisattvas, begging them to protect my mother. Just then, a great light suddenly shone before my eyes, and there appeared a Dharma Master wearing a kashaya and seated in full lotus. Looking closely, I saw that it was actually the Master. Overcome with surprise and joy, I quickly recited the Buddha's name silently. Before long, my mother fell into a heavy sleep, but her complexion still showed no improvement. Then an idea came to me, and I quickly found someone to go with me to see the Master. As soon as I saw the Master, I burst into tears and begged him to save my mother. The Master told me, "I already knew about your mother's illness. Go home quickly, recite the Buddha's name sincerely, and contemplate; the Buddhas and Bodhisattvas will certainly aid your mother." I bowed to thank the Master and went home. Following the Master's instructions, I stayed up the whole night reciting the Buddha's name, praying for aid for my mother. By daybreak, my mother's illness was more than half gone, and her spirits had recovered a great deal. Through this experience I came to appreciate even more deeply the inconceivability of the Buddhadharma. I will never forget the Master's kindness!

From the Venerable Master's instructional talk of September 4, 1983

In their lifetime everyone must go through the four great sufferings of "birth, old age, sickness, and death"; nobody can escape these four kinds of suffering, unless you cultivate the Way and end birth and death, which is another matter. Ordinary people all have to undergo these four sufferings. At the time of "birth," it is like being squeezed between two mountains, so when a child is born, the first thing it does is cry, expressing suffering. At a birth, relatives and friends are turned by the state of birth and all come to celebrate; although they offer congratulations, it is actually suffering. In "old age," the eyes grow dim, the ears go deaf, the teeth fall out, the hair turns white, and the hands and feet no longer obey orders; they all go on strike together, and you can't move. That is very painful too. In "sickness," the four elements are out of balance and won't cooperate with each other, to the point that you lie in bed and can't get up; and if poverty and sickness strike together, it is suffering upon suffering. At that time the spirit is willing but the strength is lacking. Tell me, is that suffering or not? When it comes to "death," the suffering is even more beyond words; it is just like a cow being skinned alive. And with sons and daughters tugging at one's heart, deluded by the seven emotions and six desires, one still cannot let go even at death.

"Death" is in fact a road that every life must travel, so why be happy at birth and grieve at death? Unfortunately, ordinary foolish people cannot break through this attachment. Now we want to investigate the question of "where we come

from at birth and where we go at death." If we investigate it until we understand it, we can escape the Three Realms and no longer undergo the cycle of rebirth. To investigate this question, Shakyamuni Buddha left home to cultivate the Way. He sought the Way for six years and practiced austerities for six years, yet he still did not find a way to resolve birth and death. Finally he sat in stillness beneath the Bodhi tree for 49 days, saw the bright star at night, and awakened to the Way, thoroughly understanding the wheel of life, "the Twelve Causes and Conditions."

Why am I talking about these principles today? Because when I first arrived in Hong Kong, the first disciple who took refuge with me was Upasika Luo Guo Ming. She was 81 this year, and she passed away yesterday morning, and this has moved me. All her life she was hard pressed by her circumstances, but she never surrendered to them. She endured suffering and toil and raised five children, and all of her children have achieved considerable success. So Upasika Luo Guo Ming can rest with a smile in the world beyond, or else be reborn in the Land of Ultimate Bliss.

[Addendum] Upasika Tan Guo Shi recounted:

Because Guo Song often helped with the chanting at Dharma assemblies together with me, and Upasika Guo Ming often joined my mother, Yuan Guo Lin, and Mrs. Luo, the four of them pooling money to handle the various expenses and affairs of the Dharma assemblies, I thought of Upasika Guo Ming as if she were my own mother. One morning at around four or five o'clock, I was awakened by the sound of a crisp, lively trumpet. While I was still bleary-eyed, I saw Upasika Guo Ming tell me very happily that she was liberated and was leaving. That afternoon, I received word from Hong Kong that Upasika Guo Ming had passed away the previous evening. When I worked out the time, it was exactly my morning in America.

26. Wondrous Accounts of Saving Lives (1)

Saving people's lives is the most important thing: this was the Venerable Master's principle in all he did. Whether in China, in Hong Kong, or in America, the Venerable Master saved many people's lives. Because Mrs. Wu had borrowed money to build a stone house...

In the Venerable Master's own words:

Saving people's lives is the most important thing! In my more than ten years in Hong Kong, I saved many people's lives. Now that their circumstances have improved, they all come very sincerely to repay the Buddha's kindness, and wherever I go, they support me. In America, too, I have saved many people's lives; it isn't only lecturing on the sutras and speaking the Dharma. When I say this, don't go digging to the bottom of it: "Whose life exactly did you save? What good deeds did you actually do? You say you did this and that, but we don't know." You can organize an investigation team and go to Hong Kong to investigate.

I remember there was a man surnamed Wu whose wife took refuge with me. What did this Mr. Wu do? He was the village head of a small village, and he smoked opium. His wife borrowed 9,000 dollars from someone. What for? She planned to build a stone house and make money by collecting rent on it. Unexpectedly, as soon as the stone house was built, it was torn down by the authorities concerned, and in an instant everything was gone, and there was no money to repay the debt either. In her desperation, Mrs. Wu was going to hang herself.

Speaking of this, I'm not advertising myself. Let me make it clear to you first: what I'm telling you about are real people and real events. Just as she was about to hang herself, she saw Shifu come and say, "Don't hang yourself. Tomorrow this problem will be solved; someone will help you." At that moment she didn't know whether it was real or not, and when she looked again, Shifu was gone. The next day, sure enough, a friend came and lent her money, and her problem was solved. That is one case; as for the rest, you can understand what it's all about.

There was also a child who still couldn't walk at the age of 5. I don't know whether it was polio or something else, but he just couldn't walk. When he was 9, his family heard about me from someone and came to find me. I said to his mother, "Every day, bow to the Buddha all the way from the foot of the mountain to the top. Whenever you have bowed enough, your child will get better." His mother brought him to the Buddha hall to bow to the Buddha every day. Going up the mountain there were more than 300 stone steps, and at every step they made one kowtow. They did this once a day and kept bowing for half a year, and without taking any medicine, the child's illness was cured. His family had no money, so they bought 5 catties of oil and offered it to the monastery. These are two incidents that I remember.

[Addendum] Upasika Tan Guo Shi recounted:

One night I was woken up. Bleary-eyed, I got up and saw my mother kneeling before the Buddha, murmuring something; I didn't know what she was reciting. Only the next morning did I learn that my mother hadn't slept the whole night, because my elder brother's old illness had flared up again; he was coughing up blood and couldn't stop, and the doctor was at a loss. The doctor said that if my brother kept on coughing up blood, last night might be his last. When my mother learned this, never mind that it was nighttime, she grabbed a servant and ran to Western Bliss Gardens to beg the Master for help.

After seeing the Master, my mother went back home and continued kneeling before the Buddha, sincerely reciting the Great Compassion Mantra and asking for Great Compassion water for my brother to drink. After my brother had drunk it two or three times, the bleeding lessened. My mother kept on reciting the Great Compassion Mantra without stopping, and my brother finally stopped coughing up blood and slowly fell asleep. The next day the doctor came to see my brother and was astonished to find that he had come through the critical

period and had actually survived. My mother loved her son so much that, besides sincerely praying for Guanyin Bodhisattva's aid, she also vowed to eat less. Hong Kong people take eating very seriously; eating less is regarded as a very serious matter. A mother's love is truly great!

Our family's servant, Sister Yin, often went with my mother to help at the Dharma assemblies at Western Bliss Gardens, and gradually she too came to believe in the Buddha and recite the Buddha's name. In particular, when she saw the response in which my brother received the aid of Guanyin Bodhisattva and the Master, she also resolved to take refuge. Before long, she quit her job with our family and went to a nuns' monastery as a volunteer, and later she too shaved her head and left home. A few years ago I went back to Hong Kong to visit Sister Yin; she was still cultivating at the nuns' monastery.

Question: I earnestly beg Shifu to be compassionate and save my daughter. My daughter has "hereditary mucopolysaccharide metabolism disorder," which has affected her bones, tendons, and heart.

The Venerable Master: When I was in Hong Kong, there was a child of 5 who couldn't walk. His mother brought him every day to my Buddha hall up on the mountain to bow to the Buddha. After bowing for half a year, he got better without taking any medicine at all. As for this matter, you would have to ask the one who did the bowing; only that person knows. I don't understand it.

27. Wondrous Accounts of Saving Lives (2)

In the spirit of great kindness and great compassion, whenever people were in suffering, distress, danger, or illness, the Venerable Master, seeing their utmost sincerity, fulfilled their wishes without exception. Upasaka Li Guo Yuan's youngest daughter, Dieyan, accidentally fell, and several days later she ran a high fever all over her body...

Li Dahua, whose Dharma name was Guo Yuan, had a youngest daughter, Dieyan, who accidentally fell while walking. At the time nothing seemed wrong, but several days later her whole body was burning hot, and her leg was also in severe pain. Li Guo Yuan and his wife thought it was caused by the fall and took their daughter to a bonesetter, Li Zifei, for treatment. After examining her, Dr. Li told them that it was not an injury from the fall but was caused by a sore growing on her leg. After they returned home, they called in another doctor to treat her, but it did no good.

Later, through someone's introduction, Li Guo Yuan's wife carried her little daughter on her back to Western Bliss Gardens Monastery to ask to see the Venerable Master. The Venerable Master said that he was not familiar with medicine and could not treat her. Li Guo Yuan's wife would not give up and came again to beg him to save her daughter, but the Venerable Master again refused. The third time, Li Guo Yuan and his wife came to Western Bliss Gardens Monastery together. The two of them knelt before the Venerable Master and begged him to find some way to save their daughter. Seeing that the

couple was utterly sincere, the Venerable Master made an allowance for them as an expedient and finally agreed to pray to the Buddhas and Bodhisattvas on their behalf for protection. After one week, Li Dieyan's illness was, astonishingly, cured. Li Guo Yuan's whole family deeply believed that this was due to the Venerable Master's virtue and the protection of the Buddhas and Bodhisattvas, so all five members of the family took refuge with the Triple Jewel and became the Venerable Master's disciples.

In the Venerable Master's own words: There was a policeman named Li Dahua whose 4-year-old daughter couldn't walk after a fall, and the doctors couldn't cure her. Li Dahua went to Western Bliss Gardens and bowed to the Buddha a few times, and his daughter was able to walk; because of this, many people said I could cure illnesses. I also remember a very poor man whose mother was ill, and seeing doctors didn't help. Because this poor man's mother had heard that I could cure illnesses, she told him to come to me and ask. At the time I said, "If you want your mom to get well, you have to give 100,000 dollars." If he had asked why money was needed, I would have told him, but he didn't ask; he just left in a huff.

He went home and told his mom that I was a monk who was greedy for money. That night he had a dream in which someone told him, "When the Dharma Master told you it would take 100,000 dollars, he didn't mean for you to give him HK$100,000. He meant for you to spend 1 dollar to buy a 100,000-dollar note of paper money, the kind of money ghosts use, and burn it; then your mom's illness will get better." He really did just that, and his mother's illness got better. Why was that? There's no explaining it.

[Addendum] From the diary of Upasika Tan Guo Zheng:

The Master showed me a letter from Mrs. Zhan Liwu. Her husband, Zhan Liwu, was a devout Buddhist; she too had taken refuge with Elder Master Hsu Yun, and the whole family lived in Canada. In the letter she mentioned that her daughter had polio. Because she had read about the responses described in *Records of Chan Master To Lun*, she bowed morning and evening to the Master's photograph in the *Records*. After only a few days, her daughter felt strength in her legs and could move about, and she soon recovered completely. She also enclosed a photograph of her daughter. Every day she recited the "Hsuan Hua Verse" that the Master wrote in the *Pictorial Biography of Elder Master Hsu Yun*.

28. A Deaf Woman Listens to the Sutras

The elderly Upasika Liu Guo Juan had been deaf for many years. In 1951 (the xinmao year), she took refuge with the Venerable Master at Western Bliss Gardens. After taking refuge, she suddenly brought forth the Bodhi resolve. Her hands never let go of her recitation beads, and every day she did nothing but recite the great six-character name "Namo Amitabha Buddha"...

Whenever Western Bliss Gardens held a Dharma assembly or the Venerable Master lectured on a sutra, Liu Guo Juan attended, come wind or rain. In the summer of 1953 (the guisi year), the Venerable Master lectured on the *Amitabha Sutra* at Western Bliss Gardens, and Liu Guo Juan came to listen as usual. She was over 60 years old, and her legs and feet were not strong; going up the mountain meant climbing more than 300 rugged stone steps. Even so, she insisted on climbing up every day; she was truly full of sincerity. But how could a deaf person listen to a sutra lecture?

In the Venerable Master's own words:

At Western Bliss Gardens Monastery in Hong Kong, I lectured on the *Shurangama Sutra* for 14 months. During the summer vacation of 1968, at the San Francisco Buddhist Lecture Hall, I lectured on the entire *Shurangama Sutra* in 96 days. That was really as fast as riding a rocket to explore the moon: it was finished in three months. At a sutra lecture assembly, whether or not you can understand what you hear, listening to the sutra here brings inconceivable benefits. I had an old disciple who was very strange: whenever I lectured on a sutra, she would insist on coming to listen. Could she hear? No! She was deaf and couldn't hear the lecture, but she still wanted to listen.

When others lectured on the sutras, she didn't go to listen, because she couldn't hear anything at all. Strangely enough, though she couldn't hear my lectures either, she still came to listen. She told people that if she didn't come to listen to the sutras, she would feel uncomfortable all over, and she felt that if she didn't come this time, she would miss the opportunity. A deaf person coming to listen to the sutras doesn't amount to much in itself. But she was 60 or 70 years old, and she wasn't put off by how high the mountain was, climbing more than 300 stone steps. Someone asked her, "What are you listening to?" She said, "I don't know what I'm listening to." It was just that wonderful.

Once, when I was lecturing on the *Universal Door Chapter*, she was deaf and couldn't hear the lecture, but she still came to listen. They listened and listened, and then one day, which happened to be the second day of the fifth month, before the lecture on the *Amitabha Sutra*, when the assembly began reciting "Namo Lotus Pool Ocean-Wide Assembly of Buddhas and Bodhisattvas" three times, in the snap of a finger she heard a line of "Namo Lotus Pool Ocean-Wide Assembly of Buddhas and Bodhisattvas." She heard it! From then on, her deafness was completely cured, and she was no longer deaf. Tell me, isn't that very mysterious? After she was no longer deaf, she believed in the Buddha even more sincerely. Whenever I lectured on the sutras she came, not lazy even once; she wasn't afraid of heavy rain or strong wind, and she would always come and listen. So this proves that she had a sincere mind in coming to listen to the sutras: even though she couldn't hear, she still wanted to listen, and in the end her deafness was cured.

[Addendum 1] From the diary of Upasika Tan Guo Zheng:

The Master said, "In Manchuria I often came across many extraordinary things. But in Hong Kong there weren't any strange happenings. If there were, I didn't get involved, or I handled them in secret without letting anyone know." Guo Mi, who was beside him, answered, "There were! The case of Liu Guo Juan."

[Addendum 2] On March 10, 2013, Dharma Master Heng Gui said at the Dharma Realm Buddhist Books Distribution Society in Taipei:

Upasika Liu Guo Juan was the wife of my lay grandfather's elder brother. She had great affinities with the Venerable Master. Although she was deaf, she went to Western Bliss Gardens Monastery every day to listen to the Dharma.

Western Bliss Gardens Monastery no longer exists. Some 10 or 20 years ago, while the Master was still in the world, the government wanted to develop the area and widen the road, and the Venerable Master, being very compassionate, gave up Western Bliss Gardens Monastery for the public good. So now it no longer exists.

Western Bliss Gardens Monastery was in a slum, and to get there you had to climb more than 300 steps. I still remember going there as a child: halfway up there was a heap of garbage beside the path, but if you kept climbing up to Western Bliss Gardens Monastery, you found a whole other world; the atmosphere was completely different.

Every day Upasika Liu Guo Juan climbed up there, umbrella in hand, to listen to the sutras. How could a deaf person listen to the sutras? It must have been because she had those good roots! One day she heard people reciting "Namo Lotus Pool Ocean-Wide Assembly of Buddhas and Bodhisattvas," and from then on she was no longer deaf. Although she was no longer deaf, she was Cantonese, while the Venerable Master had a Manchurian accent, so it would have been very hard for her to follow the Venerable Master's Dharma talks. But whether she was deaf or not, she kept on going to apply effort.

29. Earnestly Exhorted, Yet She Did Not Awaken

The sea of suffering is vast, yet people take suffering for pleasure; they know full well that turning back is the shore, yet no one is willing to give up the red dust of the world. Two sisters often went to hear the Venerable Master lecture on the sutras, and each time they saw golden light radiating from the body of the Venerable Master on the Dharma seat...

When the Master was lecturing on the sutras at Tung Sin Tan, the sisters Yuan Guo Xiang and Yuan Guo Zhen often went to listen, and Yuan Guo Xiang saw with her own eyes golden light shining from the Master's body. From then on they had great faith in the Master, and later Upasika Liu Guo Juan introduced them to the Master. The first time Yuan Guo Zhen paid her respects to the Master, on the way home down the mountain she suddenly felt herself bobbing up and down in a vast, boundless sea. She was very frightened, but when she later steadied herself and looked again, the sea had disappeared. Afterward she

mentioned this to the Master, and the Master said, "The sea of suffering is vast and boundless; turn back, and there is the shore." But being young at the time, she could not grasp what the Master meant. The Master said she would have no blessings to enjoy in this life unless she left home.

Some time later, Yuan Guo Zhen's marriage ran into trouble, and before long she gave birth to a daughter. Once, when her daughter was seriously ill, Yuan Guo Zhen carried her daughter on her back up to Western Bliss Gardens. Halfway there they were caught in a heavy rain, and mother and daughter arrived to see the Master soaked to the skin. The Master said to her, "I knew long ago that you would come to this, but still you don't turn back, and still you don't wake up." The Master immediately recited a mantra for her daughter and rubbed the crown of the child's head to bless her, and only then did her daughter gradually grow strong and healthy.

For many years, Upasika Lu Tanzhen had been Yuan Guo Zhen's close friend. One day she told Yuan Guo Zhen to go up the mountain to pay respects to the Master, but Yuan Guo Zhen didn't want to go, because she was hard up and had no money to make an offering to the Master. So Lu Tanzhen lent her money to put in an offering envelope for the Master, and only then did the two of them go up to Western Bliss Gardens together. Once they were up the mountain, Yuan Guo Zhen offered the envelope to the Master. The Master said, "There's no need for an offering envelope here. Take it back." But she left the envelope on the table anyway. Later, the Master said to Lu Tanzhen, "When you go back, tell that lady surnamed Yuan not to give me an offering envelope again next time, because she has no money; the money she put in the envelope was borrowed." Truly inconceivable! Only Yuan Guo Zhen and Lu Tanzhen knew about this, and they never imagined that it could not be hidden from the Master.

[Addendum 1] Yuan Guo Xiang is the mother of Dharma Master Heng Gui, and Yuan Guo Zhen is Dharma Master Heng Gui's aunt and also the mother of Mei Miaoling. When Yuan Guo Xiang was pregnant with Dharma Master Heng Gui, she went to Western Bliss Gardens to see the Master, and the Master said to Guo Xiang, "She isn't born yet, but I already know her!" Dharma Master Heng Gui became the Venerable Master's disciple while still an infant. As a child, she often went with her mother to Western Bliss Gardens to bow to the Buddhas and make offerings. At least 40 or 50 people in her family took refuge with the Venerable Master.

30. A Way to Turn Back Heaven's Decree

The Venerable Master had deeply studied every school and thoroughly investigated the Chan sayings, yet in ordinary times he taught his disciples only to recite the great six-character name "Namo Amitabha Buddha." The Venerable Master's refuge disciple Tang Guo Shan had taken refuge with the Venerable Master early on and believed in the Buddha most sincerely...

When the Venerable Master learned of it, he comforted her with kind words, telling her not to worry, and told her that when she went home she should tell her husband to diligently recite "Namo Amitabha Buddha." If his lifespan was not yet over, then by the power of the Buddha he might recover. If his fate was inescapable, then by sincerely reciting "Namo Amitabha Buddha" he could still be reborn in the Pure Land at the end of his life. The Venerable Master also explained to her in detail the principle that "Heaven is hard to fathom, and life is impermanent," and again instructed her to go home and tell her husband.

When Luo Kangrui heard his wife relay the Venerable Master's words, he felt that they truly made sense, so he begged his wife to go and ask the Venerable Master to let him take refuge. Three days after taking refuge, Luo Kangrui dreamed at night that the Venerable Master was wearing a Five Buddha Crown and a red kashaya, followed by a host of Bodhisattvas of majestic appearance. The Venerable Master told Luo Kangrui, "Your illness will get better. Don't worry!"

When he woke up, he had diarrhea that would not stop. As it turned out, besides his lung disease, Luo Kangrui also had a lump growing in his abdomen. The lung disease alone had already left his whole family terribly worried, so to keep his family from worrying, he had hidden the abdominal mass even from his wife. As a result, during the diarrhea, the mass in his abdomen was actually expelled along with the waste. From then on, Luo Kangrui had even greater faith in the Buddhadharma. Whether walking, standing, sitting, or lying down, his hands never left his recitation beads, and he recited the Buddha's name tens of thousands of times a day. His sincerity evoked a response: within just a few months his body gradually recovered, and when he went back to the hospital for an X-ray, his lung disease had, astonishingly, completely healed.

31. Scalp Sores Heal and Hair Grows Back

From the time Huang Xuemei was 100 days old, she began to break out in scabby sores on her head, which oozed pus and blood and gave off a rank, foul smell that made people cover their noses. Especially in the intense heat of summer, the condition got worse and her hair kept falling out, until she was nearly bald, which was very unsightly. Her family took her to every doctor there was, but both Chinese and Western doctors were helpless. After that they tried every kind of folk remedy, things to eat, things to rub on, injections, every one of them, but none had any effect.

When Xuemei was 3 years old, her father died, and she depended entirely on her mother, who worked as a domestic servant, to raise her. Almost all of each month's income went to pay her medical bills, yet her scabby head was the same as ever. Whenever Mother Huang thought of her daughter's condition, she wept tears of blood, her heart pierced as if by an awl, and she lamented her own ill fate. When Xuemei was 10, the scabby sores on her head still showed no improvement. Then, through a fortunate turn of conditions, she met the Venerable Master and took refuge with him. After she took refuge, strangely

enough, the sores on her head began to scab over and heal; even in the intense heat of summer they gave her no great trouble, and her hair gradually grew back. The scabby, festering sores that had troubled her for more than ten years were completely cured. Seeing her full head of thick hair, nobody could imagine what she had originally looked like.

32. Rich and Poor Alike

The Venerable Master's disciples were rich and poor, old and young. Some were in dire straits and hard up, even working for others as servants or cooks. Whatever a disciple's situation, the Venerable Master treated them all equally well...

Upasika Xu Xiangjun recounted:

My parents both came to Hong Kong from the mainland, and they came to know the Master through Tan Guo Shi's mother. My father was a disciple of Elder Master Hsu Yun, so the Master said he didn't need to take refuge again. When my mother took refuge with the Master, the Master struck her with the incense board and asked her, "Do you know why I struck you with the incense board?" My mother shook her head and looked at the Master. The Master said, "You are my disciple now. I struck you with the incense board to eliminate disasters for you." My mother still looked at the Master with puzzled eyes. The Master went on, "When your father passed away, you didn't go to his funeral, so I struck you with the incense board." That was during the War of Resistance against Japan, and my mother was pregnant, so she had not gone back for the funeral. My mother was astonished that the Master knew even this.

Because our family was poor, the children had to share the housework, so when we wanted to go to Western Bliss Gardens to take part in the group cultivation, we could only take turns going each week. Our family lived in an illegal squatter structure, shabby and run-down. The Master came to our home, and he didn't look down on us because we were poor.

Once my mother was very seriously ill, and the family all thought she would not recover. But the next day she said to the family, "I'm going to get better! Nothing will happen to me. Yesterday I dreamed that the Master came to see me. I'm definitely going to get better, really!" Afterward she really did get better day by day. Sometimes we would have a meal up on the mountain; the Master ate very simply, sometimes just chili peppers with steamed buns.

[Supplementary Note] Upasika Tan Guo Shi recounted:

The children all loved the Master and weren't afraid of him, because he was very friendly to children. As for older disciples, such as my father, the Master never allowed my father to kowtow when he saw him. The Master said, "You're so old; there's no need! No need to bow." My family was not especially rich, but we were comfortably off. We had servants and a driver, so I didn't know how to do any housework; I didn't even know how to wash my own hair. Before I met the

Master, I had a very bad temper. Even though the Master often taught us to treat everyone alike, I would still bully them, thinking of them as servants who were beneath me.

Later I met the Master. The Master taught me many things, I changed a great deal, and my temperament changed as a result. When we went to Western Bliss Gardens for Dharma assemblies, our family's maids and cook sometimes went along too. Mother had them help in the kitchen and also sit with us to listen to the Master lecture on the sutras and speak the Dharma. For me, this was a big turning point. I realized that all people are equal, whether rich or poor, high or low. As long as one truly cultivates, then no matter how poor one is, one will attain unsurpassed wisdom; if one does not cultivate, then even a rich person will die in the end just the same and be just as unable to escape the cycle of rebirth. Later, two of our family's servants, having heard the Buddhadharma, both took refuge with the Master, and afterward both of them left home. I truly feel I fall far short of them!

33. A Ghost Seeks the Five Precepts

At the end of 1952 (the renchen year), Western Bliss Gardens commenced a Buddha-recitation practice, holding a Buddha Recitation Dharma assembly that ran for seven days in a row. On the fifth day of the Buddha Recitation session, as the sixth incense period was ending, a ghost suddenly possessed Zhang Guo Yu...

In the Hong Kong of the 1950s, natural disasters and man-made calamities kept occurring, and society was turbulent and unsettled. The Venerable Master traced this to its root cause and revealed that it had been brought about by the karmic power of living beings; therefore, to turn back this calamitous fate, the strength of the multitude was indispensable. Accordingly, in the renchen year, taking the occasion of Amitabha Buddha's birthday (the seventeenth day of the eleventh lunar month), he held a Buddha Recitation Dharma assembly for seven days in a row (from the eleventh to the seventeenth day of the eleventh lunar month), from 8 a.m. to 7 p.m. every day. Western Bliss Gardens was located up on a mountain, and although the mountain was steep and the way long, many devotees still took part.

Several days went by like this. On the fifth day of the Buddha Recitation session (that is, the fifteenth day of the eleventh lunar month), toward evening, just as the sixth incense period ended, Zhang Guo Yu suddenly knelt before the Venerable Master. It turned out that a ghost had attached itself to Zhang Guo Yu and was earnestly begging the Venerable Master to give it the precepts. Only after the Venerable Master granted its request did Zhang Guo Yu come out of a stupor and regain clear consciousness. Those attending the Dharma assembly clicked their tongues in amazement: even ghosts knew to come and seek the precepts!

From the Venerable Master's instructional talk at the opening of the Amitabha Buddha Recitation session at the City of Ten Thousand Buddhas, winter 1979:

The whole world is full of natural disasters and man-made calamities; it is dark and without light. This shows that the lives of all humankind are in danger. Such murderous, violent energy has never existed before. We know about atomic bombs, hydrogen bombs, and nuclear weapons, and now there are lasers as well. Once these lethal weapons are put to use, humankind may well perish all together. Therefore, at this point in time, only by cultivating according to the Buddhadharma can we wipe out disasters before they ever take form. The whole world is filled with black energy; wherever there are genuine cultivators, that place will have somewhat fewer disasters. When many people cultivate together, their combined strength can eliminate disasters and dissolve calamities, imperceptibly turning violent, hostile energy into auspicious, harmonious energy. But you must keep your feet on the ground, actually put it into practice yourselves, and cultivate according to the Buddhadharma. Everyone, bring forth your true mind and recite the Buddha's name. Each time you recite the Buddha's name once, a ray of light appears in empty space. If you can recite the Buddha's name earnestly and with utmost sincerity, this light will shine throughout the three thousand worlds, making the atmosphere of the three-thousand-great-thousand world system turn auspicious and transforming the polluted, violent, disaster-laden atmosphere.

[Addendum 1] From the diary of Upasika Tan Guo Zheng:

The Buddha Recitation session had six incense periods each day. By the time we did the dedication of merit, it was already six or seven in the evening; we were there all day long. The Master was very strict: not a single person could get out of morning recitation.

[Addendum 2] Upasika Tan Guo Shi recounted:

Because most of the devotees at Western Bliss Gardens were poor and could not read much, the Master taught them to recite the Buddha's name. During a Guanyin session or an Amitabha Buddha session, each time we would recite the Buddha's name for about an hour and then sit in meditation for half an hour. The Master gave an instructional talk every day, and sometimes he also had disciples go up on the platform and speak for a while. There were two instructional talks each day, one in the afternoon and one in the evening. The Dharma assembly went from morning until night, and after evening recitation we continued reciting the Buddha's name. After the Master finished his instructional talk, we did the great dedication of merit, and it ended at about nine o'clock.

34. The Departed Are Freed from Suffering

Out of great compassion, and as an expedient for all living beings, the Venerable Master transmitted the precepts for the deceased [Tr.: precepts transmitted on behalf of the departed] in order to rescue the spirits of ancestors, wronged souls, and other beings. The Venerable Master's disciple Li Guo He, in a moment

of carelessness, forgot to receive the precepts for the deceased on behalf of his late mother...

After the Venerable Master built Western Bliss Gardens in Hong Kong, the devotees grew more numerous day by day, because there was now a fixed place. To meet the needs of living beings, he often held Dharma assemblies; he also set up memorial tablets for rescuing the deceased and transmitted the precepts for the deceased.

Once, when Western Bliss Gardens was going to transmit the precepts for the deceased, Upasaka Li Guo He went and signed up to receive the precepts for the deceased on behalf of his ancestors. Afterward he went down the mountain with everyone else, but halfway down, his legs suddenly hurt so much that he couldn't take a single step forward. Strangely, when he turned around and walked back up the mountain, he moved freely and his legs didn't hurt at all. Li Guo He tried this several times, and it was always the same, so he had no choice but to turn back to Western Bliss Gardens and report the matter to the Master. The Venerable Master smiled and asked him, "Did you forget to receive the precepts for the deceased on behalf of your mother?" When Li Guo He heard this, it suddenly dawned on him, and he hurried to sign up his mother to receive the precepts for the deceased. Once he had signed her up, he had no trouble going down the mountain.

[Addendum] Dharma Master Heng Sure, speaking on the evening of August 31, 2000, in the outdoor tent Buddha Hall at the City of Ten Thousand Buddhas:

Requesting the precepts for the deceased is an act of filial piety and of repaying kindness; it is practicing great filiality. As you all know very well, the saying goes, "The tree wishes to be still, but the wind will not stop; the child wishes to care for his parents, but they are no longer here." A person's parents may already have passed away, and while they were alive he himself didn't understand how to be filial; when he wakes up and wants to be filial, there's nothing he can do, because his parents are no longer here. You originally had several decades in which you could have served them, been filial, and repaid your parents' kindness, but sadly you missed it. So what then? The precepts for the deceased can help you continue practicing filial piety: "The spirits on whose behalf I request the precepts have already passed away, but I am still willing to keep doing meritorious deeds for them and to dedicate to them the merit and virtue of the precepts for the deceased." That extends filial piety beyond the stage at which their bodies are no longer here. Isn't that wonderful? This enables the merit and virtue of the Dharma door of filial piety to continue. Why? Because although the people are no longer at our side, the relationship between us still continues in our hearts, so we use this relationship to do meritorious deeds and dedicate them to them. This is very wonderful. This is how the Venerable Master explained the precepts for the deceased at the City of Ten Thousand Buddhas.

35. The King of Praises of His Generation

Dharma Master Xu Lang was often invited to Western Bliss Gardens and Cixing Chan Monastery to help with Dharma ceremonies. The Venerable Master praised his chanting as being among the very best in China; he was universally acknowledged as the "King of Praises"...

Dharma Master Xu Lang once wrote an essay in remembrance of the Venerable Master:

I came to know Dharma Master To Lun at Nanhua Monastery in Guangdong. At that time he had just resigned from his post at the Vinaya Academy and was in charge of the Sutra Library, and I got to know him because I went to the Sutra Library to borrow sutras. Since he was from Manchuria and I was also from Manchuria, he took special care of me. Unexpectedly, we later ran into each other again at Tung Po Tor Monastery in Hong Kong, but he left after staying only a few days. It was not until he had Western Bliss Gardens Monastery and often asked me to come and help perform Dharma ceremonies that we were in regular contact.

[Addendum] Upasika Tan Guo Shi recounted:

The Master did not put emphasis on chanting; he often respectfully invited Dharma Masters to come and help with the Dharma assemblies. I remember that when I was little and went to Dharma assemblies at Western Bliss Gardens, what impressed me most was hearing the chanting voice of one Dharma Master. It truly "lingered around the rafters for three days, ringing on and on in the ears," and it filled those who heard it with joy. I had always loved singing, so I ran to ask the Master, "Who is that cantor Dharma Master?" The Master said, "That's Dharma Master Xu Lang. Did you know? Before the Liberation, his chanting was among the very best in China, and he was especially famous for chanting praises. If you said he was number two, nobody would dare claim to be number one. He's universally acknowledged as the 'King of Praises,' so of course he chants well!"

The Master went on, "I knew him when I was at Nanhua Monastery, and I never expected that we would meet again at Tung Po Tor Monastery, so I've invited him to help with the Dharma assemblies. If you're willing to learn from him, how about I ask him to teach you?" Before long, the Master announced to everyone, "Whoever wants to learn chanting from this 'King of Praises,' hurry and sign up! I don't know how to chant, so I can't teach you. Since you can learn from this 'King of Praises,' don't miss this good opportunity. That this 'King of Praises' is willing to teach you is your good fortune!" When they heard the Master say this, everyone rushed in a swarm to learn chanting from Dharma Master Xu Lang.

I remember that one day 20 or 30 laypeople came to class. Some were 60 or 70 years old and some were 40 or 50, and I counted as the youngest. At the beginning, everyone thought it would be great fun and very easy: imagine standing before the Buddhas, holding the Dharma instruments and striking away; how impressive! Who would have known that Dharma Master Xu Lang

would be so serious about teaching, and especially meticulous in teaching how to play the Dharma instruments? Within a few days, fewer and fewer people came to class, until only the four or five of us young ones were left.

He said that what he had learned was the Shanghai "Sea Tide Sound" style of chanting. He wanted us to sing using the breath from the dantian [Tr.: the energy center in the lower abdomen]; every note had to be drawn out very long, rising and falling like waves, and every word had to be enunciated correctly with a full, round tone. He had us follow the beat, striking the table hard with our hands to keep time. He said the more it hurt to beat, the faster we would remember, and only after we had learned it thoroughly by heart and wouldn't make mistakes could we play the Dharma instruments. Dharma Master Xu Lang taught us to chant praises and to play the large Dharma instruments, and he also taught us the repentance ceremonies, reading out the memorials (shu), the Mengshan Food Bestowal, and all the ceremonial procedures for bowing to the Buddhas. He said, "Chanting praises, reciting sutras, and playing the Dharma instruments must all be dignified, because we are making offerings of sound to all the Buddhas and Bodhisattvas. If the chanting is not in accord with the Dharma and the Dharma instruments are played in a chaotic jumble, not only will it give the devotees afflictions, it is also disrespectful to the Buddhas and Bodhisattvas. What would originally have brought limitless merit and virtue ends up bringing no merit and virtue at all."

I remember the first time Dharma Master Xu Lang taught us to chant the *Medicine Master Repentance*. I don't know whether it had something to do with my past lives, but as soon as I looked at the text, I knew how it should be chanted. Sometimes the Dharma assemblies were led by Dharma Master Xu Lang, and sometimes by Dharma Master Heng Yue and Dharma Master Heng Zhi, with Guo Song, Guo Su, and me helping. Later on, I served as cantor for most of the Dharma ceremonies. In Hong Kong we bowed the *Great Compassion Repentance* and the *Medicine Master Repentance*. Most of the people who took refuge with the Master in Hong Kong spoke Cantonese, so apart from the texts of praise, which were chanted in Mandarin (Putonghua), the sutra texts and the repentance texts were all recited in Cantonese. Nowadays repentance ceremonies in Hong Kong are all chanted in Cantonese; that was something we started in the early days.

I once asked Dharma Master Xu Lang why his chanting voice was so beautiful. He said, "For this I have to thank Guanshiyin Bodhisattva! I left the home-life at 15, and when I heard a cantor whose chanting was extremely beautiful, I admired him tremendously. An elder Dharma Master learned what was on my mind and said to me, 'If you want a good chanting voice, go and pray to Guanshiyin Bodhisattva. If a monastic doesn't know how to chant, how is he going to make a living in the future?' You see, ours was a small temple, and the monastics mostly lived on the income from reciting sutras and bowing repentances for people. This elder Dharma Master said, 'Go buy a large bell. In front of the Buddha, first strike it three times, then recite Guanyin Bodhisattva's

name once. After that, strike the bell once, bow once, and sincerely pray to Guanyin Bodhisattva to give you a good voice.' So I did as the elder Dharma Master instructed, and I kept bowing like this until I received full ordination at 18. One day the cantor was sick, so the abbot had no choice but to have me stand in for him. Because I had always paid very close attention to chanting, I completed the ceremony without a hitch. There were no loudspeakers in those days, yet everyone at a Dharma assembly of several hundred people could hear my voice just the same. From then on, whenever there was a big Dharma assembly, people would come and ask me to serve as cantor."

Elder Xu Lang was never the least bit careless about the chanting and recitation in Buddhist ceremonies. When he presided over the "Yoga Flaming Mouth" ceremony, there were a great many spiritual responses, which people passed on by word of mouth. At the Opening-the-Light ceremony of Cixing Monastery on Lantau Island, the Venerable Master invited Elder Xu Lang to help with the Buddhist ceremonies. One evening, during the "Yoga Flaming Mouth" ceremony, many people saw and heard the spirits of the dead and the beings of the ghost realm hurrying there to be rescued.

In 1995, when the Master entered perfect stillness at Long Beach Monastery in Los Angeles, Elder Xu Lang, considering it his bounden duty, guided the arrangements for the ceremonies so that they could be carried out in accordance with the Dharma and with proper ritual, and he performed a "Three Periods of Mindfulness" ceremony for the Master (one of the supreme practices of the Pure Land Dharma door). Afterward, at the City of Ten Thousand Buddhas, Elder Dharma Master Xu Lang and Elder Master Ming Yang jointly presided over the Venerable Master's cremation ceremony.

[Appendix] In Respectful Memory of Elder Master Xu Lang (excerpted from the February and March 2010 issues of *Vajra Bodhi Sea*)

The Venerable Master's old friend Elder Master Xu Lang passed away in Los Angeles, U.S.A., on September 29, 2009, at the age of 90; with his passing the Buddhist world lost a Good and Wise Advisor. The Venerable Master said that his chanting and recitation were among the very best in China, and that he was universally acknowledged as the "King of Praises." Elder Master Xu Lang was born on April 27, 1919, in Liaoning Province, China. He left the home-life at 15 and received full ordination at 18; he had been a monastic for 75 years and a fully ordained monk for 72. Following Elder Xu Lang's final instructions, his disciples did not publish a notice in the newspapers, did not send out an obituary, and still less spent lavishly on an elaborate funeral. From the following memorial couplet offered by the Dharma Realm Buddhist Association, one can see that Elder Xu Lang's conduct and deportment are a model for us. We sincerely hope that his example will inspire those who come after, so that the Buddhadharma will flourish greatly.

> *Radiant, radiant, the light of wisdom has left behind a legacy of love;*
> *though on this day it has faded,*

the light of wisdom ever remains,
shining everywhere, even beyond the Saha world. [Tr.: the two lines of this couplet open with the two characters of the Elder's name: Xu, "rising sun," and Lang, "bright, clear."]

旭旭慧光曾遺愛 此日雖銷 慧光常存 娑婆界外尤普照

Clear, clear, the Brahma sound long circled the rafters;
though this present body has passed away,
the Brahma sound seems still to be here,
heard from afar even within Maitreya's Court.

朗朗梵音久繞梁 今身已滅 梵音宛在 彌勒院中亦遙聞

36. Guo Shi Takes Refuge

To teach and transform the Westernized young people of Hong Kong, the Venerable Master used expedient means to guide them and change their bad habits and faults, hoping to nurture Buddhist talent with proper knowledge and views. Upasika Tan Guo Shi grew up in Westernized Hong Kong. She came to know the Venerable Master when she was in primary school, and she took refuge with the Venerable Master during the Guanyin session in Western Bliss Gardens' second year...

Upasika Tan Guo Shi recounted:

To me, the Master was like one of my own family, an elder; that's why I always went to Western Bliss Gardens after school. At school I would finish my homework first and then leave school a bit early to go to Western Bliss Gardens to see the Master. That way, every day I had almost an hour to read books aloud to the Master or listen to the Master tell stories. The Master had me read *Biographies of Eminent Monks* and *Stories of Jigong*. The book that made the deepest impression on me, and also the one I liked best, was *National Master Yulin*. After reading stories, I would go home for dinner.

When I first met the Master, I didn't take refuge right away. Even after I had learned to play the Dharma instruments, and even helped out at the Master's refuge ceremonies, I still never took refuge. To me it was just a formality; I didn't know that I needed to take refuge. Since he was my parents' teacher, I should properly have called him "Grand Master"; but to me he wasn't a Grand Master, he was "our" Master, so I always called him "Shifu."

Although I studied at a Christian school and could recite the whole Bible from memory, I didn't believe in Catholicism or Protestant Christianity at all. That was because I had asked my teacher: if God created human beings, why are there so many poor people and ugly people? Why did he create people so different from one another? Right up until I graduated, my teacher never answered my question. My elder sister went to a Catholic school, and she too never came to believe in Catholicism, because some of her questions never got answers. When I met the Master, I asked the Master the same question, and the

Master's answer completely convinced me: "Whatever we do, that is what we will get."

I also asked the Master, "If I had past lives, then what was I like in my past lives?" The Master did answer me. I didn't ask these questions directly; instead I wrote a little poem whose last line was "May I ask about my roots and origins?" The Master said to me, "I've read your poem. Do you really want to know your roots and origins?" I said, "Of course! You've said we have all had many, many lives. I want to know what I used to be." He told me what I had been in a past life, but he said, "I've told you about your past life, but only you may know it. In the future you're going to help me; you will be my right and left hand." I said, "No problem!" At that time I was always thinking up very striking, unusual questions, and I was very competitive, so that's how I answered the Venerable Master. I never thought about taking refuge, and the Master never brought it up either.

In the sixth lunar month of 1953, Western Bliss Gardens held a Guanyin session. When I went to Western Bliss Gardens, I saw the Master lying on his bed, not saying a word, perfectly quiet. Some people were kneeling beside the Master; my mother, my elder sister, and Guo Song and her mother were kneeling there too. Some of them were crying, and some looked very sad. I asked my sister in a low voice, "What's happened? Why are you all kneeling here?" "The Master isn't eating. He won't eat anything; for the last few days he's only been drinking water. The Master is going to die!" Nobody dared say anything, and that silence was terribly sad. I ran to the Master's bedside, knelt, and said to the Master, "Shifu, why aren't you eating?"

"The people of Hong Kong are too hard to teach and transform. They're so stubborn, they won't listen to teaching, and I don't know how to teach them anymore. I'm thinking of leaving," the Master said.

"Shifu, I remember when you were speaking the Dharma, you said you wanted to save everyone. You want to cross over living beings!"

"Cross over what living beings? They're so obstinate, there's no way I can cross them over."

"Didn't you teach me that no matter what difficulties I meet, it doesn't matter, I must find a way to overcome them? Why are you giving up?"

"But no one is helping me."

"I'll help you." I blurted it out at once; even I didn't know why I said it.

"Is that so? You'll help me?"

"Yes. If you eat, I'll help you."

"But you're still an outsider. How can you help me?" At the time I didn't know what "outsider" meant, so I said, "What did you say?"

"I said you're an outsider."

"What's an outsider?"

"It means you're still standing outside the door."

"That's easy. I'm standing inside the room right now; I've already come in."

"No, that's not what I mean. I mean you haven't taken refuge yet, so you're still an outsider."

"Haven't I already been calling you 'Shifu'? I think taking refuge is just a formality; it doesn't mean anything."

"No! Without a compass and a square, you cannot make circles and squares."

"That's easy. I can become an insider: I'll just take refuge. If I take refuge, will you eat and not leave?"

In the end the Master did eat, and that same afternoon (the nineteenth day of the sixth lunar month) I formally took refuge.

Guo Jun took refuge before me, and Guo Mi took refuge after me. The Master composed a verse for each of us, working our Dharma names into them. I know that Guo Song had one, but I don't remember what the Master wrote for her. (Editor's note: The Venerable Master presented his refuge disciple Huang Guo Song with the lines "With the plum as the cause, prajna blossoms; with the pine as the fruit, Bodhi is certified." [Tr.: the lines pair yin, "cause," with guo, "fruit," and the plum (mei, from her name Huang Jiemei) with the pine (song).]) Using my Dharma name, the Master wrote this verse: "Vigorously cultivate the One Vehicle, / and be a model for ten thousand generations. / Universally transform your fellow beings, / so that together all ascend to the ground of Buddhahood. / Be a model! Be a model!" [Tr.: shi, the second character of her Dharma name Guo Shi, means "model, pattern."] What did it mean? The Master said he wanted me to set an example for everyone; I'm ashamed that I've never managed to do it! This treasured calligraphy of the Master's is still enshrined in the Buddha hall in my home today. After taking refuge, I often went to Western Bliss Gardens, and whatever the Master told me to do, I did my best to do, such as learning the Buddhist ceremonial procedures and helping out at Dharma assemblies.

Once, the Master took me to see Dharma Master Mao Feng. Before he left the home-life, Dharma Master Mao Feng had been a xiucai, a scholar who had passed the imperial examinations, and poetry flowed from his lips whenever he opened his mouth. After asking my name, the elder Dharma Master wrote two couplet scrolls using my name and my Dharma name: [Tr.: the lines begin with the characters of her birth name, Mu and Jie (Tan Mujie), and of her Dharma name, Guo and Shi.]

> *First line: Admiring the sages and admiring the worthies, become a superior person;*
> *purifying the mind and purifying the will, become a lofty one.*
> 上聯：慕聖慕賢為上士，潔心潔志作高人。

Second line: If you can truly make the great Bodhi vow,
you will fittingly be a model teacher for humans and gods.

下聯：果能發大菩提願，式合人天模范師。

Once, when the Master came to my home to receive a meal offering, he saw that I had hung these two couplet scrolls in the house, and he joked with me:

"Dharma Master Mao Feng thinks so highly of you, he's praised you all the way up to the heavens and made you a guiding teacher of humans and gods!"

"Shifu, didn't you say that when heavenly beings have used up their blessings, they fall? I don't want to go up to heaven and then fall back down," I answered.

"Don't worry. If you drop down (fall), I'll catch you (save you)," the Master said.

"All right, you have to keep your word. If I fall, you have to come and save me," I said.

We often joked like this. I learned a great deal from the Master, and I respected him very, very much, even though I sometimes joked with him.

37. Praying for Rain to End a Drought

Wherever the Venerable Master went, places that had no water came to have water. Once there was a drought in Hong Kong, and it did not rain for six months in a row. Many Way-places, monasteries, and viharas were praying for rain, but the drought still went on...

In the Venerable Master's own words:

One year Hong Kong had a terrible drought. From spring to summer it didn't rain for six months, so water use was restricted every day. All the Buddhist Way-places, monasteries, lecture halls, and viharas were praying for rain. With so many people praying for rain, I didn't get involved. I've never been willing to meddle in other people's business. With so many people praying for rain, their strength had to be greater than mine alone, so I stayed out of it. But after five or six months, I couldn't stay out of it even if I wanted to. Why? Because the water at Western Bliss Gardens was about to dry up too. Very little water was coming down from the mountain, and it had such a strong taste of sulfur that it was practically undrinkable. At that point I gave Liu Guo Juan an order: "Within three days, you have to pray for rain for me. You must recite the Buddha's name every day. If it doesn't rain, then don't you ever come to see me again!" Actually she had no special abilities; I said that to her on purpose.

Now Liu Guo Juan really panicked. What she feared most was not being able to see the Master; she could do without seeing anything else, but she had to come and see the Master every day. She was really very simple and honest. She took a string of recitation beads and recited the Buddha's name for all she was worth, even forgetting to eat, for fear that it wouldn't rain. I said to Cheng Guo Cheng, "They've been praying for rain for several months, and it still hasn't rained. Now I've given Liu Guo Juan three days to pray for rain; I figure it will rain in about

two and a half days." She recited for two and a half days, and sure enough, it started pouring rain, and so Hong Kong lifted its water restrictions.

As soon as this rain came, all the temples and Buddha halls put advertisements in the newspapers, every one of them coming forward to claim credit and saying it was all thanks to them. This one said, "Our repentance bowing was efficacious; we're the ones who brought the rain." That one said their Buddha recitation was efficacious and that their Buddha hall had brought the rain. In reality, they had no idea how the rain came! All the Buddha halls got credit; only Western Bliss Gardens didn't claim any credit or report any virtue. Nobody knew that the rain had come from my old disciple's Buddha recitation, either. Why? Because she didn't put it in the news; we didn't publicize how this rain came about. Still, if this made them happy, I rejoiced along with them. I'm not saying these things at all to show off any power of my own, but to explain the principle that "where the mind is sincere, there is a response."

Why did I give Liu Guo Juan three days to bring down rain? I wanted this old disciple to recite the Buddha's name more, to pray for rain on everyone's behalf, and to accumulate a bit more merit and virtue. I'll tell you, never mind three days: if I told the heavens to rain that very day, the rain would come. Why? Because I have ten dragon disciples. If these ten dragons aren't lazy, whichever one I tell to make rain will make rain. Things like this have happened many times, so you must be sincere in your cultivation, and these dragon disciples of mine will all help you; if you don't cultivate the Way, they won't protect and support you.

Another time, during the first lunar month, we were making offerings to the heavens. Because there were too many people and not enough room inside Western Bliss Gardens, we set up the tables outside on the open ground. Just as we were about to make the offerings to the heavens, clouds rolled in as if it were going to rain, and everyone said, "This won't do, this won't do! We have to move into the Buddha hall; it's going to rain out here!" At the time I thought, it can't rain now, so I told them, "Don't move. It won't rain. If we're making offerings to the heavens and the heavens still rain on us, that would be a complete lack of response! We make offerings to the heavens, and the heavens weep anyway? There's no such principle."

In short, as their teacher I'm just this dictatorial, this autocratic: whatever I say goes. If what I say is right, it's right, and if it's not right, it's still right. So they didn't dare move. The offering to the heavens took about three hours. Because I didn't allow it to rain, the sky was just covered with dark clouds, and no rain fell. Only after we had finished making offerings to the heavens and carried the incense burners, candlesticks, and tables into the Buddha hall did it immediately start pouring outside. So some of my refuge disciples in Hong Kong had great faith in me; they knew that what I said was very efficacious and always came true.

Today I manifested a small spiritual power again. Early this morning I said to Guo Xiu (the American Bhikshuni Dharma Master Heng Chih), "Guo Xiu, go tell the deity, tell this God, that it's not allowed to rain before four o'clock this afternoon. If it rains, I'm going to lose my temper!" You all know that, sure enough, it didn't rain before four o'clock today. Guo Xiu, I didn't tell you a lie, did I? You heard it with your own ears! What I did doesn't count as a spiritual power; I haven't got a single power, not one. It's just that when I say something, it does it.

[Addendum 1] In the summer of the jiawu year (1954), since the nineteenth day of the sixth lunar month is the anniversary of Guanyin Bodhisattva's attainment of the Way, the Venerable Master held a seven-day Dharma assembly at Western Bliss Gardens (from the thirteenth to the nineteenth). On the eighteenth and nineteenth, as many as several hundred devotees came to Western Bliss Gardens. It was the height of summer; the weather was scorching hot and dry, and to save water the Hong Kong government supplied water for only three hours a day, so the people complained bitterly about the water shortage. Yet the pond at Western Bliss Gardens was the same as always, without the slightest sign of drought; water kept flowing in without end, fully supplying several hundred people with drinking water and everything else they needed. It could well be called "a miracle among miracles."

[Addendum 2] Upasika Mei Miaoling recounted:

When I was little, about 8 to 10 years old, I went to Western Bliss Gardens with my mother (Yuan Guo Zhen), and the Master would always bring out lots of things for me to eat. Once when it was raining heavily, my mother brought me up the mountain while I was sick. When it was time for the meal, the Master told the kitchen not to serve the meal yet; only after we arrived did the Master begin to eat. Every time we went up to Western Bliss Gardens, my mother would tell the Master beforehand when we would next come up. Several times the Master told my mother to come up the mountain an hour early, and it turned out that an hour later it started pouring rain. The Master always gave me shiitake mushrooms to eat; the Master would chew them up first and then give them to me.

38. The Typhoons Vanish

During the Venerable Master's 12 years in Hong Kong, typhoon warnings were issued again and again, yet each time, just as the storm's circle was closing in, it would suddenly change course. In 1960, when the Venerable Master left Hong Kong for Australia, a powerful typhoon struck Hong Kong and caused heavy losses...

In the Venerable Master's own words:

I'm not trying to scare you, and I'm not saying how great I am, but the gods, dragons, and the rest of the eightfold division, and all the ghosts and spirits, listen to me! At Western Bliss Gardens I planted lots of flowers, plants, and

trees: papayas, bamboo, and fruit trees, and the papayas they bore were very sweet. The following spring, that is, the spring of my third year in Hong Kong, just when the papayas were ripe and the bamboo was at its most luxuriant, a typhoon suddenly came and tore the papaya trees, the pine trees, and the bamboo up by the roots, leaving everything scattered in a wreck.

I lost my temper, pointed my finger at the sky, and said, "Jade Emperor! If this typhoon has anything to do with you, I have something to say to you now: for as long as I live in Hong Kong, I won't allow you to blow any more typhoons. If Hong Kong gets hit by another typhoon, I'm telling you straight, I won't be polite about it! Later on, once I leave Hong Kong, then I won't concern myself with it!" After I said that, I thought, "Hey, how could I act like this? Losing my temper at Heaven is not right!" But even though I felt it wasn't right, the words had already been spoken.

Very strange! From then on, during the more than ten years I lived in Hong Kong, Hong Kong was never hit by a typhoon. Every time the observatory said a typhoon was going to strike Hong Kong, the typhoon, which had been heading straight for Hong Kong, would suddenly turn and go somewhere else when it was still 20 miles, or 15 miles, from Hong Kong. It was just that strange! But I had been in Sydney, Australia, for only one month when Hong Kong was hit by a typhoon: signboards flew all over the sky, a great many houses were smashed, and the losses were incalculable. In 1962 I went to America, and that summer a record-breaking great storm came; the mud on the hillsides of Sha Tin slid down too, and more than 150 people were killed or injured. How such a thing could happen, nobody knew.

These are things of the past. What I've said is absolutely true; believe it or not, as you like!

Because I don't tell lies, Heaven won't oppose what I say either; this is my own experience from the past. I hope everyone can refrain from killing, stealing, sexual misconduct, lying, and drinking alcohol. If you do, the gods, dragons, and the rest of the eightfold division, and all the Dharma-protecting spirits, will protect and support you, and everything will go as you wish and be auspicious.

[Addendum 1] As recorded in Wikipedia:

In the 1960s Hong Kong was struck by a number of severe typhoons, which caused major economic losses and heavy casualties. These led the Hong Kong Observatory to hoist the No. 10 Hurricane Signal as many as six times. Among them, Typhoon Mary, which struck Hong Kong in June 1960, left 45 dead and 127 injured and destroyed about 10,000 homes. Typhoon Wanda, which struck Hong Kong in 1962, caused 130 deaths and left 72,000 people homeless. It set Hong Kong's records for the lowest air pressure, the highest hourly mean wind speed, and the highest gust speed, and was one of the most disastrous typhoons ever to strike Hong Kong.

[Addendum 2] As reported at the time by Hong Kong's *Sing Pao*:

For Typhoon Wanda, the Observatory hoisted the No. 10 signal on September 1, 1962; it was the most powerful typhoon to strike Hong Kong since records began after the Second World War. Wanda brought serious destruction to the whole of Hong Kong. According to the authorities' subsequent tally, it caused 183 deaths and 388 injuries, and 108 people were missing. Because many residents at that time lived in squatter huts and rooftop wooden huts, the force of the typhoon completely destroyed these poorly built dwellings, leaving as many as 72,000 people homeless. The damage was most severe in the Sha Tin district, where about 3,000 squatter huts collapsed, and the roads were strewn with debris, corrugated iron sheets, scaffolding, broken windows, and the like. Wanda also set several meteorological records, including the records for the highest gust and the highest hourly mean wind speed, which no other typhoon has broken to this day.

In the Venerable Master's own words:

One year I went back to Hong Kong and spoke the Dharma for five days at a monastery. Since I hadn't been back to Hong Kong for a long time, returning felt like seeing my own family. Things I had never said while I was in Hong Kong, this time I wanted to talk over very sincerely with my elders and brothers there. I talked about how, during the more than ten years I lived in Hong Kong, Hong Kong was never hit by a typhoon. I said it honestly at the time, without the slightest lie, but then someone got people to write articles in magazines saying that what I said was not true. When I read them I just smiled. Who would have thought that even telling the truth would get you slandered? But this too is "the Dharma is naturally thus": "All dharmas arise from conditions; all dharmas cease from conditions." So I just treated it as wind passing my ears. But some of my well-educated refuge disciples were very unhappy and wrote letters to me, asking my permission to start a war of words with these people, so I wrote a few lines of verse for these people:

> *Why must right and wrong be argued?*
> *Given time, what is true and what is false become clear of themselves.*
> 是非何須辯，真偽久自明。
>
> *The wise see what is true and real;*
> *the foolish practice falsehood and pretense.*
> 智者見真實，愚者行虛偽。
>
> *The good learn from the Bodhisattvas;*
> *the evil dare even to scold the Buddha.*
> 善者學菩薩，惡者敢罵佛。
>
> *With impartial, great kindness and compassion,*
> *gather in all beings with consciousness everywhere.*
> 平等大慈悲，普攝諸含識。

"Why must right and wrong be argued?": If you say something is right, he can say it's wrong; if you say it's wrong, he'll say it's right. There's no way to get

right and wrong sorted out. The evil world of the five turbidities is just this chaotic; good and evil are muddled together and can't be told apart. Only with the eye that discerns dharmas can you recognize them, so there's no need to go arguing over right and wrong. "Given time, what is true and what is false become clear of themselves": whether something is true or false, after a long time everyone will naturally know whether it was true or false. "The wise see what is true and real": people with wisdom see only what is true and real. "The foolish practice falsehood and pretense": foolish, ignorant people only go around deceiving others and promoting themselves everywhere.

"The good learn from the Bodhisattvas": although good people are not Bodhisattvas, they are willing to learn the Bodhisattvas' spirit of kindness, compassion, joy, and giving. "The evil dare even to scold the Buddha": never mind a poor monk, evil people would dare to scold even the Buddha to his face. Therefore, "With impartial, great kindness and compassion, gather in all beings with consciousness everywhere": we use a mind of impartiality, a mind of great kindness and compassion, and a mind of great joy and giving to gather in all creatures that wriggle and all that have spiritual awareness, all living beings.

After I gave these lines of verse, the war of words was quietly defused. It wasn't that I was afraid; it's just that there's no need to stir up so much right and wrong within Buddhism. So after that I seldom went back to Hong Kong, so as not to arouse people's jealousy and have them take the false for true and the true for false.

I'm telling you, whoever you may be, don't praise your teacher. As long as you don't scold your teacher or lose your temper at me, that's enough. There's no need to flatter me, and no need to praise me, because whether I'm good or not, I myself know perfectly clearly. I don't need others to tell me, and I don't want others praising me in any way. Your praising me like this may not seem to matter much, but some Buddhist figures in Hong Kong will write articles scolding me again, saying, "This Dharma Master and his disciples are putting on a show together! The disciples praise and praise their teacher, and the teacher praises and praises his disciples; they praise each other, putting on a show!"

Question: Since the Dharma Master was able to keep all typhoons from striking Hong Kong when he lived there, can he now stop all typhoons for the residents of Hong Kong?

Venerable Master: You should ask that nobody in all of Hong Kong will ever die!

Question: Most people in Hong Kong are anxious about what lies ahead. Could the Venerable Master please put the minds of the people of Hong Kong at ease?

Venerable Master: Rather than looking to the road ahead, better to look to the road behind. Whatever is behind is what will be ahead; and whatever is ahead, the same will be behind. "Originally nothing is wrong under heaven; ordinary people stir up trouble for themselves." "Upon those with virtue, blessings descend; upon those without virtue, calamities descend."

39. The Crab Harbors a Grievance

In the summer of 1953 (the guisi year), the lay Buddhist Dong Guo Qi and the Dharma Master who was manager of Chi Lin Nunnery at Diamond Hill in Kowloon respectfully invited the Venerable Master to lecture on the *Earth Store Sutra*. At that time a crab of flesh had grown on the manager's finger, causing her unspeakable pain, and she asked the Venerable Master for help...

In the Venerable Master's own words:

In Hong Kong I once came across something. In the summer of 1953 I was lecturing on the *Earth Store Sutra* at Chi Lin Nunnery. The manager was a disciple of Elder Hsu, and she had great merit and virtue from supporting Elder Hsu. No matter where Elder Hsu was establishing a Way-place, she would help him seek donations in Hong Kong, and she raised a great deal of money. She couldn't read, but she was a very good talker, and laypeople in general trusted her a great deal. Before she left the home-life, she worked for others, cooking meals, and she often bought chickens and ducks and brought them home to kill. Once she bought some crabs and brought them back, intending to prepare them for her employer to eat. One of the crabs clamped onto her middle finger with its pincer and wouldn't let go, so she chopped the pincer off with a knife and then cooked the crab to be eaten. Not long afterward, her finger hurt terribly from morning to night; the pain was simply killing her.

Later she bowed the *Water Repentance* for seven days at Fu Yung Shan. Although this crab of flesh became a little smaller, it still swelled and hurt. When I was lecturing on the *Earth Store Sutra* at Chi Lin Nunnery, she knew I wasn't competing with her for Dharma affinities, so at that time she didn't yet have any jealousy toward me, and she told me about the causes and conditions of this crab and asked me to help her find a way to resolve the grievance. She asked me, "My hand often hurts. How can it get better?" I said, "Just go and repent!" She said, "I've bowed this repentance and bowed that repentance, I've bowed lots of repentances, but none of them has repented away this Big Brother Crab of mine." She called this crab "Big Brother Crab." "Big Brother Crab just won't leave!" I said, "It's going to leave you now. Have it take refuge, and you'll be fine." When she heard this, she signed it up to take refuge, and I gave it the Dharma name "Sheng Luo" [Tr.: "Sagely Conch"]. From then on, her Big Brother Crab ran off, and her hand stopped hurting. After her crab ailment was cured, she saw that her group of devotees all believed in me, so she began spreading rumors and slandering me. That's just how Buddhist circles are, and that's why they can't develop.

Even so, this person had some affinity with the Buddha and some affinity with ghosts too. How is it that she had some affinity with the Buddha and also some affinity with ghosts? If she had no affinity with the Buddha, she wouldn't have met Elder Hsu, nor could she have become a great Dharma protector supporting Elder Hsu. And how is it that she also had some affinity with ghosts? When she was cooking for people, she beat a cat to death, and this cat ghost kept coming

after her to take her life, making her whole body ache from head to toe and keeping her sick from morning to night. Wanting to save her life, she said, "Big Brother Cat! If you make me suffer to death like this, this debt between us still won't be settled. Why don't you help me win the sweepstakes instead? Then I'll have money to rescue you so that you can be reborn. Wouldn't that be better?" When she said this, the cat ghost did as she said: she went to Macau and bought a sweepstakes ticket, and she really did win the grand prize. That's how she made her fortune. She used to sell plain congee; later she opened a vegetarian food shop in Hong Kong, and after she made her fortune she left the home-life. She did very well, and so she became the manager of Chi Lin Nunnery. That's why I say she had affinity with the Buddha and affinity with ghosts as well.

40. The Acharya Resolves a Difficulty

The Venerable Master was ordinarily frugal in providing for himself and was never willing to spend a cent on himself; yet for Bhikshus who truly cultivated, he would come to the rescue in times of danger and never begrudged his help. On the other hand, toward Bhikshus who did not truly cultivate and came begging, he was not the least bit polite...

In the spring of 1952 (the renchen year), Dharma Master Qin Jue bought a house at Diamond Hill in Kowloon. He had lived there only a little over a year when the landowner suddenly forced the house to be demolished and the land returned. Meeting with this heavy loss, Dharma Master Qin Jue was quite distressed, and his spirits sank unusually low. One night at 11 o'clock, the Dharma Master happened to be reading the "Contemplation of the Four Noble Truths" chapter of the *Treatise on the Middle Way*: "All dharmas produced by causes and conditions, I say, are empty; they are also false names, and they are also the meaning of the Middle Way. There has never been a single dharma that did not arise from causes and conditions; therefore, of all dharmas, there is none that is not empty." He contemplated its meaning and silently recited this passage over and over to relieve the afflictions he was mired in, and without realizing it he fell asleep and had a dream. In the dream he strolled into a mountain forest. While he was wandering about there, a violent storm of wind and rain suddenly descended, and thunder cracked across the sky, deafeningly loud. As he stood frightened and at a loss, a monk whose whole body emitted purple-burnished golden light descended from the sky, and the wind and rain instantly vanished; everything became still all at once. Dharma Master Qin Jue thought it was a manifestation of Guanyin and hurriedly knelt and bowed. Only when the monk came closer did he recognize him as one of the honored certifying Acharyas [Tr.: Sanskrit for "teacher"; at an ordination, one of the senior monks who confer or certify the precepts] from his ordination: Dharma Master To Lun. In the dream, the Venerable Master told him, "Don't worry. I'll help you resolve all your difficulties!" At that point in the dream, he woke up.

Not long afterward, Dharma Master Qin Jue found a plot of land and was preparing to build another house, but he was short of money. At that time the

Venerable Master was lecturing on the *Earth Store Sutra* at Chi Lin Nunnery. When he heard about this, he immediately took out 1,500 dollars to help him acquire a new house, so that he had a place to live.

In the Venerable Master's own words:

At Tung Po Tor there was an old monastic who told people he was in closed retreat, yet he often went out to all sorts of places seeking alms, saying, "There's no oil in my retreat room to light the lamp. Won't you give me a little oil?" He would also say, "I've run out of incense. Why don't you buy me a little incense?" Or, "Dharma Master, please be compassionate and give me a little money so that I can buy some rice to cook a meal!" In this way he collected quite a lot of money, and he even thought of coming to Western Bliss Gardens to swindle me. When he came to my place, he put on his robe and his sash, fully unfolded his sitting cloth, and bowed down to me; then he knelt upright with his palms joined and said:

"Dharma Master, please be compassionate and save me. Let me become enlightened!"

"Why are you carrying on like this?" I said.

"I'm in closed retreat over at Tung Po Tor. As soon as I sat in meditation, I saw you come. You emitted great light and floated gently down through empty space to land in front of me. You struck me three times with the incense board, and I became enlightened. Today I've come here to fully unfold my sitting cloth before you in person and bow to you with nine kowtows. Please strike me three more times with the incense board so that I can have a bit more enlightenment!" he said.

Why was he doing this? He was thinking, "Dharma Master To Lun surely likes being flattered too. If someone says he's a Buddha, he'll be pleased and will certainly give some money as a reward." But never in his wildest dreams did he imagine that this time I really would give him three blows of the incense board. As he knelt there, I glared at him and knocked him over with one kick, and I said:

"Get out of here right now! How dare you come here and try to cheat me!" But I saw that this man was older than I was; his hair was white, and his beard was white too. I didn't know whether he had gone white from thinking about "before" (qian, which sounds the same as "money") or from thinking about "after," but I knew he didn't think about the present. I felt a bit bad toward him, so I took 5 dollars out of my pocket, threw it on the floor, and said:

"You want to get enlightened? You don't want to get enlightened; all you want is money! Now I'll give you an enlightenment about money! I don't have any more than this, just 5 dollars for your bus fare. Take it and get out of here fast, and don't you ever come here again!" He looked at me, took the 5 dollars, and ran off.

He had heard that Qin Jue dreamed of me and said he saw me emitting light and so on and so forth, and he wanted to copy him. He didn't know that copying is useless! The reason Qin Jue had said that was that earlier he had sought alms from me and I had given him HK$1,500. In those days everything was very cheap, and 1,500 dollars was worth a great deal then. This old monastic knew about it and wanted to use the same method to cheat me. Am I someone who can be cheated? So I gave him a kick to make him wake up: "When I kick you, you'll wake up! You'll wake up to the fact that a kick landing on your body hurts!" So cultivators should not tell lies. True is true, and false is false.

[Addendum] From the diary of Upasika Tan Guo Zheng:

A letter came from Bhikshu Qin Jue. He told the Master about something that had happened about nine years before: he had dreamed that he walked to a remote, secluded place. Rain was pouring down at the time, and he was terrified. Suddenly he saw a very majestic Bodhisattva, who said to him, "Don't be afraid. I am here." When he looked closely, it was none other than the Venerable Master!

41. The Wealthy Merchant Goes Back on His Word

In the sixth month of the guisi year (1953), a certain Zhang, suffering from incurable cancer, begged the Venerable Master to save him. The Venerable Master told him that he must take refuge with the Triple Jewel, and urged him to give medicines and bolts of cloth to establish affinities with the Bhikshus and Bhikshunis, so as to dissolve his karmic offenses...

In the Venerable Master's own words:

In Hong Kong I had a bad refuge disciple. How was he bad? This refuge disciple had harmed people. His surname was Zhang, and his family ran a Western pharmacy. Who knows how much money he had; it was more than could be counted. How did he get his money? By harming people. After Japan surrendered, there were contagious diseases everywhere on the Chinese mainland and epidemics were rampant, because "after a great war there are bound to be years of calamity." He went into partnership with a very rich man to do business: they went abroad to purchase Western medicines and brought them back to Hong Kong to sell.

He made a lot of money, and when he had made money, he went and bought more medicine. On top of that, he also made imitation Western medicines and sold them in China, and from then on he was rich. After he got rich, what do you think happened? Probably because of grievance being repaid with grievance, he got cancer. At that time there were six doctors in Hong Kong who were the most famous, and all of them concluded that he would definitely die within 100 days, saying that there was no way to cure his illness. So he put a notice in the newspapers publicly begging for someone to save his life, saying that whoever could keep him alive would be given US$200,000. At that time US$200,000 was

a considerable sum, but still nobody answered; nobody had a way to save his life.

Someone asked me if there was anything to be done. I said I would have to see the person to know. A certain Ye brought Zhang to Western Bliss Gardens to see me and asked me how his illness could be cured. I said, "If you want not to die, that's very easy; it's not a difficult problem at all. Since you've gotten this illness, first you must take refuge with the Triple Jewel, and then you must make offerings to the Triple Jewel. If you do this, perhaps your illness will get better!" He wanted to take refuge with me right then. I said, "If you take refuge with me, well, I don't have much virtue. But if you're willing to take refuge, I won't refuse you."

He came to take refuge on the eighteenth day of the fifth (lunar) month. During the refuge ceremony, he saw Guanyin Bodhisattva anoint the crown of his head with sweet dew, and he immediately felt much better physically. Right then, kneeling before the Buddha, he also made a vow: if he didn't die within 100 days, he would give me US$200,000 to build a monastery. After that, I told him to make offerings to the Triple Jewel and to establish affinities by doing good deeds. At that time there were probably two or three thousand Bhikshus and Bhikshunis who had fled to Hong Kong as refugees; none of them had anywhere to stay, and they didn't have enough clothes to wear. So I told him to give every monastic a bolt of American cotton cloth, enough to make two sets of monastic clothing, and also to offer each person HK$20. I said, "If you can do this, I guarantee you will certainly not die!" He agreed at the time.

There were many monks in Hong Kong with great reputations. In particular, when many of the elder Dharma Masters heard that Zhang had taken refuge with me, these monks all started displaying their spiritual powers. What spiritual powers did they display? They went through friends and relatives to talk to Zhang, wanting him to come to their temples to create merit and virtue. One elder Dharma Master knew that the wife of one of his refuge disciples was a relative of Zhang's, so he had her go and plead his case: "This Dharma Master To Lun is nothing much! This elder Dharma Master is his teacher; why don't you take refuge with his teacher?" When Zhang heard this, he thought, "This is his teacher, so of course he must be even more brilliant than he is." So he went to the elder Dharma Master's temple to create merit and virtue, and he created some merit and virtue at other temples too. This reputable elder Dharma Master had never been one to perform rescue ceremonies for people, but because Zhang gave him 5,000 dollars, he bowed the *Medicine Master Repentance* for him for seven times seven, or 49, days.

All six doctors had concluded that Zhang would surely die within 100 days. This time, when he passed 100 days without dying, some monks said, "It was our bowing repentances for you that made you well!" That elder Dharma Master said, "It was our sutra recitation for you that made you well!" Another elder Dharma Master also said, "We prayed for you before the Buddha every day; that's what made you well!" At this point every Dharma Master had a share of

the credit. Only I, over here, had no credit at all, and I didn't care to go and explain to him what had really happened.

When I was building Cixing Monastery on Lantau Island, Zhang had a worker bring me 200 dollars for building Cixing Monastery. I picked up the 200 dollars and, without even looking at it, threw it out the door. I said, "Go back and tell him I won't use his filthy money. This money is too unclean! I don't just take people's money casually." Afterward, some monks slandered me: "What kind of monastic is that? Someone gives you money, and you go and throw it out the door right in front of them. That's wrong!" Zhang then asked the elder Dharma Master who had been currying favor with him to put in a good word with me, wanting to give me some more money. I said, "My construction work is finished now, so I don't need money. If he has money, he can create some other merit and virtue. There are so many Dharma Masters and so many temples; he can do it wherever he is willing to go."

42. Blessings Bestowed on Monks and Nuns

Zhang had earlier promised the Venerable Master that he would make offerings to the monastics of Hong Kong, but after recovering from his illness he went back on his word and reduced the amount of the offering, cutting it to 5 dollars and one bolt of cheap cloth per person. Faced with Zhang's breach of faith, the Venerable Master did not say a single word...

In the Venerable Master's own words:

Originally I had told Zhang to give every monastic 20 dollars, but those elder Dharma Masters had courted his favor and drawn all that away; he went back on his word and gave only 5 dollars. He did give a bolt of cloth, but it wasn't American cotton cloth. Still, when I said to give each monastic a bolt of cloth, I hadn't said how big, so that part could still be justified. Originally a bolt of American cotton cloth was enough to make two robes (long gowns) and two sets of trousers and jackets, but he switched to Shanghai Dachen gray cloth, and there wasn't enough cloth to make them. Since I had told all the monastics in advance that someone was going to offer each person 20 dollars, and now he was giving only 5 dollars, what could I do? I never force people to do things; if he wouldn't put it up, so be it. So I went and borrowed money and added another 10 dollars. In addition, two big companies, Daguang and Daming, put in 25 cents each, so with difficulty we pieced together 15 dollars and 50 cents to offer to each Dharma Master. Some monastics, not knowing the ins and outs of it, even said that I had secretly kept 4 dollars and 50 cents for myself. Truly, getting things done is so hard! At that time I was the one who scraped together those 10 dollars, and I slowly paid back the borrowed money afterward. Even now nobody knows about it, and the matter just passed like that.

[Addendum 1] The Venerable Master personally supervised the distribution of the goods. He notified the monasteries and hermitages throughout Hong Kong and Kowloon in advance and registered the number of monks and nuns, and

then bought bolts of cloth and medicines, such as Tiger Balm, Shiling Dan pills, lemon essence, and the like. On the ninth day of the sixth lunar month (July 19), the goods were first transported to Tsuen Wan for distribution; the first distribution points were Tung Po Tor Monastery, Chuk Lam Sim Yuen, Luk Ye Yuen in Kowloon, and other places. The next morning, distribution was made at Nam Tin Chuk, Tung Lin Buddha Recitation Hall, and Hongfa Vihara. On the eleventh day of the sixth lunar month (July 21), they went to Haichao Monastery at Castle Peak, Yuen Long, and other places. In Yuen Long there were few monasteries but many hermitages, so the Venerable Master notified the monasteries and hermitages to gather in one place for the distribution; among them were the Bhikshunis of Yuen Tung Monastery, Ling Wan Monastery, and others. A few days later they went to Sha Tin, where the monks and nuns gathered at Prajna Vihara: several dozen monks and nuns in all, from Sai Lam Monastery, Facheng Monastery, and elsewhere. After that, they went on to distribute at Dafo Monastery in Wong Tai Sin, Kowloon, and at Chi Lin Nunnery at Diamond Hill.

At every place, at each distribution point, the monks and nuns of the monasteries were first called together, and then, following the register, their names were called out and the goods distributed; each received one bolt of cloth, one packet of medicine, and HK$5. The Venerable Master also handed over, in full, the offering envelopes he had received in the ordinary course of things, to establish affinities with the monks who had joined the Sangha Fellowship Association, HK$10 per person. In addition, two lay Buddhists, Chen and Yang, joined in the good deed, and the Venerable Master also distributed 50 Hong Kong cents to each monk and nun. After each distribution, if any names had been left out or anyone had forgotten to sign up, they could register again and receive their share after it was confirmed. As for the distribution to the monasteries belonging to Lantau Island, that was entrusted to Dharma Master Fa Ke of Po Lin Monastery to handle. In this way, nearly all the monks and nuns of Hong Kong and Kowloon received offerings.

The Venerable Master handled matters clearly and in perfect order; on this occasion of establishing affinities with the monks and nuns, everyone admired him.

[Addendum 2] From the diary of Upasika Tan Guo Zheng:

I remember that once, when the Master was distributing cloth and money to the refugee monks from the mainland, the Venerable Master organized some people beforehand to help him distribute medicine and food, and also arranged for some people to help make clothes. At that time the headquarters for the giving was at Chi Lin Nunnery. That time the Master took us to different monasteries, and he also took my parents to meet the abbots of the monasteries.

[Addendum 3] Historical background:

In the 1920s, as unrest continued without cease in mainland China, many monks of great virtue and high repute came to Hong Kong one after another to

propagate the Buddhadharma, greatly furthering the development of Buddhism in Hong Kong. By 1940 Hong Kong already had over a hundred Buddhist temples. After Hong Kong was occupied by Japan in 1941, Japanese-style Buddhism was forcibly promoted, and the development of local Buddhism was held back. During the War of Resistance against Japan and the civil war between the Nationalists and the Communists, the Chinese mainland was in ceaseless turmoil, and in 1949 in particular a historic upheaval took place on the Chinese mainland. Tens of thousands of people headed south from the Chinese mainland to Hong Kong, and Buddhist monks and nuns also migrated south to Hong Kong in group after group; this continued right on into the 1950s.

Facing the hardship of the monks from the north migrating south, the Buddhist community of Hong Kong, though in very difficult economic circumstances, still received them warmly, so that the monasteries, thatched huts, viharas, hermitages, wooden huts, and so on built early on in the Hong Kong countryside all became places of refuge. The Buddhist community of Hong Kong and the faithful devotees of Kowloon each gave support to the best of their ability, building bamboo sheds and donating grain and oil, sharing joys and hardships and getting through difficult times together. Together they ushered in several decades of stable development for Buddhism in Hong Kong, and monasteries sprang up one after another like bamboo shoots after a spring rain. (Sources: Wikipedia, Hong Kong Buddhist magazines, and others)

43. The Remarkable Story of Guo Mi (1)

Wen Guo Mi's father died early. He was the only boy in the family, and the sole male heir for nine generations. He had had a heart condition since childhood, and it was especially serious in the two years when he was 12 and 13; on doctor's orders, he had to rest at home...

One day, Wen Guo Mi discovered a secret of his sister, who was four years older than he was: keeping it from their elder sisters, who were Christians, she had taken refuge in Buddhism, and she had also brought home a copy of *Records of Chan Master To Lun*. In his heart he deeply admired this Dharma Master and asked his sister to take him to see her teacher, but his sister put him off, saying, "You have to climb more than 300 stone steps to get to Western Bliss Gardens. If you had a heart attack, I couldn't bear the responsibility!" From that day on, he secretly bowed and made prostrations to the Venerable Master's Dharma image in the *Records*. One day three months later, as he was bowing in his room, the person in the Dharma image actually walked out and rubbed the crown of his head.

In the Venerable Master's own words:

When we are working, we should recite the Buddha's name as we work: either recite "Namo Guanshiyin Bodhisattva," or recite "Namo Amitabha Buddha," or recite "Namo Fundamental Teacher Shakyamuni Buddha." Don't recite "Namo Shifu." Don't be like that stupid disciple Guo Di, who starts reciting "Namo

Shifu" the moment the Master comes into view. If you go "Namo Shifu" and your teacher goes "Namo disciple," with "Namo" going back and forth, all your time will be wasted. You'd do better with "Namo Bodhisattvas, Namo Buddha, Namo Dharma, Namo Sangha"; that's a bit better. Why does Guo Di recite "Namo Shifu"? Because Guo Di heard me tell how there was once a person who recited "Namo Dharma Master To Lun," and his illness was cured. Speaking of this, I'll have to tell this fairy tale once more:

I had a student in Hong Kong who came down with heart disease, an enlarged heart, at the age of six or seven. The doctor told him, "This illness of yours won't be easy to cure! If you want to get better, you can't go to school and you can't walk; you have to lie in bed every day, for at least five years. And you can't walk even from the head of the bed to the foot of the bed." The child followed the doctor's instructions and lay at home sleeping. But sleeping for one day, three days, or five days was all right; when he had to sleep like this every day, he couldn't sleep anymore, and when he couldn't sleep, he had idle thoughts. What idle thoughts did he have? He thought, "If I can't walk, it wouldn't be bad if I could fly!"

So he lay there for about a year or two. One day he saw a book that had a photograph of a monk in it. He asked people who this monastic was, and someone told him that this was a Chan Master named To Lun. His relatives and friends all recited "Namo Amitabha Buddha," but he, oddly enough, put the photograph on his bed, sat in full lotus facing the photograph of the monk in the book, joined his palms, and recited, "Namo Dharma Master To Lun, Namo Dharma Master To Lun, Namo Dharma Master To Lun..." He recited like this from morning till night.

He had never even seen me. It was rare for a child to have such perseverance, sitting on his bed every day reciting "Namo Dharma Master To Lun." After he had recited for more than 70 days, something strange happened. What strange thing? He saw the photograph turn into a person, who walked right out of the photograph, rubbed the crown of his head, and spoke to him. From then on, his heart disease was cured. When he went to see the doctor, the doctor said, "Huh? This illness of yours is completely better now!" These things sound very much like a fairy tale, but this was his own personal experience. As long as you are sincere, even a photograph can bring a response.

He first saw me at Chi Lin Nunnery, when I was lecturing on the *Earth Store Sutra*. When I saw this child, he seemed very familiar, and when he saw me, he immediately resolved to take refuge with the Triple Jewel. From then on, his wisdom opened up greatly. Before he fell ill, he had been very slow at his studies, but after taking refuge, no matter what book he read, he never forgot anything once he had read it. Within three years, he skipped ahead five grades in school. For example, he jumped from first grade to second grade; when he was in second grade, he jumped to fourth grade; and from fourth grade he jumped to fifth grade. Why could he skip grades? Because he understood the

lessons of the higher grades as soon as he heard them, so the teachers let him skip ahead.

This young disciple of mine was very unusual; he was always wanting to see me. In Hong Kong I didn't teach people to investigate Chan and sit in meditation; whoever wanted to investigate Chan and sit in meditation applied effort on their own. When others were playing, he would sit in meditation. He would go up the mountain and sit in meditation on a rock, or, like the Venerable Rahula going into the toilet to sit in meditation, he would sit in the toilet; that place stank, yet he could sit there in meditation and enter samadhi.

All you Good and Wise Advisors, don't go hearing me tell this story and then all start reciting "Namo Shifu" too, until you've recited this teacher into having no response at all. Because if too many people recite it, I won't know which one to help. You should know that the intertwining of stimulus and response is the response to a single thought of true sincerity; if you can do it at the level of the primary meaning, there will definitely be a response! Nobody taught this child to recite like that, and he had never heard my story either; he had this response because he made the resolve himself. If you hear about it and then copy him, you've fallen to the level of the secondary meaning: half true, and half heard from others. He recited for 70 days and had a response; you'd have to recite for seven years, and then perhaps you might achieve a little something; otherwise there won't be any response. Someone says, "Everything we have now is learned." That's right, all of it is learned. If you can understand without learning, that is enlightenment; you've attained awakening!

[Addendum 1] Upasika Tan Guo Shi recounted:

I knew Guo Mi before I took refuge with the Master. Guo Mi's father had died early and his mother was quite old. He was the only son in the family and had had heart trouble since birth, and his elder sisters all looked after him well. When he became the Master's disciple, at first he didn't dare let his family know; only later, when his health was getting better and better, did he tell them. He was very intelligent and could sit in Chan meditation for a long time; the Master said Guo Mi had some attainment in Chan samadhi. He didn't go to Western Bliss Gardens or the Buddhist Lecture Hall very often, only on weekends or holidays, but his sister (Guo Shu) went often. He was a very good speaker and often gave talks at the Sunday Dharma assemblies.

[Addendum 2] From the diary of Upasika Tan Guo Zheng:

My classmate Margaret and I often went swimming and bicycle riding together. Then for a time she suddenly found she couldn't find me and didn't know where I had gone. When she learned that I had a teacher, she asked me to take her to see the Master, and she too took refuge with the Master, with the Dharma name "Guo Shu." Her family were all Christians, and at the time they didn't know about it. She had a younger brother called Guo Mi (Wen Songyi), who, because of a heart problem, had been out of school for a year or two. He knew what his sister Guo Shu had done, and Guo Shu even showed him the records of the

Master's life. Every day he bowed to the Master's photograph, and unexpectedly the Master in the photograph appeared; from then on his heart disease was cured without any medicine.

In 1961, the Master once said at the Buddhist Lecture Hall, "Guo Mi can be said to be the foremost Dharma protector of the whole Lecture Hall!" The Master also said to me, "When I say these things, I hope you can listen with a straight mind. I'm not saying this deliberately; the Bodhisattvas can all certify what I say. The reason Guo Mi has been able to achieve something in his cultivation so quickly has to do with his previous lives. If, before he took refuge with me, his capacities had not been suited to the teaching, then no matter how I taught him, it wouldn't have had much effect, and his progress would have been limited."

I understood why the Master said these things. At that time I hadn't believed in Buddhism for long, and I thought of myself as one of the top students at school. I was very angry that the Master wouldn't teach me to cultivate Chan samadhi and spiritual powers, so I tried to find ways to make the Master angry. I knew the Master very much hoped that we would cultivate vigorously, so I deliberately did the opposite. Within a month or two, I joined the drama club, went to night school in the evenings, and very soon I had a boyfriend too. When the Master found out, he told my mother, and my mother had a big fight with me. The Master had my classmate Guo Shu (Wen Guo Mi's elder sister; Guo Mi did not yet know the Master at that time) pass on a message that I was not allowed to come to Western Bliss Gardens anymore. At the time I was just about to sit for the public examination for graduation from secondary school, and I said to Guo Shu, "Fine, if I'm not to go, I won't go. I don't have time anyway!"

The public examination was finally over. Although my name was on the list of those who passed, I felt very depressed; my boyfriend could not make up for the unease I felt at being without the Master. One day at noon, unable to stand it any longer, I ran up the mountain alone and rang the bell at the bamboo-fence gate of Western Bliss Gardens. Dharma sister Guo Ping came out to answer the gate, but as soon as she saw it was me, she turned and walked away. After a while she came out again and said to me quietly, "The Master says you're to kneel before the Buddha." I don't know how long I knelt. It had already gotten dark and everyone who had come to the Buddha hall had left before I heard the Master call my name. Weeping and sobbing, I knelt before the Master and poured out everything that was in my heart. The Master told me, "The straight mind is the Way-place," and told me about the principles of cause and effect.

44. Young Disciples

During his time in Hong Kong, the Venerable Master had more than ten young disciples who attended him closely, such as Wen Weibin (Guo Shu), Wen Songyi (Guo Mi), Tan Muzhen (Guo Zheng), Tan Mujie (Guo Shi), Huang Jiemei (Guo Song), Huang Ketai (Guo Jun), Cai Shuqing (Guo Su), Xu Xiangjun, Xu Lijun, Wu Xiangcai, Wu Yingcai (Guo Dong), Zhong Meiwei (Guo Jia)...

In the Venerable Master's own words:

When I was in Manchuria, I had many young disciples. Some were eight or nine years old, and there were also students in elementary school and in middle school. When they took refuge with me, they first had to observe my conditions. What was my first condition? They had to be filial to their parents and respectful to their teachers and elders. Disciples who took refuge with me had to bow to their father and mother every day; if they didn't bow to their parents, I wouldn't accept them. You want to take refuge? Then you have to practice filial piety. If you don't practice filial piety, then don't take refuge. That was my condition for entering the door.

When I got to Hong Kong, I stopped enforcing this condition, because Hong Kong was neither Chinese nor Western. The people there only half-understood Chinese, and they only half-understood English too. They wanted to learn modern things, things with a bit of a foreign flavor, and they thought Eastern ways of thinking were too clumsy. If you taught a child to bow to his parents, his father and mother would be completely baffled: "Why is he acting like this? Has the child gone mad?" They might even take him to see a psychologist. So in Hong Kong I didn't enforce this rule. When I came to America, even less so. Especially in the early days, I opened wide the door of expedient means—you want to take refuge? I accepted people's refuge with no conditions at all. That's why so many of the finest people in this world came to study the Buddhadharma. If there had been conditions, I'm afraid these Westerners couldn't have accepted them.

[Addendum 1] Upasaka Huang Guo Jun recounted:

In junior high I attended the Salesian English School in Shau Kei Wan, which had been founded by the Catholic Church. The school wasn't far from Western Bliss Gardens, so every day at noon I would run over to Western Bliss Gardens for lunch, and the Master would even peel apples for me to eat. After lunch it was my time to sit in meditation. When the Master saw that the time was up, he would tell me to get up from my sitting and go back to school.

[Addendum 2] From the diary of Upasika Tan Guo Zheng:

We went to see the Master almost every day, not just on weekends. In the summer, the English-language schools in Hong Kong held classes for only half the day, and school let out after one o'clock in the afternoon, so every afternoon we would go to Western Bliss Gardens. Even though we had to climb more than 300 steps, we never tired of it. The Master spent a good deal of time on us. We would sit around him chatting with him, and we even asked him for things to eat. We were very close to the Master and to his disciples, just like one big, happy, harmonious family.

[Addendum 3] Upasika Tan Guo Shi recounted:

Guo Jun, Guo Mi, and I were all about the same age. I loved to talk, and Guo Mi loved to talk too. Guo Jun was very bright and didn't like to talk much; his

Chinese was better than mine. Guo Mi was extremely bright, but he didn't go to Western Bliss Gardens or the Buddhist Lecture Hall very often, only on weekends or holidays. The Master changed us, especially me. Before I met the Master, I cried a lot. It wasn't because I was in poor health; it was because I was afraid of seeing so many poor people, so I often cried. The Master asked why I was always crying, and I said, "To me, there's nothing in this world that is good or that makes people happy. People are so miserable!" The Master taught me a great deal, and after that I seldom cried.

I remember the Master once told me that I was a very stubborn person. If it weren't for him, no one could have changed me; no one could have made me yield. The Master really changed me a great deal! When the Master told the story of how he had bowed to his parents, to the Buddhas and Bodhisattvas, and to everyone, I came to realize the respect one ought to show one's parents. So I went home and bowed to my parents. This is what a son or daughter ought to do, and I wanted to learn to do it too. Before long, my mother couldn't take it anymore and told me to stop right away and not bow anymore. She said that bowing to the Buddha and being a really good child was enough.

(1) Joy in Hearing the Dharma

The Venerable Master especially admonished his young disciples not to listen attentively only when someone spoke the Dharma well, and then let their minds wander when someone else spoke it poorly...

The Venerable Master especially admonished his disciples to pay careful attention to every word and deed, every action and movement, of anyone at all, and not to let any of it pass by in vain. They should use the Wonderful Contemplating Wisdom to observe whether what was said was right or not, and whether it accorded with the Dharma or not, rather than use the conscious mind to discriminate and calculate. "If it is the Way, advance; if it is not the Way, retreat." Only in this way could they gain something and open their wisdom. Opening wisdom is not something achieved in a single step; one must be at it morning and evening, studying without interruption from dawn to dusk. Only then can one accomplish something.

In the Venerable Master's own words:

The Two Vehicles are elementary school, the Bodhisattva Vehicle is middle school, and the Buddha Vehicle is university. So once in Hong Kong I said to people, "The students I teach are university students, not elementary school students." With elementary school students, you have to tell them some stories to make them happy; only then will they make progress in their studies. With middle school students, you have to explain some principles to them. When they reach university, you have to make them really learn something before they can pass. Originally there were no Two Vehicles; the Buddha set up the Two Vehicles. Originally there was no need for elementary school, but because people are so small, an elementary school has to be set up. When people grow a bit older, a middle school is set up. After they turn 18, they enter university,

where the degrees are further divided into bachelor's and master's, and there's also the doctorate.

So to become a Buddha, you first have to enter elementary school, and then middle school. Middle school is practicing the Bodhisattva Path; university is becoming a Buddha. In Buddhism, the most important thing is to become a Buddha. But if you suddenly tell someone, "Come study Buddhism and become a Buddha," he'll be scared off. What is a Buddha? Why should I become a Buddha? He doesn't understand. It's like suddenly giving a child the highest degree, a doctorate: the child doesn't even know what a doctorate is, because he's too young and his intelligence hasn't developed yet.

Listening to sutra lectures depends on the individual, on whether or not people have affinities with you. If someone has affinities with you, even if you scold him, he's happy. If someone has no affinities with you, then no matter how you flatter him and tell him how wonderful he is, he still won't be pleased. Refuge disciples who have faith in me believe whatever I say, without the slightest doubt; even if I deliberately speak an unreasonable Dharma, they still believe it. People who have just taken refuge for the first time don't have such firm faith; even those who have taken refuge for one life, two lives, three lives, or five lives don't have such deep faith. All those who have faith in their teacher took refuge with me in previous lives as well. Yu Guo Man is one of them. Guo Li also has faith in her teacher: even if she were told to die in my place, she would be willing!

At that time there were several places where Dharma Masters were lecturing on the sutras, but strangely enough these young disciples of mine wouldn't go to listen. I told them to go and listen, and they still wouldn't go. I said, "Don't just listen to my lectures all the time. Other Dharma Masters lecture better than I do; you ought to go and hear them!" "No matter how well he lectures, I'm not going anywhere else." Wu Guo Dong was like that. He said, "Why should I listen to them? Even I lecture better than they do." I said, "Don't be so arrogant!" He said, "It's true, there's just no comparison!"

[Addendum 1] Upasika Tan Guo Shi recounted:

While the Master was at Western Bliss Gardens, he also lectured on the sutras in other places. He was often invited to lecture at Chi Lin Nunnery and Tung Lin Kok Yuen. The founder of Tung Lin Kok Yuen was not a monastic, yet established a Way-place for nuns and at the same time built a Buddhist school for the poor. The Master was also invited to lecture at Tung Sin Tan, and I remember he went there more than once. Some Dharma Masters in Hong Kong always lectured by simply reading out the text and explaining the literal meaning, but the Master didn't lecture that way. He would weave stories into his lectures: some were stories from the scriptures, some came from the Master's own experiences, and some were stories the Master had heard. So every time the Master lectured, lots of people came to listen. The Master was very humorous, just as he was in America, and everyone loved his classes, especially young people.

[Addendum 2] From the diary of Upasika Tan Guo Zheng:

Wu Xiangcai (Guo Sen's eldest son) had been baptized for more than ten years, but after meeting the Master he took refuge with him. In the past he had had many questions that no one could answer; after he came to know the Master, the Master answered them for him one by one. From then on, his faith grew twice as firm. Wu Xiangcai waited for the Master to return from Australia before leaving to study in England. Before he went abroad, for several days, starting a little after six in the morning, the Master explained the *Sixth Patriarch's Dharma Jewel Platform Sutra* especially for him. The Master forgot himself for the sake of the Dharma and spared no pains in teaching his disciples.

After Wu Xiangcai arrived in England, he read the *Sixth Patriarch Sutra* and *Records of Chan Master To Lun* every day. The Master said, "It's cold in England and it snows heavily, but Xiangcai says his neck feels warm and he doesn't feel the cold. That's because he often sits in meditation and also reads the *Sixth Patriarch Sutra*." The Master remarked with feeling, "It looks as though he has had some response." The Master had taught him for only three months, but he was very vigorous, so he progressed remarkably fast.

(2) Teaching as a Strict Teacher

Many disciples had the experience of receiving the Venerable Master's instruction in person. The Venerable Master would, as the occasion arose, at any time and in any place, and when they least expected it, give a disciple a pointer...

With his disciples, the Venerable Master would sometimes scold and sometimes remind, to make them correct their bad habits. The disciples who were scolded, while repenting and reflecting on themselves, all felt a kind of refreshing coolness. More importantly, this priceless teaching often became a force that helped them break through a bottleneck in their cultivation of the Way, and a turning point on the road of their wisdom-life. This is precisely the skillful expedient means of great wisdom and great compassion that appeared in the Venerable Master's way of teaching.

In the Venerable Master's own words:

You've never seen me lose my temper in a big way. If you had, you wouldn't be so unruly and wouldn't ignore the rules like this! In Manchuria and in Hong Kong, I really carried myself with the dignity of a teacher. Never mind my telling you to do something: if I merely hinted at it without saying it and you didn't go do it, I would already be displeased! That was my style. My disciples didn't dare to talk casually in front of me; they were very afraid of me. Sometimes when the kids were naughty and didn't follow the rules, I would give them a scolding, or even a beating. In Hong Kong I really did beat my disciples, and not fake beatings either; people were beaten by me until they were swollen.

Some people say, "Shifu, don't be angry with us!" I'm not angry with you. Whether people treat me well or not, I don't get angry. Why? You huff your air

and I puff mine, so why should I get all huffy with you? Because everything is false; everything is empty and illusory. But sometimes I have to use expedient methods to teach and transform people. You're someone I ought to lose my temper with. If I don't flare up at you a bit, you'll never be vigorous; you'll always be lazy, always thinking, "I'll wait till tomorrow to cultivate, I'll wait till tomorrow to cultivate, I'll wait till tomorrow to cultivate..." Ah! You wait and wait until you're old, and even until you're dead, and you still haven't cultivated. So I have to really lose my temper with you, and even give you a beating. In Hong Kong I often beat people.

Now I'll tell you again: I have a big temper. Sometimes when I scold people it really is unreasonable, and when I beat people that's unreasonable too. But it's not that I'm unreasonable with just anybody; you have to be at that level. If you're not at that level, I'll be reasonable with you; only if you're at that level can I be unreasonable. In teaching and transforming living beings, sometimes, when you ought to be reasonable, you are reasonable; sometimes, when you ought to be unreasonable, you are unreasonable. Scolding can be reasonable and can be unreasonable; beating can be reasonable and can be unreasonable. If you're truly at that level, there's no reason to speak of at all! The Buddhadharma is inconceivable like this. You see it's this way and that way, and then it's neither this way nor that way, and it gets you all muddled. When you're muddled to the extreme, that's when your good news is coming. And if you can be unmuddled while you're muddled, that's good news too.

[Addendum 1] From the diary of Upasika Tan Guo Zheng:

The Master said, "Guo Mi often recites 'Namo Dharma Master To Lun.' He truly has faith in me, and that moves me. The Patriarchs of the past would put their disciples through torments to see whether they really had faith, and I too have deliberately tested him several times. Once he went hiking in the mountains with Guo Jun, and as punishment I made him kneel for four hours; he knelt until he could hardly stand up. Guo Shu saw it but didn't dare make a sound; she only wept in secret. Another time, at Cixing Monastery, over some small matter, I deliberately drove him down the mountain. I told him, 'Tonight you go sleep in the guest hall!' Having no choice, he took his pillow from my room and went to the guest hall. Someone asked him why he had come to sleep there, and he just sighed and said, 'I'm going down the mountain tomorrow!' Only after half an hour had passed did I call him back to my room."

On the seventeenth day of the eleventh lunar month of 1991, the Master said, "My vow is to undergo suffering on behalf of living beings. Especially in these last few years, I want to undergo suffering for living beings. I had a great many offenses, but now they are all gone. Even offenses as vast as the heavens vanish with a single repentance." Bewildered, I asked, "Shifu, why do you say you have so many offenses?" The Master said, "I often scold people, and I take the offenses of living beings upon myself. The ones I scold are good people, not bad people."

[Addendum 2] Upasika Tan Guo Shi recounted:

Those of us Dharma brothers and sisters who were close in age were very happy following the Master, because he would often give us some "sweet treats." Even though we couldn't go eating, drinking, and having fun with our other friends, it was worth it. Whenever any of us disciples slacked off a little or made a mistake, it could never be hidden from the Master. We all quickly learned to behave: before doing anything, we would first report it to the Master, and only then would we dare go ahead. Sometimes when we did something wrong, the Master would rebuke us, even in front of everyone, and punish us with the incense board. I was the only one the Master never hit with the incense board; perhaps the Master knew I was a very sensitive person.

[Addendum 3] From the diary of Upasika Tan Guo Zheng:

The Master said to me, "At home no one can keep Ah Ying (Wu Yingcai, Guo Sen's second son, whose Dharma name is Guo Dong) in line; only when I scold him does he not dare to argue back. He told his mother, 'When Shifu scolds me, I'm glad to accept it.'" Hearing this, I laughed and said, "Hitting is love, and scolding is love too." The Master said, "If one day I hit you, it won't be lightly; I'll hit you hard. Are you afraid?" I had no answer. The Master said, "For someone who believes in me, even if I were going to kill him, he would say it was liberation."

[Addendum 4] Upasaka Huang Guo Jun recounted:

The Master had a very special way of teaching according to people's potentials! At that time I was attending a Catholic school. The good schools in Hong Kong were run by either the Catholics or the Protestants, and good Buddhist schools were as rare as phoenix feathers and unicorn horns. I was about ten at the time, and one day I said to the Master, "If I have money, when I grow up I'll open a Buddhist school." The Master said, "Good! It's very good that you can make this vow." A few months later the Master said to me, "Now I have a Dharma-door: if you cultivate it for just seven days, you can go to the Western Land of Ultimate Bliss." I immediately knelt down and said, "Shifu, please teach me this Dharma-door." The Master said, "And what about your school?!" With that one test, the Master exposed the vow I had made as false. My vow wasn't sincere, so my school never got started, and I didn't get to go to the Land of Ultimate Bliss either. Everyone knew the Master could foretell things, so when I was 15 or 16, I once asked the Master, "What will become of me later on?" The Master looked at me and said just one short sentence: "Just be kind-hearted!" He said nothing more, and I didn't press him. Those four short words became the motto of my whole life.

[Addendum 5] From the diary of Upasika Tan Guo Zheng:

Wu Yingcai was Wu Xiangcai's younger brother; we all called him "Ah Ying." He and his mother had taken refuge long before. The Master told me that Ah Ying used to come to hear the sutra lectures every evening, and then at a little after seven the next morning he would first come to the Lecture Hall to bow to the

Buddhas before going to work. Christmas is a social occasion for young people, and because he went to dances, he didn't come to the Lecture Hall for several days. The Master was afraid something had changed or some accident had happened at his home, so he sent someone to go and find out. The next day, Ah Ying came to the Lecture Hall, and the Master said sternly, "None of my young disciples celebrate Christmas. If they were all like you, wouldn't that mean no one would protect my Dharma?" Ah Ying was so ashamed that he wished the earth would swallow him up, and he begged the Master to beat him. The Master said offhandedly, "I won't beat you. Why should I beat you?" Yingcai felt even worse, so he slapped his own cheeks until they were swollen, begging the Master's forgiveness.

(3) Always Learning at the Master's Side

The Venerable Master's wisdom was deep and profound, and he was thoroughly versed in ancient Chinese history, literature, poetry, and calligraphy. Every weekend, when the young disciples came up the mountain, the Master would teach them classical Chinese...

In the Venerable Master's own words:

When we study Chinese literature, we have to practice our characters and write them very neatly. As they say, "Not one stroke done carelessly." Don't just carelessly dash off a character in one sweep; you can't be careless about this. In China, no matter how well you wrote your essays, if your handwriting was poor you couldn't become the top scholar in the imperial examinations, so Chinese characters must be written well. With the writing brush there's small regular script and large regular script: large regular script is for writing big characters, and small regular script is for writing small characters. "Fly's-head characters" are each only as big as a fly's head, yet every one of them is written without a single careless stroke, perfectly clear. I'm also glad for you to learn all kinds of languages and scripts, because I don't know that many languages, and I get pushed around wherever I go. When I go to Australia, the Australian kids push me around; when I come to America, you American kids push me around. Wherever I go, people take advantage of my not understanding the language. That's something I really regret!

[Addendum 1] From the diary of Upasika Tan Guo Zheng:

On weekends the Master taught us classical texts such as *Mencius* and *Laozi*. If anyone wasn't paying attention, the Master would write a little poem on the blackboard, and as soon as that person read it, they would know the Master was talking about them. Reciting a poem is different from reading it; reciting a poem is like singing it. In the old-style schools of ancient times, the teacher would wag his head back and forth as he chanted poetry. The Master didn't do that, but his intonation was very similar. Later on the Master stopped chanting poems that way. Every time I saw the Master, he would give me a book to take home and read. Most were Buddhist books, but not all of them. I remember that the first book he gave me was *Poems in Imitation of Hanshan*, written by Layman

Meicun, Zhang Shouyue. The Master often wrote phrases freely on old newspapers, and we would copy them after him. To this day I still keep some of the newspapers the Master wrote on.

One day the Master wrote the following verse:

> *With the nature settled and demons subdued, every morning brings joy;*
> *With false thoughts not arising, everywhere is peace.*
> 性定魔伏朝朝樂，妄念不起處處安。
>
> *Flowers lovely and the moon full, people do not age;*
> *With mind settled and spirit whole, the body grows ever stronger.*
> 花好月圓人不老，意定神全體更堅。
>
> *Reach out a hand and pluck the moon from the edge of the sky;*
> *Close your eyes and see right through to the sky within the water.*
> 伸手摘來天邊月，閉眼澈見水中天。
>
> *Fine lines I chant toward a place where no one is;*
> *The true mind lies bare as it was before birth.*
> 好句吟向無人處，真心披露未生前。

[Addendum 2] Upasika Tan Guo Shi recounted:

Saturdays didn't have a full day of group cultivation the way Sundays did, so on Saturdays we studied classical Chinese, Japanese, and calligraphy. Back when the Master was young, his calligraphy was superb. He would first write on the blackboard and teach Guo Shu, Guo Song, Guo Jun, and me how to move the brush. My elder sister's Chinese was good, because our father had once hired an old-style private tutor to teach her and my elder brother classical Chinese, so both of them wrote quite good calligraphy. In Hong Kong I attended a Christian school that emphasized English, so I didn't learn much Chinese. We also studied Japanese, taught by Mr. Pei (Pei Youming; Pei Guo Jian; Pei Zhenghui), one of the Master's disciples from Manchuria. My sister studied it for a while before she went to America.

[Addendum 3] Upasika Tan Guo Zheng recounted in 1995:

The Master put a great deal of effort into teaching our band of hard-to-manage teenagers, finding every possible way to do so, without complaint and without asking anything in return, in the hope that we would become citizens of good character and sound thinking. The Master taught each person according to who they were, using a different method for each of us, so that amid the glittering, pleasure-seeking society of Hong Kong our minds still did not waver and our resolve did not retreat, and we held firm to our faith in studying Buddhism. This was truly no easy thing.

To nurture a younger generation of Buddhist disciples, the Master racked his brains and wore himself out in mind and body. He once talked with us all through the night until dawn; he saved the tastiest pine nuts for us; and he once even neglected his honored guests because he was telling us Chan cases. To

keep us in line, the Master would sometimes put on a stern face and go the whole day without eating or drinking; and when we went astray, he also punished us severely. Only today do we truly understand the pains he took for our sake.

Wherever the Master went, there was always a group of young followers. He nurtured the younger generation without ever counting the cost; even if nine out of ten turned out to be good-for-nothings, he never minded. His hope was to pass on and develop the meaning and essence of the Buddhist sutras. Even if only one became a vessel of the Dharma, it could be handed down from generation to generation, so that Buddhism would flourish and spread. The Master required his disciples to practice earnestly, both in the precepts and in cultivation, never carelessly, and to establish the Way-place of their own minds.

(4) Putting On Performances

The Venerable Master encouraged his disciples to discuss and dig out the truth, to apply the Buddhadharma in their lives, to awaken to the true meaning of the Buddhadharma in everyday affairs and human relationships, and to discover for themselves what was right and what was wrong. It was precisely the Venerable Master's blend of strictness and kindness that inspired his disciples...

[Addendum 1] From the diary of Upasika Tan Guo Zheng:

The Chinese believe that Guanyin Bodhisattva was Princess Miaoshan, the daughter of King Miaozhuang, who wanted to leave the home-life and, after many hardships, finally attained the Way. But this story does not come from the Buddhist sutras. From the *Shurangama Sutra* and the *Great Compassion Heart Dharani Sutra* we know the true story of how Guanyin Bodhisattva attained the Way. Because we didn't understand this at the time, we once put on a play about Princess Miaoshan. I think it was probably my idea, but the Master didn't tell us we were wrong; he wanted us to figure out for ourselves what was right and what was wrong. I did many kinds of foolish things, and only now do I know that I was wrong. For instance, when I was helping with the *Gold Mountain Newsletter* at Gold Mountain Monastery in San Francisco, I once tried to explain the verses the Master spoke when he ascended the hall to speak the Dharma. After the newsletter was published, I reported this to the Master, and the Master told me that the verses for ascending the hall to speak the Dharma carry the flavor of Chan; they are for people to understand for themselves and are not to be explained. A wise person may become enlightened on hearing a single word or a single line.

[Addendum 2] Upasika Tan Guo Shi recounted:

We were all very close to the Master. He was like a loving father to us; he taught us everything and also took us out to have fun. At the end of the Dharma assemblies, we would also put on some plays and performances, all of them related to Buddhism. I remember that the first play was about the Master's own life experiences. My sister's Chinese was good, and she put a lot of effort into

writing the script and preparing it. Most of the programs were things she worked on wholeheartedly.

(5) Little Soldiers of Translation

The Venerable Master encouraged his young disciples to take part in Dharma assemblies and in the work of translating the sutras and his instructional talks. He intended for them to be tempered through translation, and he taught them not to be turned by states...

In the Venerable Master's own words:

As for translating the sutras, some of you have learned a bit by now. What have you learned? You've learned that you say I translated it wrong, and I say you didn't translate it well. What counts as good? What counts as not good? If you translate well, go on translating in the direction of good; if someone else translates poorly, he'll gradually get better too. Whoever is translating, we all hope to do our very best at the work of translation. There's no need to be overjoyed when someone says it's good, or to get afflicted when someone says it's not good.

[Addendum 1] Upasika Tan Guo Shi recounted:

When I was little, I spoke with the Master in Cantonese. We communicated very well; the Master understood Cantonese. Only after we came to America did we speak with the Master in Mandarin (Guoyu). I remember the first time the Master asked us to translate Mandarin into Cantonese: there were no tape recorders then, so you had to listen and take notes with full attention. Nobody wanted to do it, so we drew lots to decide. The Master lectured on the sutras every evening at Western Bliss Gardens, and I often went to translate. The Master's Mandarin was easy to understand, but other Dharma Masters had local accents that were very hard to understand, especially Dharma Master Ming Guan.

After Dharma Master Ming Guan came to Hong Kong, the Master often invited him to Western Bliss Gardens. At first, one of the Master's disciples from Manchuria helped translate. For some reason, Dharma Master Ming Guan thought he wasn't translating correctly and got a bit angry. He said to him, "No, no, you step down!" Then he pointed at me and said, "You come be my translator." I told the Master that I simply couldn't understand what Dharma Master Ming Guan was saying and couldn't do the translation. The Master said, "Don't worry! Remember, I'm right behind you." I had no choice but to scratch my head and go up on stage, and to my surprise I actually understood what Dharma Master Ming Guan said. Afterwards I told the Master, and the Master said, "I told you I was right behind you!" From then on, the Master trained us to translate sutra lectures and instructional talks.

[Addendum 2] Upasika Tan Guo Zheng recounted in 1995:

I remember that when we were young in Hong Kong, the Venerable Master required us young Dharma brothers and sisters to take turns translating his

sutra lectures into Cantonese. At first, because of stage fright, my hands shook with fear when I translated, and I couldn't even take decent notes. But a teacher's command is hard to disobey, so I had no choice but to steel myself and go up. After this kind of training, though, I benefited endlessly, and it also laid the foundation for my later career in education.

(6) The Key to Quiet Sitting

Where does the wonderful meaning of Chan lie? Is sitting Chan? How should one practice quiet sitting and Chan meditation? The young disciples once asked the Venerable Master about the key to quiet sitting...

In the Venerable Master's own words:

As for sitting in Chan meditation, only if you like it can you sit in Chan; if you don't like it, then even if you do sit in Chan, it won't do much good.

By sitting in Chan, you gain samadhi power. Then is Chan a matter of sitting? It is a matter of sitting, and it is also not a matter of sitting. Before you sit, it's not sitting; after you finish sitting, it's not sitting; while you're sitting in Chan, it's sitting. In reality, with this Chan, standing is Chan, sitting is Chan, walking is Chan, and sleeping is Chan. If you understand this "Chan," then walking, standing, sitting, and lying down are all Chan. However, until you understand this "Chan," you must first sit in Chan. Once you have obtained Chan, you can't be separated from Chan. Whether walking, standing, sitting, or lying down, this Chan is you, and you are Chan; Chan follows you, and you follow Chan, like a shadow following a form, and even if you wanted to get away from it, you couldn't! That is samadhi power. This is sitting in Chan.

Having talked about it back and forth like this, what is this "Chan," after all? It isn't anything. If you think it is something, then you're attached! It isn't anything: that means being without attachment. Someone says, "That's vague talk that doesn't touch any edges!" Of course: if it had edges, it wouldn't be Chan! Chan has no edges at all; it is simply empty. Out of that emptiness your samadhi power is born, and samadhi is born.

Chan is half of a Sanskrit word; in full it is called dhyana. Dhyana is Sanskrit, and in Chinese it means "cultivation of thought"; it is also called "stilling of thought." That is, you sit there cultivating thought and stilling thought. If you don't know how to apply effort, you'll just sit there having idle thoughts; if you can apply effort, perhaps you'll drive the idle thoughts away, and then there won't be any idle thoughts.

Don't think "having idle thoughts" is a bad expression [Tr.: the Chinese expression for having idle thoughts, da wangxiang, literally means "hitting idle thoughts"]. Hitting idle thoughts is fine. If you can hit your idle thoughts and drive them off, if you fight with them, then as soon as an idle thought arises, you give it a blow with the demon-subduing pestle and kill it. Once it's killed, after a while another one arises; you use the demon-subduing pestle again and kill it

too. Another one arises, and once more you use the demon-subduing pestle and kill it as well.

But when you hit them with the demon-subduing pestle, sometimes after you kill them they come back to life. What then? Use the demon-slaying sword. As soon as you see an idle thought come out, you cut it down with one stroke of the sword, and it won't come back to life again! So the demon-slaying sword is very formidable. Once you have slain your idle thoughts, your wisdom comes forth. Wisdom is the demon-slaying sword. If you have wisdom, you have the demon-slaying sword; if you don't have wisdom, you don't have the demon-slaying sword.

What is the demon-subduing pestle? It is your samadhi power. If you have samadhi power, you have the demon-subduing pestle; if you don't have samadhi power, you don't have the demon-subduing pestle. Do you understand now? When you sit in Chan, samadhi power comes forth; when samadhi power comes forth, it beats your idle thoughts to death. If you keep sitting in Chan, the power of wisdom comes forth. The power of wisdom is the strength of wisdom, and it slays those idle thoughts too.

If you know how to sit in Chan, then "Walking is Chan, sitting is Chan; speaking or silent, moving or still, the substance is at peace," and "In dreams, so clearly, there are the six destinies; after awakening, all is empty, with no great thousand world system"! If you become enlightened, even this great thousand world system is gone, let alone anything else! If you don't investigate Chan and don't sit in meditation, then where did you come from at birth? Where will you go at death? You don't know. Not knowing, you are born in a muddle and die in a muddle. To pass a whole life like this, how pitiful! Those who apply effort and investigate Chan become enlightened. Once enlightened, they recognize their original face before their parents gave birth to them, and they suddenly break through, so that there is nothing in the outer and inner, the fine and coarse aspects of all things that they do not reach, and nothing in the whole substance and great function of their minds that is not clear. They attain a state of tremendous good fortune, and in the future they can accomplish Buddhahood and attain the position of unsurpassed, proper, and equal right enlightenment.

[Addendum 1] In his *Impressions of Master Hsu Yun*, Dharma Master Le Guan mentions: I remember that year, Elder Yun held the winter Chan sessions with us before he went to Chongqing. During the Chan sessions, he once gave an instructional talk in which he said something that made people laugh. He said, "To investigate 'Chan,' you have to investigate with all your might; only then will you have 'Chan.' To study the 'teachings,' you also have to study in earnest; only then can you penetrate the principles of the 'teachings.' I often see people who investigate Chan crossing their legs to investigate for a while when they're in the mood, and dropping it again when they're not in the mood, like someone 'shaking with ague' (malaria), hot one moment and cold the next, now slack and now tight. If you investigate 'Chan' like that, then even if you gain something, it will be no more than the 'chan' that sits on a tree branch [Tr.: a pun: chan

'meditation' sounds the same as chan 'cicada']. People who study the 'teachings' are the same. When the whim strikes, they summon up their energy and gnaw away at their books from morning till night; when their laziness flares up, they toss the sutra on the bed and use it as a pillow, or sometimes put it up on a high shelf and let it get eaten by bugs. When they're tense, they won't even stop to pee or pass gas, wishing they could awaken to the Buddha's knowledge and vision on the spot; when they're slack, they're like a limp 'fried dough stick.' If you study the 'teachings' like that, then even if you study for eight or ten years and become a glib talker, you'll have learned no more than to 'jiao' like a chicken [Tr.: a pun: jiao 'the teachings' sounds the same as jiao 'to cluck']." Although these words border on the comical, their meaning is well worth pondering.

[Addendum 2] From the diary of Upasika Tan Guo Zheng:

The Master telephoned, and I talked with him about quiet sitting. The Master said, "When the mind is clear, the moon appears in the water; when the thoughts are settled, there are no clouds in the sky." The Sixth Patriarch said, "Not thinking of good, not thinking of evil." I remember the Master once saying, "A cultivator of the Way must not doubt; once doubt arises, he loses his way." He also said, "Having intention is false thinking; having no intention is a response." The Master emphasized, "A cultivator of the Way is allowed only one mind; having two minds will not do."

(7) Disciples with Opened Eyes

In real life we often see that some people are blind, while others can see the different states of ordinary beings and sages, such as Buddhas and Bodhisattvas, spirits and ghosts, and past lives. Is this true?...

In the Venerable Master's own words:

In Manchuria, more than ten of my disciples could see Buddhas, Bodhisattvas, ghosts, and spirits. There were some in Hong Kong too, but I seldom had them talk about it to everyone. Why? Because Hong Kong was a very complicated place. Most people there didn't believe what was true and liked to run after what was false. If you told them something true, they said it was false; if you told them something false, they said it was true. They couldn't tell true from false. Especially some people who thought themselves clever turned right and wrong upside down even more. Why are some people blind? Why do some people have eyes? And why do some people see the different states of ordinary beings and sages? This all comes from their cultivation in the past. People who can see the different states of ordinary beings and sages mostly cultivated the Forty-two Hands and Eyes in their previous life, or in the life before that. Because by cultivating the Forty-two Hands and Eyes, one can obtain the Thousand Hands and Thousand Eyes. Even if they haven't formally obtained the Thousand Hands and Thousand Eyes, they can still see the different states of ordinary beings and sages. Why do some people have very good eyes? Because in previous lives they offered incense and flowers and lit lamps to the Buddhas,

so their eyes are bright too. Why are some people blind? Precisely because they didn't believe in anything. When others said they had seen something, they would say, "That's fake; there's no such thing!" Afterward they couldn't see anything at all. This kind of retribution is truly inconceivable.

[Addendum] Upasika Tan Guo Shi recounted:

Cai Guo Su truly had good roots; perhaps it came from her cultivation in past lives. She was able to enter samadhi. One day we were holding a Buddha Recitation session. We sat and recited the holy name of Amitabha Buddha for 10 to 15 minutes, then sat in silence reciting silently, until the Dharma Master struck the bell; then everyone stood up for walking meditation. Guo Su didn't get up. Someone was about to give her a push, but the Master said, "Don't push her, don't touch her." She was in samadhi for about half an hour. If the Master hadn't struck the bell, she could have stayed sitting in samadhi indefinitely. Guo Su could see what had happened in past lives. Sometimes the Master would have her talk about her experiences, and sometimes he would have her enter samadhi to look into other people's problems.

45. Training Disciples to Speak the Dharma

The Venerable Master gave the Dharma to people in a style all his own and was a model for monastics in speaking the Dharma. Not only did he lecture on the sutras and give instructional talks, spreading the essence of the Buddha's thought to his refuge disciples and devotees, but with earnest compassion he also trained his disciples to lecture on the sutras and speak the Dharma...

The Venerable Master taught people according to who they were. He encouraged young, educated disciples to study Buddhism, understand its principles, and awaken to the Way, so as to become successors in propagating the Dharma. Elderly, uneducated lay Buddhists he likewise encouraged to study the Buddhadharma and share what they felt, even if it was only one thing or one sentence.

In the Venerable Master's own words:

When Dharma Masters generally lecture on the sutras, one person lectures and everyone else listens. But when I lecture on the sutras, I bring two helpers along, and before I speak I have them talk first for three to five minutes. Why do I do this? Because my principle is to bring up young people to become talented propagators of the Dharma. I want to cultivate new blood for Buddhism; I want to nurture a new generation of young Buddhists. We need to train a group of genuine cultivators and teach a group of the most capable speakers. Whoever likes giving talks can practice first, and then come out and speak publicly at the large Dharma assemblies. Don't fall into the habit where you don't dare to speak, I don't dare to speak, and we don't even want anyone else to speak, but only know how to hide behind people's backs gossiping about right and wrong. That is a great and grievous mistake.

Making offerings to the assembly with the Dharma is the giving of Dharma! No matter who is lecturing on the sutras, I rejoice and praise it. As long as you dare to speak, it doesn't matter if you say something wrong; that's my principle. If you speak wrongly and there's an offense, the offense is mine. The Buddha is compassionate: if you have faults and can correct them, he forgives you, and besides, it's not as if you're deliberately speaking wrongly. Take my sutra lectures: I'm not afraid of anyone criticizing me. If what I say isn't right, then you come and lecture; that's my principle. When you're giving a talk, there should be no one in your eyes. Don't see anyone, don't be afraid of people laughing at you, and don't be afraid of what people might say; as long as what you say makes sense, that's fine. Some muddle-headed people say, "Don't speak! If you say something wrong, you'll commit an offense!" Even if you speak wrongly, it's still better than not speaking. If you don't speak, you yourself won't know whether you're right or wrong, and no one else will know either. We're all here to study the Buddhadharma. If, as just now, someone says something wrong, someone who knows can help correct it. All of you who are learning to lecture on the sutras should hold respect in your hearts for those who came before you; you may not call the Patriarchs and senior figures directly by name. For example, when referring to the Sixth Patriarch, don't just say "Huineng"; you must add "Great Master." "Great Master" is a title of respect. Don't study the Buddhadharma on the one hand while creating offense-karma on the other. You are an ordinary person, and calling a Patriarch directly by name is the most disrespectful and impolite behavior of all; it shows that you haven't yet truly understood the Buddhadharma.

As for what I'm telling you now: in the future, once you understand the principles of the sutras, you don't necessarily have to lecture the way I do; you can speak according to the principles you yourselves have awakened to. Speaking the Dharma should be concise: don't say one word too many, and don't say one word too few. Don't be like embroidery, and don't go on at great length as if you were writing a composition. Don't talk too fast, and don't talk too slowly; don't speak too broadly, and don't speak too narrowly. Sutra lectures should be such that everyone can understand. They should be plain and accessible, so that ordinary people all understand; only then are they useful. If you lecture too profoundly, so that people don't understand, that isn't of much use either.

[Addendum 1] Upasika Tan Guo Shi recounted:

After Western Bliss Gardens Monastery was completed, every weekend there was a Buddha Recitation Dharma assembly and an instructional talk by the Master, and the Master also had each of us take turns speaking the Dharma. After the adults finished speaking, we young people would go up after them and speak. Actually, it didn't matter what you said; you could even just say your name. The Master would remember who had spoken this week and whose turn it was next week. He didn't let us prepare beforehand; he wanted us to say whatever we were thinking. This was the Master's method for teaching us public

speaking. He told us, "Don't be afraid. Just go up on stage and say what you're thinking, and that will do."

At that time I wasn't afraid to go up and give a talk, because at school I often took part in debate competitions and had faced more people than there were at Western Bliss Gardens, but I didn't know what to talk about. The Master told me, "Don't worry! Just talk about your ideas, tell what's on your mind, and that's enough!" I don't remember what I talked about the first time, but everyone thought I spoke quite well. I remember an elderly Upasika in her sixties or seventies who couldn't read; she recited the Buddha's name vigorously every day, and the Master had her go up and speak too. She said, "Shifu is so compassionate. I don't know what to say; all I know is reciting Amitabha Buddha!" The Master said, "That's exactly right!"

[Addendum 2] From the diary of Upasika Tan Guo Zheng:

The Master often had us come up and speak, but we never knew when the Master would call our names; this was his method of training. The Master not only trained young people to speak the Dharma, but also encouraged older lay Buddhists to study the Buddhadharma; the Master truly hoped that everyone could speak the Dharma. There was once an elderly lay Buddhist who came up every week and recited the same verse, the same four lines, but the Master said it didn't matter, as long as we were willing to open our mouths and speak. I remember that once the Master said in an instructional talk, "After seeing through, you also have to put down." Xue Guo Su restated the main points of the Master's talk. Guo Sheng explained "precepts, samadhi, and wisdom: the Three Non-Outflow Studies." People like Ye Guo Qing and Yu Guo Man, both past fifty, spoke the Dharma full of their faith in the Master. Ye Guo Qing went on to explain the lines from Great Master Hanshan's *Song of Wasted Effort*: "Cultivation is easy, but meeting a teacher is hard; if you don't meet an enlightened teacher, it's all wasted effort." Yu Guo Man said, "The Master always urges us to recite the Buddha's name. I just recite the Buddha's name; there's nothing else for me to do. To begin with, your mind-ground must be bright. When your mind-ground is bright, everywhere is bright."

Part Three: Cixing Monastery and Providing for the Sangha

Ages 36 to 39

1953 to 1956 CE

46. Cixing Chan Monastery

After building Western Bliss Gardens Monastery, the Venerable Master vowed to found a Way-place that could accommodate more members of the Sangha to apply effort and cultivate the Way. At the time, the political situation was turbulent and unsettled, and a great many monks and nuns from mainland China had drifted to Hong Kong. Because there was no suitable place for them to settle, their cultivation of the Way was going to waste...

Seeing this, the Venerable Master felt that building Buddhist Way-places in Hong Kong was a matter that could not be put off for a moment. But alas, his resources fell short of his intentions: the Venerable Master's Way-place, Western Bliss Gardens, was close to a busy district and small in area, and there was simply no spare room to house the monastics who had fallen on hard times.

It was not until the autumn of the guisi year (1953) that conditions finally ripened, when the lay Buddhist Dong Guo Qi, after taking refuge with the Venerable Master, generously donated a two-story stone villa located halfway up Ling Wui Shan at Man Cheung Po, in the southwest of Lantau Island in the New Territories, as an offering to the Buddha to serve as a Way-place. As it happened, the villa's neighbor on the right was the abandoned Guoqing Chan Monastery, founded by Dharma Master Fa Chuan in 1930. When the gunfire of the Pacific War reached Lantau Island, Guoqing Chan Monastery was bombed and destroyed by the Japanese army, and its abbot, Dharma Master Fa Chuan, died a martyr's death. From then on, the Sangha scattered in all directions, and only broken walls remained, half-buried in heaps of rubble.

(Editor's note: Japan launched the Pacific War on December 7, 1941. On December 8 it made a surprise attack on Kai Tak Airport in Hong Kong, and on December 25 Hong Kong fell. The Hong Kong–Kowloon Brigade continued to wage guerrilla warfare against the Japanese army. In the Battle of Midway in June 1942, the American forces defeated the Japanese and regained command of the sea and the air in the Pacific. At the time, the Allies planned to land along the coast of China to wipe out the main force of the Japanese army. Lantau Island, situated on high ground, was the best place to establish an Allied beachhead, so a Lantau Island guerrilla unit was quickly formed, opening up the Lantau battlefront. Guoqing Chan Monastery was one of the operational bases of the Hong Kong–Kowloon guerrillas, and the Japanese army killed many people on the Lantau battlefront.)

Because Guoqing Chan Monastery had long been in disrepair, it was overgrown with weeds, and wherever one looked there were broken bricks and shattered

tiles. There were no doors, no windows, and no roof, and even the surrounding walls had crumbled beyond repair; the desolate, ruined scene was unbearable to look at. Facing this scene of ruin, the Venerable Master could not help feeling a deep sorrow: this was a place where disciples of Shakyamuni had cultivated, so how could it be left abandoned like this for long? So he obtained the consent of the people concerned with Guoqing Chan Monastery, and the ruins of the monastery were handed over to the Venerable Master to deal with.

In fact, Ling Wui Shan at Man Cheung Po (whose name is also written with the character for "cloth" in place of "waterfall") is a secluded mountain place where birds sing, with peaks gathered all around in a majestic sweep. But because the mountain paths were rugged and the ravines steep and perilous, it was hard to get to, and so people seldom came. Its natural environment lay hidden and unexposed, and so, on the contrary, it had escaped damage at human hands. Guoqing Chan Monastery lay right in the midst of these clustered peaks and ridges, strangely shaped jagged rocks, and secluding green forests. The Venerable Master was overjoyed to obtain this sacred site. Following the contours of the mountain and its slopes, he planned to combine the ruins of the monastery and the villa into one and renovate them as a monastery where the Sangha could apply effort and cultivate the Way.

Although the lay Buddhist Dong's villa had been built after the war, it had been abandoned for so long that all its doors and windows were gone. The only way it was better than Guoqing Chan Monastery was that its roof wasn't open to the sky! Dilapidated to this degree, it was practically a ruin itself. So how did the Venerable Master restore it?

Because funds were limited, the Venerable Master decided to repair the villa first and use it temporarily as the Buddha Hall; this later became the Left Courtyard of Cixing Chan Monastery. In the spring of 1954 (the jiawu year), the repairs to the villa and the guest hall were completed, and he named it "Cixing Chan Monastery, Spirit Mountain Way-place." The monastery was divided into an East Courtyard and a West Courtyard. The East Courtyard was the site of the ruins of Guoqing Chan Monastery and served as the place of cultivation for men; the West Courtyard, made from the villa, served as the place of cultivation for women. Besides the Buddha Hall, the Left Courtyard, and the guest hall, a dining hall, a retreat room, and a thatched hut were also added, one of each.

To build Cixing Chan Monastery, the Venerable Master worked day and night, forgetting to sleep and eat, rushing about everywhere. Whether hiring workers or buying materials, making images or laying in provisions, there was nothing he did not see to personally.

The Venerable Master wrote a verse:

Night falls on Ling Wui Shan;
I step out of Cixing Monastery.
A lone moon shines on a poor monk;
The host of stars encircles the Pole Star.

夜落靈會山，步出慈興寺。孤月照貧僧，眾星拱北極。

Worldly affairs are like dreams and illusions;
Those who know it, alas, are few!
Don't be turned by floating dust,
And I promise your six faculties will become one.

世事如夢幻，知者歎幾希。勿為浮塵轉，許汝六根一。

In the early days of building the monastery, there were difficulties everywhere. Every time the Venerable Master took the boat to Lantau Island, he had to carry 50 or 60 catties of rice and flour, or oil and salt, on his back up the mountain. Only after Dharma Master Heng Yi cleared the wasteland and began farming was there no longer any need to buy rice. At first, the monastery's residents were Dharma Master Heng Yi, Tang Guo Yun, and an elderly woman, Guo Quan; later, people came one after another to help: three worked in the kitchen, four farmed, and two did the cleaning and tidying.

In the Venerable Master's own words:

I, your teacher, was also a laborer doing hard work, hauling materials myself. Someone said, "You must like doing manual work, right?" No! I'm just like you: I don't want to do manual work either, and when I work I get very tired too. But for the sake of establishing a Way-place, I wasn't afraid of hardship. When I was building on Lantau Island, I wore myself out in mind and body, until my hair turned completely white from exhaustion! At that time I didn't have disciples to help me, so I had no choice but to hire workers.

I had to carry rice, oil, and salt on my back. From Hong Kong I'd take the 2:00 p.m. boat and reach Tai O at 5:00 in the evening, then carry 50 or 60 catties of rice, or oil or salt, and walk for two hours up the mountain. On the mountain there were lots of people working, and I carried these things up for them to eat. I'd reach the mountain at 7:00 in the evening, and early the next morning, a little after three, I'd hurry back down the mountain, because I still had to lecture on the sutras at Western Bliss Gardens in Hong Kong. Although I could have hired someone to carry the things up, that would have cost money, and I was saving every cent to buy building materials; I didn't waste a single cent! In this way, in two and a half years, I built three places. Why was there such an accomplishment in just two and a half years? Simply because I worked hard, wasn't afraid of any difficulty, and did the work myself, in person.

At Dajue Monastery on Mount Yunmen, rice was hulled by water power, and the rice it hulled was enough for the monastery's needs; villagers from nearby also went there to hull their rice. There was a pestle-and-mortar for hulling on Lantau Island too. I hulled rice there, though not often; sometimes I'd hull for an hour or two, and then others would come and take over. At that time there was a lot of grass on Lantau Island; some of the grass grew taller than a person. I saw "hundred-legs" (centipedes) three or four inches long; I saw them at Western Bliss Gardens too. Before that I had never seen centipedes that big.

At that time there were lots of discarded bricks, tiles, and stones piled up on the spot where the Buddha Hall was to be built, and to build the Buddha Hall they had to be cleared away first. Guo Li (Dharma Master Heng Yi) was there helping with the work, farming the fields, and managing the place. I told her to move the stones, bricks, and tiles away, but three times I told her and she ignored me, so I started moving them myself. Normally I just carried rice, flour, and oil on my back and seldom did any work on the mountain, so when Guo Li and the others saw me doing it too, they all got flustered and hurried over to clear it together. If I had just told them to do it, they couldn't have finished in five days; but when I led them and we all did it together, how did it go? It was all done in half a day.

[Addendum 1] Bhikshuni Dharma Master Heng Yi's oral account, given on January 7, 2001: When we first took over Cixing Monastery, I hadn't yet left the home-life; I was just living on the mountain, helping with the farming during the day and bowing to the Buddhas and cultivating in the evenings. The Master came back once every two or three days, always arriving very late. The Master's life on Lantau Island in the early days was very hard. There was no stove; to cook, we had to build a stove out of stones. There were no beds to sleep on either. From this you can get a glimpse of how hard it was. Every time, the Master would carry some food back with him. Ordinarily there was nothing good to eat; we ate congee all the time, and if on some day there was kelp, that counted as a fine dish.

One day, as night was falling, Guo Yun and I were still working in the fields when we saw a figure in the distance. When it came closer, we saw it was the Master! The Master was carrying a big sack of cement on his back and was doing three steps, one bow. The Master did a great deal of practice every day, and went down the mountain at three in the morning. (Upasika Tan Guo Zheng said, "The Venerable Master hardly ever slept at night; he spent the whole night sitting in meditation and applying effort. The Venerable Master's way of cultivating was unknown to others.")

[Addendum 2] Bhikshuni Dharma Master Heng Yi's oral account, given on September 25, 2000:

Western Bliss Gardens was built before Cixing Monastery.

After the Opening-the-Light ceremony at Western Bliss Gardens, someone came on Guanyin's birthday and said they would give a piece of land to the Master; that's what is now Cixing Monastery.

During the occupation, the Japanese killed many people here at Guoqing Monastery, the predecessor of Cixing Monastery, so when Cixing Monastery was being rebuilt back then, a lot of skeletons were dug up.

I remember that when the Master was about to build Cixing Monastery, I said to him, "Shifu, you want to put up a building here? This place is so high up, with no water, no sand, and no stone. How can we build a house?" The Master still wanted to build right there, so we had no choice but to dig the earth and quarry the stone ourselves, and carry the cement ourselves (we called it "red-hair

mud," or "English mud"). At that time a bag of cement cost 25 cents, but hiring workers to carry it cost 60 cents a bag. That was so expensive that, to save money, we had no choice but to carry it ourselves.

It took three years to build the two places. First was the Hall of the Three Sages of the West. After the Opening-the-Light ceremony for the Three Sages of the West, we built the Jeweled Hall of the Great Hero. Back then the Buddha Hall was built with big stones; where there was no concrete poured, horse-dung mud was poured instead. In the early days nobody was making offerings yet, so we had no choice but to go down to the fields and farm. At first there was only me and one elderly person; later, nine people came to help: three worked in the kitchen, four farmed, and two did the cleaning.

After Cixing Monastery was completed, at least ten Chan sessions were held there every year, and sometimes as many as 20. At that time many Dharma Masters who had fled from mainland China lived at Cixing Monastery. That was just when the Communist Party was liberating the mainland.

In those days the Master would leave at 4:00 every morning and take the boat to Lantau Island, carrying lots of fruit, vegetables, soy sauce, and so on, on his back. By the time he reached the mountain, it was already past 9:00 in the morning. These things were all for the Dharma Masters on the mountain to eat, and we would work in the fields until dark. Tell me, wasn't that hard for the Master?

At that time, the Master's conditions had ripened for him to go to America to propagate the Dharma. At first I lived at Cixing Monastery and made my living by farming. Later I went to live at the Buddhist Lecture Hall in Happy Valley, and once I was there, I stayed for 11 years; the Master, too, was in America for 11 years before he came back to Hong Kong. I phoned the Master and told him that I wanted to go back to Cixing Monastery: I couldn't live in Hong Kong too long, or I would die. After the Master had been gone for 11 years, I went back to the mountain.

[Addendum 3] Bhikshu Dharma Master Heng Xing recounted on September 25, 2000:

Cixing Monastery is in the northern part of Lantau Island, with its back to the south and facing northwest, so whenever a typhoon comes, it often gets hit very hard. It takes the northwest wind head-on. On ordinary days, when nothing happens, it's fine; but when something does happen, the wind can blow a whole awning up into the air, and the awnings over the corridors get damaged. Even the roof covering of the kitchen was once lifted up by the wind, but then it fell back into its original place without being damaged. Though it has been patched for leaks many times, it can still be used, because it's made of asbestos tiles, which hardly ever break; but even so, as we patched it, it kept leaking. In the end it leaked for a whole week: as we ate, water dripped in; it was raining outside, and raining inside too.

Cixing Monastery's predecessor was Guoqing Monastery. The land of the Three Sages of the West (the villa) was given to the Master by a lay Buddhist named Dong. When the Hall of the Three Sages of the West was being built, Guoqing Monastery, the villa's neighbor on the right, was extremely dilapidated. Seeing such a fine place, the Master didn't want it to go to waste, so he asked the people then in charge of the place and brought up rebuilding it. So the Master used the foundations of Guoqing Monastery to build what is today's Cixing Monastery.

Today's Cixing Monastery consists of two parts: there are about six buildings, but none of the spaces is very large.

Building Cixing Monastery and the Hall of the Three Sages of the West was extremely difficult. According to Dharma Master Heng Yi, the walls put up back then were built of big stones. Where did those big stones come from? It turns out they were dug out of the mountain. Workers were hired to cut the stone, and they cut it into rectangular blocks. At the time, the price was 25 cents to cut one stone, and each stone weighed on average 60 to 80 catties. The stone-cutting was done by hired workers, because we didn't know how to cut stone ourselves. Our own people did the hauling, because the stones had to be carried back to the building site; they hadn't come out of the original buildings. So what could be done? There was nothing for it but to haul them ourselves, carrying them back on our shoulders. Just imagine: one stone weighed 60 to 80 catties, so carrying two came to over a hundred catties, and you had to walk a long way, sometimes over mountains and across ridges, crossing two hilltops or two gullies and ridges, before you could get them back to Cixing Monastery. Back then they really had a very hard time building it. As for sand, it wasn't bought at the foot of the mountain, not like now, when it's bought by the truckload. So how did they get it? They took sand from the mountain gullies and the banks of streams and washed it, panning it the way people pan for gold. Sand was very precious, because without sand you can't put up a building. And there was no cement, only yellow mud slurry; cement was very costly. Because it had to be carried up the mountain (ordinarily, even going up the mountain empty-handed took a few hours), the cement had to be carried all the way up. By the time I came to Cixing Monastery, it still had to be carried up the same way. Although later on vehicles could get to Cixing Monastery, it was still just a bad road. Hiring people to carry things up the mountain was very expensive. As the saying goes, "The servant girl is bigger than the mistress" [Tr.: a Cantonese saying: the incidental cost exceeds the cost of the thing itself]. Because building Cixing Monastery was so very difficult, the Master was extremely worried.

When the Master lectured on the *Shurangama Sutra*, he mentioned that back then, because he worried so much about building Cixing Monastery, his hair turned white; later, when he put it down, his hair turned black again. So it's not hard to imagine how much the Master had on his mind back then.

Because no one knew whether the construction could be completed smoothly, the Master vowed to burn a finger as an offering to the Buddha, in the hope that

the rebuilding of Cixing Monastery would soon be completed. That was because at that time many Dharma Masters from the mainland had come to Hong Kong and had nowhere to live, and many monastics had to beg. At that time the abbot of Tung Po Tor Monastery, Elder Master Mao Feng, was very compassionate. His own monastery didn't have enough food to eat, but seeing the monks suffering so much, he opened the monastery gates and took in monastics who had fled to Hong Kong. It was just as the saying goes: "If there's congee, eat congee; if there's rice, eat rice; if there's one meal, eat that one meal." The Master too had stayed at Tung Po Tor as a visiting monk at that time. So the Dharma Masters of Hong Kong called Elder Master Mao Feng the King of Compassion.

To come back to Cixing Monastery: at that time the Master very much wanted to finish building Cixing Monastery quickly, so that we monastics would have a place to settle. So the Master vowed to burn a finger as an offering to the Buddha, in the hope that the construction of Cixing Monastery would be completed soon. The Master asked Dharma Master Yong Xing to help him bind up his finger in preparation for burning it. Unexpectedly, his disciples found out and became alarmed; besides, the rebuilding work was extremely urgent. The disciples said to the Master, "Shifu! If you burn your finger and injure your body, how can the work be finished? This will hold up the construction!" Everyone knelt and begged the Master not to burn his finger. The Master's heart softened, and he had no choice but to grant his disciples' request: according with living beings, he gave up burning his finger. Then, with tears in his eyes, the Master asked Dharma Master Yong Xing to unwind the cloth wrapped around his finger. The Master also wrote two large characters meaning "Dead!" on the ceiling above the head of his bed.

Later, the Master thought of another way to get Cixing Monastery finished soon. He boarded a boat at Aberdeen (at that time there was no Star Ferry, nor any Tsing Ma Bridge): he took a fishing boat from Aberdeen to the Tai O pier, and starting from the Tai O pier, he did three steps, one bow all the way up to Cixing Monastery. Even on an ordinary day, walking from the Tai O pier to Cixing Monastery took two or three hours, let alone doing three steps, one bow. In the end his wish was fulfilled, and Cixing Monastery was built.

From Dharma Master Heng Yi I learned that Cixing Monastery at that time was extremely dilapidated, and there were also lots of skeletons. That was because during World War II the guerrillas used Cixing Monastery as a base. The Japanese army fought its way up from the Tai O pier to Guoqing Monastery and battled the guerrillas, leaving behind many skeletons as relics of that time. Even long after the war, no one cleared them away, until Cixing Monastery was rebuilt.

I remember that around 1982 or 1983, when Cixing Monastery was being renovated again, I saw that there were still bullet marks on the walls of Cixing Monastery, and during the renovation the bullet marks on the walls were covered over with plaster.

Back then, when Cixing Monastery was being rebuilt, the Master spent a lot of time rescuing those who had been killed in battle and those who had perished. The lay Buddhists who lived at Cixing Monastery at that time often saw ghosts; Cixing Monastery was frequently haunted, and the ghosts often played jokes on the people in the monastery. What kind of jokes? There was a cook (in the old days, cooking was done on kerosene stoves or with coal) whose fire would often be blown out just as it was lit for cooking, though there was no one else around, so it often took a long time to get a meal cooked. When the Master was at Cixing Monastery, he would often recite mantras facing one particular direction. We often saw the Master not saying a word, and we knew he was rescuing them.

Dharma Master Heng Yi also said that the Master didn't spend much time at Cixing Monastery; he went back to Cixing Monastery once a week. The Master spent more of his time at Western Bliss Gardens. The Master lived at Western Bliss Gardens, or lectured on the sutras at the Buddhist Lecture Hall in Happy Valley, because the Lecture Hall was a place for receiving and guiding living beings, whereas Cixing Monastery was a place for cultivation. Those who wanted to cultivate lived at Cixing Monastery, so at that time about 20 people lived at Cixing Monastery.

From the Buddhist Lecture Hall you went to Aberdeen to take a boat, and you had to ride a fishing boat for five hours to reach the Tai O pier. The boats were what were popularly called "big-eyed chicken" fishing junks; nowadays it's a hovercraft. After landing, you still had to walk two or three hours to reach Cixing Monastery. Every time the Master went up the mountain, he carried lots of fruit, vegetables, soy sauce, and so on, on his back; rice wasn't needed, because they grew their own rice on the mountain.

At that time, a boatman told a lay Buddhist, "Your Master is very special. Once he (the Master) was on the boat when it started pouring rain. Everyone ran into the cabin to get out of the rain; only your Master stayed sitting at the bow." The Master stayed out in the rain the whole way until he went up the mountain.

Once the Master went down the mountain at two in the morning. Someone wanted to give him a flashlight to light his way, but the Venerable Master didn't want it. One of the others, however, said the Master didn't need a flashlight; he had eyes on his hands and feet! It was pouring rain at the time, and the Master got soaked in the rain all the way to the Tai O pier. After boarding the boat he sat in meditation, getting rained on all the way to Hong Kong. When he got back to Western Bliss Gardens, the lay Buddhist who looked after the Master was heartbroken to see him like that. It was already seven in the morning by then.

[Addendum 4] Upasika Tan Guo Shi recounted:

Every time I went to Western Bliss Gardens, most of the time I saw the Master sitting with his legs crossed. One day I noticed the Master was walking a little strangely, so I asked him, "Are you sick?" He said he wasn't; the Master wouldn't say anything. Suddenly I noticed that the Master's knees were bleeding. I said, "Shifu, what happened to you?" The Master said, "I wasn't

careful!" Later I asked the Master's attendant, the elderly Upasika Guo Ping, and she told me, "Don't you know the Master goes to Lantau Island every night?" I said, "Yes, I know. Why?" She said that after the Master vowed to build a monastery there, he did three steps, one bow every night, and it was only after he had been bowing for a long time that we found out about it.

Once I went with the Master to Cixing Monastery. From Hong Kong the boat took three hours; then we crossed over Pine Mountain (there were lots of pine trees there, so we called it "Pine Mountain") and walked another two or three hours on a rugged mountain trail before reaching Cixing Monastery. On the way we passed Man Cheung Po; looking down from above, it seemed bottomless. Every time we passed there, we had to walk in single file, because the path was very narrow, only wide enough for one person; walking two abreast was impossible. We carried flashlights to light the way, but we still couldn't go as fast as the Master, who didn't use a flashlight. I remember that the Master once set a record of reaching Cixing Monastery in less than two hours.

When the Master decided to rebuild Guoqing Chan Monastery, at first no one was willing to carry the bricks and timber. It wasn't a question of how much they would be paid; they thought it was an impossible job. Because the path was narrow, building materials could only be carried on the shoulders, and then you had to walk three hours on mountain trails, so no one was willing to do it. One disciple was a construction worker, and he said no workers were willing to go there, because it was up on a mountain, there wasn't anything to eat, and life there was dull and hard. Dharma Master Heng Yi hadn't yet left the home-life then; she stayed there to help the Master put the place in order.

Fortunately, there was an elderly lay Buddhist named Ye (Guo Qing) who worked for a construction company. Ye went to Lantau Island to survey the terrain and found another route. Because Lantau Island backs onto the sea, the heavier building materials could be transported by water, and then people could be hired to carry the materials up the mountain. Every time we went, we brought some materials up with us, and for the rest we hired villagers to help carry them; but what we carried was much lighter than cement and big timbers. This is the history of how Cixing Monastery was built: because of the Master's sincere and firm determination, the monastery was finally rebuilt.

[Addendum 8] Bhikshuni Dharma Master Heng Yi's oral account, given on September 25, 2000:

Later on (in the 1980s), Cixing Monastery had to be renovated again, because many places were badly dilapidated and there was no choice but to repair them. I phoned the Master and said, "Shifu, it's so vexing! Cixing Monastery has to be repaired again!"

"What's vexing about it? Put it down!" the Master told me.

"How can I put it down, Shifu?" I asked the Master.

"I can put down the City of Ten Thousand Buddhas; why can't you put this down?"

"After I put it down, where will I go?"

"Everywhere is a Way-place!" the Master said.

47. The Divine Dragon Comes to Life

In the autumn of 1953, early in the reconstruction of Cixing Chan Monastery, an episode took place. A venomous snake with a red head and a green body often appeared there. When the residents saw it, they caught it in a large iron bucket and carried it several li [Tr.: a li is about half a kilometer, or a third of a mile] away to release it...

Strangely, though, before the people who took the snake away had even returned, the snake was already back ahead of them, appearing right where there were lots of people and it would be easily seen, with an air of "What can you do to me?" Each time they took it away, it came back, over and over again. The strangest time was when they took it far away to release it. Just as they opened the lid of the bucket, they found the snake wasn't inside. They turned the bucket over and tapped it lightly, and suddenly half a snake's body dropped out of the bucket. By the time the people who had taken the snake away got back, it had become a whole venomous snake again, head raised and tongue flicking, slithering about in front of the Buddha Hall.

Snakes belong to the dragon family, and only a true dragon can keep venomous snakes in check. So the Venerable Master carefully studied the lay of the land at Man Cheung Po on Ling Wui Shan. Cixing Chan Monastery lies at the source of Man Cheung Po; nearby, mountain streams join together, majestic as a rainbow, and seen from afar it looks like a bolt of silver cloth ten thousand zhang long [Tr.: a zhang is about 3.3 meters] falling from the sky. Amid this sacred scenery, the Venerable Master chose three towering rock faces to the rear left of the monastery and set up a Dragon-Subduing Rock upon them. He then had Upasaka Chen Guo Sheng make use of the natural terrain to sculpt a golden dragon. The golden dragon is about four meters long, its scales tumbling and its claws soaring, splendid in seven colors and astonishingly lifelike. After the golden dragon was finished, the Venerable Master recited the Shurangama Mantra for seven days, and from then on the venomous snake never appeared again. Truly, it is no empty saying that virtue can subdue demons.

After the golden dragon was built, a spring welled up from a crevice in the rocks behind the monastery and flowed all year round, never drying up even in times of drought. The Venerable Master called it "Dragon's Mouth Water." A water-quality specialist once took the spring water to be tested and found it extremely pure, entirely free of impurities. (Editor's note: This great golden dragon has become one of the scenic sights of Lantau Island.)

In the Venerable Master's own words:

The man who made the dragon on Lantau Island in Hong Kong was the one who made all the sculptures in the Aw Boon Haw Garden. I hope this man can come to America; I don't know whether he'll be able to come. He said that if he could come, he'd be willing to make a Guanyin Bodhisattva image 36 Chinese feet (3 zhang 6 chi) tall on the vacant land at the monastery.

[Addendum 1] Upasaka Pei Zhenghui recounted (reproduced from *Mind Dharma* (*Xinfa*) magazine):

Cixing Chan Monastery as it is now (1956): besides the Buddha Hall, the Left Courtyard, and the guest hall, a dining hall, a retreat room, and a thatched hut have also been added, one building each. On the left is the Dragon-Subduing Rock, and on the right is the Tiger-Taming Stream. The layout is superb, spread out like stars and chessmen. Its white walls and red pillars stand out within the embrace of countless mountains. Truly it can be said to capture the spiritual energy of heaven and earth and to surpass the hidden workings of creation. Its secluded beauty is in no way inferior to that of the Four Great Famous Mountains and the Eight Great Lesser Mountains of China; even compared with Nanhua Monastery, the Way-place of the Sixth Patriarch, it is not the least bit inferior!

[Addendum 2] Lay Buddhist Liu Mianzhai recounted (reproduced from *Mind Dharma* magazine):

Adornment Peak holds Azure Dragon Ridge at its left; on the ridge towers the Dragon-Subduing Rock, and on the rock a golden dragon has been sculpted, made by craftsmen at the Venerable Master's command. Its scales tumble and its claws dance, so lifelike it seems alive. Bright as lightning, it twists and changes; rumbling like thunder, it roars and bellows. Its might strikes fear into goblins and sprites, and its spirit cows evil demons. Awe-inspiring, it bears the air of the "Dragon's Swift Vigor Samadhi."

[Addendum 3] Bhikshu Dharma Master Heng Xing recounted on September 25, 2009:

The stone dragon at Cixing Monastery was made by a lay Buddhist. Although Cixing Monastery is a very good place, a Buddha-land, it also has a flaw. What flaw? In terms of fengshui, the Azure Dragon is on the left and the White Tiger is on the right, and here the White Tiger position is higher than the Azure Dragon position. This harms people and livestock: people living there are prone to injuries or accidents, and it's hard for people to keep living there. So the Venerable Master had a dragon made at the Azure Dragon position, so that the Azure Dragon position would be higher than the White Tiger position. After the dragon was finished, the Master told everyone that now they could live there in peace. Those were the causes and conditions that brought about this stone dragon.

Below the dragon there are rocks on which you can sit in meditation.

[Addendum 4] Bhikshuni Dharma Master Heng Wei's oral account:

Back then a dragon really did often appear around Cixing Monastery. With my own eyes I saw a dragon cultivating together with the assembly in the Buddha Hall.

[Addendum 5] Upasaka Huang Ketai recounted:

This dragon was built on the hillside at Cixing Monastery on Lantau Island. After the dragon was finished, a pool of water appeared on the slope below, right where the dragon's mouth was facing. This was truly very unusual. From this you can see that it is absolutely true that the Master had gods and dragons as Dharma protectors.

48. Miraculous Foresight for a Hundred Tables

In the spring of 1954 (the jiawu year), the restoration of the villa of the Left Courtyard and of the guest hall at Cixing Chan Monastery was completed, and preparations were made to hold the Opening-the-Light ceremony for the Three Sages of the West on the sixteenth day of the third lunar month (April 14 in the Gregorian calendar), the birthday of Cundi Bodhisattva...

Starting on the thirteenth day of the third month, the *Great Compassion Jeweled Repentance* was bowed for three days in a row, and on the evening of the fifteenth the *Three Great Masters' Flaming Mouth* ceremony was performed. It was just at the turn of spring and summer, and it had been drizzling for days on end; the land seemed shrouded in a layer of white gauze, and beyond ten paces people were just blurry shapes. Dark clouds had blanketed the sky for many days in a row, and it looked as though the rain would go on for a good while yet. Everyone was worried that the great ceremony would be spoiled by the rain. Who would have thought that on the evening of the fifteenth the clouds would suddenly scatter and the rain stop? On the day of the Opening-the-Light ceremony there was neither sun nor rain; the breeze was fresh and the air crisp, and it was very comfortable.

That day, from morning until noon, people came from Lantau Island, from Castle Peak and Tsuen Wan, and even from Hong Kong and Kowloon, arriving in a continuous stream, crowding in front and behind. Local gentry and merchants, schools and organizations, fishermen, farmers, woodcutters, and peddlers, faithful devotees from all walks of life, more than 1,000 people in all, attended the Opening-the-Light ceremony, and all 100 tables of vegetarian food that had been prepared were filled.

At ten o'clock there was a Universal Buddha Ceremony, and at noon the Opening-the-Light ceremony was held. The Buddha Hall was a sea of heads, packed so tightly inside and out that not even a drop of water could have trickled through. Local people said that this Opening-the-Light ceremony for the Left Courtyard of Cixing Chan Monastery broke the island's attendance record for any celebration in several decades.

In the Venerable Master's own words:

I've never had much affinity with people, but I do have a bit of affinity with heaven. In Hong Kong, when I held the Opening-the-Light ceremony on Lantau Island (Cixing Monastery was preparing to hold its Opening-the-Light ceremony on the sixteenth day of the third lunar month), on the fourteenth and fifteenth of the third month it rained very heavily. It poured for several days in a row, the ground was soaked (it was all damp), and the robes people wore got completely wet, as if they had been washed in water.

The day before the Opening-the-Light ceremony, I had prepared a hundred tables of vegetarian food. That Liang Guo Xiao said to me, "Shifu! It's raining today, and you've prepared so much food. What if nobody comes? With the rain, nobody will come, and won't all this food spoil and be left over...?" When she finished saying this, I gave her a scolding. I said, "You don't know what you're talking about! Whether it spoils or not, even if it does spoil, I won't make you eat it! Why do you care whether it spoils or not? Why do you have to meddle so much?" I scolded her until she didn't dare say anything more. Because "The Dharma does not arise on its own; it arises in dependence on circumstances," since a disciple had come raising this kind of request, I had to find a way to make it clear up! I sat down there and called these dragon disciples of mine: "Dragon disciples, hurry up and stop the rain! I'm holding an Opening-the-Light ceremony here; how can you keep on raining? Then people won't come!" I was still sitting there in meditation when they saw the ground dry up on its own; the water on the ground was all gone, and it stopped raining. That was on the evening of the fifteenth. The next day was the sixteenth. There was neither sun nor rain, and going up and down the mountain, people didn't sweat too much.

Normally, to come from Hong Kong to Lantau Island by boat, you had to catch the boat at 6:00 in the morning. By noon that day, who knows how many people had come. We had 97 tables seated, at 12 people a table, so about 1,000-odd people came. After the Dharma assembly ended, everyone left, and strangely enough, as soon as everyone was on the boats, it started raining again, and it went on raining for several days. As for the three tables of food that were left over, there were still 50 or 60 people staying on the mountain that night, and they ate it all up in one meal. So all the vegetarian food I had prepared got eaten.

Speaking of this, it was truly inconceivable!

[Addendum 1] From the diary of Upasika Tan Guo Zheng:

When people attended Dharma assemblies at Cixing Chan Monastery on Lantau Island, because it was such a long way, everyone would stay overnight at the monastery, so the rooms and beds were usually overcrowded, and many people slept sitting up in the Buddha Hall.

I remember that during the Dharma assembly for the Opening-the-Light ceremony of the Left Courtyard of Cixing Chan Monastery in 1954, many of the Dharma brothers and sisters stayed overnight on Lantau Island, and the young girls all stayed in the same room. Early in the morning, the person assigned to

strike the board ran into the room and beat it loudly, and soon the resonant sound of the bell drifted to our ears from the Buddha Hall.

One of the girls said, "I can't get up; you all go to morning recitation!" The quilts were nice and warm, and once someone had taken the lead, everyone was glad to laze about in comfort a little longer, so no one got ready to get up for morning recitation.

Suddenly Guo Ping, the Dharma sister who lived at the monastery, rushed into the room in a fluster and cried in a low voice, "Hurry up and get up! The Master has just lost his temper. He said that whoever doesn't get up for morning recitation will be driven down the mountain! The Master also said, 'One good disciple is enough!'" In less than ten minutes, everyone in the room was standing in the Buddha Hall, wearing their robes, with their lay precept sashes on. From then on, I was afraid the Master would expel me from the monastery, and I didn't dare skip morning recitation.

Below Cixing Monastery there was a campsite where people often camped and had fun. One night the campers heard the sound of a horn in the middle of the night. The next day they came up to the monastery and asked why the horn had been blown so early. Someone answered, "No one blew a horn; we don't even have a horn." It is said that the mountain spirits had blown their horns to gather their retinues to attend morning recitation.

[Addendum 2] Bhikshu Dharma Master Heng Ding's oral account:

When the Master invited Dharma Master Xu Lang to perform the Flaming Mouth ceremony on Lantau Island, ghosts were heard talking, and there were also male and female ghosts who came rushing to get the food.

[Addendum 3] Bhikshu Dharma Master Heng Xing recounted on September 26, 2000:

Below and in front of Cixing Monastery there was a campsite where people often camped and had fun. One night, at three in the morning, the campers heard the sound of a horn. The next day they came up the mountain to ask why the horn had been blown so early. Dharma Master Guo Yi said that no one had blown a horn; we didn't even have a horn. It is said that the mountain spirits had blown their horns to assemble their retinues and followers to attend morning recitation.

In the year after the Master entered perfect stillness (1996), we respectfully escorted the Master's sharira [Tr.: relics; the crystalline remains found after the cremation of an accomplished cultivator] back to Hong Kong. They went first to the Buddhist Lecture Hall and were then taken up to Cixing Monastery. When we reached the foot of the mountain below Cixing Monastery, Dharma Master Heng Xiang, another lay Buddhist, and I drove up the mountain together. As we were going up, an elderly lay Buddhist at Cixing Monastery was looking out from the open courtyard and saw many people holding large five-colored banners and carrying a sedan chair coming to welcome the Master. So the

Master had actually arrived back at Cixing Monastery before us. This lay Buddhist later told us that those people were probably mountain spirits.

49. Sagely Conditions in the Yiwei Year

The Right Courtyard of Cixing Chan Monastery on Lantau Island, built by the Venerable Master, was largely completed by the end of the yiwei year (1955), though the interior decoration still had to be done and Buddha images and Buddhist implements added. Lantau Island is quiet, secluded, and vast; one has to cross mountains and ridges to reach it. Its scenery is extraordinary, and it is truly a superb place for cultivation...

Although Guoqing Chan Monastery had been cruelly ravaged during the Japanese occupation, the revival of the monastery now was truly a sagely condition. For this reason, at the Spring Festival of the yiwei year, the Venerable Master composed a verse:

> *Joyfully we meet the year yiwei in the cycle;*
> *A thousand blessings gather like clouds, and the multitudes rejoice.*
> *Bells ring and drums resound, reaching through to the mind-ground;*
> *Kites soar and fish leap, revealing the heaven of the nature.*
>
> 欣逢歲次乙未年，千祥雲集萬眾歡。鐘鳴鼓響通心地，鳶飛魚躍見性天。
>
> *Atomic and hydrogen bombs add to the calamities of the kalpa;*
> *The Dharma ship sailing the seas rescues women and men.*
> *Formation, dwelling, decay, and emptiness are nothing to marvel at;*
> *Kindness, compassion, joy, and giving have sagely conditions.*
>
> 原子氫氣增劫運，航海法*救女男。成住壞空無足怪，慈悲喜捨有聖緣。

50. The Jeweled Hall Shines Anew

In the summer of 1956 (the bingshen year), the Jeweled Hall of the Great Hero in the Right Courtyard of Cixing Chan Monastery was completed. On the nineteenth day of the sixth lunar month (July 26), the anniversary of Guanyin Bodhisattva's attainment of the Way, a ceremony was held for the completion of the Jeweled Hall together with the Opening-the-Light of the golden images of the Three Tathagatas...

After the Opening-the-Light ceremony for the Buddha Hall of the Left Courtyard, the Hall of the Three Sages of the West, had been brought to a successful close, here amid the fine mountains and waters of Ling Wui Shan the Venerable Master spent another two years of arduous effort, personally drawing up the plans and selecting the timber and stone, and one after another completed the reconstruction of the Right Courtyard (the site of the ruins of Guoqing Chan Monastery): the Jeweled Hall of the Great Hero and the Patriarchs Hall on the first floor, and the Sutra Library and the living quarters on the second floor. He also gradually added a number of facilities. Although the Jeweled Hall is not grand in scale, it has a particularly majestic air. In particular, the solemnity of the golden Buddha images, the wonder of the sounding bells, drums, and

chimes, and the marvel of the beams and pillars that seem to hold up the sky all came about through the Venerable Master's virtue, and display its full majesty.

On this day, the Buddha-sun shone more brightly and the ancient monastery shone anew. It was the anniversary of Guanyin Bodhisattva's attainment of the Way, and also a day of great rejoicing for Lantau Island. From the surrounding villages near and far, and from as far away as the monasteries of Hong Kong and Kowloon, venerable Elders and countless patrons and devotees, and even representatives of the police station in Tai O, came on hearing the news. They presented calligraphy to celebrate the happy occasion and mirror plaques to offer congratulations, and took part in the ceremony for the completion of the Jeweled Hall of the Great Hero together with the Opening-the-Light of the golden images of the Three Tathagatas. The Venerable Master invited the Elders of the various monasteries to preside together over the purification by sprinkling, the ceremony celebrating the completion, the Opening-the-Light Dharma assembly, and the life-liberation ceremony, and to pray for blessings: favorable winds and timely rains, a nation at peace and a people secure, abundant harvests of the five grains, and good fortune in all things. Dharma Master Xu Lang chanted in a lofty Brahma voice; the presiding Dharma Master offered incense and sprinkled water for purification, then, holding a mirror, dotted the eyes to open the light, as Buddhist disciples from the ten directions bore witness together to the Jeweled Hall shining anew.

[Addendum 1] The mirror plaques presented by the greatly virtuous ones have, over half a century, been badly damaged by damp, and only a few traces of writing remain. The few mirror plaques that are still faintly legible are now recorded below: (omitted)

[Addendum 2] Bhikshuni Dharma Master Heng Yi recounted on September 25, 2000:

After the Opening-the-Light ceremony at Cixing Monastery on Lantau Island, we began holding Guanyin sessions and Amitabha sessions, and every session drew more than a hundred people. In the evenings there were sutra lectures until 10:00, and every time, those who came to hear the sutras had to climb several hundred stone steps up the mountain to listen. At that time there were always more than 40 or 50 people who came to listen to the sutra lectures.

After the Buddhist services each day, I would shuttle back and forth between the two places, the Buddhist Lecture Hall in Happy Valley and Cixing Monastery. Every day I went up the mountain at 4:00 in the afternoon, stayed until 2:00 in the middle of the night, and then started back down the mountain. Every single day like that.

[Addendum 3] Bhikshuni Dharma Master Heng Yi's oral account, given on January 7, 2001:

A fengshui master said that the fengshui here was very good and that Cixing Monastery on Lantau Island would produce Arhats in the future; the places where the Master had sat in meditation would all emit light.

[Addendum 4] Cixing Monastery (reproduced from *Buddhist Temples of Hong Kong* (*Xiangjiang Fanyu*)):

Cixing Monastery, halfway up Man Cheung Po in southwestern Lantau Island, is an ancient monastery. The original monastery was founded in 1930, built by Great Master Fa Chuan, and was formerly called "Guoqing Monastery." Sadly, when Hong Kong fell, it was burned down by the Japanese army, and Great Master Fa Chuan also died a martyr's death. In the autumn of 1953, Dong Guo Qi, a lay Buddhist devoted to the work of Buddhism, gave Dong's two-story villa, which stood beside Guoqing Monastery on its left, to Dharma Master To Lun for use in enshrining the Buddha. Through this opportunity, the Dharma Master consulted with the people concerned with Guoqing Monastery and, after obtaining their consent, planned and carried out the combined reconstruction of the old monastery and the villa. First the villa was repaired and named the Left Courtyard of Cixing Monastery. The Triple Jewel is enshrined within it, and it remains intact to this day. Later, Dharma Master To Lun raised more funds and built the present Jeweled Hall of the Great Hero, and the Kuomintang elder statesman Yu Youren specially inscribed for Dharma Master To Lun the plaque reading "Jeweled Hall of the Great Hero." In 1962 Dharma Master To Lun went to America to spread Buddhism widely, and he founded the Dharma Realm Buddhist Association.

While Dharma Master To Lun was away from Hong Kong, he entrusted Master Fa Zang with serving as acting abbot of Cixing Monastery, while the women's section was run by Shi Guo Li and Shi Guo Ren (that is, Dharma Master Heng Yi and Dharma Master Heng Qi). Dharma Master Fa Zang was a Dharma heir of Elder Master Tan Xu, a greatly virtuous monk of the Tiantai School. Dharma Master Fa Zang spent over a year repairing the monastery and completed living quarters and guest rooms, and Elder Tan personally inscribed a plaque reading "Abode of Pure Joy," which is still there today. Through the repairs carried out by the monastery's residents, the Buddha Hall for the first time acquired the grandeur of a glazed-tile roof and a majestic hall.

In America, Dharma Master To Lun accepted many American monastics as disciples. At the end of 1972, three of his American disciples came to Hong Kong to stay at Cixing Monastery and carried out work on the English translation of the *Dharma Flower Sutra*, and Cixing Monastery thus became the first Buddhist monastery in Hong Kong to have foreign monks. Dharma Master Fa Zang left Cixing Monastery in 1974. After Dharma Master To Lun entered perfect stillness and was cremated, he left behind thousands of sharira, some of which were specially brought back to Cixing Monastery to be enshrined.

Encouraging the Chan Cultivator Heng Bo in Helping to Translate the *Dharma Flower Sutra*

Composed by Hsuan Hua on May 22, 1972

> *Affinities formed in former lives have now borne fruit;*
> *In the same boat we help one another across, ferrying those lost in*

confusion.
When waves surge up to the sky, the ship sails steady;
When winds come sweeping the ground, do not be alarmed.
結緣前生果已成，同舟共濟度迷蒙。沖天浪起船行穩，卷地風來且莫驚。

The burden is heavy and the road is long as you promote the teaching;
Patience, precepts, vigor, and Chan: practice the rules in person.
On the day the translation of the Wonderful Dharma is complete,
At the Dragon Flower Assembly your special merit will be celebrated.
任重道遠倡教化，忍戒精禅律實躬。妙法翻譯圓滿日，龍華大會慶殊功。

Born with a wholesome nature,
Not deeply stained by worldly conditions,
You met good friends early on
And leapt out of the ford of confusion.
Making light of wealth and valuing righteousness,
You resolutely left the dust.
Upholding the precept against money,
You break through the mind of greed and anger.
天生善性，染緣未深。早逢良友，跳出迷津。輕財重義，毅然離塵。持金錢戒，破貪嗔心。

Helping to translate the Dharma Flower*,*
You polish the text in search of the truth.
Donning the armor of vigor,
Your courage surpasses all your peers.
Ascend to the ground of non-retreat
And pay homage to the World Honored One.
Strive on, strive on,
And do not fail my words.
助譯法華，潤色求真。披精進甲，勇冠群倫。登不退地，朝覲世尊。勉勵勉勵，勿負吾言。

Sending Off and Encouraging the Chan Cultivator Heng Jing as He Goes to Taiwan and Hong Kong to Propagate the Dharma: In Commemoration

Composed by Hsuan Hua on December 12, 1971

In the space age, the Proper Dharma rises to meet the times;
Win glory for the teaching and do not shrink from hardship.
East and West are nothing but a single unity;
North and South have never left the divisions of the six consciousnesses.
太空正法應運興，為教爭光莫辭辛。東西不外一元化，南北未出六識分。

The mind, the Buddha, and living beings are not different;
In beings endowed with spirit, the enlightened nature is shallow or deep.
Patience, vigor, and the perfection of prajna;
Shila and dhyana: be diligent at every moment.
心佛眾生無差別，性覺含靈有淺深。忍辱精進般若度，屍羅禅定時刻勤。

Sending Off and Encouraging the American Bhikshu, the Chan Cultivator Heng Shou, Who Is Going to Propagate the Dharma at the Invitation of Hong Kong Buddhists

Composed by Hsuan Hua on November 3, 1972

People can propagate the Dharma; it is not the Dharma that propagates people. The Dharma has no Proper or Ending Age; it is people who are good or bad. Habituated to things, people no longer notice them, and one after another they follow along until it becomes the prevailing custom: they treat the Buddhadharma as idle theorizing and do not put it into practice themselves, regard cultivation as empty talk, and even go so far as to put on a hypocritical show of solemnity. This truly deserves attention. The worthy should strive to turn back this decadent custom, reform the standards of the Sangha, and handle affairs with care. By no means let down the earnest intent behind my years of teaching and guidance. Be determined that Buddhism shall flourish and spread, and that the Proper Dharma shall abide in the world. Remember this well! I also present you with a verse:

> *Cultivate blessings, cultivate wisdom, cultivate Chan contemplation;*
> *Plant many good causes and form few enmities.*
> *Kindness enters the three periods of time, constantly handed on;*
> *Transformation began in the Six Dynasties, and truly it came first.*
> 修福修慧修禅觀，多種善因少結冤。慈入三世恆相授，化始六朝果然先。
>
> *The Saha world and Ultimate Bliss appear only from the mind;*
> *Hells and heavens are contained within the Dharma Realm.*
> *With no thought and no birth, you are always at ease;*
> *The mani jewel is perfect from the very beginning.*
> 娑婆極樂惟心現，地獄天堂法界含。無念無生常自在，摩尼寶珠本來圓。

Behind Cixing Monastery, on the hillside, there are three rock faces in a row. A lay Buddhist named Guo Sheng made use of the natural terrain to sculpt a flying dragon of reinforced concrete. The dragon is about four meters long, baring its fangs and brandishing its claws, lively in form and splendid in seven colors, and it has become one of the scenic sights of western Lantau. Unfortunately, the mountain path is now overgrown with weeds and creepers, so it can only be viewed from afar and not admired up close. Behind the monastery a spring wells up from a crevice in the rocks, flowing all year round and never drying up even in drought, which is inconceivable. Dharma Master To Lun named it Dragon's Mouth Water. A water-quality specialist once had the spring water tested and found it extremely pure, entirely free of impurities.

Cixing Monastery is a Buddhist monastery that is not very open to the public. At present the men's section of Cixing Monastery is managed by Bhikshu Shi Heng Xing and other monastics sent by the Dharma Realm Buddhist Association, and the monastery still keeps the rule of eating one meal a day, at midday.

51. The Monk's Bowl Subdues a Dragon

Not long after Cixing Chan Monastery was built, a green snake, neither large nor small, often appeared. So as not to alarm the assembly, it was taken far away and released, but as soon as it was released it came right back. One day the snake appeared again, and there was the Venerable Master, setting his bowl on the ground...

Not long after the Opening-the-Light ceremony at Cixing Chan Monastery, several laywomen left the home-life one after another. The Venerable Master gave his consent for Dharma Master Heng Yi and Upasika Tang Guo Yun to bring back under cultivation the rice paddies left behind by the long-abandoned Guoqing Chan Monastery (Cixing Chan Monastery's predecessor), so as to lighten the monastery's burden of supplying rice and grain. Every day they went to work at sunrise and rested at sunset. After coming back from the fields, they still had to recite the Buddha's name ten thousand times and recite the Great Compassion Mantra 49 times. At night they went to bed very late, and they rose at three o'clock in the morning.

One evening, as they were returning to the monastery, they suddenly saw a green snake crawling on the open ground in front of the women's dormitory, and everyone got a fright. Unexpectedly, a few days later it appeared again. Dharma Master Heng Yi caught the snake in a cloth bag and took it out into the wilds to release it. But no sooner had she stepped through the main door of the Buddha Hall than she saw the same snake crawling on the open ground again. This time, after catching the snake, she sealed it in an iron can with the lid shut tight and took it to a place very far away. But when she undid the lid to let it out, the snake had vanished without a trace, and no one knew where it had gone.

It had clearly been inside the iron can, so how could it have disappeared? As it turned out, the snake had gone back to the monastery yet again. This happened again and again, time after time; the snake simply could not be sent away. Everyone was terrified and at their wits' end, so all they could do was wait until the Venerable Master came back to Lantau Island and report the facts to him. The Venerable Master said, "If it comes out and disturbs the assembly again, put it in my bowl and send it to Cha Kwo Ling to be released."

One day, when the Venerable Master was at Cixing Monastery, the snake appeared again. The Venerable Master set his bowl on the ground, formed a mudra, and recited a mantra several times. Before long the snake crawled into the bowl and lay coiled up inside it, perfectly still. Then Dharma Master Heng Yi put the bowl into a cloth bag, and a layperson was found to take it down the mountain to a place very far away. From then on the snake was never seen again.

[Addendum 1] Bhikshuni Dharma Master Heng Yi's oral account, given on January 7, 2001:

On the hill behind Cixing Monastery there are a Snake Cave, an Immortals' Cave, a Monkey Cave, and a Buddha Cave. One day, as I was passing the

Monkey Cave, a monkey knelt and bowed down to me. But this monkey had not met the Master, so I told the Master that there was a monkey who wanted to take refuge. (The Master held a refuge ceremony on the tenth day of every lunar month.) Later, when we returned to Lantau Island, we saw this monkey holding a refuge certificate in its hands and bowing over and over.

[Addendum 2] Snakes Come to Hear the Dharma

On Sunday evening, June 20, 1982, a Dharma assembly was in session at the City of Ten Thousand Buddhas, and the disciples of the fourfold assembly were circumambulating the Hall of Ten Thousand Buddhas, reciting "Namo Amitabha Buddha" in unison. When they returned to the hall, they were startled to discover a green snake with mottled markings, about three or four feet long, lying beside the front door of the Buddha Hall. Someone wanted to remove the snake, but the Venerable Master smiled and said, "There's no need. All living beings have the Buddha-nature. This snake has come to draw near to the Triple Jewel and to listen to the Dharma. It should not be driven away."

What was strange was that this snake was unlike ordinary snakes: it lay stretched out straight on the ground. Although nearly a hundred people were coming and going in front of it and behind it, it showed no fear at all and was gentle and docile. Shortly afterward the Venerable Master ascended the Dharma seat and said, "Tell it that it may come in now to listen to the Dharma!" At once the snake crawled from the front door into the hall, then crawled from the left side over to the right side, as though circumambulating the Buddha once, and then lay down in front of the Dharma seat, for all the world as though it were kneeling before the Buddha listening to the Venerable Master speak the Dharma. (Reproduced from the editor's note preceding the article "Snakes Come to Hear the Dharma" in *Venerable Master Hua's Talks on Dharma*, Volume 4.)

In the Venerable Master's own words:

Today, as everyone was entering the Buddha Hall, you saw a snake. It too is one of the living beings. But because it manifests in the body of a snake, people take fright at the sight of it; they see it but do not recognize it, and some are even scared stiff. But this snake has come to draw near to the Triple Jewel, to listen to the sutras and hear the Dharma. Otherwise, how could it lie so well-behaved on the threshold without moving at all?

Although at first glance it looks like a small snake, in fact it knows how to undergo a thousand changes and ten thousand transformations. It can make itself invisible, appear small or grow large, and it can also ride the clouds and mount the mists, flying freely through the sky. It's just that we can't know what it is capable of. In the future, when this snake succeeds in its cultivation, it too will be able to attain the Way. The Buddhist sutras speak of "the gods, dragons, and the rest of the eightfold division," and it belongs to one of these divisions, the Mahoraga, which is a great python.

Looking into this snake's origins: it may have been a high minister of a small state during the Zhou dynasty. But he harbored treacherous schemes and

plotted to usurp the throne. He hid in his sleeve a dagger that had been steeped in poisoned wine and stabbed the king. But not only did this deed fail to win him the throne, it brought on the wrath of Heaven and the resentment of the people. As he lay dying, the minister gave rise to great hatred, and after death he fell into the body of a snake and turned into a giant python.

In the world there are two forces: one is yin and one is yang; you could also say one is good and one is evil. Those who follow the good cultivate both blessings and wisdom to the full, and they can become immortals, become sages, become Bodhisattvas, and become Buddhas. The power of the evil ones is also great, but they devote themselves to dark dealings that cannot bear the light of day, taking revenge on one another and killing one another, and so they brew up an incomparably huge miasma of resentment. The world is everywhere full of venomous snakes and venomous dragons. These venomous snakes and venomous dragons cannot be seen with ordinary physical eyes, yet they truly pervade the land. These venomous snakes take shape from the greed, hatred, and delusion accumulated in people's minds, and they wreak havoc everywhere. The natural disasters and man-made calamities of the world, flying corpses and deviant ghosts, goblins, demons, and nightmare-spirits, the spread of plagues, and all kinds of strange incurable diseases are all the mischief of these venomous snakes. These evil dragons and plague ghosts specialize in releasing poisonous vapors that confuse and disturb people's minds; or else, as mountain sprites and water goblins, they steal people's vital essence, leaving people terrified and deranged. Therefore all the kinds of mental illness so common nowadays, such as schizophrenia, madness, and phobias, as well as all kinds of stubborn physical ailments, are nothing other than these demons, ghosts, and goblins stirring up waves and wreaking havoc on living beings. Modern psychology and medicine do not deeply understand the principle behind this and cannot prescribe the right medicine for the illness, so their cure rates are far from satisfactory. Of course, only the Buddhadharma is the most ultimate miraculous medicine, the wondrous prescription for dispelling calamities and quelling disasters!

This venomous snake, driven by its hatred, strove hard at its cultivation and then became a spirit creature. Its magic arts grew stronger day by day, until in time it could penetrate heaven and earth, and it always took pleasure in tormenting and harming the common people. These days, who knows how many cases there are like this snake's? I hope they will quickly give rise to repentance and no longer act as evil monsters bringing calamity upon the people.

Later, by the time of the Song dynasty, this snake had become a venomous dragon. In a great river it whipped up winds and overturned the rains, killing countless fishermen and ferrymen. At that time the people of the area lived in fear and dread, in extreme anxiety. Fortunately, a certain sagely monk of great Dharma power came especially to rescue them. Holding his monk's staff, he stood on the riverbank and loudly rebuked the venomous dragon. Hearing his voice, the venomous dragon flew into a rage and brought out its powers,

manifesting the body of a giant python several thousand zhang long. But this Dharma Master was sustained by the power of the Vajra Samadhi and had no fear at all. Using the methods of summoning and subduing, after a life-and-death struggle lasting three days and three nights, he finally brought the venomous dragon to submission. Evil cannot overcome the proper: the venomous dragon's evil arts were broken, and having no other choice, it had to surrender. The Dharma Master spoke the Dharma for it: everything is suffering, empty, impermanent, and without self, and only karma follows one. He also admonished it that it should bring forth a compassionate heart and use its magic arts to benefit living beings, and must not harm living creatures. On hearing the Dharma, the snake suddenly awakened and obtained the pure eye. The Dharma Master then transmitted to it the Three Refuges and the Five Precepts and ordered it to go to a certain mountain cave to cultivate and to stop disturbing the people. The venomous dragon gladly obeyed. From the Song dynasty until now, several hundred years have passed. By now this dragon has become one of the gods, dragons, and the rest of the eightfold division, with spiritual powers and transformations at its command.

(Editor's note: At this point a Bhikshuni in the women's section said, "Several weeks ago we saw this snake near the women's Buddha hall at Joyous Giving House. Because we were afraid it might be a rattlesnake, we put it in a can, covered it with a hard wooden board, and got ready to take it to a fairly distant grove to release it, so that it wouldn't disturb the residents. But as soon as we turned around and opened the iron can, the snake was no longer there. Logically, there was no way it could have escaped. No wonder! It turns out it has spiritual powers.")

I've known this snake for a long time. More than 20 years ago, at Cixing Monastery on Lantau Island in Hong Kong, it often came to the monastery to listen to the sutras. Although it never troubled or harmed anyone, living beings were all afraid of its snake form. Once, someone also put it in an iron can and carried it several miles away to the mountain forest, intending to release it there, but when they opened the can and looked, the snake had vanished into thin air! And now that the Buddhadharma has come to the West, it too has not shrunk from crossing the oceans to come to America to protect the Dharma.

Living beings who study Buddhism must deeply believe in cause and effect. Do not plant evil causes, or you will reap evil fruits; if you plant good causes, you will certainly reap good fruits. Cause and effect do not err by a hair's breadth: "If you kill another man's father, others will kill your father; if you kill another man's elder brother, others will kill your elder brother." Do not be so unscrupulous as to kill people just to gain some advantage. If you harm others, in the end it is yourself you harm. Heaven has the virtue of cherishing life; Heaven does not want anyone to do things that trouble and harm living beings. So do not get cause and effect wrong. As the sayings go, "One slip of the foot brings a thousand ages of regret," and "Once the human body is lost, it is not regained in ten thousand eons." You can disbelieve anything else, but you

cannot disbelieve in cause and effect. To deny cause and effect is extremely dangerous.

"Bodhisattvas fear causes, not effects." On the causal ground they are very careful to plant good causes, and as for the evil causes they planted without knowing it, they calmly accept the evil fruits. They face reality and accept their retribution, never blaming heaven or other people. On the other hand, "Living beings fear effects, not causes." When planting causes they are careless and muddled, acting recklessly and wildly. When it comes time to undergo the retribution, they are afraid, and they blame heaven and other people, saying, "Why do I have to suffer this torment? Why do I have to undergo such an unfair retribution?" But they never stop to think: if they had not created such causes in the past, how could they be undergoing such retribution?

Today we have met with this causal condition: one of the gods, dragons, and the rest of the eightfold division has appeared in person to speak the Dharma, so I am taking this opportunity to say a little about its causes and effects. "Just one wrong move, and the whole game of chess is lost." With one mistaken thought, it is not easy to turn back a calamitous fate. Fortunately it has been able to take refuge with the Triple Jewel, and in the future it will still have the chance to understand the mind and see the nature.

If any of you don't believe this account of causes and conditions, you're welcome to go try it for yourselves. If you believe in cause and effect, you should not harbor the slightest doubt.

52. Guo Man Takes Refuge

In 1956, Upasika Yu Guo Man broke a bone in her hand. The bonesetter wrote a prescription that used dragon bone [Tr.: fossilized animal bone used in Chinese medicine] as medicine. Guo Man said, "I can't use this medicine. I'm a vegetarian!" The lay Buddhist Yao Guo Bai, who was standing nearby, heard this and asked, "Who is your teacher?"...

"I haven't taken refuge yet, but at Guanyin Cave on Fu Yung Shan I once met a Dharma Master who had real cultivation, and now I have no way to find him," Yu Guo Man replied. "Who is he?" "He burned a string of recitation beads and a swastika onto his body with incense." "Ah! He's my teacher!"

When Yu Guo Man heard this she was overjoyed. Although she was stout, she wasn't daunted by the more than 300 stone steps, and she hurried to Western Bliss Gardens to pay her respects to the Venerable Master and ask to take refuge.

In the Venerable Master's own words:

After I left Guanyin Cave on Fu Yung Shan, Yu Guo Man looked for me everywhere, asking everyone she met. Some people knew but wouldn't tell her. Why? They were jealous of her, so they wouldn't tell her my address. Yu Guo Man searched for two years before she found me. She was very happy and said,

"I've been looking everywhere for you, Dharma Master. I searched for two years and couldn't find you, and now I've finally found you!" After that she went to Western Bliss Gardens, and after going a few times, she took refuge together with her son and her daughter-in-law, Xue Peilan.

This person had a special strength. What strength? She didn't spend money on herself. Her sons, daughters, and grandchildren often gave her money, and she used all of it to do works of merit and virtue. So when I was in Hong Kong, she was the most generous-hearted of my disciples and did a great many works of merit and virtue every year. She didn't put up money of her own either; she would see which of her grandsons and granddaughters had money and then seek donations from them, having them do works of merit and virtue. That was her clever method.

53. The Insects in the Tree Move Away

At Western Bliss Gardens there was a tree covered with insects, too many to count, and the insects crawled all over the place. Yu Guo Man said she would never dare come again, because as soon as she saw insects, she couldn't even walk anymore...

In the Venerable Master's own words:

After Yu Guo Man took refuge, around the nineteenth day of the sixth month she went to Western Bliss Gardens to see me. She saw that there was a peach tree at Western Bliss Gardens with no telling how many insects on it; on every leaf there were three or four crawling about. It frightened her so...

Ever since she was born she had been afraid of monks, and also afraid of crawling insects. As soon as she saw insects, her hands and feet went limp; she couldn't take a step and couldn't walk.

She liked to recite the Buddha's name. I said, "Now that you've found me, you can come often to bow to the Buddhas!" She said, "Shifu, I'd like to come here to bow to the Buddhas, but I'm terribly afraid of insects. On this peach tree of yours there are three or four insects on a single leaf, and the whole tree has thousands upon thousands of insects on it. I'm scared to death! That's the one thing I'm afraid of. With so many insects here, how can I dare to come?"

Then and there I said to her, "Don't be afraid! Tomorrow they'll be gone." The next day she came here full of faith, and sure enough, there wasn't a single insect left. It was a very big tree, as tall as two people, with thousands upon thousands of insects on it, and in a single day they had all moved away. They were gone, and no one knew where they had moved to. From then on she had even more faith.

And don't go saying, "Oh! I know. Shifu must have sprayed some insecticide and killed them all." Ha ha! I would have liked to use insecticide, but I had no money to buy any, so I just blew a few breaths at them, "Whoo, whoo, whoo!" and they all ran off! Who knows where they moved to.

If I didn't tell you, none of you would know. You see so many insects, but in fact they aren't insects at all. These insects are dragon disciples who have taken refuge with me. They came to the monastery to bow to the Buddhas. Otherwise, how could it be that when I said one sentence, "Come tomorrow and they'll be gone!" they were gone? These insects were also manifestations of the gods, dragons, and the rest of the eightfold division, displaying a bit of their spiritual efficacy. From this you can see that the gods, dragons, and the rest of the eightfold division are manifesting their bodies all the time, but when people see them they don't know it; if no one points it out, they don't recognize them. Today I'm explaining it clearly for you; if I didn't tell you, you wouldn't understand a thing.

Once, a fellow countryman from Manchuria came to see me. He was also one of my former refuge disciples, and we were very happy to meet again in a strange land. As he was leaving, I told him to come to the Way-place often from then on. He said, "I'm not going to come anymore. Look at all those big grubs on the leaves of the peach tree at the monastery gate. How frightening!" I said to him, "Dragons and snakes all mixed together! If you're afraid of them, I'll tell them to leave. I guarantee that when you come tomorrow, you won't see a single one." Sure enough, when he came the next day to attend the Dharma assembly, there really wasn't a single one left. They were just manifesting a form for you to see, that's all.

54. A Weasel Takes Refuge

Before long, whenever Yu Guo Man heard the drumbeats of a repentance ceremony, her head would ache. No matter who was beating the drum, not only did her head ache as though it would split, but fear arose in her mind; above all, she was most afraid of seeing strangers. Even the doctors were helpless before her strange illness...

In the Venerable Master's own words:

This illness of hers was very strange. It was simply fear. Fear of what? She was afraid of people and afraid of strangers. No matter where she was, she would always run off and sit in a corner where no one could see her. She was terribly afraid of people, and she also had a big temper and was always flying into a rage. She was also afraid of sounds, and above all she was afraid of me, so terribly afraid of me that she didn't even dare look at me. She went to doctors for this illness, but after one or two months of treatment she still wasn't better. One day she said to me, "Shifu! I used to have great faith in you, but now, I don't know why, I'm so terribly afraid of you. Neither Chinese doctors nor Western doctors can cure this illness of mine. What's going on?"

Now I'll tell you: the reason she was afraid of everything was that a weasel was making mischief. That weasel wanted to take refuge with the Triple Jewel. When she first told me about it, I saw that the conditions hadn't arrived yet. She was supposed to be ill for 100 days, and at that point she had only been ill for 30-

some days. I said, "Wait a while longer. After some time passes, you'll gradually get better! For example, if you're supposed to get better after 100 days, then when you reach 80 days I can make you better. Being 20 days short is all right, but now you're still half the time short, so it can't be done!"

On the afternoon of the fourteenth day of the second month (lunar calendar), I saw her and said, "Guo Man, today your illness should get better! Go kneel before the Buddha and bow, and don't stop bowing until I tell you to stop." So she bowed and bowed and bowed and bowed... for about half an hour. After this weasel had taken refuge with me, I said, "Now your illness is cured; you're all right!" With just that one sentence she immediately stopped being afraid, and her illness was completely gone. That's why it's said, "Dharma or no Dharma, it all comes down to one sentence before the altar." It was just that one sentence: I said she was well, and she was well; she had no more illness. From then on she believed in me deeply without doubt and had complete faith.

[Addendum 1] Yu Guo Man, whose name was Yu Shaochen, was born in 1906 into a Buddhist family in Shanghai, China. Her father was a vegetarian for many years, but Guo Man did not become a vegetarian until she was 41. Because the family tradition was honest, kind, and good, Guo Man was always glad to help others, and she taught her children that they must never gain without labor. During the hard years of the war, when a food rationing system was adopted, supplies were limited, yet Guo Man still shared her food with unfortunate people. Guo Man met the Venerable Master on Fu Yung Shan when he had just arrived in Hong Kong, and from time to time she offered him new clothes and food. After taking refuge, she often went to Western Bliss Gardens Monastery to take part in group cultivation and to listen to the Buddhadharma.

Guo Man's whole family believed deeply in the Buddhadharma and encountered many inconceivable things; they were the Venerable Master's loyal disciples. In the sixth year after taking refuge with the Venerable Master, Guo Man fasted on the first and fifteenth days of every lunar month, drinking only water. Once, on a fasting day, she planned to go to Western Bliss Gardens, but her son Guo Xing tried to dissuade her, worried that, as old as she was and having eaten nothing, she could not walk such a long mountain path. Heeding her son's words, Guo Man changed her mind and turned back home. Guo Man's home was on the sixth floor, and since there was no elevator, she had to climb the stairs. That day, just as she walked into the apartment building, she found herself already on the sixth floor without having climbed a single stair. She thought this very extraordinary and hurried back downstairs to go to Western Bliss Gardens.

Once, her daughter-in-law contracted severe tuberculosis for the third time, and there was almost no medicine that could cure it. Although her son and daughter-in-law were Catholics, they still asked their mother to seek the Venerable Master's help. The Venerable Master said, "Although the tree is sick, it will still blossom again." Before long, Guo Man's daughter-in-law did indeed recover, and afterward she gave birth to three more children. Because of this, they too came to believe in Buddhism.

[Addendum 2] From the diary of Upasika Tan Guo Zheng:

The Master never wanted people to talk during meals, so at the noon meal he often spoke the Dharma for the assembly; sometimes Wen Guo Mi or Huang Guo Jun would speak in his place, expressing the Master's intent. Once, after listening to the Master speak the Dharma, Xue Guo Feng (Yu Guo Man's daughter-in-law) said to the Master, "I feel that every word and every phrase you say, Shifu, is the speech of a sage. It's a pity that among those present there may not be anyone who truly understands." The Master smiled and said, "Since you know what it means, aren't you the one who truly understands?"

55. Strange Happenings During Chan Sessions

After the Opening-the-Light at Cixing Monastery, a hundred or more people came every time a Guanyin session or a Buddha Recitation session was held. The sutra lectures in the evening went on until ten o'clock. Most of those who came to hear the sutras were lay Buddhists in their forties and fifties or older, and they had to walk a long way to reach the mountain...

Cixing Monastery held at least ten Chan sessions every year, and as many as twenty. Many Dharma Masters who had fled from the mainland also cultivated there. During the Chan sessions the Venerable Master was very strict: except to go to the toilet, no one could take a single step out of the Chan Hall.

In the Venerable Master's own words:

I had an old refuge disciple in Hong Kong whose way of applying effort was very special. How so? Other people investigated "Who is reciting the Buddha's name?" and she investigated too. What did she investigate? She investigated "Eighty-four years old, eighty-four years old." She said she wanted to live to 84.

[Addendum 1] Bhikshuni Dharma Master Heng Yi recounted on September 27, 2000:

There is an old disciple in his nineties who is still alive today. In this life he is wealthy. In his cultivation he was always preoccupied with building a big house to live in himself, and when he got sick he insisted on eating bird's nest. Because he was always ill, the Master wanted him to make a vow, but he refused to make one. Once, during a Chan session at Cixing Monastery, in the third incense period, everyone, men and women alike, heard the clanking of iron chains and also heard the ghost of impermanence calling his name (Liang Guixian), and then they heard him let out a great cry. In a former life, because someone would not pay back money they owed him, he killed that person. Only after the Master had him repent and vow to protect and support the Way-place was he all right.

[Addendum 2] Upasika Tan Guo Shi recounted:

All the Buddha Recitation sessions, celebrations, and chanting gatherings were held at the Buddhist Lecture Hall; before there was a Buddhist Lecture Hall, they were held at Western Bliss Gardens. We never held Chan sessions at

Western Bliss Gardens or at the Buddhist Lecture Hall; the Chan sessions were all held at Cixing Monastery. The Master often invited Chan masters who were quite famous at the time; the only one I remember is Dharma Master Ming Guan, who presided over several Chan sessions there. During Chan practice, talking was not allowed, and you couldn't sway from side to side when you walked. If you dozed off while sitting in meditation, the Dharma Master would hit you with the incense board. If you go to Cixing Monastery now, you can still see many incense boards; these wooden boards were all used in the Chan sessions back then.

The Chan sessions went from early morning until night. The Master gave instructional talks twice a day, once in the afternoon and once in the evening, and sometimes he would have a disciple go up and speak for a while. The Master told us that when sitting in meditation we shouldn't close our eyes completely; the eyes should be fixed on the tip of the nose, "the eyes contemplating the nose, the nose contemplating the mind," and that way we wouldn't doze off. The Master also said that our thoughts should be concentrated on one thing, investigating a meditation topic (huatou), such as investigating "Who is reciting the Buddha's name?"

Because many of the disciples in Hong Kong were elderly people, housewives, and people without education, the Master said, "If some people can't use the Chan method, it's also fine for them to silently recite the name of Amitabha Buddha." The first time I met the Master, he taught me how to sit in full lotus. For the older disciples, never mind full lotus, even half lotus was hard, but for us children it was no problem.

By the year-end Chan session my winter vacation had already begun, so I was able to take part. Every day we got up at three-thirty and did the morning recitation at four. After the morning recitation we had breakfast, rice porridge and pickled vegetables, and then we began sitting in meditation. During a Chan session no dinner is eaten, but the Master still compassionately had dinner prepared for the lay disciples.

I remember that once, during a Buddha Recitation session, we were reciting "Namo Amitabha Buddha" continuously. There was a Mrs. Luo from a very well-off family who couldn't read but was very diligent; whenever there was a Dharma assembly, she would come. At that Buddha Recitation session I was the cantor and Guo Song struck the wooden fish. While we were circumambulating and reciting, Guo Song suddenly smiled and asked me, "Did you hear any unusual sound?" I said, "What?" She said, "Listen!" I followed the sound of the assembly to track it down, and I couldn't help laughing too. Everyone else was reciting the Buddha's name, but Mrs. Luo was reciting, "Eighty-four years old, eighty-four years old, eighty-four years old, eighty-four years old..." After the Dharma assembly, I told the Master that Mrs. Luo kept reciting "eighty-four years old" and asked whether that meant she could only live to 84. The Master laughed too.

[Addendum 3] From the diary of Upasika Tan Guo Zheng:

Today (December 25, 1961), at around three o'clock, Mother and I went to the Lecture Hall. The Master again told us the story about reciting "Om mani padme hum." The story goes like this: There was a man who didn't recognize the character "hum," so he read the "hum" in "Om mani padme hum" as "niu" [Tr.: niu means "cow"]. Because he was very diligent, on the dry, barren hilltop where he lived, many brilliant flowers and plants actually bloomed. One day an old cultivator passed by this hilltop and found the sight strange. After asking about it in detail, he taught the man to correct his pronunciation. But from then on, no matter how hard the man worked, it no longer had any efficacy, and the beautiful flowers and plants disappeared.

The Master told us how important a single thought of utmost sincerity is. Because the man later began to have doubts, suspecting that he had been reciting the mantra wrong, idle thoughts and scattered thoughts flew about in profusion, and so it no longer worked. The Master told this story because Huang Guo Song had mentioned how Mrs. Luo turned "Who is reciting the Buddha's name?" into "eighty-four years old."

56. I've Been Waiting for You a Long Time

With his wisdom eye, the Venerable Master observed the causes and conditions of living beings and compassionately guided lost wanderers to awaken early and return home to the Buddha, their compassionate father. Once the opportunity and conditions had ripened, the Venerable Master would use skillful means to receive them...

Tan Xiuzhen (Tan Guo Qi)

Spoken at the Hong Kong Buddhist Lecture Hall on January 12, 2001:

At that time I was in my twenties (I'm 71 now) and lived on the same floor as Guo Chen. I saw that she had a photo of the Master with the words "A Living Buddha in the Human World" written on it, so I asked her why it said "A Living Buddha in the Human World" about this Dharma Master. Guo Chen said, "It's very efficacious! I'll take you to bow to the Buddhas!" And she took me to bow to the Buddhas. At that time my children were still little, and Western Bliss Gardens was high up, so it was very inconvenient to take the children up there; so I always went to bow to the Buddhas on the first and fifteenth days of the lunar month. The Master was the only monastic there. The Master lectured on the sutras in the evening, and the Dharma assemblies were all led by lay Buddhists; there were Guanyin sessions, Amitabha sessions, and other Dharma assemblies.

In 1954, something suddenly grew on my son's body. I took him to the hospital to see the doctor and had X-rays taken, but they couldn't find the cause. Guo Chen said, "Why don't you go and ask the Master for help!" So I went to the Master and knelt to beg him for help.

The Master said, "Why are you kneeling here?"

"Sharp spines have grown on my son's body. Every time I bathe him, they prick my hands," I said.

"I don't know how to heal people."

"You do. Guo Chen's whole family has said that you know how to heal people."

"Do you have great faith in me?"

"I have great faith in you!"

"Very well, then! Then take refuge!"

"We don't have any money. How can we take refuge?" I said.

"Does taking refuge cost money?"

"How can you take refuge without money?"

"It doesn't cost any money." "But I'm young, and I don't understand anything."

"You don't need to understand. As long as you know to come back and bow to the Buddhas, that's enough."

After I took refuge, my Dharma name was "Guo Qi." The Master then had me carry my son over to him, and the Master blessed him. In less than a week, the spines on my son's body were completely gone.

57. Taking Refuge Equally

Guo Li took refuge with the Venerable Master because she had read the Venerable Master's *Records* and also wanted to ask the Venerable Master for help in curing her sick husband. And to seek blessings and wisdom for her children, she brought her own two children to take refuge with the Venerable Master, but her husband's several children by his former wife did not get the chance to draw near to the Venerable Master...

Upasika Guo Li

Spoken at the Hong Kong Buddhist Lecture Hall on January 12, 2001:

I took refuge with the Master when I was in my twenties; now I'm 75. I took refuge at Western Bliss Gardens. My causes and conditions for taking refuge came through a worker I had hired, who had taken refuge with the Master and showed me the Master's *Records*. At that time my husband was ill, and because the *Records* contained true accounts of real people the Master had saved, I too wanted to take refuge and ask the Master for help. I set out from Prince Edward Road, asking the way as I walked, and walked a very long way before I reached Western Bliss Gardens.

When I saw the Master, I said I wanted to take refuge together with my husband. The Master said, "That will have to wait until your husband wants to take refuge!" When I heard that, I wanted to leave right then and there. A lay Buddhist who was helping cook in the kitchen said to me, "Take refuge yourself

first, and later bring your husband to take refuge." So that day I took refuge. I loved wearing pretty clothes, so my Dharma name was "Guo Li" [Tr.: li means "beautiful"]. After I took refuge, whenever the Master spoke to me I always listened on my knees, but I couldn't understand what the Master said. Also, because I lived very far away and the road was out of the way, I gradually came to Western Bliss Gardens less and less.

Once when I went to Western Bliss Gardens, the Master said, "Why don't you have a Dharma ceremony done!" So I had a Dharma ceremony done for my husband. Later, when Cixing Monastery was built, the Master told me, "That time you gave 200 dollars, so now you have a longevity plaque at Cixing Monastery."

In 1956 my husband passed away. At that time I was too young, and I had a very complicated extended family, so I seldom went to Western Bliss Gardens. Only after the matters of the estate had been settled, wanting to seek blessings and wisdom for my children, did I return to the Buddhist Lecture Hall, where I helped out with the work and took part in Dharma assemblies reciting the *Earth Store Sutra*.

Both of my children took refuge with the Master. Because I was the second wife, I didn't take the five sons and two daughters my husband had had before to take refuge with the Master. The Master once said to me, "You should have all the children come and take refuge together. It isn't right that only the ones you gave birth to take refuge. You have no mind of your own; you just listen to what other people say..." Whenever I think of the Master's words, I feel very uneasy and feel that I was rather selfish, so I often bow to the Buddhas and repent of this matter.

58. The Departed Break into Smiles

After the Ullambana Dharma assembly, at the request of the faithful in general, the Venerable Master spared no effort to open a Dharma assembly for rescuing the departed. Monastic and lay disciples received the precepts for the deceased on behalf of relatives and friends who had passed away, planting in them the seeds of the vajra precepts. This was an act of great filial piety and great compassion...

The fifteenth day of the seventh lunar month of 1954 (the jiawu year) was the Buddha's Day of Joy. At Cixing Chan Monastery on Lantau Island, the Venerable Master held an Ullambana Dharma assembly lasting three days (the thirteenth, fourteenth, and fifteenth of the seventh month), and quite a large number of monastics and faithful devotees took part. Those who attended the Dharma assembly wanted nothing other than to use its merit and virtue to benefit their relatives, hoping that the karmic obstacles of the living would be eliminated and their good roots would grow, and that the departed would be reborn in good places. At that time Bhikshu Dharma Master Heng Yue and the Upasikas Guo Gen, Guo Quan, and others, more than 30 people in all, made a request to the

Venerable Master, hoping he would transmit the precepts for the deceased on the concluding day of the Dharma assembly. Some of these people were seeking the precepts for the deceased on behalf of their parents, some for their siblings or spouses, and some for clan relatives and family members, hoping to free them from the sufferings of the hells and of the hungry ghosts.

The Venerable Master granted their request, and at nine-thirty on the night of the fifteenth, an altar was set up in the guest hall downstairs to transmit the precepts for the deceased. At around ten o'clock, when the invitation of the sages had been completed, at the very instant the Venerable Master returned to his seat, suddenly a great hubbub of voices arose all around within the boundary of the ritual area. Dharma Master Heng Yue, who was kneeling before the altar holding his father's memorial tablet in his hands, at that very moment discovered that his father had suddenly appeared in front of him.

At that time, Tan Guo Zheng and Wen Guo Shu had gone back to their room early to rest, because they had to go down the mountain at four o'clock the next morning to return to Hong Kong. They had only just lain down when suddenly they heard a commotion of voices in the corridor outside the door and a confused trampling of footsteps, as though many people were passing back and forth. When they opened the door to look, there was no one there at all; when they closed the door, the sound of scrambling footsteps came again, making their hair stand on end.

Dharma Master Heng Ding was cultivating in quiet on his own in a small thatched hut several hundred meters from the Buddha hall. This thatched hut had been built beside the path, and anyone who wanted to take the shortcut down the mountain had to pass in front of its door. That night, at around ten-thirty, he heard from inside the hut the footsteps of many people going down the mountain. These people talked as they walked, and every now and then someone would burst out laughing; it was a great uproar. The next morning, when Dharma Master Heng Ding and the two laywomen each told of what they had experienced the night before, everyone exclaimed in wonder with one voice.

[Addendum 1] Bhikshuni Dharma Master Heng Yi recounted on September 26, 2000:

Cixing Monastery always had a lot of ghosts. Once the Master told me to write a memorial tablet. I said, "No one in my family has died. What memorial tablet would I write?" That was because during that period I kept falling down, even when going up the stairs. The Master said, "There's a big, tall ghost following behind you." But I still didn't know who this ghost was. After the Buddha Recitation session had been going for three days, the Master blessed me, and only then did I learn that a clansman of mine had died of a high fever not long after coming to Hong Kong. The Master said, "There are a lot of ghosts at Cixing Monastery, but when they see you, every one of them is frightened away."

[Addendum 2] Bhikshu Dharma Master Heng Xing's supplementary account, given on September 26, 2000:

Once, when Cixing Monastery was holding a Buddha Recitation session in which the precepts for the deceased were transmitted, during the last three days Dharma Master Heng Yi kept falling down for no reason at all, and no one knew why: she fell when walking, and she fell when going up the stairs. The Master told her to write a memorial tablet, but no matter how hard she tried, she couldn't think of any relative who had died recently. At that time she was still a laywoman. Later the Master had her come into the Buddha Hall and blessed her, and only then did she learn that her clansman had died of a fever. She immediately wrote a memorial tablet to rescue this clansman of hers to rebirth. The Master once said that the ghosts were all afraid when they saw Dharma Master Heng Yi. Cixing Monastery always had a lot of ghosts; other people could see them, and only she couldn't.

[Addendum 3] Upasika Tan Guo Shi recounted:

There were many beings in that area, and they all placed their hopes on Cixing Monastery to bring them liberation. My elder sister Guo Zheng and the sister and brother Wen Guo Shu and Guo Mi all saw them, and they also heard voices saying, "Go to Cixing Monastery and we can be rescued!" On the second night of the Ullambana Dharma assembly, Dharma Master Xu Lang performed the Flaming Mouth ceremony. Dharma Master Xu Lang performed the Flaming Mouth ceremony very well, so the Master had invited him to perform this ceremony. That night my younger brother, my cousin, and I, the three of us, stood behind the Dharma Master fanning him; because there was no electricity there, we used fans to stir up a breeze and drive off the heat.

That night my elder sister and Guo Shu were in a room on the second floor of the villa when they suddenly heard some voices. My sister said to Guo Shu, "What are you saying to me?" Guo Shu said, "I thought you were talking to me!" "Did you hear something too?" "Yes, I heard it!" They had both heard "people" talking, saying, "Hurry, hurry, we have to hurry and go seek rescue!" Only then did it suddenly dawn on them that it wasn't "people" talking. The two of them were so frightened that they went pale and ran downstairs as fast as they could. Later my sister told me, "We also heard someone talking, saying, 'Come, come, come, hurry and come!'" It wasn't only them: Dharma Masters Heng Ding and Heng Yue, who lived in thatched huts by the roadside next to the monastery, heard it too.

59. Reflections on Propagating the Teaching

Although Western Bliss Gardens had been built, there were few educated people who believed in Buddhism at that time, and most people regarded Buddhism as superstition. At that time it rained heavily day after day; the roof of Western Bliss Gardens cracked, rainwater leaked in, and the Buddha Hall became a watery marsh...

The Venerable Master lamented the listless and dispirited state of Hong Kong's Buddhists. Eager to propagate the teaching, he composed a verse to make his resolve clear:

> *Five autumns I have passed in vain since coming to Hong Kong;*
> *Others call it cause for joy, but I call it cause for worry.*
> *A single patched robe, the same as it has always been;*
> *Sitting in lotus in a humble room, I carry on with new sorrows.*
> 來港空度已五秋，人道可喜我道憂。衲衣一襲仍舊貫，陋室趺坐續新愁。
>
> *The censer in the Buddha Hall is drenched by the rain;*
> *In the guest hall, you could sail a boat up to the meditation bed.*
> *Among the faithful devotees and disciples, who pays any heed?*
> *The Dharma protectors leave the Triple Jewel to stay or go as it may.*
> 佛殿香爐遭雨淋，客堂禅榻可行舟。善信弟子誰關注，護法三寶任去留。

In the Venerable Master's own words:

Let me tell you, at Western Bliss Gardens Monastery in Hong Kong, a single bed had six places where the rain leaked through. Now tell me, wasn't that hard? But hard as it was, I didn't repair it. I didn't care whether my own house leaked or not; if I had money, I wanted to use it to help others. Tell me, is that foolish or not?

There was a monastery that was making Buddha images, and I donated more than HK$1,500. It would have taken only 200 dollars to repair the house, but I couldn't bear to spend that money. Spending more than 1,500 dollars to help others make Buddha images was no problem. When I was in Hong Kong, all told, I had more than 100 Buddha images made and gave them away. For example, the Three Sages of the West at the Chinese Buddhist Association of Hawaii were a gift from me.

There was a monastic who often came to Western Bliss Gardens to bring me gifts, biscuits, milk, and powdered milk. There was a reason for this. Earlier, when he was building his Buddha hall, I had donated several thousand dollars. After the Buddha hall was washed away by floodwaters, he made Buddha images, and I also gave him an image of Amitabha Buddha. It was the seventh day of the first lunar month when the elder Dharma Master from that place came to Western Bliss Gardens and said to me, "I've been waiting for you to come and pay a New Year's call on Amitabha Buddha. I waited until today and you still hadn't come, so I came over to see you."

"Where is Amitabha Buddha?" I asked him.

"It's the Amitabha Buddha you gave to our Buddha hall."

"That Amitabha Buddha was made by me. Since I made him, why should I go and bow to him? I have an Amitabha Buddha here too, and Amitabha Buddha and Amitabha Buddha are not separate. Why are you telling me to forsake what is near and seek what is far?" My question left him with nothing to say.

Next he tried to win me over with sentiment, saying, "I think of you every day. Do you think of me?"

"Me? I don't know how to think of anyone, and I don't know how to miss anyone either," I said.

"The Dharma you speak is higher than mine!" he said, looking at me.

"Why don't I think of anyone or miss anyone? Because I have no knowing and no awareness."

"The Dharma you speak gets higher with every step!" He said that the more I spoke, the higher it got, higher with every step.

"The *Vajra Sutra* says, 'This Dharma is level and equal, with no high or low.' Elder Dharma Master, why did you come out with the word 'high' today? Explain!"

In the end he couldn't say a single word. He turned to the Dharma Master who had come with him and said, "He's really formidable!" The Dharma Master who had come with him was someone who studied the precepts and Vinaya, but in fact he didn't understand any of the precepts and didn't keep any of them either.

He brought me biscuits, milk, and powdered milk because he knew I was a very stupid, very foolish person; he gave me gifts hoping I would help him out again. I probably don't know how to do arithmetic. I can't tell other people's affairs apart from my own, and I often handle other people's affairs as if they were my own. That's why this poor man kept on living in a house that leaked.

[Addendum 1] Reproduced from *Mind Dharma* magazine, Issue 3, news item "Our Society's President, the Venerable Master To Lun, Generously Donates Images of the Three Sages of the West to the Honolulu Buddhist Association":

Our society's president, the Venerable Master To Lun, seeking to help the Buddhadharma flourish and spread in America, has recently and generously donated three large images of the Three Sages of the West to the Honolulu Buddhist Association in the United States. However, because the U.S. government is enforcing an embargo policy, it is rather difficult to arrange their import, and the Honolulu Buddhist Association is currently having someone here in Hong Kong handle the procedures for shipping them to the United States.

[Addendum 2] Reproduced from *The Origins and History of the Founding of Tung Lin Buddha Recitation Hall*, by Dharma Master Shi Kuan Yun:

On the fifth day of the eighth month of 1952, the "Tung Lin Pure Abode" was nearly half destroyed when a mountain flash flood broke out. After the disaster... Dharma Master To Lun, Dharma Master Xu Lang, Upasaka Zhao Ren'an, and others sponsored images of the Three Sages of the West, and their Opening-the-Light ceremony was scheduled for Amitabha's birthday in the eleventh lunar month. On the seventeenth day of the first lunar month of the following year, the Pure Abode was renamed "Tung Lin Buddha Recitation Hall."

61. It Really Happened

Some people came down with strange illnesses for no reason at all. Neither Chinese nor Western medicine could cure them, and secret remedies and folk prescriptions had no effect either. At their wits' end, one after another they sought the Venerable Master's help to resolve their troubles...

Upasika Tan Guo Shi recounted:

I've heard people ask the Master to hit them: "Hit me, hit me, and I'll get better!" When the Master was in Manchuria and in Hong Kong, he cured a great many strange illnesses. The Master had vowed that whenever he came across illnesses caused by ghosts and goblins, he was willing to resolve them for these people, and because of this he drew all sorts of ghosts that wanted to contest their powers against the Master. I really liked talking with the Master, because I loved hearing these stories. I completely believe that the stories the Master told about dragons and about ghosts really happened. In fact, several times when the Master encountered ghosts and goblins, I happened to be there.

That day I went to Western Bliss Gardens Monastery. The Master was sitting solemnly in full lotus, and Guo Song was also in full lotus. With a very serious expression she told me, "Sit down and recite this section of the Shurangama Mantra!" I said, "What's happening?" "The Master told us to recite this section of the mantra to help him subdue a demon!" That was the first time I saw the Master encounter a ghost or goblin at Western Bliss Gardens. Later the Master subdued that goblin, but I don't know what the goblin looked like. After a while the Master rose from his seat and said, "All right!" He told us that a very fierce and vicious goblin had made a sneak attack on him, trying to wreck his cultivation.

In the Venerable Master's own words:

When ordinary people get sick, it is always caused either by karma or by demons. If someone's karmic obstacles have caught up with him and you make his illness go away, that's still not much of a problem. But if his is an illness of demonic obstacles and you want to cure it, the demon on him will come after you and fight with you. If your power in the Way isn't sufficient, that is, if you don't have much power in the Way, you'll enter the state of the demon king. If you do have power in the Way, you'll still form enmity with the demon. It will always be looking for a chance to fight with you and make you lose to it.

When I was in my twenties and treated people's illnesses, whatever illness someone had, I was determined to make them well. If they didn't get well, I would even go without dressing, eating, or sleeping until I had cured their illness. No matter what kind of demon, ghost, or goblin it was, I would subdue it and bring it under control. The fierce demonic obstacles I ran into were too many to count. In one person's house, teacups would fly up by themselves and float about in the air like this, and the water in the cups wouldn't spill; or a book, like this one here, would burst into flames all by itself for no reason. I've encountered all these kinds of things; they really were that fierce. Whether you

believe it or not is your business! Because I was always treating people's illnesses, I offended a great many mountain goblins and water monsters, deviant demons and externalists. They all came to oppose me, but there was nothing they could do to me, because in my every move there was not the slightest fault.

62. Hungry Ghosts Hidden in the Belly

As the saying goes, "When you want to learn to be good, your karmic foes come looking for you; if you want to become a Buddha, you must first undergo demons." The elderly Upasika Liu Guo Juan came down with a strange illness: she had to eat more than ten meals a day. If she didn't eat, she got terribly hungry. Why was she so terribly hungry?...

In the Venerable Master's own words:

Here I want to tell you all a story. Perhaps many people won't believe it, but this story is absolutely true. In a former life Liu Guo Juan also encountered something that she refused to believe, so in this life she has had to repay the retribution for her doubt. Therefore Buddhists must pay attention to cause and effect, be careful and cautious in everything, and never slander others carelessly!

It wasn't just that Liu Guo Juan's deafness was cured; she also had a peculiar, strange illness. What strange illness? When I tell you about this illness, nobody believes it, because it's just too strange. How was it strange? One night, as though dreaming and yet not dreaming, she dreamed that three chubby little children, two or three years old, burrowed into her belly. From then on she had to eat more than ten meals a day; every hour she had to eat a big meal, and she always felt she couldn't get full. But if she didn't eat, her belly wouldn't stand for it, and she felt terribly hungry. Why was she so terribly hungry? Let me tell you: with this illness of hers, although she was one person, there were three hungry ghosts in her belly, and everything she ate was eaten by those hungry ghosts. She found this illness of hers very strange, so she went to see doctors. The Western doctors examined her and said she wasn't ill; the Chinese doctors didn't know what illness it was either. None of them could detect anything, and they all said she wasn't ill. The doctors still gave her medicine, but no matter what medicine she took, she didn't get better.

Two or three years went by like this. By then she could already hear, and whenever there was a sutra lecture she still went to listen. When I lectured on a sutra for two hours, she would listen for half of it and then have to run to the kitchen and soak some biscuits in boiling water to eat; that's how it was. I knew she had this illness, but I didn't want to meddle in this business. Whenever I wasn't at Western Bliss Gardens Monastery, Guo Ping, being afraid to stay there alone, would ask Liu Guo Juan for company, and the two of them would look after Western Bliss Gardens.

On the seventh day of the second month I came down from Lantau Island, and at around ten-thirty in the morning Liu Guo Juan said to me, "Shifu, someone is

talking inside my belly." I said, "How can someone be talking in your belly? Are you going to have a baby? You're already in your sixties; can you still have a baby? What does it say?" She said she heard it loud and clear: there really was something in her belly that could talk.

She said, "When I got up early this morning, I had just made some glutinous rice cakes and was about to eat them when my belly spoke. It said, 'I don't like eating this!' So I said to my belly, 'If you don't eat this, what will you eat? As long as you get full, that's good enough!' Then my belly stopped talking."

I told her, "All right, never mind! The child in your belly can already talk, so it ought to be ready to be born. Tonight I'll make this illness of yours better. When you get home tonight, remember: at twelve o'clock midnight, light a stick of incense before the Buddha and keep reciting the Buddha's name, and then see what happens."

That night, following my words, she lit a stick of incense before the Buddha at twelve midnight. She recited the Buddha's name until she was in a state as though asleep and yet as though dreaming, when suddenly she saw Weituo Bodhisattva coming, holding a steaming bowl of fragrant noodles, which he set down in front of her bed. Then three plump, fair little children, some four or five years old and some five or six years old, the very same three children she had seen before she fell ill, instantly burrowed out of her belly and scrambled to eat the noodles. As they were scrambling to eat, Weituo Bodhisattva grabbed them by the ears and hauled them away. Once they had been hauled away, she felt there was nothing left in her belly; it was completely empty. From then on Liu Guo Juan's belly felt as if a heavy burden had been lifted; she was never hungry again and never again needed to eat so many meals.

What were these three strange creatures in her belly? Let me tell you: two big geckos and one big frog. As for a case like hers, never mind foreigners not believing it; even Chinese people don't believe it.

But you should understand why she got such an illness. It's because in her former life she came across someone with the same illness, and later a Dharma Master cured that person. When people told her about it, she said, "I don't believe it!" Because she didn't believe it and said one wrong sentence, in this life she got this illness so she could try it out for herself and see whether she believed it or not. That's how formidable cause and effect are! Fortunately she was sincere in listening to the sutras, and so there was a response from the unseen realm that resolved this calamity.

[Addendum] Dharma Master Heng Gui, speaking at the Dharma Realm Buddhist Books Distribution Society in Taipei on March 10, 2013:

The Master told me this story himself back then. Some time after Upasika Liu Guo Juan was no longer deaf, because she was often hungry, every time she went to hear a sutra lecture she had to bring along some bread and biscuits, and every little while she would have to go out, take a couple of bites, and come back in; she went in and out like that. Later, after she had eaten something, a

voice in her belly told her, "Don't like eating this." (This was said in Cantonese; in Mandarin it would be: "I don't like eating this.") Not knowing what else to do, she reported it to the Master. Later she did as the Master told her, and only then was the problem solved.

When I heard this at the time, I asked, "Shifu, why did she get this illness?" The Master said that in her former life she had a friend who had this very illness, and later the friend was cured by a monastic. This friend told Guo Juan, "So-and-so, a monastic cured my illness for me." Right then Guo Juan got cause and effect wrong and said one wrong sentence! She said, "There's no such thing! You've been fooled!" It was just because of that one sentence that in this life she herself had to get a taste of this illness of hunger. So I asked:

"Shifu, who was that monastic?"

"Probably me!" the Master said with a smile.

63. Editing the *Records*

The lay disciples Tan Guo Zheng, Guo Jue, and others felt that the Venerable Master's *Records* had a profound and far-reaching influence, that readers were deeply moved by them, and that they helped the propagation of the Buddhadharma. So that more of the faithful could benefit, they joined forces to re-edit the Venerable Master's *Records*...

"Though freezing to death, stand facing the wind; though starving to death, walk with your belly thrust out. Be the sturdy grass in the gale, the true gold in the blazing fire." The white mountains and black waters of Heilongjiang forged the Venerable Master's tenacious and resolute character. The Venerable Master was born into turbulent times of social upheaval, the Japanese invasion of China, and the war between the Nationalists and the Communists, and he went through all kinds of suffering, including poverty, hunger, and the loss of his mother. When Manchuria was occupied by the Japanese army, the Venerable Master was in his youth. Although he could not fulfill his dream of joining the army to serve his country, he realized the true meaning of life in another way: awakening people from their deluded dreams, then pointing directly to the mind-ground, and even to seeing the nature and becoming a Buddha.

When the Venerable Master was in Hong Kong, he was only a little over 30, yet everything he did moved people to the depths of their hearts and earned the reverence of humans and gods. Whether in favorable or adverse circumstances, the Venerable Master was always consistently vigorous, setting an example of cultivation for his disciples. The Venerable Master's deeds, teaching by word and by example and transforming people through virtue, have a wondrous power to rescue those in peril and save the world.

In the fifth month of the yiwei year (1955), Upasaka Tan Guo Pu wrote in his article "Starting from How I Came to Study Buddhism":

One day I happened to obtain a book, *Records of Dharma Master To Lun*, respectfully written by his disciple Guo Jue: "It gives an outline of how the Master, in Songjiang Province in Manchuria, entered the Way in childhood, journeyed far into China, and then went on to Siam. Reading it, I was moved. At the same time I learned that in serving his parents, the Master fulfilled the worldly dharma to the utmost; in helping people, he manifests the conduct of a Bodhisattva. His vows are such that even empty space cannot contain them; his worthiness and wisdom stand revealed through the passing springs and autumns. Such resolve and such words are worthy to be a model for others; such conduct and such virtue can revive the style of the lineage. I am old, and moreover unlearned and unlettered, and I am ashamed that I have been unable to set down the Master's deeds in a book to benefit the ways of the world and the hearts of the people." Now, fortunately, several lay Buddhists have come to share this view and have joined forces to re-edit the Master's *Records*, removing errors and supplying omissions in the hope of making it complete, and adding printed photographs to inspire reverent admiration. Moreover, because Chinese writing is profound in diction and meaning and not easy for people of other lands to read, someone with the knowledge has translated it into English. Without dwelling on the merits of the wording, and at the risk of being laughed at by the learned, this is done simply so that the book may circulate widely. For this book has not been compiled to make anyone's name known; it is truly because we see that the Master's deeds have the power to proclaim the Buddhadharma, rescue those in peril, and save the world. May Buddhist disciples and faithful lay devotees, Chinese and Western alike, kindly give it their attention and read it.

[Addendum 1] From the diary of Upasika Tan Guo Zheng:

One day the Master gave me a biography of himself. It was printed in the style of early Chinese editions, long and narrow, with only 10 to 15 pages. After the Master gave me that biography, I tried adding what I had seen and heard in Hong Kong, to complete that booklet.

[Addendum 2] Upasika Tan Guo Shi recounted:

Much of the Master's first *Records* was compiled by my elder sister on the basis of the original biography, with what she had seen and heard in Hong Kong added in; some parts were also written with the help of the Master's disciple Upasaka Pei Guo Jian.

64. Founding *Mind Dharma*

In March 1956, the Venerable Master founded *Mind Dharma* magazine. Running a magazine could propagate the Dharma and benefit living beings, and it could also encourage the disciples to publish articles and turn their reflection back upon themselves. The Venerable Master encouraged his disciples to write down the principles they had heard in the form of articles, poems, or songs, so that more people could understand Buddhism...

The following is the prologue, "Written at the Outset," from the inaugural issue of *Mind Dharma* magazine:

Buddhism's teaching and transformation takes all living beings as its object, rescuing and saving them equally, without any prejudice or discrimination of high or low, great or small. This is where the greatness of the Buddha lies. But today, in an age when science is flourishing, Buddhism ought to be advancing shoulder to shoulder with science, so why is Buddhism still maliciously misunderstood? It is because we have failed to propagate it. The blame for this should be laid on the fact that we Buddhists have not truly shouldered our responsibility.

Fellow practitioners, let us all press forward bravely together! Let us win glory for our great Buddhism and stand up for the spirit of the Buddha, which is gradually being neglected by people. *Mind Dharma* was born with this mission, and its four great aims have already been set out at the front. Although its strength will not be very great, we will advance toward our goal.

We will certainly overcome all difficulties, never shrinking back, and wholeheartedly propagate the lofty and supremely good teachings of our Buddhism. We hope that fellow practitioners will support us with all their strength, continually favoring us with their writings and donating toward printing costs, so that, through the concrete actions of fellow practitioners everywhere who cherish *Mind Dharma*, we may, besides being grateful, gain a great deal more confidence and courage. In this Dharma-Ending Age, it is truly rare to see such a hopeful new sprout. This is not self-importance or arrogance on our part; we truly hope that *Mind Dharma* can grow strong. We believe that all Buddhists, and all who are unwilling to look on indifferently as Buddhism heads toward the fate of decline, will come together to help *Mind Dharma* flourish and spread, so as to bring forth the supreme, perfectly interfused, and wonderful teachings and spread them to every corner of the human world. We earnestly hope that fellow practitioners everywhere will not stint in giving us their guidance and will join together in supporting this undertaking. We would be most grateful and look forward to it with the utmost hope!

The following is an excerpt from the "Editor's Afterword" in the inaugural issue of *Mind Dharma*:

In Hong Kong, writings about Buddhism can be said to be extremely scarce. Yet under these circumstances this magazine has at last come into the world. Not only are we, the colleagues at this society, overjoyed beyond our expectations, but the greatly virtuous ones everywhere, monastic and lay, who have placed their hopes in this magazine will surely all rejoice as well...

The following is an excerpt from the "Editor's Afterword" in the second issue of *Mind Dharma*:

The year before last, this magazine's publisher, the Venerable Master To Lun, proposed founding a Buddhist periodical; at the time he said this to several of our present colleagues at the society. But we all felt that we had no foundation

at all in Buddhist studies and no experience in founding a periodical, so we didn't dare act rashly, and in the end the idea ran aground. In fact, we had overlooked the enthusiasm for propagating the Dharma among the greatly virtuous ones, monastic and lay, and the capable writers everywhere. Now the words the Venerable Master To Lun told us at the time have been proven true: "As long as it is wholeheartedly for the sake of propagating the Dharma, not only will people help, but even the Buddhas and Bodhisattvas will lend their aid!" Truly, not long after the inaugural issue of *Mind Dharma* went into circulation, we received one after another nearly ten manuscripts from Taiwan, Indonesia, and other places, and greatly virtuous ones, monastic and lay, who cherish this magazine wrote from Indonesia, Manila, Vietnam, Taichung, and elsewhere, offering to set up distribution centers on our behalf. Some praised this magazine to the skies; of course, there were also people who wrote to point out its shortcomings. As for praise, we will never become complacent; we will be all the more vigilant and strive all the harder, so as to live up to the kind hopes of those who wrote to us. As for advice, we accept it with complete sincerity and will strive to improve.

In this issue, English has been added to both the cover and the table of contents, because we hope to extend *Mind Dharma*'s distribution network to every corner of the world and let the light of the Buddha shine upon all living beings under heaven. We therefore earnestly hope that Buddhist organizations and individuals in all the countries of the world will get in touch with our society, exchange experiences, and work together to propagate the Buddhadharma...

Should Buddhism undergo some reform and renewal? This is a major matter, so we only have this idea and hold no subjective preconceptions. On this question, this magazine plans to solicit differing opinions from all quarters and publish them in successive issues. Without doubt, correct opinions will be accepted by Buddhists; conversely, we can also publish the others, so as to stir up responses and serve the purpose of "tossing out a brick to attract jade"...

In the Venerable Master's own words:

In Hong Kong I put out a magazine called *Mind Dharma*. It came out once a month, and three issues were published. All three issues were given out to establish affinities; we never collected a single cent from anyone, and they were all given to people to read for free. Later, because of financial constraints and personnel problems, it was not published anymore.

Everyone should learn to write articles, articles in Chinese and articles in English. The more you write, the better you'll write. You can take the principles you've heard and write them up freely as an article, or compose a song or a poem, to propagate Buddhism, and send it to all the newspapers and magazines; it doesn't matter which one publishes it. Letting more people in the world understand Buddhism and shaking them awake from their habit of sleeping brings limitless merit and virtue. All of you should understand what I mean.

Don't keep retreating. Buddhists should go forward with courageous vigor; don't always be retreating.

[Addendum 1] Upasika Tan Guo Shi recounted:

The Master's *Mind Dharma* was produced by my elder sister together with Upasaka Pei Guo Jian. Upasaka Pei was from Manchuria and was also the Master's disciple. The Master also had him teach us Japanese.

Mind Dharma published articles of ours: articles by Guo Song, Guo Jun, my elder sister, and me. I remember publishing an article that had a poem in the middle, which the Master corrected for me. The articles appeared under either our Dharma names or our precept names. When we received the five precepts, the Master gave us precept names, which began with the character "Zheng." My precept name was "Zheng He," my elder sister's was "Zheng Wu," and Guo Jun's was "Zheng Ren."

[Addendum 2] Copyright page of *Mind Dharma* (omitted)

64. Demonic States in the Pratyutpanna Practice

One day the Venerable Master suddenly heard his Dharma nephew from Manchuria, Dharma Master Heng Yue, reciting the holy name of Amitabha Buddha very loudly, his voice growing faster and faster, as though he were gasping for breath. The Venerable Master understood what was happening, so he immediately headed for the little hut...

Hong Kong was densely populated, and everywhere there were places of luxury and dissipation. Many young monastics who did not yet have enough samadhi power, after coming to prosperous Hong Kong, began to grow lax without realizing it, and some even went bad, forgetting why they had left the home-life.

The Venerable Master had a Dharma nephew who had come from Manchuria. Although he had donned the robes and shaved his head to leave the home-life, he was usually not serious about his cultivation and not strict in keeping the precepts, and the Venerable Master often admonished him. This time, in order to thoroughly correct his past mistakes, he asked the Venerable Master to let him hold a Pratyutpanna session [Tr.: the Pratyutpanna Samadhi practice consists of constant walking and standing, without sitting or lying down, for a set period]. What the Venerable Master liked best was a cultivator who applied effort, so he had a retreat room built especially for him near Cixing Chan Monastery. On March 30 (the nineteenth day of the second lunar month) he entered the retreat room and began the 90-day practice of the Pratyutpanna Samadhi.

In the Venerable Master's own words:

When Heng Yue came to Hong Kong, at first he didn't cultivate much. He smoked cigarettes, and he had other faults too, which I won't go into, and he didn't dare come to see me. Then, because he had no place to live, he brought

forth the resolve for the Way and told me he wanted to hold a Pratyutpanna session on Lantau Island.

What is the Pratyutpanna Samadhi? "Pratyutpanna" is Sanskrit; here it is translated as "the Buddhas stand," so it is also called the "Samadhi of the Buddhas Standing." In this practice, a person walks constantly inside a room, so it is also called the "Samadhi of Constant Walking." How many days do you go on like this without sitting or lying down? Ninety days. You just walk like this inside the room and don't sit down anywhere. Apart from eating meals and going to the toilet, you simply don't sleep; this is specifically to counter the demon of sleep. Sometimes you walk until your feet swell up and your legs swell up too, and all kinds of ailments arise, but you still have to keep walking and must not fall down. If you fall down, the session is broken, and you can't attain the Pratyutpanna Samadhi. You see, in Buddhism there's this kind of method of cultivation, a method of cultivating with such courageous vigor.

Here we are now holding a Buddha Recitation session, walking for a while, sitting for a while, reciting aloud, reciting silently, getting up at three-thirty in the morning and resting at ten o'clock at night. That still doesn't count as too hard!

At that time (February 1956) I had a small house built for him, a room of about 20 feet by 30 feet, to help him cultivate the Pratyutpanna Samadhi. I also found someone to protect his session, boiling water for him, bringing him his meals, and looking after him there. Heng Yue recited the Buddha's name until he saw Amitabha Buddha! Then he ran for all he was worth, reciting for all he was worth, "Namo Amitabha Buddha, Namo Amitabha Buddha, Namo Amitabha Buddha...," louder and louder, louder and louder. I was up on the slope, and he lived down below, about 200 paces from where I was. When I heard him reciting so loudly down there, I knew he had entered a demonic state, so I went to see him. I saw him running very fast in that room, reciting the Buddha's name as he ran, running extremely fast, running around like a madman.

What do you say was going on? In his former life this Bhikshu was an ox. Because he had worked for a monastery plowing the fields, in this life he was reborn as a human and became a monk, but his ox nature hadn't changed, and he always had a big temper. Why did he run like that? Because he saw Amitabha Buddha coming, and he was chasing after this Amitabha Buddha. But what was really happening? He had fallen into a demonic state. It was actually a water buffalo from the sea: a sea monster had come! This water buffalo was running in front, and he thought Amitabha Buddha had come, so he chased after it. It was luring him on like this, wanting to drag him off to be one of its retinue. How could this water-buffalo spirit manifest the form of Amitabha Buddha? Not only can it manifest the form of Amitabha Buddha; all heavenly demons and externalists have this kind of spiritual power. If you don't recognize it, at a time like this you won't be able to keep your samadhi!

When I got there, I used Dharma power to break up this demonic state. He said, "Just now I saw Amitabha Buddha coming to receive me. Where did Amitabha Buddha go?"

"First settle down. Don't be so flustered! What are you in such a hurry for? When you recite the Buddha's name, you have to recite according to the Dharma!" I said.

"Just now I saw Amitabha Buddha coming to receive me."

"And now?"

"As soon as you came in, Amitabha Buddha ran away," he said.

"You've mistaken it! That wasn't Amitabha Buddha coming. That was a demonic state coming to lure you," I said.

That's how he managed to escape that state. If I hadn't gone, he would have gone off the rails and been possessed by demons. So sometimes even reciting the Buddha's name can lead to demonic possession. In short, in cultivation you must have virtuous conduct, you must have the Way and virtue; without the Way and virtue, even if you recite the Buddha's name, you'll still run into demons.

And what became of Heng Yue after he finished that Pratyutpanna session? He stopped cultivating again. All day long all he thought about was eating. He ate three meals a day and ate a great deal, and he got very, very fat, so fat he could hardly walk. Because he ate too much, he often went to the toilet, and unexpectedly, he breathed his last in the toilet. When he died he was not yet over 40. This is an example of someone who cultivated and then stopped cultivating!

[Addendum 1] *Mind Dharma* magazine, Issue 2, news item "A Dharma Master Holds a Pratyutpanna Session at Cixing Chan Monastery on Lantau Island":

At Cixing Chan Monastery on Ling Wui Shan at Man Cheung Po on Lantau Island (its abbot is this magazine's publisher), a retreat building was specially constructed in the second month of this year (1956) for the convenience of those who resolve to cultivate the "Pratyutpanna Samadhi method." A certain Dharma Master, hoping to accomplish his work in the Way early, entered the retreat room on the nineteenth day of the second lunar month and began cultivating the "Pratyutpanna Samadhi" method for a period of 90 days.

"Pratyutpanna" is Sanskrit; translated into Chinese, it is "the Buddhas stand." "The Buddhas stand" has three meanings: first, the awesome power of the Buddhas; second, the power of samadhi; third, the power of the practitioner's own merit and virtue. During the 90-day Pratyutpanna period, one walks around the room, not sleeping or resting day or night, only reciting the great six-character name. In the room there is no bed, table, chair, or the like. If a monk cultivating this ascetic practice suddenly feels drowsy, he may stand still for a little while and reach up to hold on to a cloth strap hanging in the air. After a short rest, he continues walking around the room. Cultivating vigorously like

this, with the three karmas in accord, one can see the Buddhas of the ten directions in samadhi. After seeing the Buddhas, one understands the mind and sees the nature, and one can open up understanding and awaken to wisdom.

[Addendum 2] Bhikshu Dharma Master Heng Ding's oral account:

Over on Lantau Island there is a retreat room, which was built when Dharma Master Heng Yue did the Pratyutpanna Samadhi practice there. At that time he saw many states, not just Amitabha Buddha.

[Addendum 3] Upasika Tan Guo Shi recounted:

The Master was very respectful toward genuine cultivators and toward the older generation in the Sangha, but if someone in the Sangha did not behave properly, the Master would also criticize them sternly. I remember that the Master scolded Dharma Master Heng Yue more than anyone. Dharma Master Heng Yue and Dharma Master Heng Zhi were two of the Master's Dharma nephews. When they first came to Hong Kong, they stayed at Western Bliss Gardens most of the time. Western Bliss Gardens was originally a small house; when they came, it was enlarged with an extra room for them.

At the monastery, the Master didn't allow us to talk much, and this was even more so for the Sangha. The monastics did not talk casually with laypeople, and above all could not talk with women, except when giving instruction. Dharma Master Heng Zhi always sat in full lotus, fingering his recitation beads as he recited the Buddha's name, whereas Dharma Master Heng Yue would talk with us, and sometimes with other people too. In 1993, when the Master came to Hong Kong, Dharma Master Heng Zhi paid the Master a visit.

66. Receiving Dharma Transmission in the Weiyang Lineage

In 1946 the Venerable Master set out from Manchuria and trekked more than 3,000 li, enduring hardship all along the way, and in 1948 he arrived at Nanhua Monastery at Caoxi in Guangdong to pay his respects to Elder Master Hsu Yun. Elder Hsu, who was 109 years old at the time, gave the Venerable Master certification as soon as he saw him, saying, "So it is! So it is!"...

On May 18, 1956 (the ninth day of the fourth lunar month), in the Dharma Hall at Yunju, Elder Hsu transmitted the Dharma to the Venerable Master, making him the ninth-generation Dharma heir of the Weiyang lineage [Tr.: one of the five houses of the Chan School], and gave him the name "Hsuan Hua." From Mount Yunju he specially sent the Venerable Master the record of the origins and lineage of the Weiyang patriarchs, and he also wrote a "Verse of Certification" [Tr.: The four lines begin with the characters of the names Hsuan Hua and To Lun.]:

> *Proclaiming the wondrous meaning of Wei, he revives the family name;*
> *Transforming, he inherits from the Spiritual Peak, and the Way of the Dharma flourishes.*

宣沩妙義振家聲, 化承靈岳法道隆,

Crossing beings over with the "four and six," he transmits the mind seal;
The wheel turns without rest, rescuing the suffering multitudes.

度以四六傳心印, 輪旋無休濟苦倫。

Elder Hsu transmitted the Dharma to the Venerable Master, making him the forty-fifth generation counting from the Western Land of India, and the ninth-generation Dharma heir of the Weiyang lineage in the Eastern Land of China. Nevertheless, the Venerable Master's monastic and lay disciples have always carried on the Dharma lineage of the "Golden Summit Vairocana" branch of the Chan School. It was only after the Venerable Master went to America in 1962 that he began to use the name "Hsuan Hua" and raised the banner of the Dharma far and wide.

In 1956 the Venerable Master received from Elder Hsu the scroll of Dharma transmission, *The Treasury of the True Dharma Eye: The Origins and Lineage of the Buddhas and Patriarchs*, which lists the successive patriarchs since Shakyamuni Buddha and the successive patriarchs of the Weiyang lineage. On the scroll was written: "The Old Man Deqing Hsu Yun, eighth generation of the orthodox Weiyang lineage, now entrusts the Treasury of the True Dharma Eye to the ninth-generation Chan practitioner Hsuan Hua To Lun. Guard and uphold it well."

In 1958 Elder Hsu sent the Venerable Master a set of the *Images and Biographies of the Buddhas and Patriarchs (Expanded Edition)*, which Elder Hsu had revised, together with a letter. After each patriarch's page in the book, the Venerable Master added a verse introduced with the words "Again I speak a verse, which says," and after the fourth volume he appended the lives and verses of several dozen eminent monks of recent times. This became the *Images and Biographies of the Buddhas and Patriarchs (Further Expanded Edition)*, which was later printed and distributed.

In the Venerable Master's own words:

When I built Cixing Chan Monastery, I made a statue of the Venerable Yun while he was still living, to show my reverence. I wrote to the Venerable Yun: "I have been entrusted with the Treasury of the True Dharma Eye, the origins and lineage of the Buddhas and Patriarchs: the Dharma of sealing mind with mind, the special transmission outside the teachings, the wondrous mind of Nirvana, the real mark that is without marks, true emptiness that is not empty. Above, I shall carry on the intent of the Patriarchs; below, I shall transform living beings. Such profound kindness in nourishing me with the milk of the Dharma is in my thoughts at every moment."

[Addendum 1] The Weiyang lineage is one of the five houses of the Chan School (Linji, Caodong, Weiyang, Yunmen, and Fayan). From the Venerable Kashyapa the Dharma was passed down to the Patriarch Bodhidharma, the Twenty-eighth Patriarch of the Western Heaven (India), who was also the First Patriarch of the Eastern Land of China. From the First Patriarch it passed down

through five transmissions to Great Master Huineng, the Sixth Patriarch. Great Master Huineng transmitted it to Nanyue Huairang; Chan Master Huairang transmitted it to Mazu Daoyi; Chan Master Daoyi transmitted it to Baizhang Huaihai; and Chan Master Huaihai transmitted it to Chan Master Weishan Lingyou, the thirty-seventh generation counting from the Western Land. Chan Master Weishan then transmitted it to Yangshan Huiji. At that time their Dharma affinities flourished greatly, and so it became the Weiyang branch of the Chan School. The line runs from the first patriarch of the Weiyang lineage, Chan Master Weishan; the second, Chan Master Yangshan; the third, Chan Master Xita Guangmu; the fourth, Chan Master Zifu Rubao; the fifth, Chan Master Baoci Deshao; the sixth, Chan Master Sanjiao Zhiqian; and the seventh, Chan Master Xingyang Ciduo, down to Elder Master Hsu Yun, the eighth patriarch of the Weiyang lineage in the Eastern Land. Elder Hsu transmitted the Dharma to the Venerable Master, making him the forty-fifth generation counting from the Western Land and the ninth-generation Dharma heir of the Weiyang lineage in the Eastern Land.

[Addendum 2] From "The Origins and Lineages of the Five Schools of Chan," in Volume 8 of the *Collected Dharma Talks of Elder Master Hsu Yun*, respectfully recorded by Hsu Yun Deqing:

While I was living at Nanhua, in the summer of the jiaxu year [1934], Upasaka Guo Hanzhai (Kuan Hui) of Changsha, Elder Baosheng of Nanyue, Head Seat Jiucheng Liaozhao, and others came one after another from Great Mount Wei to earnestly request that I rebuild Great Wei. Their thinking was that this school ranked as the eldest of the five houses, but sadly it had lacked heirs, so that the flame at its ancestral monastery had gone out, and the monastery now kept the bell and board of the Linji school. This time it had been burned down by bandits and reduced entirely to ashes, so they had resolved to make a fresh start and restore the Weiyang line. Because I was advanced in age and senior in monastic years, and was respected and trusted by the monasteries everywhere, the assembly asked me to carry on and revive the Weiyang lineage. Since I could not lay down my responsibilities at Nanhua, yet could not decline, I did my best to follow the records. On investigation: this school began with Patriarch Lingyou and after four transmissions reached Bajiao Huiqing, whose disciple Jiche began a lineage verse of twenty characters; the character following "Ji" should be "Miao," and so on in order, to carry on the earlier lineage. However, the records stop at the two masters of the Song dynasty, Sanjiao Zhiqian and Xingyang Ciduo. One account says the two were brothers who both succeeded Patriarch Shao of Baoen as the sixth generation; another says that Zhiqian was the sixth generation and Ciduo the seventh. Since very little of this school's transmission has come down to us, I have kept both accounts, taking Xingyang Ciduo, as heir to Sanjiao Zhiqian, to be the seventh generation. After that there are no records to go by. Now I have taken the first character of Venerable Ciduo's name and of my own name, and continued them by unfolding fifty-six characters, awaiting worthy ones of later times to carry on the work without end. The verse says [Tr.:

Each character of such a verse serves in turn as the generation character in Dharma names; this one begins with Ci and De.]:

> *Words of virtue proclaimed and spread, the Way greatly flourishes;*
> *The fragrance of the precept censer pervades, the fivefold incense made new.*
>
> 詞德宣衍道大興 戒鼎馨遍五分新
>
> *The flame of wisdom spreads through worlds as many as the sands;*
> *Clouds of incense shelter all, shining through past and present.*
>
> 慧焰彌布周沙界 香雲普蔭燦古今
>
> *With kindness and compassion saving the world, the vows are endless;*
> *The light shines like sun and moon, making the great heavens bright.*
>
> 慈悲濟世願無盡 光昭日月朗太清
>
> *Reviving the flower once held aloft, we spread it wide from Wei;*
> *The circle-form, the lamp of the mind, shall shine forever bright.*
>
> 振啟拈花宏沩上 圓相心燈永昌明

[Addendum 3] From the diary of Upasika Tan Guo Zheng:

The Master once took out the Dharma scroll of the ninth generation of the Weiyang school, which Elder Master Hsu Yun had transmitted to him, and showed it to me. The Master also had the walking stick and the chopsticks that Elder Hsu had used in his daily life. The bearing of that greatly virtuous one lingers in my heart.

[Addendum 4] Note appended to the second enlargement of the *Images and Biographies of the Buddhas and Patriarchs (Expanded Edition)*:

In the summer of the yihai year [1935], I, Yun, took the images of 69 patriarchs that I had collected over several years, attached a biography and a eulogy to each one, and added them to the *Images and Biographies of the Buddhas and Patriarchs* compiled by the virtuous ones of the past, naming the result the *Images and Biographies of the Buddhas and Patriarchs (Expanded Edition)*. New printing blocks were carved, and it was distributed from Gushan. In the twenty years since then, I have obtained 27 more, again attached biographies and eulogies to them, and had them carved and added as a further supplement, for a total of 330 images. Yet the true face of the patriarchs is surely not limited to these. Long ago Wenxi asked Manjushri how many were in his assembly. Manjushri replied, "Three three in front, three three behind." [Tr.: A well-known Chan dialogue; the phrase points to a number beyond counting.] Now I, Yun, have added, and added again, completing the "three three in front." As for the "three three behind," that awaits the wise ones to come, who will add and add without end. This is my record.

Buddhist Era 2982, the yiwei year [1955], on the Double Ninth, the ninth day of the ninth lunar month

Recorded by Hsu Yun at his thatched hut on Mount Yunju, at the age of 117

[Addendum 5] Preface to the *Images and Biographies of the Buddhas and Patriarchs (Further Expanded Edition)*

The Way fundamentally has no image; what has an image is not the Way. The Buddhas and Patriarchs have no marks; what has marks is not the Buddhas and Patriarchs. Because living beings are attached, images are shown where there are no images, and marks are shown where there are no marks. If only one can leave marks while in the midst of marks, and let go of images while in the midst of images! That is why the *Images and Biographies of the Buddhas and Patriarchs* has been expanded once more; the causes and conditions lie here. Now I have also added ten eminent monks, greatly virtuous ones of recent times, so that seeing the worthy, we may strive to equal them and take them as our models. Perhaps this comes close to the principle of no image and no marks!

November 28, 1985

Preface written by the Monk of Changbai Mountain at the City of Ten Thousand Buddhas

[Addendum 6] *Vernacular Commentary on the Images and Biographies of the Buddhas and Patriarchs*

The *Images and Biographies of the Buddhas and Patriarchs*, as its name suggests, records the practice of the Way and the Dharma images of the successive patriarchs of the Western Heaven and the Eastern Land, so that they may be handed down in China and abroad as a standard for later cultivators. It serves the purpose of "seeing the worthy and striving to equal them."

To continue the mind-lamp of the Buddha, the Venerable Master also added seven patriarchs of the Pure Land School, naming the work the *Images and Biographies of the Buddhas and Patriarchs (Further Expanded Edition)*. In 1986 the original text was published first, as a thread-bound set of four volumes, which is of great value for research into the history of the Chan School.

Because the original book is written in classical Chinese, people today find it very hard to understand the virtuous conduct of the greatly virtuous ones of old and the deep and secret states of their enlightenment. The *Vernacular Commentary on the Images and Biographies of the Buddhas and Patriarchs* consists of lectures the Venerable Master gave from 1972 to 1985, over a span of 13 years, 346 sessions in all. After the Venerable Master entered perfect stillness, his disciples, mindful of the painstaking efforts of those before them to protect and preserve the sagely teaching, transcribed and edited the Venerable Master's vernacular explanations of those years step by step, and published them volume by volume.

March 11, 2004

Buddhist Text Translation Society

67. Deluded People, Deluded Dreams

Hong Kong was a society of vanity and glitter. Although a group of young people followed the Venerable Master, they had all received a Westernized education. The Venerable Master went to great pains to teach them, and he wrote a song of social realism expressing his pity for wayward youth...

> *Living beings in the Dharma-Ending Age have scant blessings and heavy karma;*
> *Defiled thoughts easily blaze, while pure virtue is hard to achieve.*
> *Ignorance stirs falsely, and where there is karma, deeds follow;*
> *Drifting through birth and death, now they float, now they sink.*
>
> 末法眾生，福輕業重。染心易熾，淨德難成。無明妄動，有業斯行。流浪生死，或浮或沉。

> *They take suffering for pleasure, and mistake a thief for their own son;*
> *So used to it they no longer notice, numbed by the rain and drunk on the wind.*
> *"Freedom" and Europeanization dazzle their eyes and blur their sight;*
> *They vie in prizing falsehood, while the truth grows dimmer day by day.*
>
> 以苦為樂，認賊作子。習然不察，麻雨醉風。自由歐化，眩目迷睛。競尚虛偽，真實日蒙。

> *Social life is warped, and bizarre behavior runs rampant;*
> *One cheats and another swindles, each showing off his wondrous skills.*
> *Men seduce and women beguile, with far-reaching schemes and deep designs;*
> *Sparing no money, they try to win each other's favor.*
>
> 畸形社交，怪態橫生。彼欺此詐，各顯神功。男誘女惑，計遠謀深。不惜金錢，討好對方。

> *Once they succeed, they become a resentful and sorrowful couple;*
> *Without any joy at all, it ends in desolation.*
> *Living beings so upside down are truly to be pitied—*
> *Alas, how painful!*
>
> 及其成功，怨偶悲傷。毫無樂趣，結果淒涼。顛倒眾生，實堪憐憫。嗟呼痛哉！

Before the Venerable Master left the home-life, he read widely and was well versed in the Taoist classics. When lecturing on the sutras and speaking the Dharma, the Venerable Master often quoted the texts and principles of Laozi's *Tao Te Ching* and the *Most High Scripture of Clarity and Stillness*. The following verse on cultivating the Way, written on the sixth day of the ninth lunar month of 1956, draws on stories from the Taoist *Biographies of the Seven Perfected* to encourage his disciples to emulate the firm and sincere resolve for the Way of those in the stories, and to leave the mundane world behind to cultivate the Way.

> *Randeng resigned as chief minister and entered the mountain forests; (Note 1)*
>
> 燃燈辭相入山林，（注一）

> *Bu'er, in Luoyang, went deep in the work of the Way. (Note 2)*
>
> 不二洛陽道業深。（注二）

Zhongli of the Han house sealed away his marshal's seal; (Note 3)

漢室鐘離封帥印，（注三）

Li Er of the Shang era abandoned the red dust. (Note 4)

商時李耳棄紅塵。（注四）

(Note 1) Liu Haichan, whose original name was Liu Cao and whose Taoist name was Haichanzi, was a patriarch of the Northern School of Taoism who lived during the Five Dynasties. He served as chief minister to Liu Shouguang, the Prince of Yan, but later abandoned his office and followed Zhengyangzi to live in seclusion and cultivate on Mount Zhongnan.

(Note 2) Sun Yuanzhen (also written Yuanzhen, with a different first character) was one of the Seven Perfected. She took Wang Chongyang as her teacher and was given the name Bu'er. She disfigured her face, left home, and, disguised as a madwoman, went to Luoyang to cultivate the Way.

(Note 3) Han Zhongli, that is, Zhongli Quan, was a great general of the Eastern Han, styled Zhengyangzi, and is one of the Eight Immortals.

(Note 4) Li Er is Laozi.

[Addendum] From the diary of Upasika Tan Guo Zheng:

I remember that in Hong Kong the Venerable Master often spoke the Buddhadharma to us. He not only explained to us what the "Triple Jewel" is, but also told us stories from the Taoist *Biographies of the Seven Perfected*, such as those of Qiu Changchun, whose cleverness led him astray, and Sun Bu'er, who disfigured her face to study the Way, as lessons for our own cultivation.

Part Four: The Lecture Hall and Crossing Over Living Beings

Ages 39 to 45

1956 to 1962 CE

68. The Buddhist Lecture Hall

Within a few years of arriving in Hong Kong, the Venerable Master had built two Way-places one after the other: Western Bliss Gardens Monastery and Cixing Chan Monastery. However, because both were hard to reach and the round trip took a long time, it was difficult for them to draw in more devotees, so some laypeople resolved...

With Western Bliss Gardens Monastery and Cixing Chan Monastery, the Venerable Master had refuge disciples all over Hong Kong, Kowloon, and the New Territories. But Western Bliss Gardens Monastery was on a ridge at Ma Shan Village in Shau Kei Wan on Hong Kong Island, where the hillside was steep and the path winding; the place was cramped and crude, and there were more than 300 stone steps to climb up and down. Cixing Chan Monastery was even farther from the city, halfway up the mountain at Man Cheung Po on Lantau Island, and the round trip meant several hours of climbing mountains and crossing water. To help the Venerable Master spread the Buddhadharma widely, and to make it easier for more devotees to come to a Way-place to hear the Dharma and cultivate, Yu Guo Man and some other laypeople resolved to buy a floor of a building in Happy Valley, Hong Kong. In 1956 another Way-place established by the Venerable Master, the Buddhist Lecture Hall, came into being.

In the Venerable Master's own words:

It was because the building at Western Bliss Gardens leaked. In the space of just one bed there were six leaks. Yu Guo Man said, "Shifu, how can we let you suffer like this? I'll buy you a floor in Happy Valley, and you can move to Happy Valley!" I said, "If you want to buy it, then buy it!" She went home and told her son, and then they bought a floor to be a Way-place. That floor originally cost HK$45,000. She put up HK$40,000, and I and some others made up the rest; we also bought another floor next door. When I was at Western Bliss Gardens I was very thin, but after I moved to Happy Valley I put on weight. Now that I'm here in America I've gotten thin again; I've lost more than 20 pounds.

When I was about to come to America, I had no money, so I thought of selling one of the floors so that I could come to America and establish a Way-place. Yu Guo Man said, "Shifu, don't sell this floor to anyone else! Once it's sold, you'll never be able to buy it back!" I said, "I won't be buying it back anyway! I have no money, and I have to take a little money with me to America." "Oh, then I'll buy it!" So she had her son once again put up about 60,000 dollars, and she bought the floor back. She said, "Never mind! Whenever you come back, Shifu,

I'll give it back to you. Right now you need the money!" She also said, "If I told my sons to give you money, they wouldn't be happy about it. But if I say it's to buy your floor, they're fine with it. When you come back in a few years, it will still be yours." I said, "Then do as you like!" That's how I went from Hong Kong to America.

[Addendum] Because Yu Guo Man had great faith in the Venerable Master, she came several times from Hong Kong to San Francisco, America, to see him. When she came to San Francisco in 1973, she resolved to leave the home-life. Through the Venerable Master's compassion, on November 27 she shaved her head and left the home-life at Gold Mountain Monastery together with five other disciples, Westerners of American nationality. The Venerable Master gave her the Dharma name Guo Man and the Dharma title Heng Fu. She was already 67 years old at the time. Being simple-hearted, she loved reciting the Buddha's name more than anything, but she was old, and as she recited she would fall asleep. The Venerable Master said: "Guo Man has left the home-life at such an advanced age, and she is so sincere about it. Look at her—the Buddha is always aiding her, aiding her to sleep a bit more. She eats her fill and sleeps soundly; she lies down there and falls right asleep. She can do that because she doesn't have idle thoughts. If she were full of idle thoughts, she couldn't sleep. For instance, when she was in Hong Kong about to come to America, she said she didn't sleep for two days. Of course: 'When will I get to America? What will it be like sitting on the plane? When will I see Shifu?' She had these idle thoughts from morning till night, so she couldn't sleep. Yesterday when she arrived here, she fell asleep as soon as she lay down on the bed, because her idle thoughts had stopped, and so she could sleep."

Yu Guo Man had left the home-life. The Venerable Master always made allowances for elderly people, especially in the Buddha Hall. The Venerable Master said: "Don't make the elderly bow so many times! Standing up like this and kneeling down takes a lot of effort. When she does it on her own, she'll be careful; but when she bows along with everyone else, she gets flustered—she sees these young people so nimble and quick, bowing so neatly and crisply, and she gets very tense there. So you should pay attention to this and not make old people feel rushed. Especially when bowing to the Buddhas, you should bring a bowing cushion for the elderly. Take Guo Man: I told her to use that bowing cushion, to make things a bit easier for her, because she has lumps on her legs again, and kneeling down on the floor is very hard for her. Young people are agile, and their hands and feet are nimble; even if they take a tumble while kneeling there, it doesn't matter—they won't get hurt. But if an old person falls, then there's trouble! Their old bones and old flesh aren't very sturdy. You all need to understand this!"

In the Venerable Master's own words:

She really should have left the home-life long ago, but she had three sons. This eldest son of hers was especially filial: every time he came back to Hong Kong, he bought her good things to eat, bought her clothes, and gave her money. All

the money she contributed came from her son. Her whole family took refuge with me. Now that she wants to leave the home-life, I'm very happy too. In the future her skill in reciting the Buddha's name will be very good; she doesn't have many idle thoughts, and she works very hard.

Someone once asked me, "Why doesn't Guo Man leave the home-life?" That has to wait until the time is right! When the time comes, she'll leave home even if she doesn't mean to. If the time hasn't come, telling her to leave home won't work; even if she did leave home, she might sometimes regret it! Guo Man is so old now that she no longer has any problems between men and women to bother her. But her family is very wealthy, and there are many of them: her husband, three sons, and three or four daughters as well, and her daughters-in-law and grandchildren are all very good to her. That she could leave the home-life shows she has truly been able to let go! I'm not saying this for others to hear; I'm saying it for you to hear!

69. Better Still to Put It into Practice

Once the Buddhist Lecture Hall was established, it lived up to its name: the Venerable Master often lectured on the sutras and spoke the Dharma there, and every weekend he trained his disciples to take turns speaking the Dharma. It goes without saying that the young disciples who constantly followed the Venerable Master received this training; even...

...an elderly Upasika over 60 years old, Hu Guo Wei, took part every time. She once recited this Pure Land poem for everyone:

> *Far off I point to the West, beside the setting sun;*
> *The road home runs straight as a bowstring.*
> 遙指西方落日邊，一條歸路直如弦。
>
> *When I go, I'll need no shoes or socks:*
> *With every step, lotus flowers will bloom.*
> 去時不用穿鞋襪，步步蓮花朵朵生。

This elderly Upasika was Li Guo Yuan's mother (see the chapter "27. Wondrous Accounts of Saving Lives (2)"). After taking refuge with the Venerable Master, she never let her recitation beads out of her hand. One day, probably some time after 1962, she suddenly took it into her head to go around visiting relatives and friends she had not seen for a long time. Three days later she passed away peacefully at home. The Venerable Master once said, "Those who can speak are not as good as those who can listen, and those who can listen are not as good as those who can practice." She is truly someone worth emulating!

In the Venerable Master's own words:

Take listening to the Dharma: people may hear a great deal, but they understand very little; or they may understand a lot, but very few can put it into practice. That's why I often say, "Those who can speak are not as good as those who can listen; those who can listen are not as good as those who can practice;

those who can practice are not as good as those who can realize it." People who can speak may speak so well that heavenly flowers rain down in profusion and golden lotuses well up from the earth, but if they don't put it into practice, if they don't carry it out in their own conduct, that's called "talking about food and counting others' treasure." It's like a stone man: the stone man can talk, but he can't walk, because he's made of stone. So it's said, "Speaking well, speaking wonderfully—if you can't practice it, it isn't the Way." And how do people who know how to listen listen to the Dharma? It's "Coarse words and subtle speech all return to the primary meaning."

[Addendum 1] Bhikshu Elder Zhi Ding wrote in his article "In Memory of Elder To Lun": After Elder To Lun returned from Thailand to settle in Hong Kong, he immediately set about the work of propagating the Dharma and benefiting living beings. First he founded Western Bliss Gardens Monastery in Sai Wan Ho, Hong Kong, and drew in beginners with the Dharma door of reciting the Buddha's name, which reaches those of all three kinds of faculties. Later he bought the 12th floor of a building in Happy Valley and established the Hong Kong Buddhist Lecture Hall. As its name suggests, it was for propagating the great sutras, broadly benefiting those of superior faculties and sharp wisdom while also reaching the general public. Moreover, it gave monks one more place to lodge. Besides accepting monastics to stay and lecturing on the sutras and expounding the teachings in Hong Kong, Elder To Lun also printed sutras for free distribution and circulated Dharma treasures.

[Addendum 2] Tan Guo Shi recounted:

The elderly Upasika Hu Guo Wei was illiterate, but after taking refuge she attended every Dharma assembly and sutra lecture at Western Bliss Gardens without fail. At every break she would sit off to one side with her recitation beads in her hand, reciting the Buddha's name. When I greeted her, she always smiled at me. At the weekend Dharma assemblies, every time the Master asked her to go up on the stage to speak, she would only say, "My name is Hu Guo Wei. I don't know how to give talks. Amitabha!" and then step down, all smiles. But one day she suddenly recited the verse above, and everyone was astonished!

According to her daughter-in-law, for three days before she passed away she went everywhere visiting her relatives and friends. On the morning of the day she passed away, she bathed, changed into her robe and lay precept sash, sat in full lotus on the bed in her room, and passed away while reciting the Buddha's name! Only when her daughter-in-law went to see her at lunchtime did she find out that she had already passed away.

[Addendum 3] Tan Guo Zheng recounted in 1995:

To spread Buddhism, one must lecture on the sutras and speak the Dharma. Every weekend there were Buddhist talks at the Hong Kong Buddhist Lecture Hall. The Buddhist Lecture Hall was set up not only for great Dharma Masters, but also to train the little Dharma Masters of the future.

The Venerable Master required his disciples, male and female, old and young, all to speak. Even the elderly Upasika Hu Guo Wei, who was in her sixties, would go up to speak, reciting the same verse every time. Expounding the Buddhadharma without notes, speaking straight from the heart and saying whatever came naturally—this was the Venerable Master's unique method of training his disciples to lecture on the sutras, and it has continued to this day.

[Addendum 4] *Nature Daily* (*Ziran Ribao*), Monday, November 10, 1958 (the twenty-ninth day of the ninth month of the wuxu year):

Buddhist Lecture Hall Teaches the Mahayana Dharma

(Special report) The Hong Kong Buddhist Lecture Hall, on the top floor of 1A Shing Woo Road, Happy Valley, in this territory, held a Dharma-propagation lecture assembly yesterday (Sunday), presided over by the eminent monk Dharma Master To Lun, and the audience turned out enthusiastically. Dharma Master To Lun formerly served as dean of academic affairs at the Nanhua Buddhist Academy. Since coming to Hong Kong, he has founded three Way-places in succession: Western Bliss Gardens in Shau Kei Wan, Cixing Chan Monastery on Lantau Island, and now the Buddhist Lecture Hall in Happy Valley. His refuge disciples are found throughout Hong Kong, Kowloon, and the New Territories. From now on, every Sunday from 2:00 to 5:00 p.m., Dharma Master To Lun will lecture on the Mahayana sutras to save the people of the world. Good men and faithful women are welcome to come and hear the Dharma.

70. Pilgrimage to Burma

In July 1957, Chen Zhenfu, the Burmese consul, and Judge Yu Zhendong invited the Venerable Master to go to Burma to take part in the Opening-the-Light ceremony of the World Peace Pagoda. The Venerable Master's long-cherished aim was to unite Mahayana and Small Vehicle Buddhism into one, so that Buddhism in the world...

The Venerable Master went to Burma accompanied by Wen Guo Mi. They visited the Buddhist university at Pegu, paid homage at the Great Golden Pagoda in Rangoon, led several hundred Rangoon Buddhists in circumambulating the pagoda while reciting the Buddha's name, and at the Reclining Buddha Temple sat in meditation, investigated Chan, and studied together with Burmese Bhikshus. The Venerable Master set an example himself, guiding Mahayana and Small Vehicle practitioners to cultivate together, advance together, and develop together, so that Buddhism throughout the world would be united as one, with no views of "Great" and "Small" Vehicles.

While in Burma, the Venerable Master stayed at the World Buddhist Society. After the Dharma assembly concluded, he went from Rangoon to Penang in Malaysia, where he stayed at Kek Lok Si Monastery, and then went on to Singapore. When the Venerable Master left Burma, the laypeople could not help

kneeling and weeping at the airport as they saw him off. Although his time there was short, it let them see the bearing and virtue of a true cultivator.

In the Venerable Master's own words:

The Buddhadharma originated in India and later spread to every country, and many of these countries regard the Buddhadharma as their own. Burma has Burmese Buddhism, Cambodia has Cambodian Buddhism, Vietnam has Vietnamese Buddhism, Thailand has Thai Buddhism, China has Chinese Buddhism, Japan has Japanese Buddhism, and Korea has Korean Buddhism. When the Buddha first spoke the Dharma, did he speak it for just one country? No. The Buddha observed the potentials of his listeners and taught accordingly, and the Buddhadharma suits the people of every country. The Buddhadharma itself is not divided into so many national Buddhisms. But these many countries are themselves unwilling to let Buddhism spread and flourish widely, so they take it as their own and say that this Buddhism belongs to their country.

For this reason, several decades ago (1957), when I went to Burma and visited a Buddhist Way-place, they brought out a guest book and asked me to write some words to commemorate the visit. I wrote: "Our vision should take in the whole world; our resolve should embrace the nature of the Dharma Realm. Promote the inherent, concrete, and perfect Buddhism, so that the teachings and vehicles are unified, and the Great and the Small return to the source. May everyone together reach the other shore, and each one see the nature and become a Buddha." My reason for saying those few lines at that time was that if Buddhism is to spread and flourish, our vision must reach far. We must spread Buddhism to every country and every corner, even into every mote of dust, turning the great Dharma wheel there to teach and transform living beings, so that everyone can leave suffering and attain bliss, and end birth and death. That's why I boldly said, "This Buddhism of ours is not the private Buddhism of any one country. It is the Buddhism of all humankind, the Buddhism of all living beings. We should not treat Buddhism as a private treasury; we should make it available to the whole world, doing as much as we can."

The Shurangama Mantra has Dharmas for averting disasters. For example, if you're clearly headed for some accident, it turns a big disaster into a small one, and a small one into none at all, so that most of the time things turn out to be a scare without real harm. Someone who was supposed to fall into the sea and drown won't drown once they recite the Shurangama Mantra. Or if you take a boat and the boat is supposed to sink, when you recite this mantra, the boat won't sink. Or if you're on an airplane that's supposed to explode in midair, as soon as you recite this mantra, it won't explode. This is truly miraculous beyond words! The leg of the flight from Burma to Thailand was very dangerous, yet the plane I was on didn't shake or sway the whole way. Even the pilot said, "How come the plane is so steady this time?" He didn't know that at the time the gods, dragons, and the rest of the eightfold division, and all the Buddhas and Bodhisattvas, were protecting the plane on the left and right, in front and behind.

In the countries of Southern Buddhism, such as Siam (Thailand), Burma, and Ceylon, the monastics all go on alms rounds to beg for their food; only in China do they cook for themselves in the monasteries. When monks beg for food in Siam and Burma, a monk comes to the house of a donor, and the donor kneels on the ground, raises the bowl of food above their head, pours it into the monastic's bowl, and then bows three times. That is how they make offerings to the Triple Jewel. Every household makes offerings to the Triple Jewel in this way.

I saw that the bowls of the monastics in Siam and Burma were very big; when full, they held enough for several people to eat. Their monastics eat with their hands, using neither spoons nor chopsticks. This is called "eating by the handful," and they say that eating this way makes the food taste more fragrant. Since I'm not used to it, I've never tried it.

The Burmese are in the habit of putting cooked onions and garlic on the dining table. The smell of the onions and garlic gets breathed right down into your stomach. Even without eating any, I couldn't stand it; that whole day I felt as if the smell were in my stomach and intestines. Onions and garlic are among the five pungent plants. The five pungent plants are onions, garlic, chives, shallots, and asafoetida. Eating them gives you a very unpleasant odor, so those who keep a vegetarian diet should abstain from them.

In India, Siam, Burma, and Ceylon, they still follow to this day the system of wearing the sash that existed when the Buddha was in the world. The kashayas that monastics wear are all yellow and have no hook and ring. Why do Chinese kashayas have a hook and ring? This is an expedient adaptation suited to the circumstances. When Chinese monastics put on the sash, they also leave the right shoulder bare; this too follows the system established by the Buddha. Because China's climate is rather cold, they had to wear padded cotton clothes and simply put the kashaya on over their clothes. If the kashaya slipped off, it was hard to notice, and it could easily be lost. The Patriarch Bodhidharma was very clever, and he was also an inventor: he invented the use of a hook and ring on the kashaya, which both preserved the system the Buddha established and allowed for expedient adaptation. That is the origin of the hook and ring in China.

After I left the home-life, I asked many elder Dharma Masters about the hook and ring. These Elder Masters all shook their heads; they didn't know. It's a very small question, so no one knew. So who actually told me? No one told me. When I compared the climate of China with the climates of India, Siam, and Burma, I realized that the patriarch who first came to China put on clothes because the climate was cold, and later worked out a way to fasten the kashaya with a hook and ring, so that when it was draped over the body it wouldn't slip off. When I mentioned this reason to some elder Dharma Masters, they all said that was how it was.

[Addendum 1] Dharma Master Le Guan mentions in his *Impressions of Master Hsu Yun*:

Elder Hsu asked me, "Have you come to request lodging and stay on here, or are you just passing through?" I said, "I came specially to pay my respects to you, Elder Master, and right after that I have to go on to Guangzhou." He said, "You've gone to the trouble of coming all the way here to see me, so you must stay a while longer; only then will I be at ease. However, life in the monastery is plain, and we have no fine tea or food to offer you." I replied, "I'm very grateful for your compassion, Elder Master, and I would like to stay close to you longer, but unfortunately I didn't bring my robes with me, so it's inconvenient to stay in the monastery." He said, "In times of war and chaos, don't be too particular about that. The round-collared robes that we Chinese monks usually wear are not, according to the precepts and Vinaya, the clothing a monk ought to wear. Only the kashaya is the true monastic garment. If you feel it's inconvenient, then don't follow the assembly to the Buddha Hall or to the formal meals in the dining hall; just take your meals in the guest hall every day."

[Addendum 2] The World Peace Pagoda is located in the northern suburbs of Rangoon, Burma, and is a famous Buddhist structure in the city. In 1954, in order to convene the "Sixth Council," the Burmese government held a two-year World Buddhist Scripture Council at this site (Auspicious Hill). At the foot of Auspicious Hill is a cave called the Great Sacred Cave, which can hold an assembly of more than 10,000 Bhikshus. The cave has six entrances and six stone pillars; on the walls are six relief carvings, and on the platform are mounted six candle-shaped electric lamps, symbolizing the Sixth Council. The World Peace Pagoda stands to the right of Auspicious Hill.

The architecture of the Peace Pagoda also embodies the symbols of the Sixth World Buddhist Scripture Council: the pagoda is 35 meters high, its base is 35 meters in circumference, and its body is hollow. The whole pagoda is supported by six great pillars and has six doors, and at each entrance a huge statue of the Buddha is enshrined; all of these symbolize the Sixth Council of the scriptures. At the very center of the pagoda is a small treasury, where a Buddha image cast of pure silver and weighing nearly a ton is enshrined in the sharira shrine; it is the treasure that guards the hall and is extremely precious. The sharira of the Buddha's two great disciples, the Venerable Shariputra and the Venerable Maudgalyayana, are also enshrined here. In the niches on the round pillars inside the pagoda there are 28 small statues of the Buddha. Inside the pagoda there is also a museum of Buddhist art, which has gathered a wide range of Buddha images and Buddhist scriptures from many places. Its collection includes two sharira originally enshrined in the Potala Palace in Tibet, presented by a Chinese Buddhist delegation in 1955; a photographic facsimile of an 800-year-old Chinese Tripitaka; and Chinese and Tibetan monastic robes, bowls, monks' staffs, and other items, all displayed in the pagoda's display cases. Although the World Peace Pagoda is the youngest pagoda in Rangoon, it holds

an extremely important place in Buddhist history and culture, and it is also the center of Burmese Buddhist culture.

(Editor's note: [The Sixth Council] On Vesak Day (World Buddha Day), May 17, 1954, Burmese Buddhism, with state sponsorship, convened the "Sixth Council of the Buddhist Scriptures" on a hill at Yegu in the northern suburbs of Rangoon. This council took as its basis the 729 marble slabs inscribed at the Fifth Council, and it consulted the Pali editions of Ceylon, Thailand, and Cambodia and of the Pali Text Society of London, as well as the various Pali editions of Burma, carrying out a detailed critical collation. The council also invited Bhikshus from all the countries of Southern Buddhism to take part, and Bhikshus from the countries of Northern Buddhism were also invited to observe. In all, more than 2,000 people from the Buddhist world took part. It took more than two years and was completed in 1956 (Buddhist Era 2500), and the materials of the council were printed and distributed. The significance of this council lay in uniting Buddhists and furthering the flourishing of Theravada Buddhism. This is called the Sixth Council.)

[Addendum 3] The Great Golden Pagoda of Rangoon, also called the Shwedagon Pagoda, stands on Singuttara Hill in Rangoon. It is the highest point in Rangoon and the most famous pagoda in Burma. It is also the most sacred pagoda in Burma, because it enshrines relics of four Buddhas: the staff of Krakucchanda Buddha, the water filter of the Perfectly and Equally Enlightened Kanakamuni Buddha, the robe of Kashyapa Buddha, and eight hairs of Shakyamuni Buddha. It was first built in 585 BCE. The main stupa is 99.36 meters high. The entire pagoda is covered with gold from top to bottom; jeweled bells hang from the golden umbrella at its summit, and the very top is set with 5,448 diamonds. The Great Golden Pagoda of Rangoon, together with Angkor Wat in Cambodia and Borobudur in Indonesia, is acclaimed as one of the three great ancient monuments of Southeast Asia. It is a world-famous pagoda and a symbol of the Burmese nation.

[Addendum 4] The Reclining Buddha Temple

The Chaukhtatgyi Pagoda enshrines the largest reclining Buddha in the world. It was first built in 1907 and rebuilt in 1966. The image is 75 meters long and 30 meters high. On the soles of its feet are 108 designs, which represent the 108 rounds of rebirth that people undergo and also symbolize that all things in heaven and earth lie beneath its feet. The Great Golden Pagoda and the Reclining Buddha are the most representative symbols of Burmese Buddhism.

[Addendum 5] Wen Guo Mi recounted on September 13, 2010:

In July 1957, the Master went to Rangoon, Burma, at the invitation of the Chief Justice of Rangoon; the invitation was delivered through Mr. Chen Zhenfu, the Burmese consul in Hong Kong. When we arrived in Rangoon, devout local Buddhists of Chinese descent came to the airport to meet us. The Master stayed in the back courtyard of the World Peace Pagoda. During the day the Master attended meetings, discussing the development of the Buddhadharma in various

regions with participants from Burma and neighboring countries; in the evenings, the Master went to a nearby Chinese temple to give instructional talks to local Buddhists, and the audience was very respectful toward the Master.

We stayed in Rangoon for about two weeks; our next stop was Penang in Malaysia. Shortly after takeoff, the twin-engine plane we were on ran into a storm. The plane shook violently and dropped sharply, things on board rattled, and everyone was terrified. The Master began to sit in meditation and pray to the gods, dragons, and the rest of the eightfold division to steady the plane, and I did the same. A few minutes later the plane stabilized, and the rest of the flight was smooth.

In Penang the Master stayed at the renowned Kek Lok Si Monastery, where he was warmly welcomed by the monastery's abbot and the local Dharma Masters. The Master met with local Buddhist devotees, many of whom were students. The Master stayed in Penang for a week and then continued his journey. Singapore was the last stop before returning to Hong Kong, and our host there was Ms. Bi Junhui, president of the Singapore Buddhist Association. She was a devout Buddhist and very respectful toward the Master. While in Singapore, the Master held several meetings with people from the Buddhist association and gave an instructional talk to the students of the Bodhi Primary School.

[Addendum 6] From the diary of Upasika Tan Guo Zheng:

The Master praised Guo Mi, saying, "When Guo Mi went with me to Burma, he was only 16, and he handled affairs and interpreting extremely well." Guo Mi had a heart condition and had never dared to fly before. When Guo Mi went to Burma with the Master, on the flight from Burma to Penang the plane ran into turbulence and bounced up and down, yet he came through safe and sound; he believed it was the Bodhisattvas' protection. After Guo Mi returned to Hong Kong, a doctor's examination confirmed that his heart was normal and fine! When Guo Mi went to Burma with the Master he was still very short, but not long after coming back he grew taller—he even became taller than the Master!

71. The Remarkable Story of Guo Mi (2)

Once, when the Venerable Master was lecturing on a sutra at the Buddhist Lecture Hall, the Venerable Master sat on the Dharma seat without saying a word the whole time, and only Guo Mi spoke. People whispered to one another, resentful, and everyone was thinking, "We came to hear the Venerable Master speak the Dharma. How can he let this teenager talk nonsense!"...

Everyone was thinking this. When the lecture was over, the Venerable Master said earnestly: "We ordinary people very easily attach to outward appearances. As soon as we see that it isn't a Dharma Master speaking the Dharma, we immediately give rise to discriminating thoughts, regardless of whether the sutra is being explained correctly or not. What Guo Mi said is also what I wanted to say. What came out of his mouth was just what I had in mind to say."

In the Venerable Master's own words:

This little disciple wasn't tall, but he spoke English very well. In Hong Kong, whenever Westerners wanted to see me, he was the one who interpreted. But when foreigners saw how small he was, they didn't take what he said very seriously. I told him, "Hurry up and grow taller! You're so short that no matter how well you speak, people see you as a little kid and find it hard to have faith in what you say!" He was very obedient: he grew three inches in one week, and now he's taller than me. That too is quite an inconceivable thing! He was the disciple I cherished most in Hong Kong. He had originally promised me he would leave the home-life, but now I don't know whether he'll leave home or not.

After about a year, he opened the Buddha Eye. He was extremely clear about everything, understood a great deal of the Buddhadharma, and had great faith in me. When I lectured on the sutras in Hong Kong, he interpreted into Cantonese. Whatever I wanted to say, I'd say just one sentence, and before I had finished, he could say it all for me, explaining the principles very completely. Some people objected, saying, "Shifu didn't say any of this. How come he's saying so much?" Actually, he said that much because I told him to. Because he had the Buddha Eye, he knew I wanted him to say more. Why did I have him say more? Because what he said was the same as what I would say. Some ignorant people became very jealous of him, so much so that it was as fierce as when Shenxiu wanted to kill the Sixth Patriarch.

[Addendum 1] From the diary of Upasika Tan Guo Zheng:

Once the Master and his disciples took the Tai O ferry to Lantau Island, and Guo Mi was among them. There were more than 300 people on the boat, more than half of them Buddhists, so the Master told Guo Mi to speak the Dharma on board. The topic the Master gave was "One, two, three, four, five, six, seven, eight, nine, ten." Guo Mi did as he was told and spoke with unobstructed eloquence, and the listeners were full of praise. Afterwards the Master said to Guo Mi, "You spoke very movingly, but it's a pity you're so short; people don't notice you or take you seriously. It would be good if you were a bit taller!" After the Master said this, Guo Mi grew three inches in one week.

[Addendum 2] Upasika Tan Guo Shi recounted:

I went to America at the end of 1957. Before I left, I transferred to a Catholic school and was in the same class as Guo Mi. At that time Guo Mi was very short. In the 1970s, when the Master returned to Hong Kong from America for the first time, I went back with him, and when I saw Guo Mi then, he was already taller than the Master. He was working on a cruise ship that sailed between Hong Kong and Australia.

72. Unforgettable Kindness

In those turbulent times, although the Venerable Master was unable to return to Yunmen to be near Elder Hsu again, he often exchanged letters with Elder Hsu

and supported Elder Hsu with all his heart and strength. Below are letters from Elder Hsu:

To the Benevolent One, To Lun, for your wise perusal:

Yesterday Guang Miao came up the mountain bringing a great deal of gold leaf. Apart from the HK$1,500 that you, Benevolent One, kindly contributed as a meritorious donation, HK$1,298.40 of the price is still owing. You earlier resolved to have a statue of Amitabha Buddha made, so I very much hope that you will hand over the amount owing, HK$1,300, to Guang Miao. I would be most obliged. Furthermore, this monastery is now in urgent need of funds for construction, and I very much hope that you, Benevolent One, will continue to resolve to support it. I also hope that when it is convenient you will lead overseas Chinese laypeople on a visit to the mountain. This is my hope. With this I wish you

Dharma joy.

Hsu Yun

Zhenru Chan Monastery, Mount Yunju, the second day of the fourth month

To Dharma Master To Lun, for your perusal in the Way:

Several years have suddenly passed since we parted, and I often think of you. Some time ago the layperson Guo wrote to say that your Dharma work in Hong Kong is flourishing, which greatly comforts me! Just now Taiping Lotus Lodge in Guangdong forwarded your kind letter, together with your gift of HK$600, and I was glad to learn of everything. Your resolve is extraordinary: you are restoring an ancient monastery, and you have also kept us in mind from afar and kindly given meritorious donations. I cannot help sighing at how rare this is. It is now almost three years since I, Yun, came to Yunju and built a thatched hut. This too is a famous Way-place of the patriarchs in this country, but it had long lain in ruins, its halls completely reduced to rubble. After I came here, monks from all over heard of it and came too, so the year before last we managed to build a Dharma hall to house the assembly so they could dwell in peace. This spring we are building the Buddha Hall, the Hall of the Heavenly Kings, and other structures. But our means are very strained; the resident assembly numbers over a hundred, and provisions for the Way are also hard to come by. Your Dharma affinities are very extensive, and I very much hope you will do your best to help us and bring this meritorious work to completion. That would be most fortunate! As for what you said about making more than ten holy images, these are all extraordinary deeds. But as for making an image of me, how could I deserve it? That is quite out of the question! Please don't do so! You are earnest for the sake of the Dharma and continue the wisdom-life of the Buddhas and Patriarchs, so your wish should be fulfilled. Enclosed I send the lineage record, so that you may carry on the patriarchal line and the Way of the Patriarchs may be revived through it. This is my utmost hope! This reply cannot say all. With this I wish you

Dharma bliss.

With palms joined, the patched-robed Yun, the ninth day of the fourth month

Letterhead of Zhenru Chan Monastery, Mount Yunju

In the Venerable Master's own words:

The Elder wrote asking me to do meritorious deeds, so I vowed to donate a dozen or so images, such as the Buddha images for the Jeweled Hall of the Great Hero, to Zhenru Chan Monastery on Mount Yunju. I also went to Burma to buy gold leaf to gild the Buddha images: more than 300 boxes of gold leaf in all (large boxes at that). The Elder was very pleased and wrote several times to thank me. This shows how deep and far-reaching his regard for the younger generation was. In his humble virtue he never let up; he was sparing toward himself and generous toward others, and he set aside his own way to follow others. His great spirit, unsurpassed compassion, lofty virtue, and utterly true equality won people's heartfelt and sincere admiration. He also wrote summoning me to Yunju. In my Chan contemplation I knew that he wished to entrust me with the heavy responsibility of Zhenru Monastery, but because of various causes and conditions I was unable to answer his call, which I regret deeply to this day. And once I had established the Buddhist Lecture Hall, I was busy all day long propagating the great Dharma, and I felt all the more that I could not split myself in two. I had intended to put affairs fully in order and entrust them to someone, and then go back to be near the Elder and serve at his side...

73. The Dhuta Left Speechless

Once, a dhuta with long hair down to his shoulders, who had burned off a finger, came to the Buddhist Lecture Hall to visit the Venerable Master. The Venerable Master said to him, "Dharma Master, I have the first line of a couplet. If you can match it, I'll call you a seasoned cultivator."...

The Venerable Master went on, "If you can't match it, I'll call you an old demon king. Listen! 'White and water make a spring; within, one and great make heaven.'" For half an hour the old dhuta scratched his head and ears but couldn't match it, so the Venerable Master spoke a verse to admonish him. (Editor's note: The original text has been lost; it is translated here freely from the English rendering.)

> *Old demon king with tangled hair and grimy face,*
> *Everywhere you go, you set people gossiping.*
> *In the end, will you let go or not?*
> 蓬頭垢面老魔王 到處令人說短長 究竟放下不放下

Why did the Venerable Master give him such a hard time? Because when this dhuta first came to Hong Kong, he went around proclaiming that he was the teacher of Elder Master Hsu Yun. Many of Elder Hsu's disciples believed it was true, and so they supported him and made offerings to him.

In the Venerable Master's own words:

A man came to Hong Kong with long hair and a long beard, looking very scruffy. When people said, "I've taken refuge with Elder Master Hsu Yun," he would say, "Oh! He's my disciple." When Elder Hsu came to Hong Kong, his refuge disciples said, "Our Grand Master is now..." Elder Hsu said, "Who is your Grand Master?" "So-and-so—he says he's your teacher!" Elder Hsu just smiled and said nothing. When I was in Hong Kong, there was also someone who passed himself off as my teacher, though I didn't even know him. So in Buddhism there are plenty of strange people and strange happenings.

[Addendum 1] Coming up with a good matching line for a couplet is certainly not easy, but composing a good first line is even harder. Take this first line, "White and water make a spring; within, one and great make heaven": it is a character-splitting puzzle, and it also subtly contains a Chan meaning. The first two characters, "white" and "water," must combine to form the third character, "spring"; and the fifth and sixth characters, "one" and "great," combine again to form the last character, "heaven."

[Addendum 2] Professor Yang Fusen recounted on August 14, 1995:

Once, in a class on couplets, the Master said, "I'll give you a first line, and we'll see whether you can match it with a second line." I nodded in agreement. The Master said that the first line was: "White and water make a spring; within, one and great make heaven."

I immediately grasped that the cleverness of this first line lay in taking the two characters "spring" and "heaven," splitting them apart, and then putting them together into a line. The second line would have to do the same.

So I immediately wrote down the four characters for "mountain," "stone," "crag," and "below" as the first half of the second line. To match "one" in the first line, I thought of the number "two." Then it suddenly occurred to me to use the character "husband," because "husband" and "heaven" are almost identical: "heaven" is made up of "one" and "great," and "husband" should be made up of "two" and "man." But how could I match "one, great, heaven"?

While I was still pondering it, the Master, watching from the side, knew I was stuck, and couldn't help giving me a hint: "Wouldn't 'two, man, husband' do it?" Suddenly it dawned on me: "two, man, husband" means "the husband of two people," which matches "one, great, heaven" perfectly. So I was the first one present to hand in an answer, and the couplet became:

> *White and water make a spring; within, one and great make heaven,*
> 白水泉中一大天，
>
> *Mountain and stone make a crag; below, two and man make husband.*
> 山石巖下二人夫。

The Master looked at it, nodded, and smiled without a word.

74. The Brahma Net, Layer upon Layer

In 1958 the Venerable Master invited Dharma Master Sheng Yi to lecture on the *Brahma Net Bodhisattva Precepts Sutra* and the *Vajra Sutra* at the Hong Kong Buddhist Lecture Hall, over a period of three months. The couplet inside the Buddhist Lecture Hall reads:

> *The Brahma Net, layer upon layer: the Buddhas of the ten directions transmit the mind-ground;*
>
> 梵網重重十方諸佛傳心地
>
> *Its sound, clear and distinct: all living beings awaken to the heaven of their nature.*
>
> 聲音了了一切眾生悟性天

—Composed and inscribed by To Lun, a Bhikshu in the mountains

[Addendum 1] *Wah Kiu Man Po*, Friday, January 2, 1959 (the twenty-third day of the eleventh month of the wuxu year):

Buddhist Lecture Hall Holds Lectures on the *Vajra Sutra*

Dharma Master To Lun, abbot of the Buddhist Lecture Hall on the 12th floor of Yu Yuen Mansion, Happy Valley, together with many Buddhist devotees, has respectfully invited Chan Master Sheng Yi to come down from the mountain to the Hall to expound the Buddhadharma and lecture on the entire *Vajra Prajna Paramita Sutra*. The lectures began on the evening of the nineteenth day of this lunar month and are held every evening from 7:30 to 9:00. People from all walks of life are welcome to come and listen and share in the benefits of the Dharma.

[Addendum 2] From *A Brief Biography of Elder Master Sheng Yi*, published by Po Lam Monastery:

At the Buddhist Lecture Hall run by Dharma Master To Lun, Master Sheng Yi lectured on the *Brahma Net Bodhisattva Precepts Sutra* and the *Vajra Sutra*.

[Addendum 3] Elder Dharma Master Sheng Yi, the retired abbot of Po Lam Monastery on Lantau Island, Hong Kong, passed away peacefully on August 3, 2010. Elder Dharma Master Sheng Yi was a native of Xinhui in Guangdong. He lived to the age of 92, had been a monastic for 69 years, and had held the precepts for 67 autumns. Besides restoring Po Lam Monastery, Elder Sheng Yi served from 1983 to 1990 as the fourth-generation abbot of Po Lin Monastery at Ngong Ping. In March 1958, at the age of 36, he went to Mount Yunju to pay his respects to Elder Hsu, received the mind seal, and was given the name Xuan Xuan, becoming a ninth-generation heir to the Dharma lineage of the Weiyang school. His Verse of Certification says [Tr.: The four lines begin with the characters of the names Xuan Xuan and Sheng Yi.]:

> *Proclaiming and spreading the wondrous meaning, he carries on the ancestral school;*
> *Mystery upon mystery, traces vanish, and all affairs merge and fuse.*
>
> 宣宏妙義繼先宗　玄玄泯跡事镕融

Sagely understanding and worldly feelings are but shadows of flowers in the sky;
Let him be one who roams free and at ease.
聖解凡情空花影 一任逍遙自在人

75. Dharma Master Heng Yi

Bhikshuni Heng Yi (Dharma name Guo Li) was born in 1924; her ancestral home was Shunde County in Guangdong Province. In 1954 she went to Cixing Monastery on Lantau Island to study the Buddhadharma. After taking refuge with the Venerable Master, she worked hard at clearing land and growing crops...

In 1961, deeply distressed by the shortage of hands, she got gasoline and rice straw ready, intending to burn herself on Amitabha Buddha's birthday. Fortunately the Venerable Master became aware of it, and on the day before Amitabha's birthday he told her to come down the mountain. The Venerable Master asked her, "When the fire burns your body, will you run or not?" She replied, "Heaven knows! I've never been burned before." The Venerable Master told her to let it go and go recite the Buddha's name, and to stop farming.

That day she happened to come across a copy of the *Treatise on the Vajra Mind Dharani* and read Chan Master Zuyuan's section on the ten demons that disturb the proper; only then did she recognize her own demonic obstacle. So she decided to shave her head and leave the home-life at Western Bliss Gardens Monastery on the day of Amitabha's birthday. In the early days after she left home, Dharma Master Heng Yi missed her lay father very much. The Venerable Master instructed her, "Amitabha Buddha is your father!" At that one word from a good teacher, she woke as if from a dream and suddenly understood. From then on she devoted her thoughts wholeheartedly to her Dharma family, and for the rest of her life she supported the Way-places.

In September 1963, Po Lin Monastery held a Triple Platform Ordination, and the Venerable Master had Dharma Master Heng Yi take part in this transmission of the precepts, and so she became a Bhikshuni.

Dharma Master Heng Yi's own account, September 25, 2000:

I was at Cixing Monastery for such a long time, and I didn't know I would leave the home-life; I only knew to help the Master with the work. It was the Master who brought me across to leave home! When the Master told me to leave home, I didn't know that the Master wanted me to leave home. At that time I was afflicted, and only when I read about the ten demonic obstacles in the *Treatise on the Vajra Mind Dharani* did I realize that this obstacle of mine was a demonic obstacle, and then I thought of leaving home. The Master said, "I didn't know you wanted to leave home either." I said, "You're my Master, and you didn't know I was going to leave home? Then what did I bow to you as my Master for?" Then the Master asked me, "When do you want to leave home? I'll give you three

dates to choose from: Amitabha Buddha's birthday, Guanyin's birthday, or Shakyamuni Buddha's birthday."

I shaved my head and left home at 37, and received the precepts at 39 (in September). After I left home I stopped farming and recited the Buddha's name. The year after I left home, in February, the Master went to America. The Master brought me to the Hong Kong Buddhist Lecture Hall and wouldn't let me go back to Cixing Monastery; he wanted me to stay at the Hong Kong Buddhist Lecture Hall. I hadn't realized that, as soon as I had left home, the Master was going to leave. That year, when the Master was about to leave Hong Kong for America, I cried so hard I nearly fainted. The Master said to me then, "You've just left home, and I'm going away. I'm afraid that after I've gone, you'll change your mind and give up the monastic life." I told the Master, "I won't change my mind. I still have kindness to repay: I have to repay the Buddha's kindness and my teacher's kindness. I have to repay your kindness, Shifu!"

We accompanied the Master all the way to see him off on his flight, and the whole way the Master kept saying he was afraid we would change our minds, because there was someone else who had also left home under the Master, who was still very young then. Once the Master went to America, he was gone for 11 years; only after 11 years did he come back to Hong Kong.

At that time it was very hard for the Master to establish Way-places in America; he had nothing at all, so I saved up supplies and sent them to the Master. Now the Master has built so many Way-places, and you must resolve to support them! Don't be afraid of hardship! Don't let the Master's painstaking efforts go to waste.

Dharma Master Heng Yi's own account, September 26, 2000:

Back then, when I was clearing the fields at Cixing Monastery, I accidentally killed a lot of earthworms while digging. One day I saw a great many earthworms come to demand my life in payment. I said to them, "I didn't mean to kill you when I was digging; I couldn't see you. If you want to take my life now, then go ahead, but please let me tell my fellow cultivators first. When I come back, you can come for my life!" So I told my fellow cultivators about it, and when I came back, I said to the earthworms who had come for my life, "Come on!" Then I saw them, their whole bodies glowing, circle three times above my head, and then they flew out the window and were gone.

There was also a kind of insect that ate only flowers and leaves. Because its head was red and its body black, it was called the "Red-Headed Army." They often came to eat the flowers and leaves. We caught them and took them several hills away, but they came running back; we sent them away and they came back again, always like that. Each time, we caught them in cans, mooncake tins, and boxes like that, and then took them away to liberate them. The Master once taught us to recite the Great Compassion Mantra to tell them not to come, but that didn't work either; they always came back. As long as there was something to eat, no matter what you did to them, they wouldn't leave. Later, when the

Master came back to Cixing Monastery, he asked me to take him around the fields to have a look. At the edge of the fields, the Master nudged the cans there with his foot and asked me what they were. I said they were Red-Headed Army. The Master opened them and saw that they were all full of dead Red-Headed Army insects. The Master asked why we hadn't liberated them. I answered the Master, "Sometimes when we're too busy we forget." The Master said, "These past few nights, tens upon tens of thousands of Red-Headed Army insects have been at the head of my bed, weeping and complaining that you killed them." The Master had us kneel before Guanyin Bodhisattva and repent. While we were repenting, I saw many Red-Headed Army insects and other insects and ants appear, and we prayed to Guanshiyin Bodhisattva to rescue them to rebirth. That was a fault committed knowingly.

[Addendum] Supplementary account by Bhikshu Dharma Master Heng Xing, September 26, 2000:

When Dharma Master Heng Yi and the others were farming, they piled up a lot of rice straw and burned it to make fertilizer, intending to use the burned straw as fertilizer. Who would have thought that for a moment they couldn't keep watch over it, and the fire got completely out of control. In the end it burned several hillsides and killed many animals and insects. When the Master found out, he said, "You've created bad karma again!"

Dharma Master Heng Yi's own account, September 26, 2000:

I remember that once when I was small, I chased a cat away, and it accidentally fell from the second floor and died. After I took refuge I had many spiritual responses. Not long after taking refuge, my chest started to hurt badly. Later the Master saw a cat whose body was glowing, clawing at my chest. The Master asked me whether I had ever killed a cat. I said no, but I remembered chasing a cat away; maybe when I chased it away, it fell from the second floor and was killed. Afterwards the Master rescued it to rebirth.

Dharma Master Heng Yi's own account, January 7, 2001:

When I left the home-life, a snake came to settle accounts with me, because once when I was farming, I dug into a snake's nest and accidentally sliced a snake into three pieces, killing it. While I was sitting in meditation, the snake emitted light and circled me three times, coming to settle accounts with me. I explained to it that I had been farming at the time and had no intention of harming it, and I repented to it. Then the snake went away.

Another time, at New Year, the Master told me not to beat the ox. I said, "But the ox won't move if I don't beat it!" The Master said, "Don't beat it. In the past it was an official; now it's an ox plowing the fields. Look, sometimes it even kneels on one knee. It's already repenting, so don't beat it." So I explained to the ox that I beat it because it wouldn't work, but we had to plow the land and grow vegetables in order to have food to eat; I didn't mean to beat it. After that the ox became obedient.

Dharma Master Heng Yi's own account, September 26, 2000:

The Master said to me, "I don't know how long I've been looking for you."

One day I saw a very dirty monk come out from the cattle pen. I knew this was the Master.

Dharma Master Heng Yi's own account, January 7, 2001:

Why did I leave the home-life? It was while we were holding ten Buddha Recitation sessions. During the sixth session, the Master sent someone to tell me to come down the mountain to Hong Kong. I said, "Let me finish the ten Buddha Recitation sessions first, and then we'll see!" After I finished the ten sessions, while I was sitting in meditation, I saw a bird appear, and it told me to go buy gasoline to burn myself to death. I also watched it being burned to death, and from then on I planned to burn myself to seek liberation. That day I went down the mountain to see the Master, and I happened to come across a copy of the *Treatise on the Vajra Mind Dharani* with the ten demonic obstacles written by Chan Master Zuyuan. It mentioned my very kind of demonic obstacle. I knew I had an obstacle from past lives, and I got rid of it right away, and then I left the home-life. At that time I was very busy every day, and I had never read or studied any other scriptures. I don't know how I happened to come across this book that day; I think the Master was helping me. If the Master hadn't sent someone to call me down the mountain and told me that he knew my situation, I'm afraid I would already have burned myself to death.

The method of cultivation the Master taught me was to sit in meditation every day for the time of three sticks of incense. That way I could become a Buddha in ten years. But my mind wasn't settled, so I still haven't become a Buddha.

[Addendum 1] Bhikshuni Dharma Master Jin Run recounted:

Because Dharma Master Heng Yi was very old and in poor health, I was sent to Hong Kong to take care of her. When the Venerable Master came to America, he entrusted her with looking after the three Way-places in Hong Kong. She usually spent most of her time at Cixing Monastery up on the mountain. Life on the mountain was very inconvenient, transportation was poor, and there were large fields on the mountain that she had to tend. She was very strong and could wield a very big hoe to till the fields. Once she carried a very big, heavy refrigerator up the mountain, and she was much faster than the rest of us. After she got up the mountain she even cooked a meal, and only after the meal was cooked did the laypeople behind her arrive. While I was looking after her, she told me many of her stories.

When I first went there, Dharma Master Liang told me that in the very early days, Dharma Master Heng Yi did seven Great Compassion Repentances a day, as well as 20,000 recitations of the Buddha's name. She was always farming, and she made use of that time, and of the time going up and down the mountain, to recite the Buddha's name. She spoke very little, especially when she was older, so I could only learn from her conduct and bearing. She was a very good

model for me. Although I went there to take care of her, I can say that she took care of me more than I took care of her; she was very concerned about my health and my cultivation.

Dharma Master Heng Yi was very tall and sturdy. She was very genuine, very plain and simple, and very patient. Her vigorous cultivation and her sense of responsibility moved me, and so I respected her. She taught each of us cultivators to talk less; to do the recitation services in the Buddha Hall, and to work diligently at the Way-place; and to be honest and down-to-earth and not keep running outside, because when we go out, our minds become scattered.

I remember that Dharma Master Heng Yi's cremation was held at Elder Master Sheng Yi's Po Lam Monastery. The Dharma Master in charge of the cremation furnace said that in all the time she had been doing this work, she had never seen anyone whose fire burned so brightly and so densely. She also said that from the way the fire burned, one could tell that Dharma Master Heng Yi was a cultivator of hidden practices. Po Lam Monastery specially offered her a very thick, large piece of sandalwood, about the height of a big tree, which was placed beside the coffin and burned together with it at the cremation.

[Addendum 2] In the second year after Dharma Master Heng Yi left the home-life, the Venerable Master went to America to propagate the Proper Dharma. At that time only she and a few nuns lived in the Hong Kong Way-places. The Venerable Master worried that their resolve for the Way might not be firm enough. Dharma Master Heng Yi said, "Shifu, don't worry. We won't retreat!"

The Venerable Master had three Way-places in Hong Kong, and Cixing Chan Monastery in particular had many places that needed rebuilding, repair, and upkeep. Usually, as soon as she finished her daily recitations, she went out to work, reciting the Buddha's name as she worked; in addition she had to lead Dharma assemblies. The hardship involved is not hard to imagine. Even when she was advanced in years, on the birthdays of the Buddhas and Bodhisattvas she would come down the mountain to the Buddhist Lecture Hall in Happy Valley to attend the Dharma assemblies. Every time she returned from Happy Valley to Cixing Monastery, she had to carry daily supplies weighing over a hundred catties on her back onto the ferry, change to a bus, walk more than ten li of mountain path, and climb over a hundred stone steps to get back to Cixing Monastery. In this way she lived at Cixing Chan Monastery for more than 40 years.

[Addendum 3] Dharma Master Heng Yi passed away peacefully on December 28, 2004 (the seventeenth day of the eleventh lunar month), Amitabha Buddha's birthday. She was the Venerable Master's first female monastic disciple to receive full ordination; her Dharma name was Guo Li, and her Dharma title Heng Yi. Therefore all the female monastic disciples whom the Venerable Master accepted after he came to America honored her as their eldest Dharma sister. After the Dharma Master passed away there were a great many elegiac couplets; only a few are selected here as a sample.

Elegiac couplet 1 [Tr.: These couplets weave in her names (Guo Li, "fruit of benefit"; Heng Yi, "constant benefit") and the names Ling Wui Shan and Cixing.]:

Guo Li, of keen roots and nature:
Her benefit runs throughout Ling Wui Shan,
Her benefit gathers where spirit and grace converge;
All sentient beings of the ten directions look up to her.
果利根性 利貫靈會山 利集靈秀會聚 十方有情皆仰止

Heng Yi, ever benefiting living beings:
Her benefit shines clear through Cixing Monastery,
Her benefit adds to the ship of compassion and the flourishing of the teaching;
There is nowhere in the three realms the wheel does not turn.
恆益眾生 益澈慈興寺 益增慈航興教 三界無處不轉輪

Elegiac couplet 2: With respectful condolences

Guo Li, whose fruits benefited the altars and halls:
A lifetime of practice and upholding, her merit and virtue complete;
果利壇宇 一生行持功德滿

Heng Yi, ever benefiting living beings:
The Three Sages come to receive and guide her, amid the fragrance of sandalwood.
恆益眾生 三聖接引旃檀熏

Elegiac couplet 3: In memory of our eldest Dharma sister, Dharma Master Heng Yi, who has returned to the West

Thirty years ago,
A newly ordained one first visited the Buddhist Lecture Hall,
And was amazed to see our elder Dharma sister's unbending backbone;
三十年前 新戒子初訪佛教講堂 驚見釋兄硬骨

An instant later,
Our old fellow cultivator has indeed returned to the Land of Ultimate Bliss,
Forever a model for those who come after.
一剎那後 老同參果歸極樂世界 永為晚輩楷模

76. Achievements of Eight Years

Western Bliss Gardens was completed at the end of 1951, and its Opening-the-Light ceremony was held on the Buddha's birthday in 1952. From then on the Venerable Master lectured on the sutras and spoke the Dharma there every day, held all kinds of Dharma assemblies, and transmitted the Three Refuges, the five precepts, and the precepts for the deceased, using skillful expedient means to draw in living beings. The Guanyin Dharma assembly of 1958...

Instructional talks by the Venerable Master during the Guanyin session at Western Bliss Gardens Monastery in 1958

Morning of the thirteenth day of the sixth lunar month, wuxu year (excerpt):

The consistent aim of Western Bliss Gardens has always been to promote the "Pure Land Dharma door" and to urge everyone to recite the Buddha's name vigorously. Therefore every year, on the nineteenth day of the sixth lunar month and the seventeenth day of the eleventh lunar month, we routinely hold recitation assemblies: a Guanyin session and an Amitabha Buddha session. But you mustn't just "attend as a matter of routine," going through the motions carelessly and leaving it at that; you should be more vigorous each year than the year before. Keep it constantly in mind: during these seven days, everywhere and at every moment, you should diligently recite the Bodhisattva's name and not be lax.

We should be mindful of the Bodhisattva, rather than making the Bodhisattva mindful of us. Why do I say we shouldn't make the Bodhisattva mindful of us? Because during this session, if you're taking part in the session in name only, with scattered thoughts swarming, and not diligently reciting Guanyin's great name, then the greatly kind and greatly compassionate Bodhisattva will surely feel sorry for you, pitiful living being that you are, and worry because you are not sincere in the session. So everyone should recite with utmost sincerity, and further, should have a heart of kindness, compassion, joy, and giving. If you can do this, I can say with certainty: "The Bodhisattva will definitely aid every one of you!"

Moreover, Western Bliss Gardens has never sent an invitation card to anyone; everyone comes to the session of their own accord. This shows that you are not lacking in sincerity, and this spirit of coming of your own accord is very praiseworthy. That being so, all the more we shouldn't let this sincerity go to waste. We should all vow to recite until "the water recedes and the rocks appear," until the Bodhisattva appears in person and speaks the Dharma; only then will we not have taken part in this session in vain.

Today is the first day of the session. On this opening day, I wish you all in advance some accomplishment this year. Otherwise, I'm going to settle accounts with you all, and if the accounts can't be squared, don't come to regret it! I won't say any more idle words; let's recite the Bodhisattva's great name a few more times!

Afternoon of the thirteenth day of the sixth lunar month (excerpt):

In this hot weather, you've all braved the heat and, undaunted by the high mountain and the long road, hurried here to take part in the session. What benefit is there in it, after all? The real benefit can't be put into words. It's like drinking water: only the drinker knows whether it's cold or warm. Only those with a true mind can naturally comprehend the wonder of it.

How can you obtain the benefit? It's nothing else but this: as I said just now, you need only recite the Bodhisattva's name with a true mind. A true mind, in other words, is a concentrated mind. As the saying goes, "Concentration brings efficacy; division brings obscurity." If you can be single-minded, then naturally the response and the Way will intersect. The power of this intersection of the response and the Way is inconceivable. But you have to apply the effort yourself; no one else can do it for you, and still less can you count on luck.

During these seven days we also recite the Great Compassion Mantra. The merit and virtue of the Great Compassion Mantra is inconceivable. Without considerable good roots, you couldn't easily get to hear even the three words "Great Compassion Mantra." Now you are not only able to hear its name, but also able to receive, uphold, read, and recite it, which shows that all of you have great good roots, having planted good roots in the times of many Buddhas. Since you have great good roots, you must not lightly let this life pass in vain.

I remember that when we first held sessions at Western Bliss Gardens, eight or nine out of ten laypeople couldn't recite the Great Compassion Mantra. But now, more than eight out of ten can recite it. This is a marked improvement on the part of you laypeople.

The *Great Compassion Heart Dharani Sutra* says, "Those who recite and uphold the Great Compassion Mantra can dispel all difficulties: fire will not burn them, and water will not drown them." So I urge the laypeople who can already recite it to recite it at least three times every day, and those who can't yet should hurry to learn it. The merit and virtue of reciting the Great Compassion Mantra not only drives off thieves and robbers, but also cures a hundred illnesses and quells all demonic difficulties, so we should recite and uphold it sincerely.

On this opening day of the session, the atmosphere of the Dharma assembly is very good, and everyone is taking it very seriously. I hope you will keep up your efforts and strive to be even more vigorous!

Morning of the nineteenth day of the sixth lunar month (excerpt):

Today is the day the Bodhisattva attained the Way. Although Western Bliss Gardens is built on a mountain, up more than 300 steps, people have turned out in great numbers to take part in the session. This shows that everyone who has come to celebrate the birthday has a true mind and is courageously vigorous.

In terms of numbers, over these eight years the number of people taking part in the session has grown year by year. What's more, many people who have come here to bow to the Buddhas say that everything has gone more smoothly for them than before. For example, ever since Upasika Yuan Guo Lin started coming to Western Bliss Gardens, business has been especially prosperous. Upasaka Tan Guo Pu, after taking refuge, has also increased his blessings and prolonged his life; he is over 80 this year, yet his health is still excellent. There was also someone with bad legs who could not walk from the age of four until nine, but after bowing to the Buddhas here was able to walk. Besides that, Upasaka Li Guo Yuan's daughter injured her leg in a fall, and neither Chinese nor Western

doctors nor bonesetters could cure it, but after bowing to the Buddhas it healed too. So some people have spread the rumor that I can cure illnesses. In fact, it's nothing more than the merit and virtue of bowing to the Buddhas.

Today everyone is so happy and so enthusiastic, but such a grand gathering doesn't happen often; it won't be held again until next year. For next year's Guanyin session, please come early. Moreover, you should vow to attend the full seven days. And at the Amitabha Buddha session in the eleventh month, you should also be courageously vigorous, and you must not be lax or lazy.

[Addendum 1] *Nature Daily* (*Ziran Ribao*), Thursday, December 18, 1958 (the eighth day of the eleventh month of the wuxu year):

Amitabha Buddha's Birthday: Dharma Master To Lun Lectures on a Sutra

(Special report) The seventeenth day of the eleventh lunar month is the anniversary of Amitabha Buddha's birthday. To bring salvation to people everywhere, Dharma Master To Lun, a native of Jilin Province, will hold a Buddha-recitation assembly for a full week, from the eleventh to the seventeenth, at the Buddha hall of Western Bliss Gardens at the hilltop of Ma Shan Village, Shau Kei Wan, and will lecture on the Mahayana *Amitabha Sutra*. Devotees are welcome to come and hear the sutra.

[Addendum 2] *Wah Kiu Yat Po*, Sunday, December 21, 1958 (the eleventh day of the eleventh month of the wuxu year):

Buddhist Lecture Hall Transmitted the Three Refuges Yesterday; Western Bliss Gardens Begins Amitabha Session Today

At the request of Buddhists, Dharma Master To Lun, abbot of the Buddhist Lecture Hall on the 12th floor of Yu Yuen Mansion, Happy Valley, transmitted the Three Refuges at the Hall yesterday at 2:00 p.m. Those who took refuge included (list omitted). At Western Bliss Gardens, Ma Shan Village, Sai Wan Ho, Dharma Master To Lun, beginning yesterday evening, led elders of the various monasteries, such as Dharma Masters Fa Yun and Ru Xiu, in perfuming the altar and purifying it by sprinkling. From this morning an Amitabha session Dharma assembly is being held for seven consecutive days. With this merit and virtue, they pray for world peace and the happiness of humankind. All are welcome to rejoice and share in the benefits of the Dharma.

77. A Maze Hard to Escape

During his time in Hong Kong, the Venerable Master put all his heart and strength into training a group of young disciples who were only in their early teens. In their spare time after school, he taught them culture and history, sutra study and mantra recitation, Chan meditation and sitting, translation and public speaking. Whether it was...

...the wonderful principles of the sutras, moral cultivation, or the rules for disciples relying on a teacher and the small details of daily life, the Venerable Master spared no effort in guiding them with expedient means. In those years

the Venerable Master exhorted them earnestly and patiently, combining strictness with kindness, in the hope of fostering a group of successors who would cultivate wholeheartedly, have penetrating wisdom, and stand tall between heaven and earth, and so of preparing a group of pillars for Buddhism. However, faced with the glitter and Westernization of Hong Kong, how many could truly awaken to the real meaning of life and not be deluded by the vain dust of the world, willing to cast off the illusions of the dust and return to the original simplicity and truth?

One disciple took refuge with the Venerable Master when she was about 14 or 15. Her good roots were deep, and she cultivated seriously, so she made amazingly rapid progress and often had extraordinary states. When she was about to get married, the Venerable Master, lamenting how hard it is to save living beings, wrote two verses on the night of August 1, 1958 (the sixteenth day of the sixth lunar month):

> *Rising early and retiring late, for whom am I so busy?*
> *Living beings are so hard to save—it's truly heartbreaking.*
> 夙興夜寐為誰忙？眾生難度頗堪傷。
>
> *Lost in the wearisome dust, their natures turned upside down;*
> *I take them by the ear and earnestly exhort them, yet find no way to transform them.*
> 迷諸塵勞性顛倒，耳提諄諄化無方。
>
> *Glory in a dream—what is there to rejoice in?*
> *Riches and rank before your eyes are not real either.*
> 夢裡榮華何足喜，眼前富貴亦非真，
>
> *Why are the foolish always so deluded,*
> *Living drunk and dying in a dream? Truly pitiful.*
> 緣何癡人總迷昧，醉生夢死實堪憐。

In the Venerable Master's own words:

There's someone who used to be a little layperson and now (1971) has become a big layperson. He took refuge with me when he was in elementary school, and after that he always wanted to see Shifu. If his mother didn't bring him to see me, he'd get angry at home and cry. As for him, if he hadn't taken refuge with the Triple Jewel back then, he would certainly have become a bandit when he grew up. It's because he took refuge with the Triple Jewel that he didn't become a bandit.

One of my American monastic disciples said to me, "I've been a monastic for over two years, and I haven't accomplished anything." Look at this disciple of mine who took refuge as a child. He originally wanted to leave the home-life, yet decades have gone by and he hasn't accomplished anything. Compared with him, how are you doing? Maybe he saw that there were so many Westerners in America who hadn't left home, and thought, "I'll wait for them!" So he still hasn't left home, and he let all of you leave home first!

This disciple of mine who came from Hong Kong knows that gambling isn't proper, but probably because he hasn't had enough money since he got married, he went off to Reno (America's gambling city) to gamble, hoping to win a little money. As a result, not only did he not win any money, he wore himself out, and when he got home he had to sleep for a whole day, so he couldn't come to the sutra lecture today either. He's very intelligent, but he goes and does some muddled things. He used to say that marriage was a lot of trouble, and he was going to cultivate the Way as a lifelong celibate and never marry. Now he's married, and he's run right into that maze himself. Wouldn't you say that's foolish! Knowing something is wrong and not doing it is wisdom; knowing something is wrong and doing it anyway is foolishness. Like that, it's not easy to obtain the Five Eyes. If you want the causes and conditions for obtaining the Five Eyes, you must be very clear and very conscientious in what you do; you can't be casual and sloppy.

[Addendum 1] Upasika Tan Guo Shi recounted:

When we received the five precepts, the Master asked Dharma Master Sheng Huai to teach us how to kneel and bow, how to arrange our robes, and how to unfold the sitting cloth (the nishidana). Because we had all received the precepts, we all had the sash, the robe, and the sitting cloth. Our sitting cloths were the same as those used by monastics; only our sashes and robes were different. Every year when we celebrated the Master's birthday, the disciples used their sitting cloths to perform the great ceremony, fully unfolding the sitting cloth and bowing nine times. So after receiving the precepts, many of the Hong Kong disciples knew how to use the sitting cloth. We were young and loved the Buddhadharma so much that people often asked us, "Do you want to leave the home-life?" Several of us said, "We're all going to leave home someday!" I said too, "Yes, I want to!"

Once Guo Song asked the Master about her future, and the Master said she would become a very wealthy person. A few years later she married, and she really did become very wealthy. At that time I also asked about my prospects, and the Venerable Master told me that I would enjoy a life of quiet ease and wouldn't need to worry about making a living, but I wouldn't be as wealthy as Guo Song. My elder sister asked too at that time, and so did Guo Shu, but the Master didn't say any more. He only said, "Don't you have any other questions to ask?"

Guo Su was a few years older than me. She had very good roots and often entered samadhi and saw things, but unfortunately she didn't leave the home-life. Her family was very poor, and she didn't have many friends, but she and I were very close. After I went to America, I lost touch with her. When I came back to Hong Kong in the 1960s, she had already died, and I set up a memorial tablet for her to rescue her to rebirth. Her mother told me that not long after she married, she gave birth to a girl, and soon after that she passed away.

[Addendum 2] From the diary of Upasika Tan Guo Zheng:

After I came to America for university, the more than ten of us Dharma brothers and sisters who were close in age all went our separate ways: Huang Guo Jun and one of his elder sisters went to Africa, and Wen Guo Shu and Wen Guo Mi went to Australia. In the end, all of us dozen or so young disciples who used to gather around the Master in those days got married. I remember that the Master once explained the "Twelve Causes and Conditions" to me:

"Ignorance" is love and desire. From desirous thoughts, "activity" arises. From activity there is the awareness of "consciousness." From the not-yet-formed individual of "name and form," the "six entrances" of eye, ear, nose, tongue, body, and mind are produced. With the six entrances there is the chance of "contact," and with contact there is "feeling." When there are selfish thoughts of love, one must "grasp" and "possess" the other. Having emotional desire is ignorance beginning all over again, and so the cycle of birth and death is created.

Unfortunately, I let the Master's teachings go in one ear and out the other. Leaving the home-life truly takes firm faith and the determination to give up one's life for the Dharma. That is why the Master encouraged everyone to uphold the precepts strictly and avoid contact; then one can break the chain of the Twelve Causes and Conditions.

In 1961 my younger sister (Guo Shi) wrote to say that she was about to get married. I asked whether I should write to my sister, and the Master, composing on the spot, told me to write down the following verse:

> *It's long since a letter came from you;*
> *At the ends of the earth, my thoughts are with you.*
> 久未見來函，天涯任念懸。
>
> *Weary of travel, I've returned from Australia;*
> *Dharma affairs are many and complex.*
> 澳洲倦游歸，法務頗紛繁。
>
> *Now, through Muzhen's letter,*
> *I send you a few words.*
> 今因慕貞箋，聊以寄片言。
>
> *Esteeming the worthy can replace love of beauty;*
> *Following the Way can turn back heaven's course. [Tr.: The first line echoes a saying in the Analects; the second plays on the opening of the Tao Te Ching.]*
> 賢賢能易色，道道可回天。
>
> *At all times, be diligent and vigorous,*
> *So the Dharma's transformation pervades the billion worlds.*
> 時時勤精進，法化遍大千。

[Addendum 3] Upasika Tan Guo Zheng recounted on February 11, 2015:

Back at Western Bliss Gardens, there was a girl with us named Zhong Meiwei (Guo Jia), who was two years younger than me. She came to America to study around 1960 and soon got married. When the Master arrived in America in 1962, her husband was stationed far away in Texas for military service, so they had no way to be in touch with the Master, which they have always regretted. They once told me, "In the 1980s, when we had to choose one of three houses in different locations, we asked the Master for advice. The Master said, 'Buy the one in Millbrae.' We followed the Master's instructions, and now the house has gone up in value more than tenfold. Everything has gone smoothly for us living here." As they spoke, the couple's gratitude was plain to see.

As for the two sons of Lin Guo Sen (Dharma Master Jin Ci), the elder son went to England. When Dharma Master Jin Ci passed away, her elder son in England came specially to the City of the Dharma Realm to see his mother off on her final journey. As for Ah Ying, I have not been in touch since I left Hong Kong in 1968. Also, two sisters went to Taiwan with their parents. The elder sister, Xu Xiangjun, is still in Taipei, and when she comes to America she sometimes chats with us for a while; the younger sister, Xu Lijun, may still be in Australia, but we're not in touch.

In the early 1980s, Huang Guo Jun and his whole family immigrated to America and settled here. In 1993, with the Venerable Master's consent, he and some laypeople in Silicon Valley, such as Hu Dawen and Wang Hongyi, founded the Hearing, Contemplating, and Cultivating Lay Buddhist Society in San Jose, which still holds various activities today.

Huang Guo Song and her whole family also immigrated, at about the same time in the early 1980s, to Calgary (Canada), and later returned to settle in Hong Kong. Before the Venerable Master entered perfect stillness, she went to Los Angeles to pay her respects to him.

In 1982 Wen Guo Mi brought his two daughters to America to see the Master, and I saw Wen Guo Shu at the City of Ten Thousand Buddhas. In 1983 I saw Wen Guo Shu again in Hong Kong; after that, I don't know what became of her. Wen Guo Mi now lives in Australia. After the Venerable Master entered perfect stillness, he came to America and went to the City of Ten Thousand Buddhas to pay homage to the Venerable Master. Guo Jun and I met with him. Life is like a play; the past is too painful to look back on!

78. The Opening-the-Light Ceremony at the Lecture Hall

On March 1, 1959, an Opening-the-Light ceremony was held for the image of the Thousand-Handed, Thousand-Eyed Guanshiyin Bodhisattva of Great Kindness and Great Compassion enshrined in the Buddhist Lecture Hall. For three days before the Opening of the Light, the "Jeweled Repentance of the Medicine Master for Eradicating Disasters and Lengthening Life" was held, and for three days afterward the "Jeweled Great Compassion Repentance" was bowed...

In his 14 years in Hong Kong, the Venerable Master devoted himself to propagating the Buddhadharma and established three Way-places: in the winter of 1951 he founded Western Bliss Gardens Monastery; in 1954 he built Cixing Chan Monastery; and in 1956 he established the Buddhist Lecture Hall.

In the Venerable Master's own words:

I built several places in Hong Kong. Western Bliss Gardens Monastery in Shau Kei Wan faced north; Cixing Monastery on Lantau Island also faced north, with its back to the south; and the Buddhist Lecture Hall in Happy Valley also faced north. Now that I've come here to America, I thought that perhaps things would shift and change direction, but turn this way and that, it just won't turn around: now this Way-place faces north again. Ah! I think that, in some unseen way, this has a little to do with Guanyin Bodhisattva, because Guanyin Bodhisattva doesn't want to face south; the Bodhisattva sits facing north. Why does Guanyin Bodhisattva sit facing north? Because the people of the world don't know to turn back! They all just keep going forward and don't know to go back. So it is said, "Why does Guanyin of the Southern Sea sit facing backward? Because the people of the world will not turn back!" The Buddha faces south and Guanyin Bodhisattva faces north precisely because the people of this world are unwilling to turn back. "The sea of suffering is boundless; turn back, and there is the shore." But they won't turn back! So Guanshiyin Bodhisattva sits facing backward, hoping that living beings will awaken soon and turn back to the shore.

[Addendum 1] The lay Buddhist Hong Guo Hong's oral account, given on January 12, 2001, at the Hong Kong Buddhist Lecture Hall:

I am 75 this year. I took refuge with the Master at Western Bliss Gardens in 1954. We often went to the Buddhist Lecture Hall to hear the Master lecture on the sutras, and the Master also invited other Dharma Masters to come and lecture. I remember that when the Buddhist Lecture Hall held its Opening-the-Light ceremony, there was a vegetarian banquet of more than 30 tables at a vegetarian restaurant. We told the Master we were afraid there wouldn't be enough money to pay for it, and the Master said, "Don't worry!" It was truly wonderful: when it came time to settle the bill, there really was just exactly enough money to pay it.

[Addendum 2] *Wah Kiu Man Po*, Wednesday, February 25, 1959 (the eighteenth day of the first lunar month of the jihai year):

Buddhist Lecture Hall to Hold Opening Ceremony

Dharma Master To Lun, abbot of the Buddhist Lecture Hall on the 12th floor of Yu Yuen Mansion at the Happy Valley bus terminus, is an eminent disciple of Elder Master Hsu Yun of Nanhua Monastery in Shaoguan. Since he arrived in Hong Kong, ten years have passed in the blink of an eye. He founded Western Bliss Gardens Buddha Recitation Hall in Ma Shan Village, Sai Wan Ho, and Cixing Monastery at Man Cheung Po on Lantau Island. Since returning to Hong Kong after propagating the Dharma in Siam, with a view to expounding the

great Dharma and benefiting and bringing joy to living beings, he has established this Buddhist Lecture Hall in Happy Valley. He has repeatedly invited the Elders of the various monasteries, greatly virtuous ones of the ten directions, and eminent monks of various countries passing through Hong Kong to come and expound the essentials of the Dharma, in the hope that people from all walks of life will hear much of the Buddhadharma and understand the wonderful principle of True Suchness in the teaching bequeathed by Shakyamuni, the World Honored One. At the same time, the Hall has printed many kinds of tracts on the true meaning of Buddhism; they are not for sale, and all are welcome to take copies to read. The Hall will hold its opening ceremony on March 1 (that is, Sunday, the twenty-second day of the first lunar month), and has invited Elder Dharma Master Ding Xi to preside over the Opening-the-Light of the true-body image of the Thousand-Handed, Thousand-Eyed Guanshiyin Bodhisattva. A vegetarian meal will be served all day, with guests served as they arrive. People from all walks of life are welcome to attend.

[Addendum 3] *Wah Kiu Yat Po*, Monday, March 2, 1959 (the twenty-third day of the first lunar month of the jihai year):

Record of the Grand Opening of the Buddhist Lecture Hall, Yu Yuen Mansion, Happy Valley

Dharma Master Ding Xi Presides over the Opening-the-Light of the Thousand-Handed, Thousand-Eyed Guanyin

More Than 1,800 Faithful Devotees, Men and Women, Attend the Grand Event

(Special Report) The Buddhist Lecture Hall on the 12th floor of Yu Yuen Mansion in Happy Valley held its opening ceremony yesterday and invited the greatly virtuous Buddhist Elder Dharma Master Ding Xi to perform the Opening-the-Light ceremony for the Hall's newly sculpted image of the Thousand-Handed, Thousand-Eyed Guanshiyin Bodhisattva of Great Kindness and Great Compassion. The abbot, Dharma Master To Lun, laid on more than 100 tables and received distinguished guests from all walks of life and Buddhists all day long. The program began at 10:00 a.m.:

(1) All assembled in the Buddha hall and bowed three times; (2) purification by sprinkling: the "Willow Branch and Pure Water" praise, "Great Compassion Guanshiyin Bodhisattva" recited three times, the "Great Compassion Mantra" recited, and the *Heart Sutra* chanted, with "Maha Prajna Paramita" recited three times; (3) the Opening of the Light; (4) speeches; (5) praise to the Buddha; (6) praise to Guanyin; (7) the verse of dedication; (8) the meal offering; (9) bowing to the Buddha, followed by the vegetarian banquet.

(2) Mirror plaques, flower baskets, and gifts were sent from all quarters, a dazzling array; the rest is omitted.

[Addendum 4] A great many pieces of calligraphy were presented by people from all walks of life, but most of them have been damaged. A few of these pieces of calligraphy have been selected and are recorded below (omitted).

[Addendum 5] This image of the Thousand-Handed, Thousand-Eyed Guanshiyin Bodhisattva at the Buddhist Lecture Hall was made by the well-known sculptor Wang Taisheng. In the 1970s this Bodhisattva image and its shrine were moved from Hong Kong to Gold Mountain Sagely Monastery in San Francisco, USA. In the winter of 1983, when DRBA's Way-place in Vancouver was established, this Bodhisattva image, the shrine, and the altar table were respectfully moved again, from San Francisco to Gold Buddha Monastery, to receive offerings there, and from then on the Bodhisattva has resided there.

79. Praying for a Grandson to Carry On the Family Line

After Western Bliss Gardens was established, a laywoman, Mrs. Luo, often came to bow to the Buddha. Mrs. Luo's son had been married for many years without having any children, and she was anxious to hold a grandson in her arms, so time and again she asked the Venerable Master to grant her wish. Although she deeply believed that the Venerable Master could fulfill people's wishes to their hearts' content, she did not pass the test the Venerable Master gave her...

In the Venerable Master's own words:

I'll tell you about the filthiest thing I've ever done. I'm not afraid to tell it; anyway, you're all my disciples, and if you want to laugh at me, go right ahead. What was it?

When I was in Hong Kong, there was a woman surnamed Luo, whom people called Mrs. Luo; her family was very wealthy. After she took refuge with me, she was always coming to ask me to grant a wish. She would ask one time, and I wouldn't agree; she would ask another time, and I still wouldn't agree. What wish was she asking for? She wanted a grandson, because her son had been married for many years and still had no children. She wanted a grandson. One time she came again, just when I was washing my feet. In Hong Kong it wasn't so convenient to bathe, so sometimes I would wash my feet every three or five days, or perhaps once a week. When I had finished washing my feet, she knelt in front of me again to make her request, asking me to grant it. I said, "All right! Whatever you ask for, I'll fulfill your wish. But right now, can you drink this water I washed my feet in? If you can drink my footbath water, then whatever you ask for, I can fulfill your wish." I handed her the basin of footbath water and said, "Go on, drink it!"

And this time, what do you think happened? Right there on the spot, sweat broke out on her forehead. Sweating, she just knelt there, staring wide-eyed at this footbath water. Ah! It was so filthy; how could she drink it? "Shifu, you must be joking! It's so filthy, how could I drink it?" I said, "Well, are you going to drink it or not?" Sweat was pouring off her whole body, and she said, "You can tell me to do anything else, but this I can't do."

I said, "You can't do it? Then I'll do it!" I picked up the footbasin, a basin of water this big, and somehow or other I drank all of it, without leaving a drop. As soon as I drank it, she started crying and said, "Oh! How could you do that?" I

said, "Why couldn't I? For more than two years now you've been asking me for this: today asking for a grandson, tomorrow asking for a grandson again. Today I wanted to fulfill your wish, but you weren't sincere enough, so your hope of getting a grandson is gone. Don't ask me for it anymore from now on!"

When I finished speaking, she burst out sobbing, terribly regretful, and said, "What am I going to do?" I said, "There's no 'what am I going to do' about it. Whatever wishes you have, don't come asking me again. I asked you to do this one little thing and you couldn't even do it, so what's there to do? If you had drunk the water at first, you'd have gotten whatever you asked for; I'd have guaranteed that you'd get it. But now that's past, and even if you want to drink it now, there's no way to fulfill your wish." After that she would often start crying; she cried again and again, until my heart softened once more, and I said, "All right. Whether you drink it or not, I'll fulfill your wish. Go home, and before long you'll have a grandson!" Not long afterward, her daughter-in-law became pregnant, and sure enough she gave birth to a boy. At the time I didn't tell her what good would have come of drinking my footbath water; my aim was simply to fulfill her wish for a grandson. I wanted to use this method to see whether she really wanted a grandson, whether she had a bit of sincerity, and the experiment showed the result. Although she wasn't sincere, she cried so much that I had no way out, and I agreed to grant it after all.

Let me tell you: don't think I'm the same as you. The things I can do are things you can't do. Let me tell you something else: when I eat, whether it tastes good or bad, it all seems to me to be one flavor. I could even eat excrement and urine, simply because to me it's all one flavor. You say, "Ugh, this Dharma Master is too dirty and too smelly. We don't want to be near you anymore!" Amitabha! Whoever wants to stay far away from me, that's fine; whoever wants to slander me, that doesn't matter either. There's nothing good about me; I'm just the kind with no abilities. Do you understand now?

Let me say a bit more. Why can I eat things that taste so awful? Why can I drink water that is so impure? And after drinking it, I don't get sick. What's the reason? It's nothing else: it's just putting oneself aside and not feeling that one is drinking such foul, dirty water, so in the end there's no problem at all. If each of you can truly get rid of this "self," then there won't be any problems at all. If you want to give it a try, perhaps you too can attain this kind of state; if you don't want to try, that's no problem either. I absolutely won't force you; I won't force you to cultivate this method.

[Addendum] Upasika Tan Guo Shi recounted:

Mrs. Luo wanted a grandson. She went to the Buddhist Lecture Hall to see the Master, and I happened to run into her when I went there. We had never seen the Master wash his feet in the Buddha Hall of the Buddhist Lecture Hall, since the Master's room was just at the back. That day, when Mrs. Luo arrived, the Master was washing his feet in a basin of water. After the Master finished washing his feet, Mrs. Luo said to the Master:

"Shifu, please be compassionate. I want a grandson. My son still hasn't given me a grandson."

"I don't know how to give you a grandson," the Master said.

"You can do it. You have spiritual powers!"

"Do you really want a grandson?"

"I really do!"

"All right, then. If you really want a grandson, drink this basin of footbath water right now, and you'll have a grandson."

"Shifu, are you joking? How could I drink this water?"

Just then I had come into the Buddha Hall, and I too saw that the basin of water was murky and dirty, but I didn't dare say anything. The Master said:

"Didn't you say you wanted a grandson? If you really want one, drink this basin of water."

"No, no, I can't drink it!"

"If you won't drink it, I can't promise to give you a grandson." Then the Master lifted up the basin and, gulp, gulp, drank down the whole basin of water. Besides me, there were some other people there too, and we all watched the Master in amazement. When the Master had finished drinking the whole basin of dirty water, he said to Mrs. Luo, "Now your grandson is gone! Even if you ask me again, there's nothing I can do." I remember that Mrs. Luo began to cry right then. I saw this with my own eyes.

In Hong Kong, some things seemed very strange and very funny, but they really and truly happened.

80. Elder Hsu's Pictorial Biography

In 1959 the Venerable Master commissioned painters to depict the life and deeds of Elder Master Hsu Yun as a biography in pictures: 208 Chinese-style paintings in all. The Venerable Master wrote the text and composed verses for the events of the pictorial biography, running to tens of thousands of words. Before long, the *Pictorial Biography of Elder Master Hsu Yun* was published...

Before the pictorial biography was published, in the seventh lunar month of that year, the Venerable Master learned that Elder Master Hsu Yun was in poor health. He immediately invited greatly virtuous ones of the ten directions to commence the *Jeweled Repentance of the Medicine Master for Eradicating Disasters and Lengthening Life* for Elder Hsu, together with a Universal Buddha Ceremony for prolonging his life. Not long afterward, a letter arrived from Mount Yunju saying that Elder Hsu had recovered, and the Venerable Master was greatly relieved and gladdened!

In the Venerable Master's own words:

There was a Chinese man to whom I gave the name "Hu Nao" [Tr.: hunao means "acting foolishly, making mischief"; Hu is also a surname], because like a little child he did nothing but make mischief. He didn't understand the Buddhadharma at all. He said that Elder Hsu wasn't 120 years old, and some ignorant people followed him; foreigners who considered themselves scholars also chimed in, saying, "So-and-so said so." Actually, the hardships and difficulties of Elder Hsu's whole life are truly more than words can tell! I believe that no one else could have withstood such torment. In the course of this century, the Elder crossed over himself and crossed over others, benefited himself and benefited others, and the auspicious events of his life, sublime and miraculous and beyond what others could attain, are too many to list.

Whenever anyone bowed to Elder Hsu, even the youngest person, he would always join his palms and return the bow, and it was the same whether they were monastics or laypeople. Therefore, at no time may monastics put on airs toward monastics or laypeople. Even more must Bhikshus not put on airs toward shramaneras, shramanerikas, or Bhikshunis. The more you put on airs, the more you stink. A monastic should not be the first to make a half-bow to a layperson, but neither should a monastic stand there like a block of wood or a lump of clay, putting on airs: "I'm a monastic!" without even a word of greeting. When a layperson bows, the monastic should sincerely recite the Buddha's name and dedicate the merit to that person, wishing that he or she will soon realize the Buddha Way.

[Addendum 1] (omitted)

[Addendum 2] (omitted)

[Addendum 3] *Pictorial Biography of Elder Master Hsu Yun*, Volume One:

The book *Records of the Responsive Manifestations of Shakya Tathagata* has been in circulation for a long time. It is a great work within the teaching and a precious raft for the realm of living beings. Everyone delights in reading it and wishes to look at it, and it is easy to understand. It is truly an excellent text suited to its readers, a wonderful treatise in accord with principle.

Now, out of reverent admiration for the Venerable Elder Hsu Yun—for his virtue, his precepts and conduct, his learning, wisdom, ascetic practice, power of vows, actual practice, kindness and compassion, joy and relinquishment, impartiality, giving, patience, vigor, Chan samadhi, and all the doors of the paramitas—and for the extraordinary deeds of his life, which are worthy to be a compass for the Dharma-Ending Age and a savior for this century, we have spared no expense in engaging experts, Buddhists of talent, to paint over 200 exquisite Chinese-style paintings. After several years of painstaking thought and design, it has now at last been completed and published. Through it we will spread the Elder's virtue throughout the whole world, so that everyone has a copy in hand and it becomes known to every household; so that by means of it people will bring forth the Bodhi mind, by means of it accomplish the unsurpassed Way, and by means of it

turn the ship of compassion back to teach and transform living beings; and so that all will attain irreversibility in the position of Bodhi enlightenment.

On the birthday of Maitreya, in the first month of the gengzi year,

respectfully prefaced by this mountain monk, To Lun, in the Avatamsaka Seat Room of the Buddhist Lecture Hall on the island of Hong Kong

[Addendum 4] From the diary of Upasika Tan Guo Zheng:

All the creative content, text, and verses of the pictorial biography of Elder Master Hsu Yun were written by the Master. In the pictorial biography there is one verse written to refute the criticisms of Elder Hsu made by so-called intellectuals and scholars. Among the Master's disciples, Xue Guo Feng could recite all the verses of the entire book from memory.

[Addendum 5] Reported in *Mind Dharma* magazine, Issue 3, December 1956:

Dharma Heir of the Venerable Elder Master Yun Vigorously Promotes the Chan School in Hong Kong

(Report from this magazine) After the Second World War, our society's president, the Venerable Master To Lun, out of reverence for the Venerable Elder Master Yun, the sole greatly virtuous master of the Chan lineage, came south from Manchuria to fulfill his long-cherished wish. Arriving at Nanhua Monastery in Maba, Guangdong, he paid his respects to the Venerable Elder Master Yun and was held in high regard by the Elder Master, who soon appointed him proctor of the Nanhua Vinaya Academy; later he was transferred to the post of dean of academic affairs. Not long ago, the Elder Master transmitted to him the mind seal, the Treasury of the True Dharma Eye, the wondrous mind of Nirvana, so that he would carry on and make flourish the Weiyang lineage and continue the line of the Chan School.

Seven years ago, the Venerable To Lun left Guangdong for Thailand, and soon afterward he came to Hong Kong, where he immediately resolved to promote and revive the Chan School. In the winter of the year before last, at Cixing Chan Monastery at Man Cheung Po on Ling Wui Shan, Lantau Island (of which the Venerable To Lun is the abbot), he specially held Chan sessions lasting 70 consecutive days, attended by a great many Buddhists of the fourfold assembly.

Embodying the aspirations of the Venerable Elder Master Yun, the Venerable To Lun vigorously promotes the Chan School. He has also had sculpted a full-body image of the Sixth Patriarch and a four-foot-high statue of the Venerable Elder Master Yun, made while the Elder Master is still living, and has enshrined them at Cixing Chan Monastery to receive offerings. Beginning on the fifteenth day of the tenth lunar month of this year, he plans to hold another ten Chan sessions.

81. Elder Hsu Enters Perfect Stillness

The telegram from Mount Yunju read: "The Elder entered perfect stillness peacefully at Zhenru Chan Monastery on Mount Yunju at 1:45 p.m. on the

twelfth day of the ninth month of the jihai year (1959). He instructed those who come after him to 'diligently cultivate precepts, samadhi, and wisdom; extinguish greed, anger, and delusion; forget yourselves for the sake of the Dharma; and respect and love one another.'"...

On October 16 (the fifteenth day of the ninth lunar month), the Venerable Master held in his hands the telegram from Zhenru Chan Monastery on Mount Yunju in Jiangxi Province. To hear the news so suddenly was for him nothing less than as if the mountains had crumbled and the earth had quaked, as if the human world had been destroyed and the fire at the end of the kalpa were blazing through everything. He could not tell whether he was dreaming or awake, whether it was real or unreal; he was like a dull, senseless wooden puppet, like a clay image without consciousness. Only after a long while did his awareness return, and he was overwhelmed with grief!

On the day after the telegram arrived (the sixteenth of the lunar month), the Venerable Master called together his disciples and the lay Buddhists and established the "Permanent Memorial Committee for the Nirvana of Elder Master Hsu Yun." It was resolved to begin a 21-day Buddha Recitation session the following day (the seventeenth), and to hold a 120-day Great Prajna session beginning on the tenth day of the tenth lunar month.

They sent out a hundred telegrams to notify Buddhist organizations around the world, and released the news in Hong Kong, calling on Elder Hsu's disciples and Buddhists to come and take part in a memorial assembly reciting the 600 fascicles of the *Great Prajna Sutra*.

> *We grieve for our supreme teacher, teacher of gods and humans,*
> *Who has become a sage among sages in that Pure Land.*
> 痛我天人師上師，成彼淨土聖中聖。
>
> *Our only hope is that he will pity the living, those subject to birth,*
> *And come again to save and transform the sentient, mired in sentiment.*
> 惟望憐憫生有生，再來度化情中情。

In the Venerable Master's own words:

Of the three places I built, Lantau Island could house several hundred people, and it could also house 20 or 30; at Happy Valley, more than 20 monastics lived at one time. After Elder Hsu entered perfect stillness, I held a memorial Dharma assembly for him at the Hong Kong Buddhist Lecture Hall: a 120-day Dharma assembly reciting the *Great Prajna Sutra*, plus three Buddha Recitation sessions, for a total of more than 160 days. Every day 20 or 30 people were living there, and at mealtimes there were so many people that they couldn't all sit down in the hall; they had to stand and eat wherever they could. Every day it cost a great deal of money, but I never said to any disciple, "Help out a bit with this Dharma assembly; put up a little money!" Never! I just toughed it out! With me it's "Though freezing to death, stand facing the wind; though starving to death, walk

with your belly thrust out." I would never tell anyone that I couldn't manage and beg them to come and help!

After Elder Hsu entered perfect stillness, the Buddhist Lecture Hall did more than 160 days of merit and virtue, reciting the *Great Prajna Sutra*. Nothing like this had ever been done before. From the time of Shakyamuni Buddha until now, whenever a Patriarch entered perfect stillness, no one had ever recited the *Great Prajna Sutra* for him or held such a great Dharma assembly. This is called a great offering.

The memorial assembly organized by Elder Hsu's Dharma disciples and refuge disciples in Indonesia invited me to write a message of condolence. I sent my message, and it was printed in the commemorative publication of the Indonesian memorial assembly for Elder Hsu. I heard that someone had actually spent several thousand dollars to have paper effigies of a large mansion, a steamship, and a car made for Elder Hsu. I hope that Buddhists will abolish such superstitious and backward customs, and think more about whether what I say makes sense.

[Addendum 1] *Sing Tao Daily*, Sunday, October 18, 1959 (the seventeenth day of the ninth lunar month of the jihai year):

Having Lived in the World 120 Years, Elder Master Hsu Yun Enters Perfect Stillness; Buddhists Held a Dharma Assembly Yesterday

Elder Master Hsu Yun—who sat through the reigns of five emperors and four eras, scarcely noticing how many times the seas turned into mulberry fields; who endured to the full nine ordeals and ten difficulties; and who thoroughly understood the impermanence of worldly affairs—passed away peacefully, entering perfect stillness at the venerable age of 120, on the twelfth day of this lunar month at Zhenru Chan Monastery on Mount Yunju in Yongxiu County, Jiangxi Province.

Yesterday, at the Buddhist Lecture Hall on the 12th floor of Yu Yuen Mansion in Happy Valley, Dharma Master To Lun, Dharma heir of the Venerable Hsu, on learning that the sad news had arrived, immediately called together the Hall's refuge disciples and other Buddhists, and beginning yesterday evening they first held, at the Buddhist Lecture Hall, a Buddha recitation Dharma assembly of three consecutive Buddha Recitation sessions. After that Dharma assembly is completed, it will be followed on the tenth day of the tenth lunar month, the fourth seven-day period after the Venerable Hsu's entry into perfect stillness, by a "Prajna session" lasting 120 consecutive days.

The telegram that the Buddhist Lecture Hall received yesterday from Mount Yunju read as follows: "To the Dharma seat of the Venerable To Lun: Elder Hsu Yun passed away peacefully, entering perfect stillness, at Zhenru Chan Monastery on Mount Yunju on the twelfth of this month by the old calendar. He instructed those who come after him to strive vigorously, diligently cultivate precepts, samadhi, and wisdom, extinguish greed, anger, and delusion, forget themselves for the sake of the Dharma, and respect and love one another.

Respectfully sent on the thirteenth by the old calendar by your precept disciple Kuan Chang."

Those who took part yesterday evening in reciting the Buddha's name and dedicating the merit to the Venerable Hsu numbered more than 100, including such Elders of the various monasteries as Dharma Masters Bao Xian, Ren Guang, Rong Xiu, and Fa Yun, as well as Li Kuan Zhong (the rest omitted). Buddhists are welcome to come, rejoice, and offer incense.

In addition, the lay Buddhist Yang Kuan Zhuang of the Daoci Buddhist Society in Sai Wan, having received the news of Elder Master Hsu Yun's entry into perfect stillness at the same time, sent a circular to all the members of that society to hold a Buddha Recitation session beginning at 10:00 a.m. today, dedicating its merit to the Venerable Hsu. All Buddhists are welcome to take part in the recitation, so it was announced.

[Addendum 2] In the winter of 1959, the Hong Kong Buddhist Lecture Hall published the *Special Commemorative Issue on the Nirvana of Elder Master Hsu Yun*:

Daily schedule of the Great Prajna Dharma assembly: (omitted)

[Addendum 3] Bhikshu Dharma Master Zhi Ding wrote in "In Memory of the Venerable Elder Yun":

(Excerpted from the *Special Commemorative Issue on the Nirvana of Elder Master Hsu Yun*, published by the Hong Kong Buddhist Lecture Hall in the winter of 1959)

On the afternoon of October 17, I had gone to Halona Blow Hole on some business. When I came back, I received a telegram from Dharma Master To Lun in Hong Kong, saying that the Elder had already entered perfect stillness on the 13th (the twelfth day of the ninth lunar month)... It was truly like a bolt from the blue, and it shocked me exceedingly! Had the Elder really left us, this boundless multitude of suffering beings, and gone to another world of peace and nurture? A string of question marks appeared in my mind; I could hardly bring myself to believe it. The next day I received another telegram, from Dr. Liang—a telegram that amounted to an obituary notice—so the fact was a fact after all, and I could not but believe it. When I received this news, my heart was filled only with desolation, only with grief! I had been away from the Elder for ten years. When I left him ten years ago, I could never in any way have imagined that ten years later, today, he would leave us forever!

[Addendum 4] Zhan Liwu wrote in "Mourning Elder Hsu Yun":

That day I was informed by a newspaper office of the news of the Elder's entry into perfect stillness, and in the evening I also received a telegram from Dharma Master To Lun in Hong Kong.

[Addendum 5] Recorded from the special section on the Nirvana Dharma assemblies in the *Chronicle and Collected Dharma Talks of Elder Master Hsu Yun (Expanded Edition)*:

Hong Kong Buddhists Unite to Mourn Elder Master Hsu Yun; Memorial to Be Held This Sunday at Tung Lin Kok Yuen

Yesterday, when the sad news arrived that the great Buddhist figure Elder Master Hsu Yun had manifested stillness and returned to the West, the Buddhist fourfold assembly of Hong Kong, monastic and lay, immediately called together Buddhists from all over Hong Kong, Kowloon, and the New Territories, and at 2:00 p.m. yesterday, in borrowed premises at the Ching Kok Lin Association in Happy Valley, they convened a Dharma assembly to remember Master Hsu Yun. A great many Elders of the various monasteries and laymen and laywomen attended. Dharma Master You Tan was elected on the spot to chair the meeting, and Upasaka Chen Jingtao took the minutes. The proceedings of the meeting were as follows (omitted).

[Addendum 6] Elder Dharma Master Shao Yun, "Glimpses of Elder Master Hsu Yun's Life on Mount Yunju":

After 1958, the Elder Master said to us, "I'm going to leave." We were very sad and asked him, "Venerable Elder, why do you want to leave now?" He said, "You don't know. There will be ten years of suffering ahead, and it will be terribly hard to bear!" At the time we didn't understand. Later came the ten years of catastrophe of the Cultural Revolution.

Starting in 1958, the Elder often had minor illnesses, so he handed over his affairs one by one to those who would come after him, and he distributed all his belongings to the assembly.

On the afternoon of the tenth day of the ninth (lunar) month of 1959, the Elder Master gave the assembly his final instructional talk and his last testament. The Elder Master said, "My last words are just these: 'Diligently cultivate precepts, samadhi, and wisdom; extinguish greed, anger, and delusion.'" After a while he said further, "With proper mindfulness and a proper mind, cultivate a spirit of great fearlessness, and save people and save the world." The Elder admonished us to transmit the precepts and cultivate well.

At twelve noon on the twelfth day of the ninth (lunar) month, the Elder Master said to his attendant, "Just now, in my sleep, I dreamed that I saw an ox step on and break the stone slab of the Foyin Bridge, and I also saw that the water of the Bixi stream had stopped flowing." Then he closed his eyes and said nothing. At 12:30 the Elder Master called his attendants to come in together and said to them, "You have served me for many years, and you have all worked hard. I won't say much about all these matters. For nearly ten years now I have endured every bitterness and hardship, living every day amid danger, suspicion, and upheaval, suffering every slander and injustice, and I have been willing to bear it all, wishing only to preserve the Way-places of the Buddhas and Patriarchs within this country, to uphold the virtuous pure rules of the

Patriarchs for the monasteries, and to preserve this one great robe for monastics in general [Tr.: the formal robe (sanghati), standing for the monastic tradition itself]. I fought with my life to win back this one great robe. You are all disciples who have entered my room; you know what happened. From now on, whether you have a bundle of thatch to cover your heads or go out in all directions in response to conditions to teach, you must likewise firmly uphold and preserve this one great robe. But how can it be preserved forever? There is only one word for it: precepts." When the Elder Master had finished speaking, he joined his palms and bade everyone take good care. Everyone withdrew in tears and kept watch under the eaves outside the room.

At 1:45 p.m., in his thatched hut on Mount Yunju, the Elder lay on his right side in the auspicious reclining posture and peacefully entered perfect stillness. During the month and more before he entered perfect stillness, many of the monks had seen a patch of light come out of the thatched hut and go toward the Buddha Hall. They saw only a bright ring of light and no figure of any kind; once it entered the Buddha Hall, the ring of light gradually faded away. After a month and more, the Elder Master had arranged everything properly and written a will in his own hand; then he told his two attendants to leave, and he stayed behind in the thatched hut and quietly departed! (This piece is excerpted from *Silicon Valley Brahma Sound*, Gold Sage Monastery, December 2011.)

[Addendum 7] Elder Hsu's final verse at the end of his life:

> *Of old, pitying the lives of ants, one did not cast [remains] into the water;*
> *I, to comfort the water creatures, cast my body into the river.*
> 蝦恤蟻命不投水　吾慰水族身擲江
>
> *I pray that all who receive my body, gladly offered,*
> *Will together realize Bodhi and cross over living beings.*
> 祈諸受我身願供　同證菩提度眾生
>
> *All you Dharma companions,*
> *There is no need to worry.*
> *Birth and death follow karma,*
> *Like insects bound in a net.*
> 諸各法侶　不必憂慮　生死循業　如蟲縛網
>
> *Greed and delusion never cease,*
> *Imprisoned in sorrow and joy.*
> *If you wish to be rid of this affliction,*
> *Strive to cultivate and refine yourselves.*
> 貪迷不休囚閒憂喜欲除此患努力修煉
>
> *Wondrously unite with the unproduced,*
> *Clearly penetrate the ground of the nature,*
> *Sever the emotions of love and hate,*
> *And escape the perils of the turning wheel.*
> 妙契無生明通性地斷愛憎情脫輪回險

Investigate the three studies and keep them pure,
Firmly uphold the four applications of mindfulness,
Vow to bring them to perfect completion:
This substance is illusion, dew, and lightning.

參淨三學堅持四念誓願圓成質幻露電

Awaken to and realize true emptiness:
The myriad dharmas are of one substance.
Meetings and partings, sorrows and joys,
Follow conditions, like bubbles on water.

證悟真空萬法一體離合悲歡隨緣泡水

After my death, when my body has been cremated, I ask all of you to grind my ashes into a fine powder, mix them well with oil, sugar, and flour, make them into pellets, and please place them in the river as an offering to the water creatures. If you fulfill my wish, I will be endlessly grateful! Bowing in reverence, Hsu Yun, a debtor who has not repaid

[Addendum 8] Dharma Master Le Guan wrote in his article "Impressions of Master Hsu Yun":

As I see Elder Yun, he truly was a man of iron of the Chan school in this latter age, with the eye on the crown of his head, and in his final move his spiritual light shone forth all the more uniquely. After coming to Hong Kong to propagate the Dharma, he resolutely hurried back to the mainland in the spirit of one leaping into a pit of fire. When he went back, he cherished a compassionate vow to save the teaching and save the Sangha; yet, in order to carry through his great vow of compassion, he took no account of success or failure. What a state of mind that was!

With this spirit he struggled on the mainland and fought his way through. One could say that he gave up everything, even his life's blood; he endured every torment and went through every hardship and danger. His conduct in sacrificing himself to defend the teaching can stand alongside and shine together with that of several greatly virtuous ones who came before him: Tanshi in the time of Emperor Wu of Wei, Zhixuan in the time of Emperor Wu of Zhou, and Xuanchang in the time of Emperor Wu of Tang. And his final outcome closely resembles the circumstances of Great Master Jing'ai in the time of Emperor Wu of Zhou, who set forth to the emperor the retribution that destroying Buddhism must bring but could not change the emperor's wicked mind; he went to Mount Zhongnan and wept and wailed for seven days, then sat on a great rock, took a knife and cut away his own flesh, hung his intestines on a pine branch, and died holding his heart in his hands. That Buddhism has until now been able to preserve some seeds of the Buddhadharma and has not suffered complete destruction is due largely to the power of Elder Yun's protection and support. This is the price that Elder Yun's sacrifice obtained, and it is something that deserves to be written in large letters in the future history of Chinese Buddhism.

82. Respectfully Bringing Back the Sharira

On November 4 (the fourth day of the tenth lunar month), the Venerable Master sent two disciples, Xue Guo Su and Ma Guo Xian, to Mount Yunju to respectfully bring back Elder Master Hsu Yun's sharira. On the 18th they arrived back in Hong Kong, having respectfully obtained more than ten sharira of dazzling five colors, which they brought back to be enshrined for offerings...

The Venerable Master wrote a verse in praise of the sharira:

> *Firm seeds of dazzling five colors,*
> *Smelted from ten thousand virtues, round as the full moon;*
> 五色缤紛堅固子　萬德煅煉滿月圓
>
> *Crystal-clear pearls of the precepts, their light blazing;*
> *Tridacna jewels of samadhi, their colors bright and fresh;*
> 晶瑩戒珠光灼灼　硨磲定寶色鮮鮮
>
> *Lapis lamps of wisdom illumine the Dharma Realm;*
> *Fruits of prajna wisdom transform the three thousand worlds;*
> 琉璃慧燈照法界　般若智果化三千
>
> *The size of lotus seeds, pure as jade,*
> *Adorned all around with the merit and virtue of the precepts and the Vinaya.*
> 蓮子大小潔如玉　戒律功德眾莊嚴

—Respectfully inscribed by Hsuan Hua, his disciple and Dharma heir

"Sharira" are the bone relics that remain after a body is cremated; they are the crystallization of a cultivator's practice of the Way. The "Chapter on Giving Up the Body" of the *Golden Light Sutra* says, "Sharira come from being permeated by the cultivation of precepts, samadhi, and wisdom; they are extremely difficult to obtain." Therefore, to bow to and make offerings to sharira is to make offerings to the Triple Jewel.

Today Elder Hsu's sharira are enshrined at the City of Ten Thousand Buddhas in the United States, and the *Pictorial Biography of Elder Master Hsu Yun* has also been published in Chinese in the United States.

In the Venerable Master's own words:

When I completed this Dharma assembly, I ran into a lot of jealousy and obstruction from people in Buddhist circles, who were angry that I had outshone them all. I sent people to bring Elder Hsu's sharira back to Hong Kong. At that time there was a certain person whose "crab ailment" I had cured; afterward she became jealous and slandered me terribly, even spreading the rumor that my sharira were fake and only hers were real. Why did she say this? She was afraid that ordinary people would believe in me, and if they believed in me, it would be bad for her.

[Addendum 1] In the winter of 1959, the Hong Kong Buddhist Lecture Hall published the *Special Commemorative Issue on the Nirvana of Elder Master Hsu Yun*:

Impressions on Reverently Beholding the Sharira Buddha-Jewels of Elder Master Hsu Yun

On the twenty-sixth day of the tenth month by the old calendar, I reverently went to the Buddhist Lecture Hall to pay homage to the sharira produced by the cremation of the Venerable Elder Master Yun, guided in my homage by Dharma Master To Lun, the Venerable Yun's direct Dharma heir. According to Master To, he had sent two disciples who braved ten thousand dangers to bring the sharira respectfully from Mount Yunju in Jiangxi. I observed that the sharira, large and small, numbered about ten in all. The one in the center, white in color, was the largest; crystal-clear and dazzling, it was like a pearl that shines in the night. Those arrayed around it were also of dazzling five colors, resplendent beyond compare. Now, such night-shining pearls are none other than mani pearls, the Buddha-jewels of seeing the nature and becoming a Buddha. Looking into the matter, the Venerable Yun had very great affinities with the people of Hong Kong. Besides coming here in person several times to propagate the Dharma and cross over living beings, he was, for example, invited to preside at the altar when the Tung Wah Group of Hospitals held an Assembly of Myriad Affinities some years ago. In recent years, when the assembly was held again, they again invited him to preside over the Dharma from within samadhi. Because of this, calamities and invasions quietly dissolved, and the whole territory benefited and relied on him. Now that the Master has entered perfect stillness, his sharira too were the first to be respectfully brought here, ahead of all other ports; this too is a matter of affinity. Master To now plans to build a stupa to enshrine them for offerings, and preparations are under way. That the people of Hong Kong will in future gain blessings and lasting protection is a certainty. Master To's resolve to repay his teacher's kindness is great indeed. Zhuangzi said, "It is as though something causes it." This is probably the guidance and transformation of the Buddhas and Bodhisattvas.

Respectfully recorded in Hong Kong by the lay Buddhist Shi Xing in the first month of winter of the jihai year

[Addendum 1] Instructional talk by Elder Dharma Master Shao Yun (excerpted from *Silicon Valley Brahma Sound*, December 2011):

The Elder Master entered perfect stillness on the twelfth day of the ninth month. On the nineteenth day of the ninth month his casket was sealed, and the cremation took place the next day; it was planned to open the furnace three days later to collect the sharira and the ashes. Unexpectedly, the next day a fire broke out on the hills outside Zhaozhou Pass. Nearly a hundred people lived on the mountain, and all the monks of the assembly went to fight the fire, leaving only some of the old, weak, sick, and disabled in the monastery. Among them, Master Kuan Huai, Master Kuan Ke, and some others ran to the outside of the

opening of the cremation furnace and peeked in. They saw that the Elder Master's ashes after cremation were still sitting upright without collapsing, seated in full lotus there just like a living person. They thought this strange and casually picked up a small piece of tile and tossed it at the ashes, whereupon the ashes collapsed entirely. Master Kuan Huai immediately reached in and grabbed a handful of ashes; looking at them, he saw several crystal-clear, shining sharira, and at once he cried out about it.

After a while, the people who had gone to fight the fire came back one after another. Hearing that there were sharira in the Elder Master's ashes, they came running one after another, scrambling to reach in and grab a handful of ashes and then run off to some secluded spot in the mountains, because the political situation at the time did not allow anyone to say there were sharira. Dozens of people did this. Some found several sharira in a single handful of ashes; those with fewer still had one or two. They varied in size and differed in color, most of them being white and crystal-clear. So there was simply no way to count how many sharira there were in the Elder Master's ashes.

At the time, many people saw the Elder Master sitting upright, cross-legged, inside the sharira; in one of them even his long eyebrows could be seen clearly. That sharira is still kept in the sharira stupa today.

[Addendum 2] Bhikshuni Dharma Master Heng He recounted:

Viewing Elder Master Hsu Yun's sharira in Hong Kong was the cause and condition for my coming to know the Master. In 1959 Elder Hsu entered perfect stillness, and the newspapers announced that the Buddhist Lecture Hall had Elder Hsu's sharira on view for people to pay their respects.

Driven by curiosity, I too went to see what it was all about. I looked and looked but didn't see anything special, so I said to the Master's lay disciples, "I've seen enough; I'm going home!" They told me to come and bow to the Buddha when I had time, saying that whatever you ask for, you get. I put them off, saying, "All right, I'll come again when I have time." Not long after, I dreamed one night that the Master asked me, "Why did you promise to come and bow to the Buddha and then not come?" I thought it strange: why did this monk want me to go and bow to the Buddha? So I decided to go to the Buddhist Lecture Hall again to see what was going on.

When I got to the Buddhist Lecture Hall and rang the doorbell, someone opened the door. The person who answered took one look at me and said, "Shifu has been looking for you. Shifu even asked where you live, but everyone said they didn't know." At that time the *Great Prajna Sutra* Dharma assembly was going on. Wen Guo Shu told me to take refuge with the Master. I thought taking refuge meant they wanted me to leave the home-life, so I said I was only 24, still young, and didn't want to leave home. Guo Shu explained that taking refuge was not leaving the home-life; it was believing in the Buddha and becoming a disciple of the Buddha. I said, "Believing in the Buddha is fine, but leaving home won't do. When you leave home you shave your head bald, and that's not

pretty!" (Editor's note: Bhikshuni Heng He, lay name Zeng Xiujuan, took refuge with the Venerable Master in 1960 and left the home-life on August 3, 1977, with the Dharma name Guo Xi and the Dharma title Heng He. She received full ordination in 1979 and passed away on September 29, 2000. Her cremation yielded sharira and sharira flowers.)

83. Remembering the Venerable Yun (1)

In order to transmit Elder Hsu's immortal merit and virtue to the world and offer it to later students, the Venerable Master organized a "Call for Writings on the Nirvana of Elder Master Hsu Yun" in countries throughout the world, and the memorial writings he received from well-known figures everywhere were collected, edited, and printed...

The *Special Commemorative Issue on the Nirvana of Elder Master Hsu Yun* was published and circulated in December 1959. The following is an essay written by the Venerable Master, excerpted from this special issue:

Remembering the Venerable Yun: Such Were the Causes and Conditions, Before and After

Shi To Lun

(The preceding part is omitted.) I reached Nanhua Monastery and paid my respects to the Venerable Yun, like an infant seeing its mother, like a wanderer returning home. My reverent longing of several years, my long-cherished wish, was at last fulfilled! When I first arrived, I served as the incense-and-lamp attendant of the Patriarchs' Hall. Dharma Master Zhi Can often came to visit me; we were in accord in our principles of the Way, and he recommended me to the Venerable Yun, saying I was a person of talent and a vessel of the Dharma. The Venerable Yun at once invited me to the abbot's quarters and told me to join the Vinaya Academy as proctor. I did not agree. He pressed me again and again. I said, "I, your student, have traveled ten thousand li to visit teachers in order to end birth and death and to draw near to a Good and Wise Advisor. If you, Elder, can guarantee that I will end birth and death, then even if I have to go through boiling water and fire and be ground to dust, I will not decline."

The Venerable Yun said, "You must end your own birth and death yourself, just as you fill yourself by eating your own food. If I said I could guarantee that you would end birth and death, I would be deceiving you, and I would never do that. Even so, in cultivation one should value inner skill and outer results, cultivating both blessings and wisdom; only then can one succeed. You must not be content to be one who looks after only himself and perfects only his own person. You should also benefit the whole world, practice the Bodhisattva Path, support and protect the monastery, and serve the assembly. Then you will be cultivating both blessings and wisdom, and birth and death will end of themselves." I still did not agree. The Venerable Yun said, "You came all the way from the Three Northeastern Provinces, thinking nothing of the ten thousand li, to draw near to

me. If you won't follow my direction, how is that drawing near?" At this, I agreed to take up the post.

Ordinarily I would quietly observe the Venerable Yun's words, deeds, and movements. They were no different from anyone else's, except that he led by his own example and was austere with himself to a degree that ordinary people could not hope to reach. (The rest is omitted.)

Not long after I went to Yunmen, I developed a damp ailment that was hard to bear, so I asked the Elder for leave to go to Guangzhou for treatment. The Venerable Yun would not permit it, saying, "Don't go! If you go, it will be hard to come back!" I said, "Not so. My mind is made up; I must go." When the Elder heard this, tears of sorrow fell, and he clasped my hand and said, "If you go, we shall not meet again!" I said, "As soon as I recover I will come back. Please, Elder, set your mind at ease and don't worry!" The Venerable Yun said, "On this journey you should do Old Shakya proud and build Way-places for the Patriarchs of all generations. Your future is boundlessly bright. Work hard! Work hard! Do your best, and don't let down my hopes." With words of "Take good care," I bowed and bade him farewell.

I reached Guangzhou and went on to Hong Kong, where I stayed as a visiting monk at Tung Po Tor Monastery. In the seventh month I went back to Guangzhou again and stayed at Liurong Monastery, where Dharma Master Ming Guan asked me to serve as hall master and also as deputy treasurer. I accepted for the time being, intending to go back to Yunmen after the Mid-Autumn Festival. Who would have thought that in the first ten days of the eighth month Shaoguan would change hands and all transportation would be cut off? Having no choice, on the evening of the eighteenth day of the eighth month, with the boat fare provided by two lay Buddhists, Xie Kuan Hui and Chen Kuan Man, I returned to Hong Kong (omitted). Every time I recall the Dharma words the Elder gave me when I left, I regret that I did not heed my Good and Wise Advisor's admonitions then. Now I wish to draw near to the Venerable Yun again, but it can no longer be. How painful! How painful! What more is there to say? (The rest is omitted.)

In the seventh month of the jihai year, I heard that the Venerable Yun was gravely ill. I was uneasy day and night, knowing this was an inauspicious sign. Earlier, in the wuxu year, the Venerable Yun had had a Dharma photograph taken in which his two eyes looked straight ahead and his eyebrows, several inches long, could reach to his ears. When I saw it, I bowed to it, and I said with feeling, "In all his photographs the Venerable Yun has always had his eyes closed, but now he is gazing upon living beings with compassionate eyes. Such a departure from the usual means there must be a great change; within a year it will become clear." So I invited greatly virtuous masters and monks of the ten directions to bow the *Jeweled Repentance of the Medicine Master for Eradicating Disasters and Lengthening Life* and to hold a Universal Buddha Ceremony for prolonging life for several days. I also published the news in the newspapers to notify the Elder's disciples, in the hope that, pooling everyone's

ideas and efforts and uniting our wills like a fortress, our sincerity would bring a response and no prayer would go unanswered. Then and there I instructed the assembly, saying, "This Universal Buddha Ceremony for prolonging the Elder's life, the bowing of the *Medicine Master Repentance*, and the other Buddhist services this time are probably the last; there will be no more chances." My voice was unusually heavy and sorrowful, and all who heard it were also choked with sobs. Soon afterward a letter came from Yunju saying that the Venerable Yun's illness had eased slightly, which was a great relief.

I then devoted myself wholeheartedly to having people design and paint the Elder's pictorial biography: over 200 exquisite Chinese-style paintings, with text running to tens of thousands of words, setting forth the Elder's lifelong superhuman virtue and his unique spirit of austerity, diligence, and toil in practice and vows, to stand as an everlasting model, to enlighten later worthies, and to provide a pattern for all ages to come. Then, unfortunately, the sad news came: on October 16 (that is, the fifteenth day of the ninth lunar month), a special telegram arrived, announcing: "The Elder passed away peacefully, entering perfect stillness, at 1:45 p.m. on the twelfth of this month at Zhenru Chan Monastery on Mount Yunju. He instructed those who come after him to diligently cultivate precepts, samadhi, and wisdom, extinguish greed, anger, and delusion, forget themselves for the sake of the Dharma, and respect and love one another," and so on.

To hear the news so suddenly was for me nothing less than as if the mountains had crumbled and the earth had quaked, as if the human world had been destroyed and the fire at the end of the kalpa were blazing through everything. I could not tell whether I was dreaming or awake, whether it was real or unreal; I was like a dull, senseless wooden puppet, like a clay image without consciousness. Only after a long while did my awareness return, and I was overwhelmed with grief! The next day, on the morning of the 17th, I called together the patrons of this Hall to discuss the memorial arrangements. It was decided then and there to hold a 21-day Buddha Recitation session, followed by a 120-day Great Prajna session, to show our remembrance and to repay the kindness of his milk of the Dharma. We immediately sent telegrams to our Dharma companions and fellow cultivators overseas: to the San Francisco Buddhist Lecture Hall, the Honolulu Buddhist Association, the Singapore Buddhist Association, Upasaka Lee Choon Seng, Upasika Bi Junhui, and others; to Upasaka Zhan Liwu in Canada; to the countries of Southeast Asia, Taiwan, Burma, Thailand, India, Ceylon, and other places; and to Upasaka Yu Zhendong, chairman of the World Fellowship of Buddhists, and others. More than a hundred telegrams were sent in all, and so everywhere people rose up in great numbers, like winds rising and clouds surging, in response, to remember the Elder. Then we notified the Buddhists of Hong Kong by telephone, and on the 18th (that is, the seventeenth day of the ninth lunar month) we released the news publicly in the Hong Kong newspapers to inform everyone. Who would have expected that this would invite jealousy? Petty people slandered, demons ran rampant, confusing what people saw and heard, and some who styled

themselves Good and Wise Advisors were glad to tag along behind and chime in. It is truly lamentable! How true it is that good deeds attract many demons.

In short, if anyone understands me, will it not be because of the Venerable Yun? If anyone condemns me, will it not also be solely because of the Venerable Yun? When Confucius wrote the *Spring and Autumn Annals*, rebellious ministers and treacherous sons were afraid; when Sima compiled the *Records of the Grand Historian*, evildoers and lawbreakers perished. I am exerting myself for the Venerable Yun's sake, and even if ten thousand spears pierced my body, I would have no fear. Please use all your tricks to the full; I welcome and accept them most heartily. Great Master Yongjia said: "Contemplate evil words as merit and virtue; then they become my Good and Wise Advisors. If slander did not give rise to enmity or fondness, how could the power of patience and kindness born of non-production be shown?" He also said: "Let them slander, let them condemn; those who hold up a torch to burn the sky only tire themselves out. When I hear it, it is just like drinking sweet dew; it melts away, and I suddenly enter the inconceivable." Yet you should know that cause and effect are inconceivable, and retribution too is inconceivable. Be careful! Be careful! If you fall into the suffering of the tongue-pulling hell, it will be too late for regret!

On the fourth day of the tenth lunar month, I sent two laywomen, Xue Guo Feng and Ma Guo Xian, to Yunju to respectfully bring back the sharira and bone relics for offerings. On the seventh day they reached Zhenru Chan Monastery and obtained more than ten sharira, radiant with unusual brilliance, of dazzling five colors. On the sixteenth they set out from the monastery to return, and on the afternoon of the eighteenth they arrived at this Hall. I led the assembly of both ranks in welcoming them with incense and flowers; everyone bowed and prostrated, all greatly delighted, and I too felt as if a heavy burden had been lifted, relaxed and happy.

The next day, together with four lay Buddhists—Mao Wenda, Li Zhongyou, Xue, and Ma—I took the sharira to visit the elderly Upasaka Cen to discuss the special issue. He advocated publishing it at a later date, so as to wait for documents from overseas. That is why this publication is only now appearing (Editor's note: the *Special Commemorative Issue on the Nirvana of Elder Master Hsu Yun* produced by the Venerable Master Hua during his time in Hong Kong). From now on, I still hope that Buddhists of all countries of the world will be united in spirit and respect and love one another.

84. Remembering the Venerable Yun (2)

Born in Fuzhou, near Mount Peng,
He received full ordination at Yongquan, with Miaolian conferring the precepts.

生於福州近彭山，受具湧泉戒妙蓮。

He paid homage at Putuo to Guanzizai,
Then bowed his way north to Wutai and Manjushri.

朝禮普陀觀自在，北拜五台文殊來。

Not dwelling on at Yunqi, he came to Nanhua Monastery;
Then Dajue at Yunmen rose up once again.

雲棲不棲南華寺，大覺雲門復又出。

At Yunju he peacefully manifested perfect stillness;
The Venerable Yun has ascended the summit of Nirvana.

雲居安詳示圓寂，雲公高登涅槃巔。

—Respectfully inscribed by Hsuan Hua, his disciple and Dharma heir, 1959

Foreword to the *Special Commemorative Issue on the Nirvana of Elder Master Hsu Yun*

The Venerable Elder Yun, a greatly virtuous one of his generation and the leader of the Chan School, entered Nirvana on the twelfth day of the ninth month (lunar) of this year, and Buddhists throughout the world are overwhelmed with grief. As the saying goes, "The noble person is distressed lest his name not be honored after he has passed from the world." In creating this publication now, we are not only proclaiming the Elder's name and virtue but truly expressing the sorrow and regret of later students. Moreover, the Elder was a Bodhisattva who responded to the world and came again to this land to save living beings. Therefore we should all the more engrave his virtue in metal and stone and spread his holy name in our words; that is why we have specially created this publication.

Right after the Elder manifested stillness, the Permanent Memorial Committee for the Nirvana of Elder Master Hsu Yun was established, and a call for writings on the Nirvana of Elder Master Hsu Yun was sent out to countries throughout the world. Well-known figures everywhere, such as Elder Tan Xu, Upasaka Yu Youren, Upasaka Yan Xishan, Upasaka Li Hanhun, Upasaka Zhan Liwu, Upasaka Yu Ta-wei, Upasaka Hang Li-wu, Upasaka Qu Yingguang, and others, as well as greatly virtuous ones of the various monasteries, kindly sent their fine writings and calligraphy, which have been compiled and printed in this special issue to commemorate the Elder's meritorious deeds and great accomplishments.

Elder Hsu Yun was renowned in China and abroad; his followers fill the world, and his disciples are beyond counting. As disciples, if we do not repay our teacher's kindness, how can we be at peace with ourselves? Now that the Elder has entered perfect stillness, if there were no writings to commemorate him and to transmit his immortal merit and virtue to the world for later generations to believe in, how could we repay the Elder's profound kindness?

He transmitted the Buddha's mind seal and continued the wisdom-lamp of the Patriarchs. The Elder's great spirit, in reviving the Buddhadharma and crossing over living beings, was enough to influence and transform both sentient and insentient beings; he was a model for students and an exemplary teacher for humans and gods. Now that he has entered Nirvana, later students should behold his radiance and take him as their pattern. Therefore this book has been

compiled and printed, so that later generations will have something to choose from.

The Elder's great age of 120 years bears witness to his lifelong strict and exacting observance of the precepts and the Vinaya and to his extraordinary achievements; his name will be handed down for ten thousand generations. Therefore we have now specially created and printed this special issue as a memorial, so that ten thousand generations hence people will have a model to revere, to emulate, and to learn from.

[Addendum] After Elder Master Hsu Yun entered perfect stillness in 1959, the Venerable Master served as chairman of the editorial committee of the *Special Commemorative Issue on the Nirvana of Elder Master Hsu Yun* and sent out calls for writings everywhere. A great many letters came in; a few are selected below: (omitted)

Editor's Afterword to the *Special Commemorative Issue on the Nirvana of Elder Master Hsu Yun*

By the editor, a mendicant monk (Editor's note: that is, the Venerable Master Hua)

Tracing back the Venerable Yun's virtue: the more one looks up to it, the higher it is; the more one bores into it, the harder it becomes; one sees it ahead, and suddenly it is behind. How could ordinary people know even its outlines? Even a sage could not fathom its bounds. How much less would a mendicant of little study and scant learning presume to take on so great a responsibility as editing this special issue? But since I have the undeserved honor of being counted among his disciples and cherish the memory of my teacher's virtue, duty would not allow me to decline. Fortunately, greatly virtuous ones and venerable elders of all quarters, Dharma-protecting patrons, faithful devotees at home and abroad, eminent men of letters, scholars of broad and thorough learning, and great Confucian scholars and calligraphers enthusiastically took part in this undertaking, responding to the call and kindly contributing fine works, for which we are grateful beyond measure. However, since this publication was launched to remember the Venerable Yun, we regret that articles concerning politics, or writings leaning to either the left or the right, could not be included; pieces that seize upon the topic to air other views, or idle arguments, have likewise not been used; and old manuscripts about past events that have already been published elsewhere are also not printed. We hope for your understanding. Owing to various causes and conditions, this publication appears only now, to satisfy the eager hopes of the readers who have been awaiting it. The contents of this publication are gold and jade, pearls and gems, all smelted together in one furnace: essays, poems, eulogies, and verses, in which the myriad dharmas are fully displayed, offered in remembrance of the Venerable Yun and in reverent expression of our longing for him. The editor is deeply ashamed of his meager talent: making trouble where there was none, searching for a head when he already has one, wishing to help but doing harm instead, and incurring

blame at every turn. My only wish is that from now on I may break off social ties and stop traveling about, close my door and decline visitors, rest my spirit in the bliss of Chan, and become a "living dead monk," so as to repay the kindness of the Venerable Yun's milk of the Dharma and to thank the Good and Wise Advisors of the world for their teaching. That is all.

The Buddhadharma has not perished, but the Sangha destroys itself;
Virtue should be cultivated, yet people do not cultivate it.
佛法未滅僧自滅，道德應修人不修。

The honest and sincere draw public censure,
While the false and cunning are praised and favored.
老師真誠招物議，虛偽狡猾受褒憂。

In a world of the five turbidities, the clear are very few;
Living beings, drunk with the three poisons, have no season of waking.
舉世五濁清甚鮮，眾生三醉醒無秋，

Earnestly I send these words to the young monks:
The revival of our teaching rests with the Bhikshus.
殷勤寄語僧青輩，振興吾教在比丘。

[Addendum] Silent tributes of mourning and praise:

Tributes of mourning and praise for Hsu Yun:

On the Nirvana of Elder Hsu Yun

Riding a tiger, he manifested birth;
He lived through five emperors and four eras;
For 120 years he weathered to the full the world's vicissitudes, its winds and rains.
乘虎示生 閱五帝四朝 一百廿年飽歷滄桑風雨

Astride a crane, he has returned;
He endured nine ordeals and ten difficulties;
The three thousand worlds, many as the Ganges' sands, relied on his torch of wisdom and ship of compassion.
跨鶴歸去 受九磨十難 三千沙界仰賴慧炬慈航

The Buddhist Lecture Hall and Western Bliss Gardens Monastery

To Lun, leading the assembly of both ranks, bows in reverence

On the Nirvana of My Kind Teacher, the Venerable Elder Yun

Revering your virtue from the northern city,
I came ten thousand li to draw near;
Honoring my teacher's compassionate command,
I will educate dragons and elephants
To diligently cultivate precepts, samadhi, and wisdom.
北城仰德 萬裡來親 尊師慈命 教育龍象 勤修戒定慧

At Nanhua you taught me face to face
The single transmission that points directly,
Continuing the mind-lamp of the Patriarchs;
You enjoined worthies and sages
To extinguish greed, anger, and delusion.

南華面授　單傳直指　續祖心燈　囑咐賢聖　息滅貪嗔癡

(Excerpted from the *Special Commemorative Issue on the Nirvana of Elder Master Hsu Yun*)

85. The Wealthy Merchant Goes Back on His Word (2)

A certain Zhang committed some crimes that defied Heaven, and before long he contracted an incurable disease. All the doctors declared that he would surely die within 100 days. To save his life, he put a public notice in the newspapers offering a reward of US$200,000 to whoever could save him, but despite the huge reward, no brave man came forward. Afterward he took refuge with the Venerable Master, and after 100 days, to everyone's surprise, he had not died...

Cause and effect are perfectly clear, but only those with clear eyes can see through them. Zhang killed people and made and sold fake medicines, deceiving the world, and that is why he contracted an incurable disease. But because he had revealed his faults and repented before the Buddha, taken refuge with the Triple Jewel, and vowed to give his wealth to make offerings to refugee monks and to build monasteries, he was granted a longer life. However, having made the vow, he did not fulfill it, deceiving the Buddha and cheating his teacher, making one mistake after another, and in the end he harmed others and harmed himself.

Zhang was certainly pitiable, but even more pitiable were the relatives and go-betweens who curried favor with him, and the blind followers who echoed them.

In the Venerable Master's own words:

Back then, Zhang knelt before the Buddha in front of me and made a vow, saying that if he did not die within 100 days, he would give me US$200,000 to build a monastery. I waited eight years for him. That year, on the first day of the first lunar month, more than 100 people came, and I told everyone, "I've been waiting for Zhang to give US$200,000 to build a monastery; I've waited eight years for him. Starting today, I'm not waiting anymore. Whatever happens to Zhang from now on, I won't have anything to do with it!" Less than three months after I said this, Zhang's cancer flared up again. He went to other temples to bow repentances, but no Buddhist service of any kind worked. He had his family come to me to beg me, but I paid them no attention at all; even if they knelt at my door until they died, I would pay no attention! Within a few days he died.

Zhang's second younger brother died by jumping into the sea; that happened before Zhang took refuge with me. To tell you the truth, if Zhang had had faith when he took refuge with the Triple Jewel, he would not have died! If he hadn't

gone down the wrong road, he would not have died! Because his faith was not firm, although he didn't die within 100 days, after eight years he died anyway, and he couldn't take with him any of the money he had swindled from people. A year after his death, the elder Dharma Master in his sixties who had curried favor with him also got cancer. People bowed repentances for him everywhere, but no matter how they bowed, he didn't get better, and after a year or so he died too! Just before I came to America, he came to see me; he was so thin it was awful to look at.

In March (1962) I went to Japan. Someone had the elder Dharma Master's disciple in Japan give me 10,000 yen. I said to this person, "Your teacher is about to die; he won't even last 100 days. Hurry back to Hong Kong and prepare for his funeral." This disciple of his thought I was cursing his teacher and flew into a rage, and even told others that it was very wrong of me to curse his teacher. You see, when you tell people the truth, nobody believes you, but when you deceive them, people believe you. I went to America in March, and in May he breathed his last. All his life he knew only money and didn't care about cultivation; he would do anything, by any means, for money, and in the end he lost even his own life. After the elder Dharma Master died, the layman who had introduced Zhang to that other Way-place got cancer of the tongue, because he had gone as a go-between and introduced Zhang there; he died too. So this whole affair is very strange! This man was very rich, and many monastics had deposited their money with him; he swindled the monastics out of more than a million. When he died, those monastics' money was all gone too.

86. Circulating the Dharma Treasure

After the Venerable Master came to Hong Kong, he was busy all day long propagating the Buddhadharma. Besides lecturing on the sutras and speaking the Dharma and founding *Mind Dharma* magazine, he also printed large numbers of sutras for free distribution. In fact, as early as when the Venerable Master was living beside his mother's grave, he never let a book out of his hands, reading widely in the scriptures and reverently studying the great sutras...

In the Venerable Master's own words:

What does "circulate" mean? [Tr.: the Chinese word, liutong, is made up of liu, "flow," and tong, "get through."] Liu, "flow," means to flow from this place to that place; tong, "get through," means that it didn't get through before, and now we make it get through. It's the same principle as water, which just flows forward and flows into the great sea. A place that sells Buddhist sutras is called a "Buddhist sutra distribution center." That is, you didn't have it, you obtain a sutra here from me, and then you have it: that is circulating the sutras. Also, if this place doesn't have a certain sutra and you bring some sutras here from somewhere else, that is also circulating. And if there are no sutras at all, and we all resolve to print sutras, that too is circulating. We should do our utmost to explain, write out, print, and circulate them. The merit and virtue of printing

sutras is the greatest, and it also opens your inherent wisdom. So we must not overlook the importance of circulating the sutras. If you can print sutras widely and circulate them, you will open your wisdom, and your wisdom will increase.

Why hasn't your wisdom opened? It's because you have no merit and virtue. With little merit and virtue you have little wisdom; with great merit and virtue you'll have great wisdom, and then you won't be foolish or deluded; you'll be awakened. Why are you so deluded? Because your merit and virtue are still not enough. "I make offerings to the Triple Jewel, I print sutras, and I do the meritorious work of liberating life too; how can I still be so deluded?" You feel you've done a lot, but in fact the merit and virtue you've done is very little. A few days ago I wrote about the "three ordinary affairs": what you eat, what you wear, and where you live. Tell me, how much money do you spend on these three ordinary affairs? Compare them. Do you spend more money on merit and virtue, or more money on food? Do you spend more money on merit and virtue, or more money on buying clothes? Compare them yourself!

Compare again: do you spend more money on merit and virtue, or more money on buying cars? Do you spend more money on merit and virtue, or more money on going around having fun and traveling? If you're someone who likes to gamble, compare again: is the money you lose gambling more, or the money for merit and virtue? You spend so much money on clothing, food, and housing; tell me, is there any merit and virtue in that? When the money is spent on yourself, you don't feel it's much; but when you print a few sutras or liberate a few lives, you feel you've spent a great deal of money and your merit and virtue is already very great.

[Addendum 1] The Venerable Master's reflections after the facsimile reprinting of the *Great Means Expansive Buddha Flower Adornment Sutra*:

While I lived beside the grave, I read widely in the scriptures. When I first read the *Dharma Flower Sutra*, I leapt for joy as if mad. I knelt and recited it for seven days and seven nights, forgetting sleep and food, until my eyes bled and my eyesight weakened. Next I read the *Shurangama Sutra*, investigating its great samadhi to the end and cultivating it in stillness, with the three stoppings and three contemplations, neither moving nor still, until I first attained a single mind, deep and still, and began to penetrate the principle of the nature. When I came to read the *Avatamsaka Sutra*, I felt it was vast and boundless, broad beyond naming, lofty and unsurpassed, clear and formless. As Qingliang [Tr.: National Master Qingliang (Chengguan), the great Tang-dynasty commentator on the *Avatamsaka Sutra*] said, "It splits open the profound and subtle, illuminates and opens up the mind and its states, exhausts principle and fully realizes the nature, penetrates the fruition and encompasses the cause. Vast as the ocean, harmoniously blended, it is great and complete in every respect." How true that is! So I could not put the book down; I reverently read the great sutra, as one cannot be without clothing for even a moment, or go a single day without food. I then privately made a vow to circulate it widely. Later, when Vinaya Master Cizhou manifested stillness, his students borrowed this Hall to

hold an Avatamsaka session, and so it was decided to make a facsimile reprint of this sutra. But the Dharma-Ending Age is full of obstacles: two or three laymen actually monopolized the project from within, taking everything into their own hands and manipulating it, regarding it as a rare commodity to be hoarded; they wasted the funds and dragged things out, so it has been delayed until now. This is truly lamentable! So I personally supervised the printing, and only then was I able to fulfill this vow. I hope that the Good and Wise Advisors at home and abroad who have subscribed in advance for this sutra will understand Lun's difficult position and forgive his foolishness and clumsiness. For this I pray most earnestly.

Respectfully written by this mountain monk, Shi To Lun, at the Avatamsaka Sutra Facsimile Reprint Office of the Buddhist Lecture Hall, Hong Kong Island

The nineteenth day of the sixth month of the gengzi year, Mahayana Buddhist Era 2987

(Editor's note: that is, July 12, 1960 CE)

[Addendum 2] The Venerable Master's account of the origins of the facsimile reprint of the *Wonderful Dharma Lotus Flower Sutra* printed by Huiyun Cloister in Xiuzhou:

Now, in the Dharma-Ending Age, the ways of the world are in decline, deviant doctrines run rampant, and demonic paths arise in droves. Foolish and deluded living beings have been entangled for kalpa upon kalpa with no prospect of escape. Whenever I think of this, how can I not grieve?

In the past, the Tathagata, out of pity for living beings, manifested in the world, proclaimed the wondrous doctrine, widely transmitted the holy teaching, and devised all kinds of expedient means, serving as a bridge to rescue living beings and a ship on the sea of suffering, so that living beings might thereby be liberated from the turning wheel and rise to proper enlightenment. Yet without the sutras the Way would have nowhere to dwell, and without the sutras the Dharma could not be transmitted. Relying on the sutras we seek the Dharma; relying on the Dharma we understand the mind. This is the purpose for which the Tathagata spoke the sutras.

The *Dharma Flower Sutra* is the king of sutras, encompassing the true meaning of all the Buddha's sutras. Pure and subtly wonderful, it is worthy of praise as rare indeed. If one can receive and uphold it, one's body and mind will surely be healthy and at peace, the light of one's nature will certainly grow gradually brighter, and one will even realize that the five skandhas are all empty and attain the purity of the six faculties; and in the future one will surely ascend the jeweled lion's throne. Thus we know that this sutra is the unsurpassed king of sutras, unequaled and beyond compare, true and not false. How could we living beings fail to receive and uphold it sincerely and cherish it without forgetting, and instead let it slip by when it is right before our eyes?

Here we have a Song-dynasty edition of the *Wonderful Dharma Lotus Flower Sutra*, placed in a stupa at Huiyun Cloister in Xiuzhou by the Bhikshu Deqiu during the Qiandao reign period of the Song. Later, on the thirteenth day of the seventh month of the jiawu year, the tenth year of Qiandao, lightning destroyed the right-hand stupa; then, on the night of the ninth day of the seventh month of the yiwei year, the sutra was stolen. Deqiu was greatly distressed and could find no peace, but in the end it was returned. This is enough to prove the supremacy of this sutra, which can move people in invisible ways. This sutra is traditionally said to have been written out by Su Dongpo of the Song dynasty, but unfortunately the calligrapher did not sign his name, so there is no way to confirm it. Still, given the excellence of the calligraphy, there can be no doubt that it was written by a famous master. The calligraphy of this sutra has an air of grace within its strength and vigor, and a measure of variety within its neatness and precision. Moreover, the woodblocks were carved with great precision, and not a single character is missing or damaged; it is a fine edition. With this peerless calligraphy writing out this unsurpassed king of sutras, it can be said that each brings out the full beauty of the other, and each enhances the other. Therefore, when this mountain monk, together with the Buddhist Publishing House of the Hong Kong Buddhist Sutra Distribution Center and many lay Buddhists of Hong Kong and Kowloon, saw it, we praised it as a treasure and resolved to make a facsimile reprint of it for the benefit of humans and gods. But this is like a cup of water against a cartload of burning firewood; I truly feel that my meager strength is not up to it. Moreover, if this sutra is to be reproduced in facsimile, it must be done in large quantity and of fine quality, so that it can be widely circulated. Therefore I hope that all you great lay Buddhists will bring forth the mind of great vows and subscribe in advance as much as you can, to help with the facsimile reprinting of this sutra; then you will obtain limitless blessings!

Printing sutras brings ten kinds of merit and virtue, which are inconceivable; and the merit and virtue of making a facsimile reprint of this king of sutras is all the more limitless, needless to say. First: all the evil karma one created in the past will be wiped out invisibly, like an iceberg meeting the sun of wisdom. Second: one will be spared all calamities such as plagues, floods and fires, wars, and imprisonment. Third: one will be able to resolve all enmities with foes and kin. Fourth: one will not be harmed by yakshas and evil ghosts, nor by any venomous snakes or ferocious beasts. Fifth: one will obtain great peace and happiness; by day there will be no dangerous incidents, by night one's dreams will be peaceful, and all things will be auspicious. Sixth: one will have ample clothing and plentiful food, a harmonious family, and long life. Seventh: one will receive the respect of humans and gods. Eighth: one will gain great wisdom and good health in body and mind. Ninth: one will leave the evil paths forever and be born in the good paths, with upright features and enduring blessings and wealth. Tenth: one will be able to plant good roots for all living beings. Ah! The merit and virtue of printing sutras truly has such wonderful benefits. If one does it, above one accords with the Buddha's mind and below one benefits living

beings; the Tathagata's seed-wisdom will flourish in the field of one's mind, and one will surely go on until one sees the Buddha and becomes a Buddha. How could we living beings let this wonderfully effective merit and virtue right before us flow away like water going east? Surely we will be glad to do it.

Composed by Shi To Lun, a Bhikshu in the mountains, in the bingshen year

[Addendum 3] The Venerable Master's preface to the facsimile reprint of Master Boshan's *True Exposition on Transcendence*:

The eighty-four thousand Dharma-doors counter the afflictions of living beings; the limitless hundreds of thousands of samadhis all enter into the dhyana of the Patriarchs. I, An Tse, was born between the White Mountains and the Black Waters, and developed a nature that loves stillness and dislikes activity. In childhood I visited Good and Wise Advisors and drew near to the Chan lineage and its greatly virtuous ones. When I grew up, I heard of the Venerable Elder Master Hsu Yun, a towering figure of the Chan lineage and a field of blessings for living beings, who was propagating the Dharma in Fujian and Guangdong and residing at Nanhua. So I vowed to pay homage to the true body of the Sixth Patriarch and to seek Elder Hsu's guidance. I made plans for a long journey, gave up my encumbering robes and bedding, and traveled alone for ten thousand li, sleeping in the open amid dew and frost, pressing on day and night, crossing seas and climbing mountains. When I passed through Nanjing, Master Liaocheng, abbot of Doushuai Monastery on Mount Kongqing, was holding a Chan session attended by several dozen people, and I too was counted among them. The senior members among them were Dharma Master Ming Guan, Great Master Jing Kong, and Masters Miao Zhen, Ji Zhong, Fo Fa, Zhi Yuan, Lü Zhen, Ji Guang, and others, all of them Bodhisattvas with resolve for the Way. Rousing their spirits, they advanced with courageous vigor, sitting constantly without lying down, without self and without others, until the session concluded. I continued south, from Shanghai to Huizhou, without half a cent to my name; fortunately, aided by the Buddha's blessing, I made it all the way to the court of the Patriarch, where I reverently bowed before the true image, paid homage to the eminent monk, received his teachings in person, and heard his kind words imparted face to face. Several years passed in a flash as I set myself aside to till others' fields, following Elder Hsu. Then I came to Yunmen. A single false thought stirred, and I wanted to travel to visit teachers; in the gengyin year I bowed farewell to Elder Hsu. Wandering like the clouds and water to Hong Kong, I lived in seclusion in the wonderful Guanyin Cave and met with a response from the people here. I lectured on the *Earth Store Sutra* and the *Vajra Sutra* at Tung Sin Tan and practiced impartial giving in Hong Kong. I built Western Bliss Gardens at Ma Shan, devoted to propagating the Pure Land, and built Cixing Monastery at Ling Wui, to receive and guide those who investigate Chan. In the middle of the seventh month of the yiwei year, at Cixing Chan Monastery on Ling Wui Shan on Lantau Island, I was discussing the profound mysteries of the Chan Dharma with Great Master Fo Fa. When we spoke of the decline of the Chan lineage, we could not stop shaking our heads and sighing.

Then I recalled Master Boshan's book *True Exposition on Transcendence*, an essential classic of the Chan lineage and a bright lamp for rescuing Chan practitioners. Printing this book would be an unsurpassed bridge, and so I resolved to have it printed, to remedy the present decline of the Mind School. The book is excellent in both its illustrations and its text and clear at a glance; even the most foolish can gain real benefit from reading it. Its content is substantial and its theory perfectly integrated; it accords with the Tathagata's original intent in establishing the teaching and, further, captures the secret purport of the Patriarchs' transmission of the mind. It is not only the prajna of words but truly a fine remedy for the ignorance and afflictions of living beings. Therefore this mountain monk is willing to do his utmost, slight as his strength is, to have this book printed; then Shakyamuni, Boshan, and all the Patriarchs and Elder Masters will surely rejoice endlessly in the Eternal Stillness and Light.

The fifteenth day of the first month of the bingshen year

Prefaced by To Lun, a Bhikshu in the mountains, at the right of his seat in his humble dwelling at Western Bliss Gardens

87. The San Francisco Buddhist Lecture Hall

The Tan sisters, who had taken refuge with the Venerable Master when they were young, went to study in the United States one after the other. The elder sister, Tan Guo Zheng, went first to study in San Francisco. She found there was no Buddhist hall there, so she wrote to tell the Venerable Master. In January 1958, when the younger sister, Tan Guo Shi...

was leaving to study in San Francisco, the Venerable Master said, "Together with your sister, bring the Buddhadharma to America!" Following the Venerable Master's instructions, the two sisters found a basement in Ross Alley, near San Francisco's Chinatown, to serve as the premises of a Buddhist hall. After asking the Venerable Master for his approval, they founded the San Francisco Buddhist Lecture Hall in February 1958. A few months after the Lecture Hall was founded, the number of people gathering every Saturday evening had grown from a dozen or so to several dozen. Later it moved to Pacific Street in San Francisco, and on March 11, 1959, it was officially registered under the name "Buddhist Lecture Hall," in English and in Chinese.

In early August 1961, because its lease had expired, the Buddhist Lecture Hall was forced to move, and it moved temporarily to Clay Street, to a basement owned by the Tan family. On August 6, after the move to the new site, a Universal Buddha Ceremony was held in celebration, with Dharma Master Zu Yin as the presiding Dharma Master, and many faithful devotees came to join in and rejoice.

Because the Tan sisters had all along been leading their fellow Buddhists in Dharma assemblies and group cultivation, many people who had never seen the Venerable Master came to the Buddhist Lecture Hall seeking to take refuge, and they hoped the Venerable Master could come to America to propagate the

Dharma. Before the Venerable Master came to America, Tan Guo Shi once said to the Venerable Master, "Shifu, coming to America will be very hard! You should think it over clearly: do you really want to come to America?" The Venerable Master said, "I'm not afraid of hardship! You know how hard things were for me when I was at Fu Yung Shan!" Later, when the formalities had been completed, the Venerable Master did not go to America right away but flew to Australia to propagate the Dharma.

From the diary of Upasika Tan Guo Zheng:

After I graduated from high school, I could go to either England or America. If I went to England, I had already completed one of the two years of preparatory courses. But my father wanted me to come to America for university; because he had property in America, he wanted me to come to America. One day I was on Lantau Island (I think it was during a Chan session) when my father sent over a letter from the consulate: they had approved my application to go to America. I cried instead of being happy. The Master told me to win glory for Buddhism. He said, "You can go to America and try to spread Buddhism!"

I arrived in San Francisco in 1955. My cousin Tan Wenrang, who was in business in America (he later took refuge and received the Dharma name Guo Quan), took me to a private home to attend a Taoist organization, where a dozen or so overseas Chinese businessmen gathered. A Taoist master from Hong Kong, Wu Peilin, was doing planchette writing there; Wu Peilin practiced Buddhism and Taoism together. There I met a group of lay Buddhists, as well as the painter You Yunshan (who later left the home-life in Taiwan, with the Dharma title Dharma Master Xiao Yun). After that I went to visit the "Buddhist Chan Society Ritual Hall" in Chinatown, which was centered on family clans. I also went with Japanese classmates to the Buddhist Churches of America, which was first established in San Francisco's Japantown, to take part in their Dharma services, which followed a ritual like that of a Catholic church. I thought that what was needed here was a Buddhist Way-place of the Proper Dharma, so when Guo Shi came to America in 1958, she brought Dharma instruments and items for a Buddha shrine.

We rented an inexpensive basement in Chinatown and began to set up a Buddhist association, which we named the "San Francisco Buddhist Lecture Hall." This was the earliest Buddhist Way-place in Chinatown. Later, more and more people came to the Buddhist hall to bow to the Buddha, so Liang Minhui (Dharma name Guo Min), who had also taken refuge with the Venerable Master at the Lecture Hall, found a very good storefront for the Lecture Hall and also signed a two-year lease for it. In this place we could hold lectures and communal meals. Since Guo Shi and I both had to attend school, and most of the devotees had to work on weekdays, the Dharma assemblies were all held on weekend evenings and on Sundays. By this time the Buddhist Lecture Hall had been registered as a nonprofit organization, and everyone donated money to hire a lawyer to apply for the Venerable Master to come to America. Just when the lease was about to expire, Liang Minhui told us that the landlord would not

renew the lease and we had to move; he would keep looking for a place. At that time I took him at his word. When the lease expired, we had no choice but to move the Buddhist hall temporarily into the basement of my father's property and then look for a suitable place. Then the lawyer also wrote to say, "The American consulate in Hong Kong has sent a notice asking the Venerable Master to come for his visa, but there has been no word." Because the Venerable Master had no fixed address in Australia, there was no way to notify him. Just after the Buddhist hall moved out, news came that Liang Minhui had rented another floor and set up the "Buddhist Association of America," and some of the devotees, not knowing the inside story, drifted along with the current and went over to it! The Buddhist Association of America was set up purely so that laypeople managed the finances, and Dharma Masters would be appointed as leaders of the Dharma assemblies. Whenever a Chinese Dharma Master arrived in America, Liang Minhui would go and invite him to stay at the temple for a while. Dharma Masters newly arrived in America were glad to have a place to stay, and that is how the association won the praise of great Dharma Masters and senior lay Buddhists who looked only at the surface.

Not long after I went back to Hong Kong in 1961, the Venerable Master returned from Australia, and only then did he go to the American consulate to collect his visa. Although I had reported to the Venerable Master on the split in the Buddhist Lecture Hall, the Venerable Master took it calmly and did not rush to make a special trip to America; he even decided to visit Buddhist organizations in Japan and Honolulu along the way. So the hardships the Venerable Master faced after arriving in America go without saying.

[Addendum 1] Upasika Tan Guo Shi recounted on March 4, 2015:

Liang Minhui set up the "Buddhist Association of America" in 1961 and took some of the members of the Buddhist Lecture Hall with him. At the end of 1961, when we moved to Clay Street, some of the members came back again.

However, one whose contribution must not be overlooked is Yu Guo Xing. He not only contributed money and effort but also often urged the disciples who had taken refuge with the Master not to run off to other places, but to guard and protect their own Master's place. During the time when Guo Zheng had gone back to Hong Kong on business, it was Yu Guo Xing who helped me keep the Lecture Hall going all along. There was also an Upasaka Yang, who helped us get news items published in the newspapers. Huang Guo Ren, Li Guo Qian, and others all came to the Lecture Hall at that time, and they brought their classmates along too.

[Addendum 1] *Gold Mountain Times*, August 7, 1961:

Notice of Thanks on Moving to New Premises

Yesterday, August 6 (the twenty-fifth day of the sixth lunar month), our association moved to its new site and held a Universal Buddha Ceremony in celebration. We were honored that the Venerable Dharma Master Zu Yin graciously came to preside at the altar, and that patrons, faithful devotees, and

Buddhist friends came to join in and rejoice and kindly bestowed generous gifts and fresh flowers. For their noble friendship and deep kindness we are sincerely grateful, and we respectfully set down these few words to express our thanks.

Furthermore, the pure funds that the faithful devotees offered that day with the merit-and-virtue dedication forms they signed have all been donated on their behalf to the Chinese Hospital (Tung Wah Hospital), as a field of blessings to increase the good fortune of all the faithful devotees; for this, too, we express our thanks.

With respectful thanks from all the members of the San Francisco Buddhist Lecture Hall

[Addendum 2] *Gold Mountain Times*, September 8, 1961:

Buddhist Lecture Hall to Celebrate the Birthday of Earth Store Bodhisattva

The Buddhist Lecture Hall at 824 Clay Street will celebrate the holy birthday of Earth Store Bodhisattva at 8:00 p.m. on Saturday, the 9th of this month (the thirtieth day of the seventh lunar month). People from all walks of life are welcome to attend.

Upasika Tan Guo Shi recounted:

Originally I wasn't going to come to America. I had applied to study in Australia, and the Australian side had approved it, but my father hoped I would come to America. I said to the Master, "Shifu, where do you think it would be better for me to go?" The Master said very simply, "America is mei, 'beautiful'; Australia is ao, 'regretful'!" [Tr.: a pun: America (Meiguo) begins with mei, "beautiful," and Australia (Aozhou) begins with ao, as in aohui, "regret."] So I applied again to come to America to study, and, probably because the conditions were right, it was approved very quickly. At the same time, Guo Mi went to Australia. Before I came to America, my sister wrote to tell the Master that there was no Buddhist hall here, only Taoist temples, so in January 1958, before I flew to America, the Master told me, "You and your sister must do a good job of bringing the Buddhadharma to America!"

In 1958 we sisters founded the "Buddhist Lecture Hall" in America, and later, when it was formally registered, its Chinese and English names followed the model of the Hong Kong Buddhist Lecture Hall entirely. Every Saturday and Sunday we held various Buddhist services. I led the Dharma assemblies, lectured on the sutras, and gave instructional talks, and we also invited Buddhists, professors, elderly overseas Chinese, and others to give talks. The number of people attending the Dharma assemblies grew from a dozen or so to over a hundred, most of them elderly overseas Chinese and merchants from the Siyi region of Guangdong. They saw that we sisters were very skilled at performing Buddhist services, and when they heard the Buddhadharma we spoke, they knew we had been trained in Hong Kong, so they treated us with great respect.

More and more devotees came to the Buddhist Lecture Hall. The older generation of overseas Chinese all knew my father, and when they heard that our family had taken refuge with the Master, some of them also wanted to take refuge with the Master. We asked the Master for instructions; the Master sent their Dharma names by letter and specified when the refuge ceremony should be held, and we held the refuge ceremony here in America. At that time I presided over the ceremony, conferring the refuge on the Master's behalf.

At the beginning of 1960, because most of the disciples who had taken refuge with the Master had never seen the Master in person (they could only see the Master's virtuous likeness on the altar), the proposal was made to "invite the Master to come to America to propagate the Buddhadharma." With everyone's agreement and support, my sister began to engage a lawyer to handle the application for the Master to come to America and to raise funds. Because the procedures of the U.S. immigration authorities were complicated, the matter of the Master's coming to America progressed slowly. Later, the Master's application to come to America was finally approved, but just then the Master had agreed to go to Australia to propagate the Dharma (1961), so it was not until March 27, 1962, that the Master's American refuge disciples finally saw the greatly virtuous and kind teacher whom they had long admired.

88. The Journey to Australia (1)

In 1961 the Venerable Master stayed in Australia for a year, traveling back and forth between Melbourne and Sydney, but very few people recognized who he was! Only two or three scholars followed him. Although the conditions had not yet ripened, 36 years later Gold Coast Dharma Realm Sagely Monastery stood tall in Australia!

On May 11, the Venerable Master was invited to speak at the Sydney Buddhist Society on the day of the Buddha's birthday celebration, with Upasaka Liu Jining, a scholar at the University of Sydney, interpreting for him. The Venerable Master began with Shakyamuni Buddha's birth in India, his awakening to the Way upon seeing the bright star at night, his speaking of the *Avatamsaka Sutra*, and his expounding of the *Agamas*, and from there he introduced the basic teachings of the Four Noble Truths and the Twelve Causes and Conditions, encouraging everyone to cultivate and turn toward goodness.

In the Venerable Master's own words:

People said of me, "He can't even read; how could he lecture on the sutras? Don't go listen to his lectures; he just talks nonsense. It's all right for him to lecture to Americans and Australians, because they don't understand the Buddhadharma, so they can accept something shallow." Even though others say I can't lecture on the sutras, I'm still going to lecture. I call this "tossing out a brick to draw forth jade." When those who can lecture on the sutras see this, they'll feel embarrassed—too embarrassed to stay lazy and idle anymore: "We also have a share in teaching and transforming living beings; we shouldn't fail to

fulfill our responsibility!" To make them all bring forth the Bodhi resolve to cross over living beings—that is my intention.

"The Thirty-seven Wings of Enlightenment" are a Dharma cultivated in the Small Vehicle, but they also extend to the Mahayana; Mahayana practitioners can cultivate them too, because this Dharma is common to both the Great and the Small Vehicles. The Mahayana is born from the Small Vehicle, and the Small Vehicle is contained within the Mahayana; without the Small Vehicle, one cannot reach the fruition of the Mahayana directly. And without the Mahayana, the position of the Small Vehicle could not be revealed either. So when I spoke the Dharma for them in Australia, I explained this principle in great detail; therefore, those who study the Mahayana should also know the Thirty-seven Wings of Enlightenment.

The Buddha's Birthday, May 11, 1961

Text of the Venerable Master's talk at the Sydney Buddhist Society:

Today is May 11, the day on which the Buddhists of Sydney, Australia, celebrate the Buddha's birthday—a most solemn and grand ceremony. I, To Lun, am fortunate to be present at this splendid occasion, and I have also received the sincere invitation of the chairman and all the Dharma-protecting laypeople to attend and give a talk for the general public, so as to establish Dharma affinities. Facing so many guests and participants from all walks of life here, this mountain monk feels deeply honored. Moreover, Mr. Liu Jining, a scholar of the University of Sydney, has kindly supported this assembly; graciously acceding to everyone's wishes, he has generously taken time from his busy schedule to serve as English interpreter, for which this mountain monk is especially and most deeply grateful.

Tracing back, our Buddhism originated in India and has spread throughout the world. Its founder, Shakyamuni Buddha, was born into a royal family as the crown prince of King Shuddhodana, and was named Siddhartha. Wandering out through the four city gates, he saw birth, old age, sickness, and death, felt that birth and death are impermanent, and was filled with grief, sorrow, suffering, and distress, his spirit uneasy. He then renounced his kingdom and city, his wife and child, together with glory, honor, wealth, nobility, pleasure, happiness, and all of life's enjoyments, and went to the Snowy Mountains to cultivate. He practiced asceticism for six years, eating only one sesame seed and one grain of wheat a day to sustain his life. Later he sat beneath the Bodhi tree, and upon seeing the bright star at night, he awakened to the Way. Three times he exclaimed, "How wondrous!" and said, "All living beings possess the wisdom and virtuous characteristics of the Thus Come One, but because of false thinking and attachments, they cannot realize them." Thereupon he first spoke the *Great Means Expansive Buddha Flower Adornment Sutra*, teaching the Bodhisattva Dharma; the great beings of the Dharma body heard the Dharma and awakened, and through faith, understanding, practice, and certification, each obtained benefit. Only the people of the Two Vehicles were as if deaf and mute—as it is

said, "They have eyes, yet do not see Vairochana Buddha; they have ears, yet do not hear the perfect and sudden teaching." The World Honored One then, for the sake of the real, set forth the provisional, and accommodating himself to the capacities of those of the Two Vehicles, spoke the teaching of the *Agama Sutras*.

He expounded the "Four Noble Truths"—suffering, accumulation, cessation, and the Way—and spoke the Twelve Causes and Conditions: ignorance conditions activity, activity conditions consciousness, consciousness conditions name and form, name and form condition the six entrances, the six entrances condition contact, contact conditions feeling, feeling conditions craving, craving conditions grasping, grasping conditions becoming, becoming conditions birth, and birth conditions old age and death. He spoke the "Six Perfections (paramitas)":

1. Giving: the giving of wealth, the giving of Dharma, and the giving of fearlessness.

2. Upholding precepts: those of the shramanera, the Bhikshu, and the Bodhisattva.

3. Patience: patience with living beings, patience with dharmas, and patience with the non-production of dharmas.

4. Vigor: there is vigor of body and vigor of mind.

5. Dhyana samadhi: there are the four dhyanas and eight samadhis, the nine successive samadhis, and so forth.

6. Prajna: the prajna of language, the prajna of contemplative illumination, and the prajna of the real mark.

Proceeding step by step, he spoke the Vaipulya teaching; to turn people from the small toward the great, he spoke the Prajna teaching. When he came to the teaching of the Dharma Flower and the Nirvana, he opened up the provisional to reveal the real; this teaching is pure, perfect, and uniquely wonderful. The Thus Come One's original intent in coming into the world was here at last fully expressed: he held nothing back and presented everything in its entirety. He proclaimed the Dharma for teaching Bodhisattvas, of which the Buddhas are protective and mindful, and which is called the true, ultimate, complete meaning, the foremost wonderful Dharma. Finally came the special single transmission: pointing directly to the human mind, seeing one's nature and becoming a Buddha. The World Honored One held up a flower, and Kashyapa smiled, comprehending the wonderful purport. The World Honored One then gave him the seal of certification, saying, "I have the treasury of the proper Dharma eye, the wonderful mind of Nirvana, the real mark which is without marks, a special transmission outside the teachings; I have entrusted it to Mahakashyapa!" From then on, it was transmitted singly from patriarch to patriarch, with mind sealing mind; this was the beginning of the Chan School. It was passed down to the twenty-eighth patriarch in India, the Venerable Bodhidharma, who then came east to China, crossed the river on a reed, and

brought the flow of the Dharma into China; he was the First Patriarch. He transmitted the robe and bowl to the Second Patriarch, Shenguang, to whom he gave the name Huike. It was then passed down to the Sixth Patriarch, Chan Master Huineng (Dajian), and "one flower opened into five petals." This is the source of the Chan lineage's transmission in China.

Surveying the Buddhism of the world today, it falls into no more than two great schools. 1) The Mahayana, which teaches the Bodhisattva Dharma. "Bodhisattva" is translated as "a living being with a great resolve for the Way," and is also called "an enlightener of sentient beings." It takes as its basis the sutras and teachings translated by Dharma Masters such as Kumarajiva and Xuanzang of the Tang dynasty, and it has spread widely throughout China, Japan, Korea, Singapore, Malaya, Penang, Manila, India, Vietnam, Cambodia, Indonesia, Thailand, Burma, the United States, Brazil, and elsewhere. The seeds of the Mahayana have been sown everywhere; they will open into countless Bodhisattva flowers and bear countless fruits of Buddhahood. 2) The teaching of the Two Vehicles, the Arhat Dharma. "Arhat" has three meanings: 1. worthy of offerings, 2. slayer of thieves, 3. without birth. It takes the *Agamas* and other sutras as its basis and now flourishes in Ceylon, Burma, Thailand, India, Nepal, Pakistan, and elsewhere.

Yet these two were originally one body. Later followers have recklessly created entanglements, arguing about the great and the small and rejecting one another. This is truly putting a head on top of one's head and seeking marks within marks—most lamentable! However, it has always been that the great can contain the small, while the small can hardly encompass the great; this is a truth acknowledged by the world. When I gave a talk in Burma several years ago, I said, "Buddhists should look out upon the entire world, and their resolve should embrace the nature of the Dharma Realm. We should promote Buddhism in its original, complete form, unifying the teachings and the vehicles so that the great and the small return to the source. May everyone together reach the other shore, and may each one see the nature and become a Buddha." So it is today as well! I hope that all of you will be happy now and become Buddhas in the future, universally transforming your fellow beings so that all accomplish proper and equal Bodhi!

89. The Journey to Australia (2)

Now that China has grown strong, learning Chinese has become a trend. Back in 1961, the Venerable Master had already given this advice in Australia: "If you don't learn Chinese now, in a few decades people who don't know Chinese will have a hard time finding work; they'll be unemployed and have nothing to eat. I'm not saying it will be like that for everyone, but most will meet with this fate."

In the Venerable Master's own words:

In the spring of 1960, several universities in Australia learned that I was a Dharma Master of the Chan School and invited me to come and lecture, but I

didn't accept right away, and it was not until November 25 that I set out. When I first arrived in Australia, no one looked after me. Later, at the invitation of the Chinese consul in Australia, I would sometimes go and sit at the consulate. Mr. Chen, who worked at the Chinese consulate, and his wife were very devoted; I stayed at their home for several days. Mrs. Chen bought me a dictionary and also sewed clothes for me. It's a pity she has a very bitter fate; she will be in a pitiable state in the future!

I encountered many strange things in Australia. For instance, once when I was waiting for a bus and had no money, someone actually drove up beside me and offered to give me a ride for free. Canberra lies between Melbourne and Sydney. One day a Westerner was driving to Melbourne but took the wrong road and went north to Sydney. Just as he arrived in Sydney, he saw me walking along George Street. He hurriedly stopped, but by the time he had parked his car and gone to look for me, I had vanished without a trace. So he went to ask in the shops in Chinatown, and someone told him, "He comes here every day! Wait here; he's sure to come." He waited three hours and still didn't see me. Then he went everywhere asking for my address, but because I had moved several times, at every place he tried he was told I had already moved. He searched from Saturday to Monday without finding me, so he left his phone number and address with the Chinese consulate in Australia. Two days later, when I went to the consulate, I learned about this. This Westerner was a university professor who believed in Mahayana Buddhism, and he engaged me to lecture on Mahayana Buddhist principles at the university.

When I was in Australia, I taught them Chinese as a volunteer, without charging any money. I told them, "There are now a great many Chinese people, and there are many Chinese all over the world. In the future, relations between people in this world will certainly become close; languages must be exchanged, cultures must be exchanged, and wisdom must be exchanged. If you don't learn Chinese now, in a few decades people who don't know Chinese will have a hard time finding work; they'll be unemployed and have nothing to eat. I'm not saying it will be like that for everyone, but most will meet with this fate." Now, if you learn Chinese well, it will be very useful in the future. All of you should pay attention to this; it's very important.

When Americans say "good day," in English it's "Good day." How do Australians say it? "G'day, G'day" (it sounds like "Good die"). An Australian came to America and, on meeting someone, said nothing else but "Good die, Good die." The American lost his temper the moment he heard it: "How come the minute we meet you're wishing me a good death?" In Australia, I saved some of my food every day to feed the little birds. The ostriches in Australia can run 40 miles an hour, as fast as a car. I also once saw a little bird that could call out, "Mummy! Mummy!" and "Honey! Honey!" It could call out all sorts of things, and it could even say, "Good morning! Good afternoon! Good evening! Good night!" If you didn't see that little bird, you'd think there was a person over there talking.

I once met a follower of a non-Buddhist path who claimed to cultivate wisdom of the mind. He asked me, "What is cause and effect?" I said, "First tell me your opinion!" The non-Buddhist said, "Cause and effect is nothing but 'death.'" I said, "If it's death, why are you still alive? Can it be that you no longer fall within cause and effect?" In southern China and throughout Southeast Asia, there is a kind of gu poison [Tr.: a form of sorcery using venomous creatures to harm or control people]. This gu sorcery makes you obey the sorcerer's commands forever; if you don't obey, you lose your life—you die. In Australia, too, there is a kind of non-Buddhist spell craft: someone recites spells up on a mountain and can, by reciting, make a person's head become like an egg; he uses these as exhibits. You see, this world is so big that there's nothing strange it doesn't have—all kinds of strange and bizarre things!

Don't say, "I haven't seen it, so I don't believe it!" If you don't believe, it's because you're too foolish. Why? There are a great many things you can't see. If you wait until you've seen everything before you believe, you'll never finish seeing all the things in this world in this lifetime. I often say that before anyone discovered this New World, no one knew there was an America. If you had told people, "There's a place called America, and there's Honolulu there, and this and that," they would have said, "You're talking in your sleep! Where in this world is there an America? There's no such place." He doesn't believe there is an America; he says there isn't. Well then, does this land of America exist or not? Would this land cease to exist just because he says it doesn't? No. If he says it exists, it exists; if he says it doesn't, it still exists. So whether you believe or not, it exists.

[Supplementary Note 1] From the diary of Upasika Tan Guo Zheng:

There was an Australian, aged about 50-odd, a very devout professor, who had taught the Master English in Australia. So after the Master returned to Hong Kong, he began studying English, and I studied English along with the Master. Not long after the Master returned to Hong Kong, this professor wrote him a letter—

Dharma Master To Lun, greetings. We are grateful that while you were in Australia you explained Buddhism to us; the doctrines you taught were extraordinary. I truly wish you knew a bit more English, Dharma Master—we would benefit even more. I have finished editing the English translation of *Records of Dharma Master To Lun* and will mail it to you, so that it can be reprinted and circulated. Now I would like to tell you about a strange event connected with you, Dharma Master. On my way home, I usually pass along a quiet little lane lined with trees on both sides, and I habitually carry a flashlight to light the way. One night, I suddenly heard a voice say, "Good morning!" I immediately switched on my flashlight and looked all around, but saw no one. I thought, "It's night now; why would someone say 'Good morning'?" I found it baffling. Not until three weeks later, when I met you, Dharma Master, and the very first thing you said to me was "Good morning!", did I finally understand that what happened that night was a prophecy!

[Supplementary Note 2] In 1997, in the suburbs of the Gold Coast in Queensland, Australia, the Dharma Realm Buddhist Association established its first branch Way-place in Australia, named "Gold Coast Dharma Realm." Since 2006, DRBA has held a series of Dharma assemblies at Gold Coast Dharma Realm every year.

90. Returning to Hong Kong from Australia

The Venerable Master was invited to lecture at the Sydney Buddhist Society and at universities, and at the same time he realized that for Buddhism to go out into the world, "languages must be exchanged, cultures must be exchanged, and wisdom must be exchanged"...

The Venerable Master was alone in Australia, in a completely unfamiliar environment. Although there was something of a language barrier, through his wisdom, broad-mindedness, and conduct he widely established good affinities, giving the Buddhadharma the opportunity to sow its seeds in the land of Australia.

On September 11, 1961, the Venerable Master took a Qantas flight back to Hong Kong. On the 13th, about 20-odd people went to meet him at the airport: Dharma Master Ci Rui, Dharma Master Xuan Yang, Dharma Master Heng Yue, and other Dharma Masters. Among the laypeople were Huang Guo Jun, Gan Guo Yan, Tan Guo Zheng, Ye Guo Qing, Xue Guo Feng, and others.

After the Venerable Master got off the plane, a Dharma Master asked, "Dharma Master To Lun, you seem to have gotten thinner." The Venerable Master replied with a laugh, "I'm not yet able to be neither produced nor destroyed, neither defiled nor pure, but now I'm already neither increasing nor decreasing!" By the time everyone had escorted the Venerable Master and the Dharma Masters to the Buddhist Lecture Hall, it was already past twelve o'clock. The Venerable Master did not eat his meal; instead, he gave everyone the strawberry powder he had brought back from Australia.

Not long afterwards, a Dharma Master came to visit and shook hands with the Venerable Master as soon as he came in the door. Surprised that he would imitate Western manners, the Venerable Master gripped his hand back hard. The Dharma Master bore the pain, unable to speak. The Venerable Master said with a laugh, "What's the matter?"

"My hand really hurts!" the Dharma Master managed to reply.

"So you're attached to this body too?" said the Venerable Master.

[Supplementary Note] A Hong Kong newspaper, September 1961:

Chan Master To Lun Propagates the Dharma in the Australian Capital; Soon to Visit the Philippines and Return Home Shortly

Chan Master To Lun, who flew by invitation from Hong Kong to Sydney, Australia, on November 26 of last year, has already achieved tremendous results

in propagating the Dharma and transforming beings. In the past, among the Buddhist leaders from countries around the world who have come to Australia to promote Buddhism, apart from one person from India as long as 20 years ago, our Chan Master To Lun is in fact the second from the Far East, and the very first from China. Master To Lun's pioneering spirit is truly admirable. After eight months of spreading the teachings by speech and in writing, with tireless efforts that left him no time even to warm his seat, it can be said that the future of Buddhism there is bright: a smooth road is in sight, and it can stride forward without obstruction.

The Chan Master's Buddhist learning is profound, and his virtue and magnanimity are lofty. In particular, he has carefully studied Chinese classical learning as well as the historical facts and the deeds of famous people of every dynasty, commenting on them in detail and knowing them like the back of his hand. He is a widely learned and erudite eminent monk of our country in modern times. On this trip, not only did the overseas Chinese living in Australia eagerly look forward to his coming, but the Australian people, too, gained much benefit from the Dharma.

It is reported that Chan Master To Lun plans to go to the Philippines on July 15, and on July 25 to proceed from the Philippines to Taiwan, where he will stay for ten days before returning to Hong Kong. The Chan Master has recently written two books, *Impressions of Buddhism in Australia* and *Water Mirror Reflecting Heaven*, totaling several hundred thousand words, which will soon be available to fellow Buddhists in the homeland.

91. Eradicating Karma and Accumulating Blessings

In the course of a lifetime, people experience all kinds of things every day, over and over in endless cycles, the six faculties and six sense objects turning along in the flow of karma. Busily rushing east and west, without realizing it they create one new string of karma after another, spreading all sorts of karmic nets for the next round of rebirth...

Dharma Master Guo Ren (Bhikshuni Heng Qi) had formerly managed a catering business in Borneo, Indonesia, and came to Hong Kong and took refuge with the Venerable Master. The Venerable Master urged her not to kill anymore, but she thought that since she assigned others to do it, she herself was not killing, so she did not stop her restaurant work. Not long afterwards, she dreamed that the Venerable Master, wearing a yellow robe, came down a flight of steps, frowning, and said to her sternly, "I told you not to kill, and you kill again! I told you not to kill, and you kill again! Why don't you listen to me?" The Venerable Master paced back and forth in front of her

and kept on rebuking her. The dream was so vivid that she could never forget it. Afterwards she quit her job at the restaurant and went to help in the kitchen of the Buddhist Lecture Hall, where she worked for a full 18 years. Because she read the *Sutra of the Past Vows of Earth Store Bodhisattva* and understood the

grave retribution for killing, she decided to leave the home-life. At that time the Venerable Master had already left Hong Kong for America, so every day she bowed in repentance before the Buddhas and Bodhisattvas. One day, while she was bowing, she saw Elder Master Hsu Yun standing before her, instructing her to offer a lamp. Not long after she had done this, she received a phone call from the Venerable Master: he was going to return to Hong Kong to propagate the Dharma. Her prayer had met with the best possible response. After leaving the home-life, Dharma Master Guo Ren served as chief cook at the Buddhist Lecture Hall all along. In her old age, when she went to the hospital for a checkup, she passed away peacefully in the hospital.

Zhang Guo Hong, at 42, took refuge with the Venerable Master in 1957. Together with Dharma Master Heng Yi, she supported the Way-place by cooking for the assembly. Three times she asked the Venerable Master to let her leave the home-life, but the Venerable Master said that her karmic obstacles were very heavy and that she should do more work at the Way-place to eradicate her karmic obstacles and accumulate blessings. She followed the Venerable Master's guidance: "If you cultivate well, Earth Store Bodhisattva will come to receive you in the future!" She lived at the Way-place for more than 30 years, doing all kinds of ascetic practices. In 1988, when the Venerable Master returned to Hong Kong to propagate the Dharma, she finally left the home-life at Cixing Monastery, with the Dharma name Guo Hong; she was 73 that year. In September 1995 she received full ordination at the City of Ten Thousand Buddhas in America, with the Dharma name Heng Wei. In 2000, Dharma Master Heng Wei, then 85, moved into the Chi Lin Home for the Aged. She passed away in 2009 at the age of 94.

[Supplementary Note] Bhikshuni Dharma Master Heng Wei: excerpted from *Vajra Bodhi Sea*, the monthly magazine of the City of Ten Thousand Buddhas

> *Ever upholding the virtue of tending the kitchen;*
> *with great vows protecting the Way-place [Tr.: the two lines begin with the two characters of her name, Heng and Wei.]*
> 恆守監齋德 偉願護道場

Bhikshuni Dharma Master Heng Wei, whose lay name was Zhang Ai, was born in 1915. In 1957 she took refuge with the Venerable Master and received the Dharma name Guo Hong. After taking refuge, she was often at Western Bliss Gardens in Hong Kong, the Buddhist Lecture Hall, and Cixing Chan Monastery on Lantau Island, listening to the sutras and hearing the Dharma, reciting sutras and bowing in repentance, and protecting and supporting the Way-places. She had a good temper and did everything wholeheartedly and with all her strength; no one ever saw her vent resentment in the kitchen. She loved reciting the Buddha's name: her recitation beads never left her hand, and her mouth never stopped reciting the Buddha's name. Her resolve to cultivate and to support the Way-places remained the same from beginning to end. She left the home-life in 1988, at the age of 73. In 1995 she received the Triple Platform Ordination. Not

long after receiving full ordination, she returned to live permanently at Cixing Monastery in Hong Kong.

As she grew older, her body gradually deteriorated. She developed gallstones and needed surgery. She was anxious and prayed to the Buddhas and Bodhisattvas and to the Venerable Master for their aid. The day before the operation, she came from Cixing Monastery on Lantau Island to stay overnight at the Buddhist Lecture Hall, so that she could go to the hospital for surgery the next day. That night she had a strange dream: she dreamed that the Master came up to her, reached into her body, and with one pull of his hand the gallstones were gone, and the Master was gone too. When she woke up the next day, her body didn't hurt as much. When she went to the hospital for X-rays and was waiting for the operation, the doctor finished looking at her X-ray films: the gallstones had miraculously disappeared, and the films were different from the earlier ones. The doctor told her, "You don't need an operation; you can be discharged." Her body also gradually recovered. In another case, she asked the Venerable Master to help her find her son, from whom she had been separated for several decades, and this, too, truly came about. All these responses are facts that I, Guo Quan, heard and saw in the 28 years I was close to this elderly lady.

In 2000 she moved into the Chi Lin Home for the Aged, where she also helped tidy and look after the large and small halls of the home. She passed away in 2009 at the age of 94. That she was able to contribute so much to the monastic community in her lifetime truly deserves our respect. We feel deep sorrow at her relinquishing of this life.

> *Unwilling to go, yet going—*
> *coming and going,*
> *bearing a heart full of compassion*
> 不願去卻去 來來去去 帶著滿懷慈悲
>
> *Riding on vows, coming back again and again—*
> *ever in haste,*
> *to save and transform the human world*
> 乘願來又來 匆匆忙忙 為了度化人間

92. Living Beings Are Hard to Save

Although under the Venerable Master's guidance many devotees gradually came to know the Buddhadharma and took refuge with the Triple Jewel—some receiving and upholding the Three Refuges and the Five Precepts, others shaving their heads and leaving the home-life—after all, they were all ordinary worldly people...

Toward his disciples—whose causes and conditions differed, who were a mixture of good and bad, and who did not follow his instructions—the Venerable Master's compassion was earnest and urgent. Like a kind father, a strict teacher, and a good physician, he guided them patiently step by step and

instructed them tirelessly; at times he scolded them sternly, and at times he taught them by manifesting examples. Everything he said and did had a purpose!

In the Venerable Master's own words:

In Hong Kong there were often Dharma assemblies for bowing to the Buddhas or for sutra lectures. Some laypeople would come, and then what? They'd fight with others over bowing benches to bow on. Seeing that someone else had a bowing bench to bow to the Buddha on while he had none, one would go over, take that person's bench away, carry it somewhere else, and bow on it himself. And what happens then? The person whose bench was snatched gets so angry that he never comes back. Why? "So I don't have to come here to bow to the Buddha and be bullied!" In Hong Kong, when they fought over bowing benches, I didn't interfere. If you want to grab, if you want to be a bandit, go ahead—I don't interfere. But this person who grabs a bench to bow to the Buddha will definitely not get any merit and virtue from bowing. We who study the Buddhadharma should not be like this.

So the laypeople who often come here and the people who live here, whether they come to listen to the sutras or for anything else, should all look after newcomers and tell them what to do. Nobody knows a person who comes to the Way-place for the first time; he may be a Bodhisattva, or perhaps even an Arhat. If you don't receive him well, you'll miss him right in front of your face and have no merit and virtue. Sometimes when there are a lot of people and not enough bowing benches, you might as well give up your own bench for him to bow on and go bow off to the side yourself. Otherwise, the newcomer will take one look around here and think, "You people are so selfish—you only look out for yourselves and don't care about others!" And he'll never come again.

In Hong Kong, quite a few disciples were asking me day and night to explain the Shurangama Mantra, but because the conditions were not yet ripe, I never agreed, so I didn't explain it. When I lectured on the sutras and spoke the Dharma in Hong Kong, I seldom taught people to sit in meditation, and I didn't teach anyone the Dharma of the "Great Compassion Thousand Hands and Thousand Eyes" either, because the "Thousand Hands and Thousand Eyes" Dharma is extremely important and I was unwilling to transmit it outside. Now I am transmitting this Dharma that I know to every disciple, every follower. If someone comes from Hong Kong and you tell him what Dharma you learned here with me, he'll say, "Impossible! None of us ever learned that." It's the same as the principle with the Small Vehicle and the Mahayana: the Small Vehicle says the Buddha didn't speak the Mahayana Dharma, that the Mahayana sutras weren't spoken by the Buddha! It's just like now: I'm transmitting this Great Compassion Dharma to you, and if you tell my Hong Kong disciples, they'll say, "That's not right! Shifu himself doesn't know the Great Compassion Dharma—how could he transmit it?" They think I don't know it, that I don't understand any of it. In fact, I simply didn't want to transmit it to them!

[Addendum 1] From the diary of Upasika Tan Guo Zheng:

The Master once told me, "Even when I haven't seen something with my own eyes, I can know everything just by closing my eyes." The Master knew about the drawing of fortune sticks at Cixing Monastery. At mealtime he told them to bring the Guanyin fortune-stick canister and the book for interpreting the sticks, and he shouted, "Bring the stick canister! I'll draw a stick to find out when I'm going to die!" When the Master scolded people, no one dared make a sound; only one person said, "Shifu, we can't find it right now." The Master was extremely angry and utterly disheartened, feeling that it was hard to transform people.

Once, when the Master was on Lantau Island, because his disciples did not follow his instructions, the Master set out from the mountain gate and bowed at every step all the way to the Buddha Hall. Everyone was moved, and only then did they correct their bad worldly habits.

One day the Master said, "I don't want to see this bunch of people anymore; they've made me too disheartened!" I said, "Shifu, doctors treat the seriously ill; why would people who aren't sick need to see a doctor?" The Master replied, "What you say makes sense, but this bunch is already beyond any cure!" The Master said, "Haven't you seen the four characters I wrote, 'I'll just die'? When you can't sleep, you can think about what this means. Everything I say and do has a purpose." Alas! I'm so dull—how could I figure it out?

[Addendum 2] Lay Buddhist Lu Guo Yan's oral account, given on January 12, 2010:

I took refuge with the Master at the Buddhist Lecture Hall in 1956. The Master lectured on the sutras in the evenings; I was in my thirties then. The Master was very kind and gentle with us; he often chatted with us, taught us how to bow to the Buddha, and gave us many instructions. We Dharma brothers and sisters got along very well. On the first and fifteenth days of the lunar month or on the Buddha's birthday, we would gather to share a vegetarian meal—as many as eight to ten tables of people—and at the New Year there would be more than 20 tables of people coming for the meal.

In the past, I didn't understand the Buddhadharma. Once, while reading the *Sixth Patriarch Sutra* lying in bed, I dreamed that the Master and two of his disciples were walking toward me from the opposite direction. I thought it was just a chance dream. The next night I was again reading the *Sixth Patriarch Sutra* lying in bed, and again I dreamed of the Master. The Master said, "You have no manners! How can you read a sutra lying in bed?" Only then did I know that the Master had really appeared.

93. Those Who Believe Will Be Saved

Countless people came to ask the Venerable Master to cure their illnesses: strange illnesses, illnesses caused by demons, depression, people unable to

walk, people critically ill and beyond saving. However, the Venerable Master had a secret for curing illness...

Looking into the causes of each person's illness, the Venerable Master would have them bow to the Buddhas and hold mantras, or take refuge with the Triple Jewel. All those who were sincere and firm in their faith received a response without exception and gradually recovered.

An Upasika named Jing Kuan came to see the Venerable Master and pleaded with him: "My nephew has fallen ill in a very strange way. One day he felt dizzy, and just like that he fell ill and hasn't been able to get up since. The doctors can't diagnose what the illness is."

The Venerable Master closed his eyes for a moment and asked, "You took refuge with a certain eminent monk; why don't you go and ask him?" Jing Kuan said nothing. The Master had her write down her nephew's name and address, had someone give her a copy of the Venerable Master's biography, and told her, "Those who believe will be saved. You can recite 'Amitabha Buddha' facing this Dharma image."

Because the Venerable Master's name was printed beside the image, the woman, only half understanding, asked, "So I recite the name that's written in the book, right?" The Venerable Master said, "That's all right too."

Afterwards, the Venerable Master said to Tan Guo Zheng, who had been interpreting beside him, "That's because I can't say that myself." The Venerable Master then told her about Wang Fengjiu. When the Venerable Master was in Manchuria, Wang Fengjiu had deep and steadfast faith in him. Once, his son fell gravely ill and would not wake up. He prayed to the Venerable Master, but for several days there was no improvement. Yet his faith remained firm, and he kept bowing at home, beseeching the Venerable Master. One night he dreamed that the Venerable Master was holding a bowl of medicine and giving it to his son to drink. The next day his son suddenly woke up, cured without any medicine.

The Venerable Master said:

Ever since I was born, I've had only one secret: being true in everything—a true mind, true words, true conduct—without the slightest admixture of falseness, and without wearing a mask. You must add truth upon truth and genuineness upon genuineness! In this way, every sentence you speak is a "true word"—a mantra—and every word is an efficacious spell. Why is it that some people hold mantras, and keep on holding them, yet get no response? It's simply because their minds aren't true enough, so they can't connect with the mantra.

[Addendum 1] From the diary of Upasika Tan Guo Zheng:

Upasika He Guo Zhang had been ill for five years and was as thin and frail as a vine. Her younger sister, Guo Yin, wanted to ask the Master to accept her elder sister as a disciple, but the Master did not agree. The Master said, "Her karmic obstacles are very heavy; it won't be easy to deal with." Later, out of compassion for her, the Master accepted her for refuge, and only then did her illness

gradually get better day by day. I have an elder female cousin who adopted a child. This child had had meningitis three times, and the doctor said, "If the illness recurs again, it will be incurable!" After he took refuge with the Master, the illness never recurred. His elder sister had suffered from depression, and she, too, recovered without treatment after taking refuge. When sick people take refuge with the Master—truly, as long as you have faith, with the aid of the Buddha's power, everyone will naturally recover.

[Addendum 2] Lay Buddhist Tan Guo Yang recounted on June 7, 2014:

My mother's name is Ruan Guo Ni. My father was in the hardware business. Although my mother had taken refuge with the Venerable Master very early on through someone's introduction and often went to bow to the Buddha, she was not a regular vegetarian. At that time, my father was in poor health; he had heart disease. My mother bowed to the Buddha very devoutly, hoping my father's health would improve a little.

One day in 1956, the Venerable Master saw my mother and said to her, "Tell your husband to go up to Cixing Monastery and stay a few days, on such-and-such days of such-and-such month." Although my mother was the Venerable Master's disciple, my father had his business to look after, so of course he wouldn't listen, and he didn't go to stay at Cixing Monastery. At that time, the living conditions at Cixing Monastery were quite poor: there was no electricity, no telephone, and no way to contact the outside world; if you got sick, you had to walk down the mountain to see a doctor. My father thought, "Why should I stay up on the mountain?"

Who would have known that during exactly the period the Venerable Master had mentioned, my father's business ran into a cash-flow problem? Dealing with it put him under too much pressure, and he had a heart attack and passed away. Afterwards, when my mother thought back on it, she realized that the Venerable Master had told my father to stay at Cixing Monastery for a few days precisely so that he would avoid the impact of this matter; if things had been allowed to ease off a bit, my father would not have had the heart attack. Whenever my mother thinks of this, she deeply regrets not having listened to the Venerable Master back then.

In 1977, after my mother closed down the business, she cultivated with great vigor every day. She never missed morning and evening recitation; she bowed to the Buddhas, recited sutras, held mantras, and sat in meditation in full lotus, and she often went to the Buddhist Lecture Hall to attend Dharma assemblies and to volunteer. Although our family was fairly well off, at her ordinary meals my mother ate only plain rice with preserved mustard greens or stir-fried green vegetables. She didn't buy new clothes and lived very frugally. Later, as she grew older, she chose to cultivate on her own at home and no longer went around. Now my mother is over 90, and she is still cultivating at home as best she can.

94. "Our Master, Master Cheng, Said"

The Venerable Master said, "Many people don't understand the meaning of Zhuzi's (Zhu Xi's) phrase 'Zi Chengzi yue.' The first 'zi' is what Zhu Xi used to refer to his teacher, namely Chengzi (Mr. Cheng Yi). The meaning of 'Zi Chengzi yue' is 'Chengzi, the teacher of me, Zhu Xi, said.'"

In the Venerable Master's own words:

There was once a Professor Cheng Xi, who wrote a book called *New Chan Sayings*. He said that in arithmetic, if you write a large number and draw a circle after this large number, the number becomes a bit larger. For example, take this "1" and keep drawing zeros after it until you've filled heaven and earth with circles—how much would that be, after all? However much you draw, there's never any end to it. This number, this large number: every circle you draw adds another place, every circle you draw makes it bigger. You draw on the wall, you fill up the ground below, you fill up the sky above too—how big a number is it, after all? So this number is endless and inexhaustible.

[Addendum 1] Professor Cheng Xi (courtesy name Zhongyan), from Iowa State University

He was engaged in education at the University of Iowa for more than 20 years and wrote many works, of which *Cheng's New Chan Sayings* is the most widely known. In 1993 Professor Cheng visited the Venerable Master at Long Beach Monastery. Professor Cheng said, "The elder Dharma Master never talked to me about spiritual powers; he was very ordinary. But he put what he knew into practice right away, and that's not easy!"

Professor Cheng Xi had met the Venerable Master once, at a discussion meeting in Hong Kong on reprinting the *Great Prajna Sutra*. Professor Cheng said, "Several decades have passed since that meeting. More than 30 years ago, I published a little book, *Cheng's New Chan Sayings*, and printed 1,000 copies to give away to establish affinities. Later the elder Dharma Master saw it and printed 5,000 copies using the same paper and format. That autumn I went to Cambridge, England, and didn't see the elder Dharma Master again. While the elder Dharma Master was in America, he selected a number of passages from *Cheng's New Chan Sayings* to reprint in *Vajra Bodhi Sea*, the monthly magazine of the City of Ten Thousand Buddhas. During that period I also published *Sayings in the Form of Questions*, and after the elder Dharma Master saw it, he assigned disciples to translate it into English for publication. The elder Dharma Master's kind regard for these little books has always stayed deep in my heart."

[Addendum 2] From the diary of Upasika Tan Guo Zheng:

When the Master was talking to me about Cheng Xi's book *Cheng's New Chan Sayings*, he brought up the phrase "Zi Chengzi yue" from the Four Books and explained it. I said to the Master, "I'd like to put up half the money to help print this book." The Master said to me, "If you're going to print it, put up all the money; otherwise, don't print it."

[Addendum 3] In 1995, in an article commemorating the Venerable Master, Professor Cheng Xi wrote:

A few years ago I went to California to see the elder Dharma Master, and it happened that I fell ill at the time. The elder Dharma Master promptly had someone take me to the clinic of a doctor of Chinese medicine, and he phoned the doctor again and again, asking him to take special care in treating me. When the herbs were brought to Long Beach Monastery, his disciples carefully decocted the medicine, put it in a thermos so it would stay warm and not cool, and brought it in, and I drank it all down in one go. From this incident one can see the compassionate care, warmth, attentiveness, and thoughtfulness of the people in the Way-place, which outsiders might not be able to imagine.

The last time I saw the elder Dharma Master was in the summer of 1994. When I flew into Los Angeles, some of the elder Dharma Master's followers came to meet me at the airport and then took me to Long Beach Monastery. I talked with the elder Dharma Master for several hours. The elder Dharma Master had long known my true character, so I didn't need any conversational art and held nothing back in what I said. So once we started talking, we spoke freely and to our hearts' content, frankly and without reservation, and the time stretched out accordingly. Just before I left, some visitors came to call, among them a doctor of Chinese medicine skilled in treating muscles and bones. Busy as he was, the elder Dharma Master had this guest examine the sprain in my left arm. After some tuina massage, it felt as if a knot in the sinews of my arm had been untied; for several months I had never felt so relaxed. From then on, my left arm regained its flexibility, up and down.

[Addendum 4] In an article commemorating the Venerable Master, Professor Yang Fusen wrote:

Back when the Master was propagating the Dharma in Hong Kong, he became friends in the Way with Cheng Xi, and they often visited each other. Cheng Xi and I were both graduates of Yenching University. When I was teaching at the University of Pittsburgh, I once invited Professor Cheng to teach summer school at Pitt (Professor Cheng taught at the University of Iowa for many years, until he retired), so we were also quite well acquainted.

96. The Opening-the-Light Ceremony for the Jade Buddha

On February 19, 1962 (the fifteenth day of the first lunar month), the Opening-the-Light ceremony for the jade Buddha was held at the Buddhist Lecture Hall. This jade Buddha was a white jade stone Buddha image, majestically carved, which the Venerable Master had chosen during a visit to Burma after looking at all the carved jade Buddha images in Burma...

Those who came to the Buddhist Lecture Hall for the Opening-the-Light ceremony of the jade Buddha included fellow cultivators from monasteries far and wide and people from all walks of life; that day more than 40 tables were

laid for the meal. Some Dharma Masters exclaimed that they had been to all the major monasteries and temples but had never seen such a majestic Buddha image. A craftsman who made Buddha images, and who had been making them for more than ten years, said he had never seen such a majestic jade Buddha.

The completion and Opening-the-Light of this jade Buddha image fulfilled a wish the Venerable Master had held for five years. The Venerable Master hoped that his disciples and devotees would all be able to see the Buddha and understand their own nature, opening up the light of the wisdom of their own nature and the light of the compassion of their own nature.

From the diary of Upasika Tan Guo Zheng:

January 8: The white jade Buddha image, which had been shipped back from Burma the year before and temporarily stored in a warehouse, was moved to the Buddha hall. The image weighs over a ton. The workers all said there was no way to get it up to the twelfth floor. Later the Master thought of a way: install a crane at the corner of the back stairway of our building, and then remove the back window on the twelfth floor. Only in this way could the wooden crate be brought into the Buddha hall. The image is incomparably majestic, its smile warm and radiant; everyone who sees it is filled with joy and is suddenly moved to reverence. Beaming with delight, the Master said, "My wish of five years is now finally fulfilled." The Master said that he had looked all over Burma, and there was only this one.

January 16: I went to the Lecture Hall just as the Buddha shrine was being built. The shrine was also designed by the Master; it is majestic and dignified, noble and elegant, and the workers couldn't stop praising it.

On the evening of the Opening-the-Light ceremony, a man none of us knew came to see the Master; as soon as he came in, he bowed. This man had once written to the Master asking for money. He had originally been disabled in one leg, and his name was Huang Juefei. On the second day of the first lunar month he had come to the Lecture Hall on crutches asking to see the Master, but the Master didn't want to see him. Later he wrote words on the window, and only then did the Master come out to see him. When he saw the Master, he begged the Master to take pity on him. The Master scolded him, "You're not a woman—why are you begging for pity? You have no backbone at all!" The Master also said, "I have the first line of a couplet: 'White and water make a spring; within, one and great make heaven'. If you can match it with a second line, I'll give you whatever you want."

Although he thought for a long time without coming up with a matching line, the Master later still gave him 200 dollars and some canned food. After Huang Juefei went home, on the seventh and eighth days of the month, in a state between dreaming and waking, he saw the Master massaging his bad leg. Afterwards, he was actually able to walk without his crutches, so he came to the Lecture Hall especially to bow and thank the Master. The Master said, "At first he didn't harbor any expectations in his heart; that's why there was such a

response." Huang Juefei said that he had gone begging for alms at Buddhist halls everywhere and had met many great Dharma Masters at those halls, but not one monastic had treated him as well as the Master.

96. Making a Point of Saving Bad People

There are often people who lack self-cultivation and are of poor character, and who have committed serious wrongs of defiance and rebellion. Once they meet a Good and Wise Advisor who enlightens them, they suddenly wake up and are willing to wash their minds clean and turn over a new leaf, abandoning evil and turning to good. Yet training such "prodigal sons," whose bad habits have become second nature, still takes a great deal of effort...

Even so, the Venerable Master, with a heart of compassion, guided them patiently step by step, leading them in accord with their circumstances, even to the point of accepting them to shave their heads and leave the home-life, so that they could turn from delusion and return to awakening, in the hope that they would become great heroes standing tall between heaven and earth. The *Avatamsaka Sutra* says:

"For those who have lost their way, he points out the right road;

for those in the dark of night, he becomes a bright light." On March 5, 1962, 41 people took refuge, and the Venerable Master also shaved the head of one of them, Wang Ziyi, a man of habitually bad conduct, so that he could leave the home-life. The Venerable Master said, "I make a point of saving these bad people. Guo Shun was like this too before he left the home-life, but two years later he obtained the power of knowing others' thoughts."

The Venerable Master had Wang Ziyi tell everyone his faults, and he admitted and repented of each one. The Venerable Master urged him to quit drugs, admonishing him, "As long as you have resolve, you can quit drugs without taking medicine. You must remember that your Dharma name is Guo Wu, 'Fruit of Awakening,' not Guo Wu, 'Fruit of Error'!"

"I'm determined to draw a breath of pride!" Wang Ziyi replied.

"Whatever you do, don't let that turn into 'determined to draw a puff of smoke'! I'm willing to place a bet and accept you as a disciple. Although others have objections, I'm not afraid of trouble; I hope you can change your evil ways and obtain the treasure of redemption," said the Venerable Master.

The Venerable Master sent him to live on Lantau Island. After he had gone, the Venerable Master told everyone, "Even though he's bad, at most he'll kill me. Even if he kills me, I'll still..." The Venerable Master's vast magnanimity and Bodhisattva heart were truly beyond the reach of ordinary people.

[Addendum] From the diary of Upasika Tan Guo Zheng:

A Bhikshu who had returned to lay life came to ask the Master for help; someone had introduced him. The Master asked him out of the blue, "Why did

you cause the death of the man surnamed Zhang?" The man immediately became frightened and said nervously, "It wasn't me! He hanged himself!" It turned out that when this former Bhikshu had been living at a certain monastery, he had embezzled tens of thousands of dollars from the temple, and the monastic in charge of finances (whose lay surname was Zhang), having been falsely accused by him, hanged himself to show that he had been wronged. With just a casual question, the Master exposed his secret.

97. Heng Ding's Demonic Test

The Venerable Master admonished his disciples to apply more effort and establish more virtue. No matter what Dharma door one cultivates, one must first emphasize virtuous conduct; if one's virtue is insufficient, whatever Dharma one cultivates will meet with demonic obstacles...

In the Venerable Master's own words:

Why did I give him the name "Heng Ding," "Constantly Settled"? Precisely because he was "constantly unsettled," so I took away the "un-," and then Heng Ding's cultivation could have a bit of constant samadhi. I had a wish to memorize the *Dharma Flower Sutra* and the *Shurangama Sutra*, but I never had the time to fulfill it. Hearing me praise these two sutras so highly, he spent a full five years and memorized both the *Dharma Flower Sutra* and the *Shurangama Sutra*. He could recite the *Shurangama Sutra* from beginning to end without a single mistake. Why did I have him study it? It's the sutra I've loved most all my life. The prose of the *Shurangama Sutra* is the best and most wonderful—better than China's *Guwen Guanzhi* and the Four Books and Five Classics!

Ordinarily I don't concern myself with Heng Ding. All these years since I left Hong Kong, Heng Ding hasn't schemed for anything either; he shuts his door, doesn't see people, and doesn't chatter with anyone. He has certain Dharma protectors who, when the time comes, bring him rice, food, and things he needs. Someone says, "Then won't he starve to death?" He doesn't even talk anymore—why worry about whether he starves? Wouldn't starving to death be the best thing? Someone says, "I couldn't do that!" If you could do it, you would attain the fundamental substance of True Suchness.

Later he cultivated in Hong Kong for more than ten years. After about 12 years, he himself knew that in one more month he would become enlightened and have some accomplishment. But just one month short of that, he became possessed by demons. Three great demon kings went to trouble him. He knew it himself and could see them too. The three demons had Heng Ding in their grip and bewildered him until he was all upside down; they made it so that he couldn't sleep, his mind couldn't settle down, and he couldn't bow to the Buddhas.

As the saying goes, "When the Way rises a foot, the demons rise ten feet." If you have no merit and virtue, the demons pay no attention to you; but if you have merit and virtue, they want to come and take a share of it, so as to increase their own power. Not everyone who cultivates the Way will necessarily encounter

this; if you haven't reached that level, the demons won't bother with you either. It's like how a knight-errant sometimes runs into great bandits of the rivers and seas; if you're not a knight-errant, you won't even run into them, and if you did, you wouldn't know it.

Heng Ding had no way out, so (in 1972) he phoned from Hong Kong and wrote a letter asking me to save him.

Now I'll tell you a piece of news that no one would believe—you won't believe it either! After Heng Ding phoned, the gods, dragons, and the rest of the eightfold division here, along with the monastics and laypeople, all dedicated merit to him. He originally wanted me to go back, but I thought, why spend several hundred dollars on a plane ticket? Right here, using something the demon kings like to eat, I caught them and brought them over. Our demon-king prison here now has three more Chinese demon kings. Now Heng Ding's demonic illness is gone. Isn't that wonderful? Do you believe this news or not? If you believe it, that's fine; if you don't believe it, that matters even less—it doesn't matter! I'm just telling it; you just listen.

Recently three Bhikshus went to Hong Kong, and I specially told them to go see him and check whether this illness of his was cured. They said he was well; there was no more demonic light in his eyes.

How does one become possessed by demons? No matter what Dharma door you cultivate, you must first emphasize virtuous conduct; if your virtue is insufficient, whatever Dharma you cultivate will meet with demonic obstacles. So in daily life you should do more meritorious work and establish more virtue. In cultivation, you must do a lot of meritorious and virtuous deeds. Supporting the Way-place while you are in the Way-place, working hard and bearing complaints without resentment—this is establishing merit. Why are we willing to do things others aren't willing to do? It's precisely to cultivate our own outer blessings, our outer merit. Establishing virtue means not obstructing others and not causing others to give rise to afflictions.

[Addendum 1] Bhikshu Heng Ding's oral account, given on January 14, 2001, at the Boat Temple in Hong Kong:

In the thirty-eighth year of the Republic (1949), I had just finished receiving the precepts. At first I was at Nanhua Monastery and Yunmen; then the *** came, and I followed the Master to Hong Kong. In Hong Kong I followed the Master for eight years; at that time the Master had not yet built a Way-place. Then I went to Tung Po Tor Monastery and lived there for nine years, and after that I moved to live at the Guanyin Boat Temple.

I had memorized the *Vajra Sutra* before I left the home-life. At Nanhua Monastery I memorized a bit of the *Shurangama Sutra*, and at Tung Po Tor I finished memorizing the *Shurangama Sutra*; it took me five years. Elder Master Hsu Yun had all the disciples he taught memorize the *Shurangama Sutra*; there are many benefits in it. When I was at Cixing Monastery, the Master printed the *Shurangama Sutra* and the *Vajra Sutra*, and I was in charge of proofreading,

because I had long since memorized them. At that time the Master was building the Way-place. I went to live at Cixing Monastery for a year and a half and memorized the *Dharma Flower Sutra*, and I experienced many states: in samadhi I saw Shakyamuni Buddha and many great Bhikshus, one of whom was wearing large earrings.

[Addendum 2] From the diary of Upasika Tan Guo Zheng:

I think the Master was fond of Dharma Master Heng Ding. The Master often said that he was a university student, and that he spent an entire year memorizing the *Shurangama Sutra*. In the 1970s, Dharma Master Heng Ding wrote to the Master saying that he was entangled by demonic states, and begged the Master to save him.

[Addendum 3] Upasika Tan Guo Shi recounted:

After the Master came to America, he asked Dharma Master Heng Ding many times to come to America, but he refused. He stayed at Guanyin Cave and didn't leave until the mid-1970s, when he moved to live in another cave, which was beside the "Guanyin Boat Temple." From then on he lived in the cave and looked after that Guanyin boat. Because he didn't go out to seek alms, he often had nothing to eat. Although the Master was far away in America, he never forgot to ask his Hong Kong disciples to make offerings to him. Dharma Master Heng Ding would come to the Buddhist Lecture Hall on the first day of the first lunar month and on the fifteenth day of the seventh lunar month; the rest of the time he sat quietly in the cave investigating Chan. The dampness of the cave also caused him to become hunchbacked later in life.

When I first met the Master, Dharma Master Heng Ding was still cultivating at Guanyin Cave on Fu Yung Shan in Tsuen Wan, in the New Territories. He didn't like the bustling city life of Hong Kong. He was an ascetic practitioner. When he and the Master came out to Hong Kong, they often had nothing to eat, or ate food that had gone moldy. I seldom saw him at Western Bliss Gardens Monastery; I saw him only on the first day of the lunar new year. As I remember, if he wasn't investigating Chan at Guanyin Cave, he was in closed retreat in a little thatched hut beside the mountain path at Cixing Chan Monastery on Lantau Island.

Because of his cultivation, the residents nearby gradually came to know of him and went to make offerings to him. Nearby temples would also look after him with a meal. Many people came from Taiwan and overseas wanting to take refuge with him, but he refused them all. Why was he unwilling to take disciples? He said he was not yet qualified to be anyone's teacher; he wanted to put an end to the cycle of birth and death in this very life. Dharma Master Heng Ding said, "If I can't even control my own birth and death, how can I be anyone's teacher?"

Dharma Master Heng Ding knew in advance that his time had come and that he was going to depart. Three days before he passed away, he told the layperson who regularly brought him meals that there was no need to bring food anymore.

The layperson found this strange and asked Dharma Master Heng Ding the reason. Dharma Master Heng Ding said he was going to leave, but the layperson did not grasp the real meaning of this and still thought that Dharma Master Heng Ding ought to keep eating until the day he left. So he had no choice but to tell the layperson to bring only liquid food, and the layperson did as told. On the third day, the meal was delivered as usual, but Dharma Master Heng Ding was found seated in full lotus before the Buddha, having passed away! (Editor's note: Dharma Master Heng Ding passed away on the morning of October 11, 2003. He had been a monastic for 60 years and was 80 years old.)

98. On the Eve of Leaving Hong Kong

On the eve of leaving Hong Kong for America, the Venerable Master still used all kinds of expedient means to skillfully transform living beings—even at the dining table when he hosted Urban Council member and barrister Brook Bernacchi...

In 1962 (the renyin year), the date set for the Venerable Master's departure from Hong Kong was the second day of the second lunar month (March 7), which was precisely his mother's birthday. When the Venerable Master was young, he served his mother with the utmost filial piety, settling her in at night and greeting her in the morning, keeping her warm in winter and cool in summer, caring for her in every detail; he even lived in a hut beside his mother's grave to observe mourning, and people called him "Filial Son Bai." The Venerable Master's choice of this day to set out was in effect commemorating his mother with his resolve to propagate the teaching in the West on this journey.

On March 6, the Venerable Master invited Urban Council member and barrister Brook Bernacchi and his friends to lunch at the Buddhist Lecture Hall, with Upasika Tan Guo Zheng and Upasaka Wen Guo Mi keeping them company. During the meal, the conversation turned to the Venerable Master's eating one meal a day, at midday; the Venerable Master had vowed to save the food he didn't eat and dedicate it to hungry living beings. Bernacchi said, "Look, the government dumps lots of rice into the sea. Your not eating doesn't do any good." The Venerable Master replied, "Each person has his own resolve." When the Venerable Master was eating, if he happened to drop a grain of rice on the floor, he would immediately pick it up and eat it.

Since he would soon be setting out on a long journey, the Venerable Master personally recorded the Great Compassion Mantra and the Shurangama Mantra on a tape recorder for everyone, and he exhorted them, "Whoever listens to these countless tens of thousands of times can be cured of any illness whatsoever."

In the Venerable Master's own words:

Ever since I was young, I've been willing to take on suffering on behalf of living beings. All the blessings I ought to enjoy I give to everyone, and everyone's

suffering I take on myself. At that time, it was just when Japan was invading Manchuria in China's Northeast. I was observing mourning at my mother's grave, and someone told me, "The Japanese are seizing Chinese people to do forced labor. They don't get enough to eat and aren't given clothes to wear. Many freeze to death or starve to death, and then the Japanese have dogs eat the corpses!" When I thought of so many people with no clothes to wear and no food to eat, with so many starving and freezing to death, I made a vow: I would eat one meal a day, and leave my morning meal and my evening meal for people who have no food.

Most of my disciples eat one meal a day—not only the monastics; many laypeople also eat one meal a day. They're willing to learn this stupid method of mine. Using this stupid method to cultivate in this age of science, you could say it's not knowing how to keep accounts, not knowing how to calculate—or you could say it's calculating very clearly. The food we don't eat, we give to others to eat, forming affinities of food and drink with them; I believe that to the end of the future we will never starve to death. Because we're afraid of starving to death, we save some of what we ought to eat, to eat slowly later.

[Addendum 1] From the diary of Upasika Tan Guo Zheng:

The Master has booked his plane ticket. The date of departure from Hong Kong is the second day of the second lunar month, which is precisely the Master's mother's birthday. The Master chose this day to set out in order to commemorate his mother with a mind set on propagating Buddhism. The seventh day of the tenth lunar month is the Master's father's birthday, and on that day the year before last, the Master flew to Australia.

[Addendum 2] Upasaka Wen Guo Mi recounted:

Bernacchi was British and had been sent to Hong Kong by the Queen. In 1960 he became a Queen's Counsel, and he was also a council member in Hong Kong for many years. Bernacchi greatly respected the Master. He had a tea garden at Ngong Ping on Lantau Island—he was its owner—so he often visited the Master at Cixing Monastery and at the Buddhist Lecture Hall. Once he invited the Master to lunch at his tea garden, and the Master took me along. Bernacchi's Ngong Ping tea garden was the first tea garden in Hong Kong.

99. Tears at the Airport

The Venerable Master had returned to Hong Kong from Australia, and his visa for America had already been approved for some time. So he prepared to fly to America on March 7, stopping for one week in Tokyo, Japan, and then for two weeks in Honolulu, Hawaii, before flying on to San Francisco. During his 14 years in Hong Kong, the Venerable Master had spent every day rushing about to propagate the Dharma. Now that his Dharma affinities lay in America and he was about to leave Hong Kong, his disciples could hardly bear to part with him...

Early in the morning of March 7, Wen Guo Mi drove to the Lecture Hall to take the Venerable Master to the airport. People from all walks of life, fellow Buddhists, and many disciples also went to the airport to see him off. When the plane took off at 9 a.m., Guo Mi wept with grief, unable to bear the parting, and the crowd seeing him off could not hold back their tears either.

In the Venerable Master's own words:

For the sake of building Cixing Monastery, I worked there until my hair turned white, and most people thought I would surely be unable to let it go. "When I see others die, my heart burns hot as fire; not that I burn for the others—look, look, my turn is coming!" When I was leaving Hong Kong, I wrote these few lines, and some people who saw them didn't even dare to read them aloud.

While I was in Hong Kong, I went to Australia, Burma, Thailand, and Singapore, but wherever I went, I wasn't welcomed. In this world, many things go awry through mix-ups, and there are people who deliberately turn right and wrong upside down. People who tell the truth are envied, and people like those who tell lies. Now Hong Kong stinks, because there are too many people; this stench has changed Hong Kong, so teaching and transforming living beings in Hong Kong isn't easy—it's very difficult. But after difficulty, there is no more difficulty. If I hadn't undergone this kind of difficulty, I wouldn't know what kind of world this is; I'd still think this world was very happy. Only after going through many difficulties do you know that this world is full of suffering. Although it is suffering, we must still, in the spirit of the Six Perfections and the myriad practices, go everywhere to propagate the Buddhadharma and work hard to transform it into a world of ultimate bliss.

When I was in Hong Kong, some of my refuge disciples were also careless and sloppy, not knowing how good their teacher was to them. After I left, little by little they came to realize how hard it is to be without their teacher, but even if they wanted to see me, they couldn't. So this one writes a letter hoping I'll go back, that one writes a letter hoping I'll go back, and I don't pay attention to any of them. That's how people are: when they can see you every day, they don't think it's important; once they can't see you and there's nothing they can do about it, then they feel it's important.

[Addendum 1] Bhikshu Elder Zhi Ding recounted in his article "In Memory of Elder To Lun":

In 1962, when Elder To Lun was coming to America to propagate the Dharma, he passed through Hawaii and stayed for two weeks. I did my modest part as host, looked after him properly, and held a welcome reception, and on many occasions I invited Elder To Lun to give instructional talks to the fourfold assembly of disciples here. After staying in Hawaii for two weeks, Elder To Lun flew directly to San Francisco.

[Addendum 2] From the diary of Upasika Tan Guo Zheng:

On the afternoon of March 8, I went to the Buddhist Lecture Hall to mail packages of sutras to America. Suddenly everything everywhere seemed gloomy, and I didn't know when we would see the light of day again.

[Addendum 3] Upasika Mei Miaoling recounted:

The Master left Hong Kong for America in 1962. My mother asked the Master why he was leaving. The Master said his Hong Kong disciples were not well-behaved and seldom came to the temple, so he was leaving.

The Venerable Master said:

I have vowed to reorganize Buddhism in the West and make it flourish anew, so that people will understand what Buddhism is really about.

Why did I come to America to propagate the Buddhadharma? Because this country doesn't have a long history, and the people's habits aren't so cunning; they're all honest, straightforward people who can very easily cultivate according to the Dharma and very easily accept the principles of Buddhism. Because of this, I came to this country to propagate the Buddhadharma, hoping to make everyone understand the true principles of Buddhism.

100. Seeing Hong Kong Again

At the end of 1974, the Venerable Master returned to Hong Kong from America for the first time. Later, in 1978, 1981, and 1988, at the invitation of the Buddhist Association of Taiwan, Buddhist circles in Southeast Asia, and the Third World Buddhist Sangha Council, the Venerable Master returned to his old haunts...

From late November 1974 to January 1975, the Venerable Master, who had been away from Hong Kong for a full 12 years, led two American disciples who had earlier made the "three steps, one bow" pilgrimage, Dharma Masters Heng Ju and Heng Yo, on a tour to propagate the Dharma and make visits in Taiwan, Hong Kong, Thailand, India, Ceylon, Singapore, Vietnam, and Japan. During the tour, besides speaking the Dharma at monasteries, Way-places, and universities in each place, he also presided over a Buddha Recitation session in Hong Kong. This was the Venerable Master's first return to Hong Kong from America.

From July to September 1978, at the invitation of Buddhist circles throughout Southeast Asia, the Venerable Master led a delegation to propagate the Dharma in Malaysia, Singapore, Bangkok in Thailand, Hong Kong, and other places. He arrived in Hong Kong at 8 p.m. on September 16; this was the Venerable Master's second return to Hong Kong. From September 22 to September 26, from 7 to 9 p.m., the Venerable Master gave instructional talks at the Buddhist Studies Lecture Hall of Tung Lin Kok Yuen.

At the end of November 1981, having been invited to attend the Third World Buddhist Sangha Council hosted by the Buddhist Association of Taiwan, the Venerable Master once again led a delegation to propagate the Dharma in

Taiwan, Hong Kong, Singapore, and Malaysia. This was the Venerable Master's third return to Hong Kong.

In December 1988, at the invitation of Buddhist circles in Taiwan, Hong Kong, Singapore, and Malaysia, the Venerable Master once again led a delegation to propagate the Dharma in these places. This was the Venerable Master's fourth return to Hong Kong, and also his last.

Over more than 40 years, there were also many disciples in Hong Kong who followed the Venerable Master with the utmost sincerity. These devout refuge disciples—such as Huang Jiefang; the couple Li Jiajing and Huang Jiemei; Liang Huixian; Ruan Guo Ni; the couple Zeng Jinyan and Zeng Wanhua; Zeng Guo Sheng; Lin Guo Sen; and others—for decades, the same from one day to the next, have held firm faith in the Buddhadharma, supported the Way-places, and revered and followed the Venerable Master consistently from beginning to end.

How difficult it was for the Venerable Master to break new ground on rocky soil, sowing the Buddha-seeds of the Mahayana Buddhadharma in Hong Kong and lighting the lamp of the mind for living beings!

Summary of the Venerable Master's instructional talk to his Hong Kong disciples, November 26, 1974:

You say you hope I'll come back twice a year, three times a year. If I came back every day, you'd say, "Shifu isn't good in this way, and Shifu isn't right in that way either!" "Shifu plays favorites! He's good to this disciple and not good to that disciple." There would be plenty of gossip! This time at Chi Lin Nunnery I said it very clearly: if you can cultivate the Way, that is truly making offerings to me. If you don't cultivate the Way but give me good things to eat, I don't like that. Whoever among you can truly apply effort in cultivating the Way and earnestly put the Buddhadharma into practice—that is what it means to give me good things to eat.

Everyone should bring forth a true mind and use a true mind to cultivate the Way. That is "true vigor, and is called a true Dharma offering..." To tell you the truth, for decades I haven't dwelt on forms, sounds, smells, tastes, tangible objects, or dharmas. If you just keep giving me good things to eat, the better I eat, the unhappier I am. It uses up all my blessings, and my wisdom too, and I'd become someone even more stupid than you. Then how could I be your teacher?

On this trip back to Hong Kong, someone wanted to hand his Way-place over to me to manage and invited me to be its abbot. I gave him three conditions: "All your monastic and lay disciples must keep the rule of not eating after noon [Tr.: the monastic precept of taking no food after midday]; they must not eat after midday. That's the first condition. The second condition: no rushing about performing sutra recitations and repentances for payment; we are not afraid of starving to death. The third condition: no one, whether monastic or lay, may smoke cigarettes, drink alcohol, or eat meat." He couldn't accept any of my three conditions. Even if he had accepted just one condition, I wouldn't have

wanted it. However big the Way-place, if it's so sloppy and its reputation so bad, I wouldn't take it no matter what!

November 1972

The Venerable Master's instructional talk to three American disciples who were about to go to Hong Kong:

When you get there, if anyone gives you something to eat after twelve noon—say he brings milk—pour the milk on the ground; if he brings candy, throw it into the toilet. And say this: "These things you've given me—I'm now telling them not to pass through a human stomach but to go straight to the toilet. You people are too bad! Why do you want to destroy our precepts? It's precisely because you didn't listen to his teachings that Shifu left and stopped teaching and transforming you. And to this day you still don't know to repent—you're still acting recklessly!"

[Addendum 1] *Kung Sheung Daily News*, Monday, September 17, 1978: (content omitted)

[Addendum 2] *Kung Sheung Daily News*, Wednesday, September 19, 1978: (content omitted)

[Addendum 3] *Kung Sheung Daily News*, Sunday, September 23, 1978: (content omitted)

[Addendum 4] In 1978, when the Venerable Master went to Asia to propagate the Dharma, while speaking the Dharma at Tung Lin Kok Yuen in Hong Kong, he revealed the hardships he had faced in propagating the Dharma in Hong Kong:

I have let down my compatriots and fellow cultivators in Hong Kong! I'm not saying this casually; these words come from the bottom of my heart. I lived in Hong Kong for more than ten years, from 1949 to 1962, and there wasn't a single day I didn't want to make the Buddhadharma flourish. But this place is very peculiar: if you tell people the truth, they don't believe it; if you tell them lies, especially rumors and gossip born of deviant views, they gladly accept them. I have always followed the principle that "the straight mind is the Way-place" and have never told lies, yet nobody likes to hear what I say. But no matter what, I'm going to speak the truth!

[Addendum 5] At the end of November 1981, the Venerable Master was invited to Asia to propagate the Dharma. From December 11 to 14, at City Hall in North Point, Hong Kong, he gave a series of Dharma lectures on four consecutive evenings, from 7 to 9 p.m. The audience listened to the Venerable Master's incisive instructional talks with great interest.

On the evening of the first day (December 11), the Venerable Master began right away by saying, "People who study Buddhism must first themselves have proper knowledge and views; only with proper knowledge and views can they know how to cultivate. In cultivation, one must first understand the Dharma door of the Seven Shares of Bodhi." He also spoke of "dhyana," saying, "When

you gain a little benefit in samadhi, you give rise to arrogance and pride, or you think you've become enlightened. Remember this! You must not claim to have attained what you have not attained, babbling that you're enlightened—what kind of enlightenment have you got! This is telling a great lie, and in the future you'll fall into the Hell of Tongue Pulling. Therefore, all who study Buddhism must not create karma that is a mixture of good and evil, must not put tall hats on themselves, 'sell' their cultivation, or advertise their own virtue. That's the behavior of a con man!"

On the evening of the second day (December 12), the Venerable Master said, "I lived in Hong Kong for more than ten years, and many young people followed me in studying the Buddhadharma, because I'm also very fond of young people. Later, when the conditions ripened, I went to America." He also said, "American Buddhism is a brand-new Buddhism, but American Buddhism originally doesn't belong to America; rather, it belongs to the whole world. Buddhism should not have distinctions of nationality, race, or self and others. Buddhism is the religion of the whole world and all humanity. True Buddhism is not limited by distinctions of nationality, region, or self and others.

"In Asia, people generally acknowledge that this is the Dharma-Ending Age. But the Dharma itself does not have a Proper Dharma and a Dharma-Ending; rather, it is because people don't cultivate that there is a Dharma-Ending Age. As the saying goes, 'People can propagate the Dharma; it is not the Dharma that propagates people.' If people cultivate earnestly and without interruption, then the Proper Dharma will long abide in the world. When people don't cultivate, that is the Dharma-Ending Age."

On the evening of the third day—since for several days running the Hong Kong newspapers had all been carrying news of the Venerable Master's return to Hong Kong to propagate the Dharma, and one of the "hot" topics was the question "Why do monastics wear the kashaya?"—the Venerable Master, in response to these circumstances, patiently explained that evening the importance of Bhikshus wearing the kashaya. Then the Venerable Master recounted an incident from San Francisco. While he told it, the audience listened with rapt attention; not one person left in the middle. What incident was it? In 1978 the Golden Dragon Massacre took place in San Francisco, shocking the community and throwing the overseas Chinese of Chinatown into panic. Afterwards, the Wah Ching gang wanted to launch a second or even a third Golden Dragon massacre, all because the Wah Ching and the Joe Boys were fighting over turf. But later they all took refuge with the Triple Jewel, took refuge at the City of Ten Thousand Buddhas, and threw their weapons into the sea. After they reformed, those who went to school went to school and those who worked went to work, and they never again did evil. The Venerable Master said, "I would rather teach people through the power of moral transformation than oppress people with force."

On the evening of the fourth day (December 14), the Venerable Master first explained "the Venerable Ananda's four questions to the Buddha," and then

expounded the "Four Applications of Mindfulness" among the "Thirty-seven Wings of Enlightenment," namely, "Contemplate the body as impure, contemplate feelings as suffering, contemplate the mind as impermanent, and contemplate dharmas as without self." The Venerable Master said, "The sea of suffering is boundless; turn your head around, and there is the shore. Don't keep bobbing up and down in the sea of suffering anymore; otherwise you will never have a day of liberation." Because the audience was delighted to hear the essentials of the Dharma and did not want it to end, the Venerable Master continued: "In the past I lived in Hong Kong for 14 years, and in 1962 I left Hong Kong for America. Although I lived in Hong Kong for so long, I made no contribution at all to Hong Kong. Coming back from America this time, I wish to establish Dharma affinities with all you elders, brothers, and compatriots of Hong Kong, and truly deliver the Buddhadharma into your hearts. If I can do this, I will feel comforted."

[Addendum 6] The Venerable Master said:

Because Hong Kong's environment is very peculiar—neither like Chinese culture nor like Western culture, neither Chinese nor Western—it's very complicated. In this kind of environment, doing business comes first, and whoever makes the most money is considered the most capable. As for the Buddhadharma, you could say people have only a superficial understanding, and not many study it seriously. Among the virtuous ones who have dabbled a little in Buddhist studies, very few truly cultivate, and it's very hard to find people who truly want to enter deeply into the sutra treasury and have wisdom like the sea. All the people here know about is profit, and all they understand is obtaining profit. There is very little study of Buddhism, so no matter where a sutra lecture or Dharma assembly is held, very few people come. This is the result of Hong Kong's peculiar environment.

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Appendix: Chinese–English Glossary of Terms and Names

Titles and Forms of Address

Chinese	English
上人	the Venerable Master
宣化上人	the Venerable Master Hsuan Hua
宣公上人 / 宣公	the Venerable Master Hua
師父	the Master (third person); "Shifu" (direct address in speech)
安慈	An Tse (the Master's Dharma name)
度輪 / 度輪法師 / 度輪長老 / 度輪禪師	To Lun / Dharma Master To Lun / Elder To Lun / Chan Master To Lun
度老 / 度公 / 度公上人	Elder To Lun / the Venerable To Lun / the Venerable Master To Lun
安慈大師	Great Master An Tse
山僧 / 乞士	this mountain monk / this mendicant
師公	Grand Master
師兄 / 師弟	Dharma brother
師侄	Dharma nephew
徒弟 / 弟子	disciple
皈依弟子	refuge disciple
出家弟子 / 在家弟子	monastic disciple / lay disciple
法師	Dharma Master
老和尚	Elder Master
長老	Elder
大師	Great Master
老法師	elder Dharma Master
和尚	monk
比丘 / 比丘尼	Bhikshu / Bhikshuni
沙彌 / 沙彌尼	shramanera (novice monk) / shramanerika (novice nun)
居士	Upasaka (man) / Upasika (woman), placed before the name: "Upasika Tan Guo Zheng"
居士	layperson / lay Buddhist
老居士	elderly Upasaka/Upasika
出家人	monastic / left-home person
在家人	layperson
善信 / 信眾	faithful devotees / devotees
護法	Dharma protector
施主	donor
方丈	abbot
住持	abbot
當家	manager (of a monastery)
知客	guest prefect

僧團	Sangha (monastic community)
釋 **X (monastic surname)**	Shi X

Monastics

Chinese	English
虛雲老和尚 / 虛老 / 雲公 / 雲公老人 / 虛雲老人 / 虛雲和尚	Elder Master Hsu Yun / Elder Hsu / the Venerable Yun / the Venerable Elder Yun / Elder Hsu Yun / Master Hsu Yun
來果老和尚 / 來果大師	Elder Master Lai Guo / Great Master Lai Guo
倓虛老和尚	Elder Master Tan Xu
茂峰法師 / 茂峰老和尚	Dharma Master Mao Feng / Elder Master Mao Feng
慧德法師	Dharma Master Hui De
知定長老 / 知定法師	Elder Zhi Ding / Dharma Master Zhi Ding
成元法師	Dharma Master Cheng Yuan
續行法師	Dharma Master Xu Xing
融秋法師	Dharma Master Rong Qiu
旭朗法師 / 旭朗老和尚 / 旭朗老法師	Dharma Master Xu Lang / Elder Master Xu Lang
明觀法師 / 明觀和尚	Dharma Master Ming Guan
聖一老和尚 / 聖一法師	Elder Master Sheng Yi / Dharma Master Sheng Yi
樂觀法師	Dharma Master Le Guan
親覺法師 / 比丘	Dharma Master Qin Jue
法藏法師	Dharma Master Fa Zang
法傳大師 / 法傳法師	Great Master Fa Chuan / Dharma Master Fa Chuan
清嚴和尚 / 法師	Master Qing Yan / Dharma Master Qing Yan
玄智老法師 / 老和尚	Elder Dharma Master Xuan Zhi / Elder Master Xuan Zhi
定西老法師	Elder Dharma Master Ding Xi
紹雲老法師	Elder Dharma Master Shao Yun
永惺法師	Dharma Master Yong Xing
寬運法師	Dharma Master Kuan Yun
博山和尚	Master Boshan
憨山大師	Great Master Hanshan
永嘉大師	Great Master Yongjia
六祖大師 / 慧能大師	the Sixth Patriarch / Great Master Huineng
二祖	the Second Patriarch
達摩	Bodhidharma
濟公	Jigong
玉琳國師	National Master Yulin
恆定法師 **(果一)**	Dharma Master Heng Ding (Guo Yi)
恆越法師	Dharma Master Heng Yue
恆智法師	Dharma Master Heng Zhi
恆益法師 **(釋果利)**	Dharma Master Heng Yi (Shi Guo Li)

恆起法師 (釋果忍)	Dharma Master Heng Qi (Shi Guo Ren)
近慈法師 (果森, 親仁)	Dharma Master Jin Ci (Guo Sen; Qin Ren)
恆貴法師	Dharma Master Heng Gui
恆興法師	Dharma Master Heng Xing
恆偉法師	Dharma Master Heng Wei
恆和法師	Dharma Master Heng He
恆實法師	Dharma Master Heng Sure
恆持法師	Dharma Master Heng Chih
恆具 / 恆由	Heng Ju / Heng Yo
恆寂 (果能) / 恆禹 (果舜) / 果維	Heng Ji (Guo Neng) / Heng Yu (Guo Shun) / Guo Wei
恆來 / 恆授 / 恆守 / 恆祥 / 恆福 / 恆順 / 恆相 / 恆靜	Heng Lai / Heng Shou / Heng Shou / Heng Xiang / Heng Fu / Heng Shun / Heng Xiang / Heng Jing

Lay Disciples and Other People

Chinese	English
譚果正	Tan Guo Zheng
譚果式 (譚慕潔)	Tan Guo Shi (Tan Mujie)
譚果璞 (譚璞才)	Tan Guo Pu (Tan Pucai), father of the Tan sisters
甘果彥	Gan Guo Yan, mother of the Tan sisters
文果蜜	Wen Guo Mi
余果滿	Yu Guo Man
余果興	Yu Guo Xing (her son)
薛果鳳	Xue Guo Feng (Yu Guo Man's daughter-in-law)
劉果娟	Liu Guo Juan
羅果明 (黃太太)	Luo Guo Ming (Mrs. Huang)
黃果松	Huang Guo Song (daughter of Luo Guo Ming)
黃果君	Huang Guo Jun (son of Luo Guo Ming)
王果海 (王太太)	Wang Guo Hai (Mrs. Wang)
陳寬滿	Chen Kuan Man
謝寬輝	Xie Kuan Hui
郭寬普	Guo Kuan Pu
袁果祥 / 袁果珍	Yuan Guo Xiang / Yuan Guo Zhen (sisters)
袁果林 (陳瑞昌夫人)	Yuan Guo Lin (Mrs. Chen Ruichang)
陳瑞昌	Chen Ruichang (Hong Kong businessman, 大光公司 Daguang Company)
李果遠 (李大華)	Li Guo Yuan (Li Dahua)
黎果合	Li Guo He
果殊	Guo Shu
果平	Guo Ping
蔡果夙 / 薛果夙	Cai Guo Su / Xue Guo Su (keep as written; flag in errata if inconsistent)
果宏	Guo Hong

果全 / 果根	Guo Quan / Guo Gen
胡果為	Hu Guo Wei
裴果鑒 (裴有明, 裴證慧)	Pei Guo Jian (Pei Youming; Pei Zhenghui)
梅妙玲	Mei Miaoling
許湘君	Xu Xiangjun
鐘美薇 (果迦)	Zhong Meiwei (Guo Jia)
伍英才 (果棟)	Wu Yingcai (Guo Dong)
阮果霓	Ruan Guo Ni
詹勵吾	Zhan Liwu
唐果善 / 麥果蓮 / 陳果發 / 葉果慶 / 董果耆 / 湯果雲 / 姚果白 / 何果章 / 洪果宏 / 陳果升 / 馬果仙	Tang Guo Shan / Mai Guo Lian / Chen Guo Fa / Ye Guo Qing / Dong Guo Qi / Tang Guo Yun / Yao Guo Bai / He Guo Zhang / Hong Guo Hong / Chen Guo Sheng / Ma Guo Xian

Places and Institutions

Chinese	English
香港 / 香江	Hong Kong
九龍 / 新界	Kowloon / the New Territories
大嶼山 / 嶼山	Lantau Island
荃灣	Tsuen Wan
芙蓉山	Fu Yung Shan
觀音洞	Guanyin Cave
跑馬地	Happy Valley
筲箕灣 / 西灣河 / 馬山村	Shau Kei Wan / Sai Wan Ho / Ma Shan Village
萬丈瀑 / 萬丈布	Man Cheung Po
靈會山	Ling Wui Shan
昂坪	Ngong Ping
大澳 / 石壁 / 長沙	Tai O / Shek Pik / Cheung Sha
北角 / 中環 / 西環 / 香港仔 / 半山 / 山頂	North Point / Central / Sai Wan / Aberdeen / the Mid-Levels / the Peak
沙田 / 元朗 / 青山 / 鑽石山 / 黃大仙 / 啟德	Sha Tin / Yuen Long / Castle Peak / Diamond Hill / Wong Tai Sin / Kai Tak
東普陀寺	Tung Po Tor Monastery
竹林禪院	Chuk Lam Sim Yuen (Bamboo Grove Monastery)
寶蓮寺 / 寶蓮禪寺	Po Lin Monastery
寶林禪寺	Po Lam Monastery
志蓮淨苑	Chi Lin Nunnery
東蓮覺苑	Tung Lin Kok Yuen
正覺蓮社	Ching Kok Lin Association
東林念佛堂	Tung Lin Buddha Recitation Hall
鹿野苑	Luk Ye Yuen
西林寺 / 凌雲寺 / 圓通寺 / 妙法寺	Sai Lam Monastery / Ling Wan Monastery / Yuen Tung Monastery / Miu Fat Monastery
通善壇	Tung Sin Tan
大會堂	City Hall

香港佛教聯合會	Hong Kong Buddhist Association
東華 **(**三院**)**	Tung Wah (Group of Hospitals)
市政局 **/** 市政局議員	Urban Council / Urban Council member
西樂園寺 **/** 西樂園	Western Bliss Gardens Monastery / Western Bliss Gardens
慈興寺 **/** 慈興禪寺	Cixing Monastery / Cixing Chan Monastery
國清禪院 **/** 國清寺	Guoqing Chan Monastery / Guoqing Monastery (Cixing's predecessor)
佛教講堂 **/** 香港佛教講堂	the Buddhist Lecture Hall / the Hong Kong Buddhist Lecture Hall
三藩市佛教講堂 **/** 金山佛教講堂	the San Francisco Buddhist Lecture Hall
金山寺 **/** 金山聖寺	Gold Mountain Monastery / Gold Mountain Sagely Monastery
萬佛城 **/** 萬佛聖城	the City of Ten Thousand Buddhas
金輪寺 **/** 金聖寺 **/** 金佛寺 **/** 長堤聖寺	Gold Wheel Monastery / Gold Sage Monastery / Gold Buddha Monastery / Long Beach Monastery
法界佛教總會 **(**法總**)**	Dharma Realm Buddhist Association (DRBA)
法界佛教印經會	Dharma Realm Buddhist Books Distribution Society
中美佛教總會	Sino-American Buddhist Association
東北	Manchuria (Northeast China)
南華寺 **/** 曹溪	Nanhua Monastery / Caoxi
雲門大覺寺 **/** 雲門	Dajue Monastery at Yunmen / Yunmen
雲居山 **/** 真如禪寺	Mount Yunju / Zhenru Chan Monastery
韶關 **/** 馬壩	Shaoguan / Maba
六榕寺	Liurong Monastery
普陀山	Mount Putuo
靈巖山	Lingyan Mountain
高旻寺	Gaomin Monastery
三緣寺	Sanyuan Monastery
古德寺	Gude Monastery
鼓山 **/** 湧泉寺	Gushan / Yongquan Monastery
五台山	Mount Wutai
雲棲	Yunqi
瀋陽	Shenyang
龍蓮寺 **/** 龍蓮禪寺	Wat Mangkon Kamalawat (Longlian Monastery), Bangkok
暹羅	Siam
緬甸 **/** 仰光	Burma / Rangoon
檀香山	Honolulu
舊金山 **/** 三藩市	San Francisco
檀香山中華佛教會	Chinese Buddhist Association of Hawaii
台灣佛教會	the Buddhist Association of Taiwan
世界佛教僧伽大會	World Buddhist Sangha Council (conference)

Texts and Publications

Chinese	English
《地藏經》/《地藏菩薩本願經》	Earth Store Sutra / Sutra of the Past Vows of Earth Store Bodhisattva
《楞嚴經》/《楞嚴》	Shurangama Sutra
《六祖壇經》	Sixth Patriarch's Dharma Jewel Platform Sutra (short: Sixth Patriarch Sutra)
《法華經》/《妙法蓮華經》	Dharma Flower Sutra / Wonderful Dharma Lotus Flower Sutra
《金剛經》/《金剛般若波羅蜜經》	Vajra Sutra / Vajra Prajna Paramita Sutra
《大般若經》	Great Prajna Sutra
《華嚴經》/《大方廣佛華嚴經》	Avatamsaka Sutra / Great Means Expansive Buddha Flower Adornment Sutra
〈賢首品〉	"Worthy Leader Chapter"
《普門品》	Universal Door Chapter
《彌陀經》/《阿彌陀經》	Amitabha Sutra
《心經》/《般若波羅蜜多心經》	Heart Sutra
《金光明經》	Golden Light Sutra
《梵網經》/《梵網菩薩戒經》	Brahma Net Sutra / Brahma Net Bodhisattva Precepts Sutra
《大悲心陀羅尼經》	Great Compassion Heart Dharani Sutra
《因果經》	Sutra of Cause and Effect
《大藏經》	the Tripitaka (Buddhist Canon)
《阿含》	the Agamas
《高僧傳》	Biographies of Eminent Monks
大悲咒/楞嚴咒/往生咒	Great Compassion Mantra / Shurangama Mantra / Rebirth Mantra
大悲懺/藥師懺/消災延壽藥師寶懺/水懺	Great Compassion Repentance / Medicine Master Repentance / Jeweled Repentance of the Medicine Master for Eradicating Disasters and Lengthening Life / Water Repentance
《心法》	Mind Dharma (Xinfa) magazine
《金剛菩提海》	Vajra Bodhi Sea
《宣化上人開示錄》	Venerable Master Hua's Talks on Dharma
《虛雲老和尚畫傳集》	Pictorial Biography of Elder Master Hsu Yun
《增訂佛祖道影》/《再增訂佛祖道影》	Images and Biographies of the Buddhas and Patriarchs (Expanded Edition) / (Further Expanded Edition)
《佛祖道影白話解》	Vernacular Commentary on the Images and Biographies of the Buddhas and Patriarchs
《虛雲老和尚涅槃專刊》	Special Commemorative Issue on the Nirvana of Elder Master Hsu Yun
《虛雲老和尚法彙》	Collected Dharma Talks of Elder Master Hsu Yun
《虛雲老和尚年譜》	Chronicle of Elder Master Hsu Yun
《度輪禪師事跡》/《度輪法師事跡》	Records of Chan Master To Lun / Records of Dharma Master To Lun

《工商日報》 / 《華僑日報》 / 《華僑晚報》 / 《星島日報》 / 《成報》	Kung Sheung Daily News / Wah Kiu Yat Po / Wah Kiu Man Po / Sing Tao Daily / Sing Pao
《金山時報》	Gold Mountain Times
《道德經》 / 《老子》 / 《孟子》 / 《古文觀止》	Tao Te Ching / Laozi / Mencius / Guwen Guanzhi
《聖經》	the Bible
《維基百科》	Wikipedia

Buddhist and Monastic Terms

Chinese	English
佛法 / 法	the Buddhadharma / the Dharma
弘法 / 弘揚佛法	propagate the Dharma
講經 / 講經說法	lecture on the sutras / lecture on the sutras and speak the Dharma
法會	Dharma assembly
開示	instructional talk; to instruct
度眾生 / 度人	cross over living beings / save people
眾生	living beings
因緣 / 緣	causes and conditions / affinity, conditions
業 / 業障	karma / karmic obstacles
業力	karmic power
因果	cause and effect
魔 / 魔障 / 魔考 / 天魔	demon(s) / demonic obstacles / demonic test / heavenly demons
鬼 / 餓鬼	ghost / hungry ghost
鬼神	ghosts and spirits
護法神 / 護法善神	Dharma-protecting spirits
菩薩 / 佛 / 阿羅漢 / 獨覺	Bodhisattva / Buddha / Arhat / Solitary Enlightened One (pratyekabuddha)
觀世音菩薩 / 觀音	Guanshiyin Bodhisattva / Guanyin
地藏菩薩	Earth Store Bodhisattva
阿彌陀佛	Amitabha Buddha
釋迦牟尼佛	Shakyamuni Buddha
藥師佛	Medicine Master Buddha
西方三聖	the Three Sages of the West
大乘 / 小乘	Mahayana / Small Vehicle (Hinayana)
南傳佛教	Theravada (Southern) Buddhism
禪宗 / 淨土宗 / 律宗 / 天台宗	the Chan School / the Pure Land School / the Vinaya School / the Tiantai School
宗門	the Chan lineage
末法	the Dharma-Ending Age
正法	the Proper Dharma
正知正見	proper knowledge and views
戒定慧	precepts, samadhi, and wisdom
三無漏學	the Three Non-Outflow Studies
七菩提分	the Seven Shares of Bodhi
三十七道品	the Thirty-seven Wings of Enlightenment

四念處	the Four Applications of Mindfulness
六度	the Six Perfections
五戒 / 菩薩戒	the five precepts / the Bodhisattva precepts
受戒 / 傳戒	receive the precepts / transmit the precepts
受具足戒	receive full ordination
出家	leave the home-life (become a monastic)
剃度	shave the head and leave home (tonsure)
還俗	return to lay life
修行 / 修道	cultivate / cultivate the Way
用功	apply effort (in practice)
參禪 / 坐禪 / 打坐	investigate Chan / sit in Chan meditation / sit in meditation
雙盤	full lotus
入定 / 定力	enter samadhi / samadhi power
經行	walking meditation
念佛	recite the Buddha's name
念佛堂	Buddha Recitation Hall
禪七 / 佛七	Chan session / Buddha Recitation session
早晚課	morning and evening recitation
拜懺	bow in repentance
回向	dedicate (merit) / transfer of merit
超度	rescue (the deceased) to rebirth
加持	aid with spiritual power; bless
放生	liberate life
供養	make offerings; offering
化緣	seek alms / seek donations
結緣	establish affinities
法供養	Dharma offering
善知識	Good and Wise Advisor
傳法 / 法脈	transmit the Dharma / Dharma lineage
衣缽	robe and bowl
祖師	Patriarch
開山祖師	founding Patriarch
頭陀 / 頭陀行	dhuta / ascetic (dhuta) practices
苦行	ascetic practice
涅槃	Nirvana
圓寂 / 示寂	enter perfect stillness / manifest stillness
往生	pass away (lit. be reborn)
荼毗	cremation (jhapita)
化身爐	cremation furnace
舍利 / 靈骨	sharira / remains (bone relics)
法相	photo of the Master / Dharma image
法座	Dharma seat
大殿	Buddha Hall
齋堂	dining hall
靜室	quiet hut / hermitage

茅蓬 / 茅棚	thatched hut
精舍	vihara / hermitage
道場	Way-place (monastery / practice center)
寺 / 禪寺 / 禪院	Monastery / Chan Monastery
磬 / 引磬 / 木魚	bell (qing) / hand bell / wooden fish
法器	Dharma instruments
海青	robe (haiqing)
搭衣	put on the sash
念珠	recitation beads
吃素 / 茹素	be vegetarian
齋 / 齋飯	vegetarian meal
盂蘭盆	Ullambana
佛誕 / 浴佛	the Buddha's birthday / bathing the Buddha
觀音誕	Guanyin's birthday
安居	summer retreat
打七 / 華嚴七 / 般舟七 / 彌陀七	seven-day session / Avatamsaka session / Pratyutpanna session / Amitabha session
扶乩 / 乩童	planchette writing / spirit medium
外道	non-Buddhist path / externalist
道教 / 全真派 / 呂純陽祖師	Taoism / the Quanzhen school / Patriarch Lü Chunyang
風水 / 八字	fengshui / birth chart (eight characters)
冤親債主	karmic creditors
南閻浮提眾生，其性剛強，難調難伏	"The beings of Jambudvipa are stubborn and difficult to tame and subdue."

Recurring Phrases

Chinese	English
凍死不攀緣，餓死不化緣，窮死不求緣	Freezing, we do not scheme. Starving, we do not beg. Dying of poverty, we ask for nothing.
隨緣不變，不變隨緣	We accord with conditions, yet do not change; we do not change, yet accord with conditions.
抱定我們三大宗旨	We hold firmly to our three great principles
不爭、不貪、不求、不自私、不自利、不打妄語	no fighting, no greed, no seeking, no selfishness, no pursuit of personal advantage, and no lying
打妄想	have idle thoughts; 妄想 false thinking
業風	karmic winds

Other Names and Terms (in order of first appearance)

Chinese	English
《韶關地方史大事記》	Chronicle of Major Events in the Local History of Shaoguan
中秋節	Mid-Autumn Festival
船舶站	ship terminal

一枝草葉一滴露，一個羅漢一份齋	Every blade of grass has its drop of dew; every Arhat has his share of the meal
大開山門，海單接眾	opening the monastery gates wide and receiving all comers with lodging as vast as the sea
葵棚	palm-leaf shed
雲水堂	Cloud and Water Hall
中國佛教律學院	Chinese Buddhist Vinaya Academy
留學僧團 / 留學僧	delegation of study-abroad monks / study-abroad monk
同參 / 打同參	"fellow investigators" (fellow Chan practitioners); practice together as fellow investigators
言語道斷	the path of words is cut off
《悼念度輪長老》	In Memory of Elder To Lun
曼谷	Bangkok
同治元年	the first year of the Tongzhi reign of the Qing dynasty
龍蓮子 / 雙心蓮子	"dragon lotus seeds" / double-hearted lotus seeds
受苦了苦，享福消福	Undergoing suffering ends suffering; enjoying blessings uses up blessings
捨不得死，換不了生	If you can't give up death, you can't gain life
閉關	closed retreat
台山	Taishan, Guangdong
方居士	Upasaka Fang
道鑒 / 光鑒	for your perusal in the Way / for your illustrious perusal
道安	Peace in the Way
頂禮	With bows
人壽十歲	when the human lifespan has dwindled to ten years
達摩剎竿	Bodhidharma's banner pole
手啟	Personally written by
揚州	Yangzhou
果前	Guo Qian
甘露	sweet dew
蠟(瀝)青紙	tar paper
香油錢	money for incense and oil
劉寬盛	Liu Kuan Sheng (female, elderly Upasika)
本地法師	"Local Dharma Master"
斤	catty / catties
中國大陸留港僧人聯誼會	Fellowship Association of Mainland Chinese Monastics in Hong Kong
理事長	chairman
國民政府	the National Government
淮海戰役	Huaihai Campaign
僧尼南遷	"southward migration of monks and nuns"

白山（長白山）黑水（黑龍江）	the White Mountains (the Changbai Mountains) and the Black Waters (the Heilong River)
僧伽聯誼會	"Sangha Fellowship Association"
肉身菩薩	flesh-body Bodhisattva
跑了	"ran off"
小阿羅漢	"Little Arhat"
坐缸 / 開缸	be seated in a vat / open the vat
慈航法師	Dharma Master Ci Hang
裝金、貼金	gild and cover in gold leaf
示現病苦相	manifest the appearance of illness and suffering
住錫	take up residence (of a monk)
大陸留港僧伽聯誼會	Fellowship Association of Mainland Monastics in Hong Kong
新店海藏寺	Haizang Monastery in Xindian
漢口	Hankou
《中國大陸留港僧人聯誼會人名冊》	Membership Roster of the Fellowship Association of Mainland Chinese Monastics in Hong Kong
夢生法師	Dharma Master Meng Sheng
四六	"four and six" (father and mother, by stroke count)
外甥女	niece (sister's daughter)
斗法	duel / contest of powers
常義法師	Dharma Master Chang Yi
徒侄 / 師伯 / 徒孫	Dharma nephew / Dharma uncle / grand-disciple
三寶	the Triple Jewel
老魔王	"Old Demon King"
茅山（老）道	Maoshan (old) Taoist
香港五大怪	the Five Great Oddities of Hong Kong
極樂世界	the Land of Ultimate Bliss
新春賀詞 / 新年賀詞	New Year's blessing
法幢	Dharma banner
寶覺寺	Po Kok Monastery
文字般若	prajna of written words
天主教英文書院	Catholic English-medium school
天眼	the heavenly eye
乩文 / 詩箋	planchette message / poem
呂祖 / 呂洞賓	Patriarch Lü / Lü Dongbin
拋磚引玉	cast out a brick to draw forth jade
歸家認祖	returning home and acknowledging his ancestors
《從參佛經過說起》	"Starting from How I Came to Study Buddhism" (essay by Tan Guo Pu)
辛卯孟冬	the first month of winter in the year Xinmao
南海茶山慶雲洞	Qingyun Cave at Chashan in Nanhai,

	Guangdong
結志街 / 威靈頓街	Gage Street / Wellington Street (Central)
群賢壇	Qunxian Tan (Altar of the Assembled Worthies)
茶山慶雲洞駐港通善壇	Tung Sin Tan of Chashan Qingyun Cave in Hong Kong
乩師	the medium
卜筮	divination
鶉結衣單 (鶉衣)	tattered, patched robe
密宗	Esoteric Buddhism
譚喬建（譚果行）	Tan Qiaojian (Tan Guo Xing), male
譚慕顏（譚果岸）	Tan Muyan (Tan Guo An), female
我相	the mark of self
獻丑不如藏拙	Better to hide my clumsiness than to put my poor skills on display
文革	the Cultural Revolution
一紀	twelve years
四十二手眼	the Forty-two Hands and Eyes
寶印手	Jeweled Seal Hand
廣成子	Guangchengzi
翻天印	Heaven-Overturning Seal
閻君 / 鬼王	King Yama / ghost kings
算命批八字	fortune-tellers who read his birth chart
兒孫自有兒孫福，何必為兒孫做馬牛	Children and grandchildren have their own blessings; why be a horse or an ox for them?
美籍華僑	Chinese American with U.S. citizenship
中堂 / 壽衣	main hall / burial clothes
神識	spirit (consciousness)
南無大悲觀世音菩薩	Namo Greatly Compassionate Guanshiyin Bodhisattva
觀音十大願 / 願我速知一切法	Guanyin's ten great vows / "I vow to quickly know all dharmas"
街喉	"street hydrant"
霸王地	"overlord land"
經懺 (趕經懺)	sutra recitations and repentance rites (rush from one to the next)
三如來	the Three Tathagatas
牌位 (排位)	memorial tablets
造叢林	build monasteries
果亮 / 果禮	Guo Liang / Guo Li (monastic disciples)
古龍玉	ancient dragon jade
南無大慈大悲觀世音菩薩	Namo Greatly Kind, Greatly Compassionate Guanshiyin Bodhisattva
荃灣東林寺	Tung Lin Monastery in Tsuen Wan
《虛雲老和尚的事跡》	Records of the Life of Elder Master Hsu Yun
應無所住而生其心	"Produce a thought that dwells nowhere"
制水	water rationing

龍天擁護	the protection of the gods and dragons
《華嚴經賢首品淺釋》	Simple Explanation of the "Worthy Leader Chapter" of the Avatamsaka Sutra
果童	Guo Tong
《上人事跡》	Records of the Venerable Master
頭上安頭 **(**盡頭上按頭**)**	putting a head on top of a head
《放眼觀世界》	Looking Out at the World (Fangyan Guan Shijie)
曲徑通幽處，禪房花木深	"A winding path leads to a secluded spot; the meditation hall lies deep amid flowers and trees."
身貧道不貧	poor in body but not poor in the Way
陋室	humble dwelling
三輩九品	the Three Classes and Nine Grades
上聯 **/** 下聯	the first line / the second line (of a couplet)
六度萬行	the Six Perfections and myriad practices
大劫	great kalpa
波羅蜜 **(**菠蘿蜜**)**	paramita
轉法輪	turn the Dharma wheel
大年初一 **/** 正月初一	the first day of the lunar New Year / the first day of the first lunar month
樓梯街	Ladder Street
頂	"ding" (to rent)
大陸留港僧人聯誼會	the Fellowship of Mainland Monks Residing in Hong Kong
風行草偃	as grass bends before the wind
《唐詩三百首》	Three Hundred Tang Poems
慧命 **/** 菩提慧命	wisdom-life / Bodhi wisdom-life
三藏寶典	the precious canon of the Tripitaka
佛經流通處	sutra distribution center
成住壞空	formation, dwelling, decay, and emptiness
重重無盡	layer upon layer without end
拜凳	bowing bench
甘果慧	Gan Guo Hui (F)
大回向	the great dedication of merit
觀音七	Guanyin session
香板	incense board
傳戒典禮	precept-transmission ceremony
沈家門	Shenjiamen
活羅漢	living Arhat
無盡	Wu Jin
神通	spiritual powers
墮落	fall / falling
常仁師伯	Dharma uncle Chang Ren
古德	the virtuous ones of old
徒孫	grand-disciple
道風山	Tao Fong Shan

掛羊頭賣狗肉	hanging out a sheep's head and selling dog meat
流連荒亡	drift, linger, run wild, and go to ruin
梵行	pure conduct
公案	case
提婆達多	Devadatta
王妹姑	Wang Meigu (= Wang Guo Hai)
加被	aid
結跏趺坐	seated in full lotus
觀想	contemplate
七情六欲	the seven emotions and six desires
四大	the four elements
生老病死	birth, old age, sickness, and death
三界	the Three Realms
十二因緣	the Twelve Causes and Conditions
輪回	the cycle of rebirth
羅太太	Mrs. Luo
大悲水	Great Compassion water
銀姐	Sister Yin
遺傳性粘多糖代謝不良	"hereditary mucopolysaccharide metabolism disorder"
李蝶妍 **(**蝶妍**)**	Li Dieyan (Dieyan)
李子飛	Li Zifei
跌打醫生	bonesetter
紙錢	paper money (money used by ghosts)
宣化偈	"Hsuan Hua Verse"
六字洪名	the great six-character name (Namo Amitabha Buddha)
南無蓮池海會佛菩薩	Namo Lotus Pool Ocean-Wide Assembly of Buddhas and Bodhisattvas
紅塵	the red dust of the world
苦海茫茫，回頭是岸	The sea of suffering is vast and boundless; turn back, and there is the shore
摩頂加持	rub the crown of the head to bless
果儀 **(**菓儀**)**	offering envelope
盧譚珍	Lu Tanzhen (F)
禪話	Chan sayings
五佛帽	Five Buddha Crown
羅康銳	Luo Kangrui (M, husband of Tang Guo Shan)
癩瘡	scabby sores
黃雪梅	Huang Xuemei (F)
中日抗戰	the War of Resistance against Japan
共修	group cultivation
違章建築	illegal squatter structure
【附記】	[Supplementary Note]
張果雨	Zhang Guo Yu

念佛道場 / 念佛法會	Buddha-recitation practice / Buddha Recitation Dharma assembly
支香	incense period
阿彌陀佛聖誕	Amitabha Buddha's birthday
彌陀佛七 / 阿彌陀佛七	Amitabha Buddha Recitation session / Amitabha Buddha session
三千世界 / 三千大千世界	the three thousand worlds / the three-thousand-great-thousand world system
氫氣彈 / 核子武器 / 鐳射	hydrogen bombs / nuclear weapons / lasers
早課 / 晚課	morning recitation / evening recitation
超薦牌位	memorial tablets for rescuing the deceased
帳篷大殿	tent Buddha Hall
孝道法門	the Dharma door of filial piety
樹欲靜而風不止，子欲養而親不在	"The tree wishes to be still, but the wind will not stop; the child wishes to care for his parents, but they are no longer here."
贊王	"King of Praises"
唱誦 / 唱贊 / 贊文	chanting / chanting praises / texts of praise
戒律學院	Vinaya Academy
藏經樓	Sutra Library
維那 (維那師)	cantor
繞梁三日，不絕於耳	"lingered around the rafters for three days, ringing on and on in the ears"
解放	the Liberation (1949)
丹田	dantian
大法器	the large Dharma instruments
海潮音 (唱法)	the "Sea Tide Sound" style of chanting
蒙山施食	the Mengshan Food Bestowal
通疏	reading out the memorials (shu)
廣東話 / 國語（普通話）	Cantonese / Mandarin (Putonghua)
大磬	large bell
亡靈 / 鬼道眾生	the spirits of the dead / the beings of the ghost realm
感應	spiritual responses / response
旭老	Elder Xu Lang
瑜伽焰口	the "Yoga Flaming Mouth" ceremony
三時系念 (三時繫念)	the "Three Periods of Mindfulness" ceremony
明暘老和尚	Elder Master Ming Yang
荼毗法事	cremation ceremony
【附錄】	[Appendix]
僧臘 / 戒臘	years as a monastic / years as a fully ordained monk
訃文 / 挽聯	obituary / memorial couplet
遼寧省	Liaoning Province
娑婆界	the Saha world
旭旭 / 朗朗	"Radiant, radiant" / "Clear, clear"
彌勒院	Maitreya's Court (Maitreya's inner court in

	the Tushita Heaven)
梵音	the Brahma sound
《濟公的故事》	Stories of Jigong
基督教學校 / 天主教 / 基督教 / 天主教學校	Christian school / Catholicism / Protestant Christianity / Catholic school
門外漢 / 門內漢	outsider / insider
無規矩不成方圓	"Without a compass and a square, you cannot make circles and squares."
一乘	the One Vehicle
佛地	the ground of Buddhahood
因梅開般若，果松證菩提	"With the plum as the cause, prajna blossoms; with the pine as the fruit, Bodhi is certified."
墨寶	treasured calligraphy
式之！式之！	"Be a model! Be a model!"
黃潔梅	Huang Jiemei (birth name of Huang Guo Song, per P0564)
對聯 **embedding** 慕潔 / 果式	couplet scrolls built on her names (acrostic)
秀才	xiucai, a scholar who had passed the imperial examinations
上士 / 高人	superior person / lofty one
人天模范師 / 人天的導師	model teacher for humans and gods / guiding teacher of humans and gods
應供	receive a meal offering
劉果娟 / 程果成	Liu Guo Juan / Cheng Guo Cheng
心誠則靈	"where the mind is sincere, there is a response"
隨喜	rejoice along with
龍弟子	dragon disciples
供天	making offerings to the heavens
果修	Guo Xiu (= Dharma Master Heng Chih)
水塘	pond
觀音菩薩成道日	the anniversary of Guanyin Bodhisattva's attainment of the Way
冬菇	shiitake mushrooms
飓風 / 台風	typhoon
暴風圈	the storm's circle
玉皇大帝	the Jade Emperor
老天爺	Heaven
氣象台 / 香港天文台	the observatory / the Hong Kong Observatory
雪梨	Sydney
十號飓風訊號 / 十號風球	No. 10 Hurricane Signal / No. 10 signal
飓風瑪麗 / 台風溫黛	Typhoon Mary / Typhoon Wanda
寮屋 / 天台木屋	squatter huts / rooftop wooden huts
法爾如是	"the Dharma is naturally thus"
筆戰	war of words
諸法從緣生，諸法從緣滅	"All dharmas arise from conditions; all

	dharmas cease from conditions."
含識 / 蠢動含靈	beings with consciousness / all creatures that wriggle and all that have spiritual awareness
五濁惡世	the evil world of the five turbidities
擇法眼	the eye that discerns dharmas
慈悲喜捨	kindness, compassion, joy, and giving
戴高帽子	flatter
前途 / 後途	the road ahead / the road behind
天下本無事，庸人自擾之	"Originally nothing is wrong under heaven; ordinary people stir up trouble for themselves."
有德者降祥，無德者降殃	"Upon those with virtue, blessings descend; upon those without virtue, calamities descend."
肉螃蟹	crab of flesh
法緣	Dharma affinities
聖螺	Sheng Luo ("Sagely Conch")
蟹大哥 / 貓大哥	Big Brother Crab / Big Brother Cat
澳門	Macau
白粥 / 素食鋪	plain congee / vegetarian food shop
馬票	sweepstakes ticket
《中觀論·觀四谛品》	Treatise on the Middle Way, "Contemplation of the Four Noble Truths" chapter
尊證阿闍梨	honored certifying Acharya
紫磨金光	purple-burnished golden light
大展具	fully unfold the sitting cloth (to bow)
關房	retreat room
九叩首	nine kowtows
前 / 錢	"before" (qian, which sounds the same as "money")
張某 / 葉某	a certain Zhang / a certain Ye
大兵之後，必有凶年	"after a great war there are bound to be years of calamity"
西藥商店	Western pharmacy
冤冤相報	grievance being repaid with grievance
一匹布	a bolt of cloth
灌頂	anoint the crown of the head
花旗布	American cotton cloth
七七四十九天	seven times seven, or 49, days
攀緣	currying favor / courted his favor
上海大陳灰布	Shanghai Dachen gray cloth
大明 (公司)	Daming (company)
長衫 / 褲褂	long gowns / trousers and jackets
南天竺	Nam Tin Chuk
叢林靜室	monasteries and hermitages
弘法精舍	Hongfa Vihara
法成寺	Facheng Monastery

般若精舍	Prajna Vihara
萬金油 / 十靈丹 / 檸檬精	Tiger Balm / Shiling Dan pills / lemon essence
青山海潮院	Haichao Monastery at Castle Peak
黃大仙大佛寺	Dafo Monastery in Wong Tai Sin
名冊 / 唱名	register / call out names
筏可法師	Dharma Master Fa Ke
難僧	refugee monks
國共內戰	the civil war between the Nationalists and the Communists
日本系佛教	Japanese-style Buddhism
北僧南移	the monks from the north migrating south
雨後春筍	like bamboo shoots after a spring rain
果蜜傳奇	"The Remarkable Story of Guo Mi"
九代單傳	the sole male heir for nine generations
法像	Dharma image
南無本師釋迦牟尼佛	"Namo Fundamental Teacher Shakyamuni Buddha"
果地	Guo Di
神話	fairy tale
心髒擴大	enlarged heart
羅睺羅尊者	the Venerable Rahula
感應道交	the intertwining of stimulus and response
第一義 / 第二義	the primary meaning / the secondary meaning
文頌頤	Wen Songyi (birth name of Guo Mi)
瑪格莉特	Margaret (English name of Guo Shu)
根器	capacities
直心 / 直心是道場	a straight mind / "The straight mind is the Way-place."
話劇社 / 夜校	drama club / night school
高中畢業會考	the public examination for graduation from secondary school
竹籬門	bamboo-fence gate
伍相才	Wu Xiangcai, M (eldest son of Guo Sen)
文偉斌（果殊）	Wen Weibin (Guo Shu), F
文頌頤（果蜜）	Wen Songyi (Guo Mi; = Wen Guo Mi), M
果迦	Guo Jia (= Zhong Meiwei)
蔡淑卿（果夙）	Cai Shuqing (Cai Guo Su), F
許麗君	Xu Lijun
譚慕貞（果正）	Tan Muzhen (Tan Guo Zheng), F
黃可泰（果君）	Huang Ketai (Huang Guo Jun), M
黃潔梅（果松）	Huang Jiemei (Huang Guo Song), F
慈幼英文學校	Salesian English School (Shau Kei Wan)
妙觀察智	the Wonderful Contemplating Wisdom
是道則進，非道則退	"If it is the Way, advance; if it is not the

	Way, retreat."
識心	the conscious mind
二乘 / 菩薩乘 / 佛乘	the Two Vehicles / the Bodhisattva Vehicle / the Buddha Vehicle
菩薩道	the Bodhisattva Path
照本宣科	simply read out the text
洗禮	be baptized
南無度輪法師	"Namo Dharma Master To Lun"
客堂	guest hall
彌天大罪，一懺便消	Even offenses as vast as the heavens vanish with a single repentance
甜頭	"sweet treats"
打是愛，罵也是愛	"Hitting is love, and scolding is love too."
阿英	Ah Ying
只要心慈	"Just be kind-hearted!"
法門	Dharma-door
西方極樂世界	the Western Land of Ultimate Bliss
觀機逗教	teach according to people's potentials
鳳毛麟角	as rare as phoenix feathers and unicorn horns
一筆不苟	"Not one stroke done carelessly"
小楷 / 大楷	small regular script / large regular script
狀元	the top scholar in the imperial examinations
蠅頭小字	"fly's-head characters"
梅村居士張守約《擬寒山詩集》	Poems in Imitation of Hanshan, by Layman Meicun, Zhang Shouyue
私塾先生	old-style private tutor
裴先生	Mr. Pei (= Pei Guo Jian)
燈紅酒綠	glittering, pleasure-seeking
自心道場	the Way-place of one's own mind
《金山通訊》	Gold Mountain Newsletter
上堂說法	ascend the hall to speak the Dharma
妙莊王 / 妙善公主	King Miaozhuang / Princess Miaoshan
不為境轉	not be turned by states
廣東話 / 普通話（國語）	Cantonese / Mandarin (Guoyu)
禪那 / 思惟修 / 靜慮	dhyana / cultivation of thought / stilling of thought
降魔杵 / 斬魔劍	demon-subduing pestle / demon-slaying sword
慧力	the power of wisdom
夢裡明明有六趣，覺後空空無大千	"In dreams, so clearly, there are the six destinies; after awakening, all is empty, with no great thousand world system"
大千世界	the great thousand world system
無上正等正覺	unsurpassed, proper, and equal right enlightenment
父母未生之前的本來面目	one's original face before one's parents gave birth to one

行也禪，坐也禪，語默動靜體安然	"Walking is Chan, sitting is Chan; speaking or silent, moving or still, the substance is at peace"
佛之知見	the Buddha's knowledge and vision
學得像雞子"叫"	learn to "jiao" like a chicken
打擺子	"shaking with ague" (malaria)
樂觀法師《虛雲和尚印象記》	Dharma Master Le Guan's Impressions of Master Hsu Yun
樹枝上的"禪"	the "chan" that sits on a tree branch
油條	a limp "fried dough stick"
雲老	Elder Yun
修道之人心莫疑，疑心若起便途迷	"A cultivator of the Way must not doubt; once doubt arises, he loses his way."
心清水現月，意定天無雲	"When the mind is clear, the moon appears in the water; when the thoughts are settled, there are no clouds in the sky."
有心是妄想，無心是感應	"Having intention is false thinking; having no intention is a response."
凡聖不同的境界	the different states of ordinary beings and sages
千手千眼	the Thousand Hands and Thousand Eyes
聖號	holy name
法的布施	the giving of Dharma
目中無人	there should be no one in your eyes
《憨山大師費閒歌》	Great Master Hanshan's Song of Wasted Effort
修行容易遇師難，不遇明師總是閒	"Cultivation is easy, but meeting a teacher is hard; if you don't meet an enlightened teacher, it's all wasted effort."
心地光明	the mind-ground is bright
果笙	Guo Sheng
看破，放下	see through, put down
大嶼島	Lantau Island
殉難	die a martyr's death
中途島戰役	the Battle of Midway
大嶼島游擊隊 / 大嶼山戰場	Lantau Island guerrilla unit / the Lantau battlefront
港九大隊 / 港九游擊隊	the Hong Kong–Kowloon Brigade / the Hong Kong–Kowloon guerrillas
叢林	monastery
左院 / 右院 / 東院 / 西院	the Left Courtyard / the Right Courtyard / the East Courtyard / the West Courtyard
慈興禪寺靈山道場	Cixing Chan Monastery, Spirit Mountain Way-place
北極	the Pole Star
六根	the six faculties
浮塵	floating dust
百足（蜈蚣）	"hundred-legs" (centipedes)

碓	pestle-and-mortar (for hulling rice)
雲門山大覺寺	Dajue Monastery on Mount Yunmen
毫子	cents (Hong Kong ho, ten-cent units)
紅毛泥 / 英泥	cement ("red-hair mud," "English mud")
大雄寶殿	the Jeweled Hall of the Great Hero
石屎	concrete
西方三聖殿	the Hall of the Three Sages of the West
馬糞泥	horse-dung mud
石棉瓦	asbestos tiles
妹仔大過主人婆	"The servant girl is bigger than the mistress"
黃泥漿	yellow mud slurry
慈悲王	the King of Compassion (epithet of Elder Master Mao Feng)
有粥食粥，有飯吃飯，有一餐便食一餐	"If there's congee, eat congee; if there's rice, eat rice; if there's one meal, eat that one meal."
燃指供佛	burn a finger as an offering to the Buddha
恆順眾生	accord with living beings
大澳碼頭	the Tai O pier
天星小輪 / 青馬大橋	the Star Ferry / the Tsing Ma Bridge
陣亡死難者	those killed in battle and those who perished
大眼雞漁船	"big-eyed chicken" fishing junk
氣墊船	hovercraft
松山	Pine Mountain (the disciples' name for a hill on Lantau)
里 (數裡)	li
丈	zhang
降龍石	the Dragon-Subduing Rock
龍口水	Dragon's Mouth Water
3 丈 **6** 尺	36 Chinese feet (3 zhang 6 chi)
胡文虎花園	the Aw Boon Haw Garden (Tiger Balm Garden, Tai Hang)
伏虎溪	the Tiger-Taming Stream
四大名山 / 八大小山	the Four Great Famous Mountains / the Eight Great Lesser Mountains
劉勉齋	Liu Mianzhai
莊嚴峰 / 青龍嶺	Adornment Peak / Azure Dragon Ridge
魍魎	goblins and sprites
龍奮迅三昧	the Dragon's Swift Vigor Samadhi
左青龍，右白虎	the Azure Dragon on the left, the White Tiger on the right (fengshui)
天龍護法	gods and dragons as Dharma protectors
准提菩薩	Cundi Bodhisattva
國歷	the Gregorian calendar
《三大師焰口》	Three Great Masters' Flaming Mouth ceremony

《大悲寶懺》	Great Compassion Jeweled Repentance
普佛	Universal Buddha Ceremony
梁果筱	Liang Guo Xiao, F
法不孤起，仗境方生	"The Dharma does not arise on its own; it arises in dependence on circumstances."
打板	strike the board (wake-up signal)
早課	morning recitation
縵衣	lay precept sash
山神	mountain spirits
號角 / 號聲	horn / the sound of a horn
趕齋	come rushing to get the food
果逸法師	Dharma Master Guo Yi (逸; not the same as 果一 = Heng Ding)
五彩大旗	large five-colored banners
天階	the open courtyard
金身	golden images
祖堂 / 藏經樓 / 寮房	the Patriarchs Hall / the Sutra Library / living quarters
佛日增輝，古剎重光	the Buddha-sun shone more brightly and the ancient monastery shone anew
墨寶 / 鏡屏	calligraphy / mirror plaques
檀越	patrons
灑淨	purification by sprinkling
點眼開光	dot the eyes to open the light
觀音七 / 彌陀七	Guanyin session / Amitabha session
風水先生	fengshui master
《香江梵宇》	Buddhist Temples of Hong Kong (Xiangjiang Fanyu)
國民黨元老	Kuomintang elder statesman
倓老	Elder Tan (= Elder Master Tan Xu)
法嗣	Dharma heir
法藏師	Master Fa Zang (= Dharma Master Fa Zang)
淨樂居	"Abode of Pure Joy" (plaque)
琉璃蓋頂	glazed-tile roof
恆伯	Heng Bo (Pinyin; replace if DRBA has an established spelling)
禪人	Chan cultivator
龍華大會	the Dragon Flower Assembly
金錢戒	the precept against money
不退地	the ground of non-retreat
世尊	the World Honored One
屍羅	shila
人能弘法，非法弘人	People can propagate the Dharma; it is not the Dharma that propagates people.
法無正末	The Dharma has no Proper or Ending Age
六朝	the Six Dynasties

娑婆	the Saha world
摩尼寶珠	the mani jewel
嶼西	western Lantau
鋼筋水泥	reinforced concrete
茶果嶺	Cha Kwo Ling
結手印	form a mudra
打皈依	hold a refuge ceremony
皈依證	refuge certificate
蛇洞 / 仙人洞 / 猴子洞 / 佛洞	Snake Cave / Immortals' Cave / Monkey Cave / Buddha Cave
佛性	the Buddha-nature
四眾弟子	disciples of the fourfold assembly
法筵	Dharma assembly (in session)
萬佛殿	Hall of Ten Thousand Buddhas
《宣化上人開示錄（四）》	Venerable Master Hua's Talks on Dharma, Volume 4
摩睺羅伽	the Mahoraga
鴆酒	poisoned wine
飛屍邪鬼 / 妖精魔魘 / 魑魅魍魉 / 惡龍疫鬼	flying corpses and deviant ghosts / goblins, demons, and nightmare-spirits / mountain sprites and water goblins / evil dragons and plague ghosts
三皈五戒	the Three Refuges and the Five Precepts
清淨眼	the pure eye
金剛三昧	the Vajra Samadhi
鉤召法、降伏法	the methods of summoning and subduing
錫杖	monk's staff
喜捨院	Joyous Giving House (City of Ten Thousand Buddhas)
撥無因果	deny cause and effect
菩薩畏因不畏果 / 眾生畏果不畏因	"Bodhisattvas fear causes, not effects." / "Living beings fear effects, not causes."
明心見性	understand the mind and see the nature
龍骨	dragon bone
卍字	swastika
薛佩蘭	Xue Peilan (Yu Guo Man's daughter-in-law; cf. 薛果鳳)
黃鼠狼	weasel
是法不是法，壇前一句話	"Dharma or no Dharma, it all comes down to one sentence before the altar."
余紹辰	Yu Shaochen (birth name of Yu Guo Man)
佛化家庭	Buddhist family
知音	one who truly understands
禪堂	Chan Hall
念佛是誰	"Who is reciting the Buddha's name?"
梁桂仙	Liang Guixian
無常鬼	ghost of impermanence
燕窩	bird's nest

念誦會	chanting gathering
參話頭 / 話頭	investigate a meditation topic (huatou)
眼觀鼻，鼻觀心	"the eyes contemplating the nose, the nose contemplating the mind"
單盤	half lotus
繞念	circumambulate and recite
唵嘛呢叭咪吽	Om mani padme hum
老修行	old cultivator
譚秀珍 (譚果屺)	Tan Xiuzhen (Tan Guo Qi), F
人間生佛	"A Living Buddha in the Human World"
果趁	Guo Chen, F
上人的《事跡》	the Venerable Master's Records
果麗	Guo Li, F
太子道	Prince Edward Road
長生牌位	longevity plaque
繼室	second wife
啟薦幽冥法會	open a Dharma assembly for rescuing the departed
金剛戒種子	the seeds of the vajra precepts
佛歡喜日	the Buddha's Day of Joy
甲午	the jiawu year
(結)界	the boundary of the ritual area
請聖	invitation of the sages
文果殊	Wen Guo Shu, F (sister of Wen Guo Mi; = 果殊)
同宗兄弟	clansman
大熱症 / 熱病	high fever / fever
表弟	cousin
本社社長	our society's president
檀香山佛會 / 美國檀香山佛教會	the Honolulu Buddhist Association
禁運政策	embargo policy
《創建東林念佛堂之緣起與經過》	The Origins and History of the Founding of Tung Lin Buddha Recitation Hall
冬月 / 阿彌陀誕	the eleventh lunar month / Amitabha's birthday
東林淨捨 (淨舍)	Tung Lin Pure Abode
趙忍庵	Zhao Ren'an
秘藥偏方	secret remedies and folk prescriptions
道力	power in the Way
魔王	demon king
山妖水怪 / 邪魔外道	mountain goblins and water monsters / deviant demons and externalists
要學好，冤孽找；要成佛，先受魔	"When you want to learn to be good, your karmic foes come looking for you; if you want to become a Buddha, you must first undergo demons."
糯米餅	glutinous rice cakes

壁虎	gecko
果覺	Guo Jue
國共戰爭	the war between the Nationalists and the Communists
白山黑水	the white mountains and black waters
乙未	the yiwei year
宗風	the style of the lineage
松江省	Songjiang Province
《寫在前面》	"Written at the Outset" (prologue of Mind Dharma, issue 1)
《編後話》	"Editor's Afterword"
緇素大德	the greatly virtuous ones, monastic and lay
流通處	distribution center
督印 / 督印人	publisher (of a periodical)
戒名	precept name
證和 / 證悟 / 證仁	Zheng He / Zheng Wu / Zheng Ren (precept names of Tan Guo Shi, Tan Guo Zheng, Huang Guo Jun)
版權頁	copyright page
披剃	don the robes and shave the head
佛立 / 佛立三昧	"the Buddhas stand" / Samadhi of the Buddhas Standing
常行三昧	Samadhi of Constant Walking
睡魔	the demon of sleep
破七	(the session is) broken
護七	protect the session (serve as session attendant)
水牛精	water-buffalo spirit
走火入魔 / 著魔	go off the rails and be possessed by demons / demonic possession
三業相應	with the three karmas in accord
表信偈	Verse of Certification
西天 / 西土 / 東土	the Western Heaven / the Western Land (India) / the Eastern Land (China)
金頂毗盧派	"Golden Summit Vairocana" branch (of the Chan School)
德清	Deqing (Hsu Yun's Dharma name)
正法眼藏·佛祖源流	The Treasury of the True Dharma Eye: The Origins and Lineage of the Buddhas and Patriarchs (transmission scroll)
禅人	Chan practitioner
再說偈曰	"Again I speak a verse, which says"
法乳	milk of the Dharma
生像	statue made during the subject's lifetime
臨濟 / 曹洞 / 沩仰 / 雲門 / 法眼	Linji / Caodong / Weiyang / Yunmen / Fayan
迦葉尊者	the Venerable Kashyapa
禅宗五派源流	"The Origins and Lineages of the Five

	Schools of Chan"
九成了照首座	Head Seat Jiucheng Liaozhao
大沩山 / 大沩	Great Mount Wei / Great Wei
寶生長老	Elder Baosheng
演字	lineage verse; generation character
芭蕉慧清 / 繼徹	Bajiao Huiqing / Jiche
郭涵齋寬慧	Upasaka Guo Hanzhai (Kuan Hui)
鐘板	bell and board
五分 (香)	the fivefold incense
圓相	circle-form
拈花	the flower held aloft
文喜 / 前三三，後三三	Wenxi / "Three three in front, three three behind"
重九	the Double Ninth
長白山僧	the Monk of Changbai Mountain (the Master's self-designation)
佛經翻譯委員會	Buddhist Text Translation Society
七真傳	Biographies of the Seven Perfected
太上清淨經	Most High Scripture of Clarity and Stillness
燃燈	Randeng
孫不二 / 孫淵貞 / 不二	Sun Bu'er / Sun Yuanzhen / Bu'er
漢鐘離 / 鐘離權 / 正陽子	Han Zhongli / Zhongli Quan / Zhengyangzi
李耳	Li Er (Laozi)
劉海蟾 / 劉操 / 海蟾子	Liu Haichan / Liu Cao / Haichanzi
燕王劉守光	Liu Shouguang, the Prince of Yan
終南山	Mount Zhongnan
道教北宗	the Northern School of Taoism
七真 / 八仙	the Seven Perfected / the Eight Immortals
王重陽	Wang Chongyang
丘長春	Qiu Changchun
法號	Dharma title
拜墊	bowing cushion
粗言及細語，皆歸第一義	"Coarse words and subtle speech all return to the primary meaning."
說食數寶	"talking about food and counting others' treasure"
三根普被	reaching those of all three kinds of faculties
悼念度輪長老	"In Memory of Elder To Lun" (article by Elder Zhi Ding)
開單接眾	accept monastics to stay
縵衣 (缦衣)	lay precept sash
自然日報	Nature Daily (Ziran Ribao)
南華佛學院	Nanhua Buddhist Academy
成和道	Shing Woo Road (Happy Valley)
世界和平塔	World Peace Pagoda (Rangoon)
余鎮東	Judge Yu Zhendong
陳振富	Chen Zhenfu (Burmese consul in Hong

	Kong), M
仰光大金塔 / 瑞光大金塔	the Great Golden Pagoda of Rangoon / the Shwedagon Pagoda
庇古	Pegu
睡佛寺	the Reclining Buddha Temple
世界佛教會	World Buddhist Society
檳城 / 極樂寺	Penang / Kek Lok Si Monastery
高棉 / 高麗 / 錫蘭	Cambodia / Korea / Ceylon
法界性	the nature of the Dharma Realm
息災法	Dharmas for averting disasters
南傳的國家	the countries of Southern Buddhism
抟食	eating by the handful
五辛	the five pungent plants (onions, garlic, chives, shallots, asafoetida)
鉤環	hook and ring (of the kashaya)
虛雲和尚印象記	Impressions of Master Hsu Yun
上殿 / 過堂 / 客堂	go to the Buddha Hall / formal meals in the dining hall / guest hall
吉祥山 / 大聖窟	Auspicious Hill / Great Sacred Cave
第六次結集	the Sixth Council
布達拉宮	the Potala Palace
舍利弗 / 目犍連	Shariputra / Maudgalyayana
上座部佛教	Theravada Buddhism
倫敦巴利聖典協會	the Pali Text Society of London
藝固	Yegu
衛塞節	Vesak Day
吳哥窟 / 婆羅浮屠	Angkor Wat / Borobudur
拘留孫佛 / 正等覺金寂佛 / 迦葉佛	Krakucchanda Buddha / Kanakamuni Buddha, the Perfectly and Equally Enlightened One / Kashyapa Buddha
聖丁固達拉山	Singuttara Hill
喬達基寶塔	Chaukhtatgyi Pagoda
首席法官	Chief Justice (of Rangoon)
新加坡佛教協會	Singapore Buddhist Association
畢俊輝	Ms. Bi Junhui, F
菩提小學	Bodhi Primary School (Singapore)
佛眼	the Buddha Eye
神秀	Shenxiu
大澳船	the Tai O ferry
仁者	Benevolent One (epistolary address)
廣妙	Guang Miao
天王殿	Hall of the Heavenly Kings
太平蓮捨	Taiping Lotus Lodge (Guangdong)
衲	the patched-robed (monk)
老修行 / 老魔王	seasoned cultivator / old demon king
拆字	character-splitting puzzle
楊福森	Professor Yang Fusen

愉園大廈	Yu Yuen Mansion (Happy Valley)
聖一老和尚略傳	A Brief Biography of Elder Master Sheng Yi
宣玄	Xuan Xuan (Sheng Yi's lineage name)
新會	Xinhui (Guangdong)
退居方丈	retired abbot
順德縣	Shunde County
十魔亂正 / 十魔障	the ten demons that disturb the proper / the ten demonic obstacles
祖源禅師	Chan Master Zuyuan
金剛心總持論	Treatise on the Vajra Mind Dharani
三壇大戒	Triple Platform Ordination
紅頭軍	"Red-Headed Army" (an insect)
近潤法師	Bhikshuni Dharma Master Jin Run, F
良法師	Dharma Master Liang
密行	hidden practices
大師兄 / 釋兄	eldest Dharma sister / elder Dharma sister
挽聯	elegiac couplet
三聖	the Three Sages
水落石出	"the water recedes and the rocks appear"
專一則靈，分歧則蔽	"Concentration brings efficacy; division brings obscurity."
法雲 / 如修	Dharma Masters Fa Yun / Ru Xiu
熏壇灑淨	perfuming the altar and purifying it by sprinkling
五眼	the Five Eyes
童貞修道	cultivate the Way as a lifelong celibate
雷諾	Reno
具 / 臥具 / 展大具	sitting cloth (nishidana) / fully unfolding the sitting cloth
聖懷法師	Dharma Master Sheng Huai
無明 / 行 / 識 / 名色 / 六入 / 觸 / 受 / 取 / 有	ignorance / activity / consciousness / name and form / six entrances / contact / feeling / grasp / possess
慕貞	Muzhen (Tan Muzhen = Tan Guo Zheng)
賢賢易色 / 道道可回天	"Esteeming the worthy can replace love of beauty" / "Following the Way can turn back heaven's course"
大千	the billion worlds
同修	husband
林果森	Lin Guo Sen (= Dharma Master Jin Ci), F
法界聖城	the City of the Dharma Realm
聞思修居士林	Hearing, Contemplating, and Cultivating Lay Buddhist Society (San Jose)
胡大文 / 王鴻義	Hu Dawen / Wang Hongyi
卡加利	Calgary
千手千眼大慈大悲觀世音菩薩	the Thousand-Handed, Thousand-Eyed Guanshiyin Bodhisattva of Great Kindness and Great Compassion

大悲寶忏	the Jeweled Great Compassion Repentance
巴士總站	bus terminus
真身	true-body image
西樂園念佛堂	Western Bliss Gardens Buddha Recitation Hall
高足	eminent disciple
特訊	(Special Report)
上供	the meal offering
楊枝淨水 **(**讚**)**	the "Willow Branch and Pure Water" praise
佛龕 **/** 佛桌	shrine / altar table
溫哥華道場 **(**法總**)**	DRBA's Way-place in Vancouver
王泰生	Wang Taisheng (sculptor)
羅太	Mrs. Luo
洗腳水	footbath water
胡鬧	"Hu Nao" (nickname; hunao = acting foolishly, Hu = surname)
打問訊	make a half-bow
《釋迦如來應化事跡》	Records of the Responsive Manifestations of Shakya Tathagata
上虛下雲老人	the Venerable Elder Hsu Yun
不退轉	irreversibility
倒駕慈航	turn the ship of compassion back
庚子	the gengzi year (1960)
彌勒聖誕	the birthday of Maitreya
華嚴座室	the Avatamsaka Seat Room
香島	the island of Hong Kong
心印，正法眼藏，涅槃妙心	the mind seal, the Treasury of the True Dharma Eye, the wondrous mind of Nirvana
教務主任	dean of academic affairs
本刊訊	(Report from this magazine)
監學 **/** 監學法師	proctor
生相	statue made while the subject is still living
大般若七 **/** 般若七 **/** 大般若法會	Great Prajna session / Prajna session / Great Prajna Dharma assembly
虛雲老和尚涅槃永久紀念委員會	Permanent Memorial Committee for the Nirvana of Elder Master Hsu Yun
天人師	teacher of gods and humans
唁辭	message of condolence
紙扎	paper effigies
九磨十難	nine ordeals and ten difficulties
五帝四朝	five emperors and four eras
永修縣	Yongxiu County
四七 **(**之期**)**	the fourth seven-day period (after a death)
虛公	the Venerable Hsu
古歷	the old calendar
寬常	Kuan Chang (precept disciple at Yunju)
法席	Dharma seat

保賢 / 仁光 / 榮修 / 法雲	Dharma Masters Bao Xian / Ren Guang / Rong Xiu / Fa Yun
拈香	offer incense
李寬仲	Li Kuan Zhong
楊寬莊	Yang Kuan Zhuang
道慈佛社	Daoci Buddhist Society (Sai Wan; official English name unknown)
《悼念雲公老人》	"In Memory of the Venerable Elder Yun" (article by Zhi Ding)
安養世界	world of peace and nurture
梁醫生	Dr. Liang
《悼虛雲老人》	"Mourning Elder Hsu Yun" (article by Zhan Liwu)
《虛雲老和尚年譜法彙增訂本》	Chronicle and Collected Dharma Talks of Elder Master Hsu Yun (Expanded Edition)
優昙法師	Dharma Master You Tan
緇素四眾	the fourfold assembly, monastic and lay
陳靜濤	Upasaka Chen Jingtao
《虛雲老和尚在雲居山的事跡點滴》	"Glimpses of Elder Master Hsu Yun's Life on Mount Yunju"
文化大革命	the Cultural Revolution
一領大衣 / 大衣	this one great robe (sanghati)
佛印橋 / 碧溪	the Foyin Bridge / the Bixi stream
入室弟子	disciples who have entered my room
把茅蓋頭	a bundle of thatch to cover one's head
《矽谷梵音》	Silicon Valley Brahma Sound (Gold Sage Monastery periodical)
吉祥臥	the auspicious reclining posture
遺偈	final verse
水族	water creatures
四念	the four applications of mindfulness
丸果	pellets
跳火坑	leaping into a pit of fire
頂門有眼	with the eye on the crown of his head
昙始 / 知玄 / 玄暢 / 靜藹	Tanshi / Zhixuan / Xuanchang / Great Master Jing'ai
魏武帝 / 周武帝 / 唐武帝	Emperor Wu of Wei / Emperor Wu of Zhou / Emperor Wu of Tang
堅固子	firm seeds (sharira)
砗磲	tridacna
嗣法門人	his disciple and Dharma heir
捨身品	"Chapter on Giving Up the Body" (Golden Light Sutra)
螃蟹病	"crab ailment"
夜光明珠 / 摩尼珠	pearl that shines in the night / mani pearl
度師	Master To
莊子	Zhuangzi
萬緣善會	Assembly of Myriad Affinities (Tung Wah)

雲公老上人	the Venerable Elder Master Yun
孟冬	the first month of winter
實性	Shi Xing
寬懷 / 寬克	Master Kuan Huai / Master Kuan Ke
封龕	seal the casket
趙州關	Zhaozhou Pass
捨利塔	sharira stupa
捨利花	sharira flowers
曾秀娟 / 果曦	Zeng Xiujuan (lay name of Heng He) / Guo Xi
虛雲老和尚涅槃征文	Call for Writings on the Nirvana of Elder Master Hsu Yun
智參法師	Dharma Master Zhi Can
祖師殿 / 香燈	the Patriarchs' Hall / incense-and-lamp attendant
常住	the monastery
東三省	the Three Northeastern Provinces
自了漢	one who looks after only himself
濕氣	damp ailment
釋迦老子	Old Shakya
堂主 / 副寺	hall master / deputy treasurer
穗	Guangzhou
延生普佛	Universal Buddha Ceremony for prolonging life
戊戌	the wuxu year (1958)
法照	Dharma photograph
世界佛教友誼會	World Fellowship of Buddhists
南洋	Southeast Asia
善事多魔	good deeds attract many demons
於振東	Upasaka Yu Zhendong
李俊承	Upasaka Lee Choon Seng (established name)
拔舌泥犁	the tongue-pulling hell
春秋 / 史記 / 司馬	Spring and Autumn Annals / Records of the Grand Historian / Sima [Qian]
兩序大眾	the assembly of both ranks
岑老居士	the elderly Upasaka Cen
毛文達 / 李仲猷	Mao Wenda / Li Zhongyou
妙蓮	Miaolian (Hsu Yun's preceptor)
彭山	Mount Peng
觀自在	Guanzizai
卷首語	Foreword
杭立武 / 屈映光	Upasaka Hang Li-wu (established name) / Upasaka Qu Yingguang
編後話	Editor's Afterword
活死僧	"living dead monk"
五濁 / 三醉	the five turbidities / drunk with the three

	poisons
志哀贊頌	tributes of mourning and praise
龍象	dragons and elephants
單傳直指	the single transmission that points directly
說客	go-between
日幣	yen
流通 / 佛經流通處	circulate (liutong) / Buddhist sutra distribution center
三凡事	the "three ordinary affairs"
影印	facsimile reprint
三止三觀	the three stoppings and three contemplations
慈舟律師	Vinaya Master Cizhou
清涼	Qingliang (National Master Chengguan)
白衣	laymen
影印華嚴經辦事處	Avatamsaka Sutra Facsimile Reprint Office
大乘佛歷	Mahayana Buddhist Era
秀州惠雲院	Huiyun Cloister in Xiuzhou
乾道	the Qiandao reign period
德求	the Bhikshu Deqiu
蘇東坡	Su Dongpo
香港佛經流通處佛教出版社	the Buddhist Publishing House of the Hong Kong Buddhist Sutra Distribution Center
種智	seed-wisdom
丙申	the bingshen year (1956)
山中比丘	a Bhikshu in the mountains
《博山和尚超脫真詮》	Master Boshan's True Exposition on Transcendence
了乘和尚	Master Liaocheng
常寂光	the Eternal Stillness and Light
庚寅	the gengyin year (1950)
心宗	the Mind School
惠 **(**由滬赴惠**)**	Huizhou
慈	I, An Tse
淨空 / 妙真 / 濟眾 / 佛法 / 志願 / 律真 / 寂光	Great Master Jing Kong / Masters Miao Zhen, Ji Zhong, Fo Fa, Zhi Yuan, Lü Zhen, Ji Guang
祖庭	the court of the Patriarch
空青山兜率寺	Doushuai Monastery on Mount Kongqing
呂宋巷 / **Ross Alley**	Ross Alley
太平洋街	Pacific Street
企李街	Clay Street
法主	presiding Dharma Master
祖印法師	Dharma Master Zu Yin
預科	preparatory courses
伍佩琳道長	Taoist master Wu Peilin
佛禪會禮教堂	"Buddhist Chan Society Ritual Hall"

日本佛教總堂	Buddhist Churches of America
日本埠	Japantown
游雲山 / 曉雲法師	You Yunshan / Dharma Master Xiao Yun (known as Hiu Wan)
譚文讓 (果權)	Tan Wenrang (Guo Quan), M
不牟利團體	nonprofit organization
梁民惠 (果民)	Liang Minhui (Guo Min), M
法會領班	leaders of the Dharma assemblies
美洲佛教會	Buddhist Association of America
楊居士	Upasaka Yang, M
黃果仁 / 李果乾	Huang Guo Ren / Li Guo Qian
喬遷謝啟	Notice of Thanks on Moving to New Premises
上祖下印	the Venerable ... Zu Yin
功德文疏	merit-and-virtue dedication forms
東華醫院	the Chinese Hospital (Tung Wah Hospital)
地藏王	Earth Store Bodhisattva
美國就美，澳洲就懊悔	"America is mei, 'beautiful'; Australia is ao, 'regretful'!"
四邑	the Siyi region (of Guangdong)
代皈依	confer the refuge on the Master's behalf
德相	virtuous likeness (photograph)
美國移民局	the U.S. immigration authorities
墨爾本 / 雪梨 / 坎貝拉	Melbourne / Sydney / Canberra
金岸法界聖寺 / 金岸法界	Gold Coast Dharma Realm Sagely Monastery / Gold Coast Dharma Realm
劉季寧	Liu Jining (male; "Mr. Liu Jining" at P1525)
四諦	the Four Noble Truths
雪梨佛教會	Sydney Buddhist Society
雪梨大學	University of Sydney
二乘	the Two Vehicles
法身大士	great beings of the Dharma body
淨飯國王 / 悉達	King Shuddhodana / Siddhartha
為實施權 / 開權顯實	for the sake of the real, set forth the provisional / open up the provisional to reveal the real
盧舍那佛	Vairochana Buddha
雪山	the Snowy Mountains
六度波羅蜜	the Six Perfections (paramitas)
生忍、法忍、無生忍	patience with living beings, patience with dharmas, patience with the non-production of dharmas
四禪八定 / 九次第定	the four dhyanas and eight samadhis / the nine successive samadhis
文字、觀照、實相（般若）	the prajna of language, of contemplative illumination, of the real mark
一華開五葉	one flower opened into five petals
大鑑禪師	Chan Master Huineng (Dajian)

方等教 / 般若教	the Vaipulya teaching / the Prajna teaching
正法眼藏，涅槃妙心，實相無相，教外別傳	the treasury of the proper Dharma eye, the wonderful mind of Nirvana, the real mark which is without marks, a special transmission outside the teachings
神光 / 慧可	Shenguang / Huike
菩提達摩尊者	the Venerable Bodhidharma
迦葉 / 摩訶迦葉	Kashyapa / Mahakashyapa
震旦	China
應供、殺賊、無生	worthy of offerings, slayer of thieves, without birth
覺有情	an enlightener of sentient beings
錫蘭 / 星加坡 / 馬來亞 / 檳城 / 馬尼拉 / 高棉	Ceylon / Singapore / Malaya / Penang / Manila / Cambodia
鳩摩羅什 / 玄奘	Kumarajiva / Xuanzang
正等菩提	proper and equal Bodhi
佐治街 / 唐人街	George Street / Chinatown
蠱毒 / 蠱術	gu poison / gu sorcery
附記	[Supplementary Note] (to distinguish it from 後記 [Addendum])
慈瑞法師 / 宣揚法師	Dharma Master Ci Rui / Dharma Master Xuan Yang
澳航	Qantas
水鏡回天錄	Water Mirror Reflecting Heaven (BTTS title)
澳洲佛教觀感	Impressions of Buddhism in Australia
六根六塵	the six faculties and six sense objects
婆羅洲	Borneo
果忍師	Dharma Master Guo Ren (= Heng Qi)
典座	chief cook
張果宏 / 張愛	Zhang Guo Hong / Zhang Ai (lay name of Heng Wei)
志蓮安老院	Chi Lin Home for the Aged
監齋	tending the kitchen
大悲千手千眼（法）	the Great Compassion Thousand Hands and Thousand Eyes Dharma
求簽 / 觀音筒 / 簽筒 / 解簽書	drawing fortune sticks / Guanyin fortune-stick canister / stick canister / book for interpreting the sticks
陸果雁	Lu Guo Yan
淨寬（寬淨）	Jing Kuan (female)
王鳳九	Wang Fengjiu (male)
真言	true words / mantra (pun)
果銀	Guo Yin (female; younger sister of He Guo Zhang)
譚果揚	Tan Guo Yang
子程子曰	"Zi Chengzi yue" ("Our Master, Master Cheng, said")
朱子（朱熹）/ 程子（程頤）	Zhuzi (Zhu Xi) / Chengzi (Cheng Yi)

新禪語 / 程氏新禪語	New Chan Sayings / Cheng's New Chan Sayings
程曦（字仲炎）	Cheng Xi (courtesy name Zhongyan)
愛荷華州立大學 / 愛荷華（愛俄華）大學	Iowa State University / University of Iowa
設問語錄	Sayings in the Form of Questions
四書 / 四書五經	the Four Books / the Four Books and Five Classics
推拿	tuina massage
燕京大學 / 匹茲堡大學	Yenching University / University of Pittsburgh
佛龕	Buddha shrine
白水泉中一大天	"Within the white-water spring, one great heaven" (first line of a couplet)
黃覺非	Huang Juefei
他心通	the power of knowing others' thoughts
王子一 / 果悟	Wang Ziyi / Guo Wu ("Fruit of Awakening"; pun on 果誤 "Fruit of Error")
真如的本體	the fundamental substance of True Suchness
魔王 / 魔王監獄	demon king / demon-king prison
船廟 / 觀音船廟	the Boat Temple / the Guanyin Boat Temple
壬寅	the renyin year
白孝子	Filial Son Bai
御用大律師	Queen's Counsel
昂坪茶園	Ngong Ping tea garden
東京 / 夏威夷	Tokyo / Hawaii
東蓮覺苑佛學講堂	the Buddhist Studies Lecture Hall of Tung Lin Kok Yuen
是真精進，是名真法供養	"true vigor, and is called a true Dharma offering"
趕經懺	rushing about performing sutra recitations and repentances for payment
直心是道場	"the straight mind is the Way-place"
拔舌地獄	the Hell of Tongue Pulling
老千	con man
金龍血案 / 華清幫 / 祖仔幫	the Golden Dragon Massacre / the Wah Ching / the Joe Boys
阿難尊者以四事問佛	the Venerable Ananda's four questions to the Buddha